Scripted Affects, Branded Selves

SCRIPTED AFFECTS, BRANDED SELVES

Television, Subjectivity, and Capitalism in 1990s Japan

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Japan and Television at the Century's Turn

Introduction

1996: Monday, 9 p.m.

Long Vacation is a primetime serial that centers on the love relationship between an aging model with rapidly narrowing career prospects and a young pianist about to give up hope that he will ever make the big time.[1] The drama features the top celebrities of 1990s Japan, including Kimura Takuya, Yamaguchi Tomoko, Matsu Takako, and Takenouchi Yutaka. Although the story is so thinly drawn as to be practically nonexistent, the drama is extraordinarily popular: the season finale earned a rating of 36.7 percent in a period in which the highest-rated drama in the United States, *E.R.*, could barely reach the 20 percent mark. In 1996, *Long Vacation* came closest to television of earlier times in its ability to draw large cross-segments of viewers to the screen. Yet the show did not tackle concerns that occupied the majority of the population; nor did it address problems that seemed crucial for the reproduction of the national community. Instead, the serial concluded with the piano player and the former model relocating

to Boston, with the last scene showing their friends joining them to attend their wedding ceremony.

2007: Sunday, 10 a.m.

The comedian Akashiya Sanma, one of the most popular celebrities in Japan, hosts a program that is sponsored by a different network almost every day. In all of these shows he plays himself, running off at the mouth and spending much of the time rolling on the floor with laughter. A talk show–variety show hybrid, the program I am watching features celebrity guests as well as non-celebrities who—in most cases—have come a long way to demonstrate some unique yet distinctly useless skill. In this episode, a fisherman is trying to catch a tangerine placed on a small train that is speeding around in circles. The discrepancy between the aura of earnestness imparted by the contestant's traditional fishing garb and the utter silliness of the challenge makes the situation comical. But what sends the program's host to the floor (and we shortly follow suit in front of the television) is that the fisherman keeps failing to catch the train-riding tangerine.

2002: Friday, 12:45 a.m.

A comedy duo known as London Boots and two young celebrity guests are sitting around a *kotatsu* (a traditional low wooden table with an electric heater underneath) in a tiny, under-furnished room, shooting the breeze over a simmering pot of *nabe*.[2] The game is the following: They have to answer questions on the cue of a studio staff member. If they answer correctly, they can enrich their dish with some lavish ingredient. If they are wrong, they will have to add an unappealing ingredient to their dinner. They rarely get an answer right, and the successive line of odd ingredients—banana, eel, strawberry shortcake, and Tabasco sauce—gradually increases the level of conviviality. The laughter of the studio staff reinforces the exaggerated casualness of the show. Staff members enter the camera frame (and our screen) only once or twice during the program to sneak a peak at the ever creepier consistency of the *nabe* dish. Yet we are made aware of their presence, as we constantly hear them laughing and making comments.

The shows I have described are typical of the entertainment fare that Japanese commercial networks have been offering over the past two decades. They are flamboyant, often extravagantly budgeted, unhesitant to take risks, and resilient to analysis that interrogates them for ideological content. Their persuasive power comes from an intensity of affect. *Long Vacation*, for instance, captures viewers by flattering them as consumer connoisseurs who deserve nothing less than the best—the hottest celebrities and cutting-edge lifestyle trends they represent. Similarly, London Boots seduces viewers into a sense of belonging by addressing them as viewer connoisseurs who—unlike the uninitiated—know how to appreciate the studio staff's violation of an imagined boundary between televisual fiction and reality. These shows are character-driven, yet the characters do not embody sociocultural ideals. Rather, they epitomize lifestyles and attitudes. Sanma, for instance, laughs at the fisherman's unsuccessful attempts to express an attitude—perhaps one that defies the normative classification of an individual's life as either success or failure, itself an outmoded effect of the postwar era's preoccupation with economic growth. All of these programs offer a sense of belonging, albeit to a community different from the one that television produced during its heyday as a mass medium. This televisual community accommodates anyone, irrespective of nationality, who shares an understanding that attitude and lifestyle are central to identity in a world in which affective alliances have become powerful sources of identification.

This book analyzes televisual culture in Japan of the 1990s, with a focus on a new genre of primetime serials, the trendy drama (*torendii dorama*).[3] I posit that this genre was instrumental in changing television by leading to the proliferation of programs such as those I have just described. Long predating the HBO show *Sex and the City* and the more recent CW serial *Gossip Girl*, trendy dramas such as *Long Vacation* saturated their viewers with information on lifestyle trends by entertaining them with images of well-heeled young sophisticates who personify ultra-hip attitudes and enjoy consumer-oriented lifestyles while managing their love lives. These dramas epitomized television production's move away from signification to affect—in other words, from story-driven entertainment to lifestyle-oriented fare. The concomitant erosion of the boundary between entertainment and advertising opened new opportunities for further tie-ins across domestic media and leisure industries and enhanced the post-

Fordist flexibility of the Japanese television industry. The trendy drama revitalized television at a time when mass media were rapidly losing their appeal in the wake of market fragmentation.

Anthropologists have analyzed television serials predominantly as projects that aim to establish unified visions of the modern nation and produce modern citizens (Abu-Lughod 2005; Mankekar 1999). By the mid-1980s, the simultaneous diversification of consumers' preferences and the stratification of purchasing power in Japan marked a shift in balance from family-oriented mass consumption to niche-driven consumer practices. Because they depended on revenue from advertising, commercial television networks could no longer avoid responding to marketers' demands to reach increasingly narrowing segments of the consumer market. Trendy dramas do not unite the population by interpellating them as members of particular national communities. Instead, by appealing to viewers' individuality, these serials increasingly separate viewers from each other and reunite them into new lifestyle collectivities and affective alliances. Yet ironically, in a context in which protectionist trade policies have eradicated the distinction between the concepts of the nation-state and the national market, these serials also reinforce membership in a televisual community that is essentially nationally based. This book thus asks: How are we to reconceptualize television for anthropological studies of society and subjectivity when this medium, which has been central to their reproduction, abandons its role of molding people of all backgrounds into a mass market and begins instead to compartmentalize the population into ever more distinct lifestyle collectivities? Further, how should conventional analytical models be revised to better understand the ways in which television forges selves and produces new forms of community?

Japan in the 1990s: Recession, Class, and Lifestyle

Regarded as the "lost decade" or, even more pessimistically, as Japan's "second defeat" (the first being in the Second World War), the 1990s saw the collapse of Japan's unique economic system and a prolonged recession. The attempts to piece together explanations for the bursting of Japan's economic bubble (characterized by a massive rise in stock and land prices in the 1980s) are profuse and various. However, there seems to be a consensus that three features of industrial relations—government-

coordinated industrial policy, the *keiretsu* system, and Japan's unique human-resource-management system—were vital in safeguarding economic growth in the postwar period (Gao 2001; Tezuka 1997). A brief overview of these institutions is in order here, for their collapse, along with the concomitant erosion of the social order on which they depended, is pertinent to understanding the development of the trendy drama.

Under the leadership of the Ministry of International Trade and Industry (MITI; now the Ministry of Economy, Trade, and Industry [METI]), the Japanese government played a central role in regulating industrial and labor relations by controlling the competition among domestic corporations. At the same time, by subsidizing unprofitable businesses, MITI was successful in preventing rapid increases in unemployment. Similarly, the keiretsu system served to keep unemployment rates at low levels by functioning as a mutual insurance system. Keiretsu refers to large industrial groups characterized by minority cross-shareholding, regular communication of top executives, and general cooperation for mutual benefit. Within the keiretsu, employment was virtually guaranteed, as members were committed to protecting each other from dropping out of competition. The third guardian of Japan's economic growth was the human-resource-management system. It functioned as a welfare program, offering a guarantee that an employer would keep its career-track male employees on the payroll until retirement.

By the 1990s, overpriced labor and government-coordinated competition were impeding economic growth. In response, Prime Minister Hashimoto Ryūtaro initiated the Big Bang plan in 1996.[4] As implied by the plan's slogan, "Free, Fair and Global," Hashimoto's cabinet tried to reform Japan's ailing economy by redefining the parameters of competition. The slogan highlights the importance of free-market principles and participation in the global economy, both of which would have had a profound impact on the institutional pillars of the era of high economic growth and, by extension, on labor and class relations. While companies tried to avoid massive layoffs, they were less capable of avoiding early retirement, transfers to lower-paying positions at subsidiaries, and, most important, hiring freezes. This meant that young people—the target audience of the trendy drama—were among the populations most affected by the recession. At the same time, younger generations were increasingly unwilling to follow in the footsteps of their parents by entering a social contract that would

reward their hard work with a financially secure yet highly regimented life. This expression of disillusionment, however, was nothing but mere self-consolation in a condition in which fewer and fewer career-track positions were available that would have required this type of commitment.

In Japan of the 1990s, a sense of nostalgia loomed over the discourses of the economic slowdown, and the term "recession" provided a consoling frame by suggesting that the economic slump was in fact transient. Although the rhetoric of the recession conveyed optimism that the postwar industrial structure and sociopolitical institutions could be revitalized to sustain economic growth, by the early 2000s it would become clear that in the 1990s Japanese capitalism had undergone something of a sea change. Whether the recession was a result of too much or too little deregulation has been the subject of impassioned debates. Whether the socioeconomic transformations of the 1990s can be understood as a shift from a liberal to a neoliberal mode of governance is a question that divides Japan scholars. It is, however, safe to say that what took place in 1990s Japan was a transition from an economic model in which the government was central to ensuring the smooth functioning of the market to a new model in which the self-regulating principles of the market started gaining an increasingly vital role in safeguarding economic growth.

An important social consequence of economic deregulation—and a pertinent backdrop to understanding the trendy dramas' preoccupation with lifestyle (*ikikata sutairu*)—was the demise of mass middle-class society (*chūkan taishū shakai*), a social formation that constituted 90 percent of the population (Vogel 1965). From the mid-1950s to the mid-1970s, steady economic growth had made a range of mass commodities available to the majority of the citizenry. At the same time, the expanding mass media had tremendous success in valorizing middle-class values (Ivy 1993). While a middle-class way of life had an enormously broad appeal in the postwar decades, mass middle-class society was not so much a reality as a social construct.[5] Scholars have noted that in the early postwar period, during which the population was united under the umbrella of trauma and desire for a quick economic recovery (Gordon 2002), the hegemonization of mainstream consciousness (*chūryū ishiki*) served economic-growth strategies by rallying the population around a common goal (Kelly 2002). William Kelly suggests that the real effect of the rhetoric of mass middle-class society was to downplay and neutralize debates about social stratification,

for the valorization of mainstream consciousness "has been a process of restructuring and standardizing differences around new axes rather than homogenizing lifestyles and equalizing life chances" (Kelly 2002, 236; see also Kelly and White 2006). In fact, gaps in income and educational attainment had already started to widen in the wake of the recession following the oil crisis of the mid-1970s. The crumbling of Japan's unique industrial system in the 1990s was but the final factor in the destabilization of the ideological foundations of mass middle-class society.

The trendy dramas' preoccupation with lifestyle—an emphasis on the freedom of the individual to choose her own way of life—was not only a new strategy to reinvent television in the wake of market segmentation, as I will argue in the next section. The rhetoric of lifestyle in primetime serials also played a vital role in mediating the changing politics of class in Japan of the 1990s. In the postwar decades, television has been instrumental in producing mass middle-class society by targeting housewives (*shufu*) and salarymen (*sarariman*),[6] who epitomized middle-class status and were the custodians of middle-class values. However, maintaining the phantasm of mass middle-class society was increasingly difficult, as the disintegration of this social formation was increasingly visible, and in parallel, advertisers were losing faith in the efficacy of mass-marketing. Instead, they started looking for differences in consumers' disposable income and ways to capitalize on those differences. Toward the end of the twentieth century, scholars observed a marked shift toward the increased segmentation of the consumer market in the advanced capitalist world. Susan Strasser (1989) has noted that segmentation has coexisted with the mass market from the beginning of modern consumer culture, but she stresses that in the late 1980s the passion for targeting tightly defined groups codified increasing class distinctions. In other words, by the late 1980s in the United States, the rhetoric of lifestyle had become a coded way for marketing and media professionals to less hesitantly discuss and capitalize on class differences.

The trendy dramas' focus on lifestyle suggests that Japanese marketers and media professionals deployed similar strategies to chart the changing social terrain. By adopting new approaches to pursue consumers—for example, by using new targeting criteria such as psychographics (i.e., features of lifestyle and attitude)—Japanese marketers skillfully articulated differences among people while rendering the concept of class obsolete. The televisual obsession with lifestyle projected the impression that class sim-

ply was not an issue in Japan in the 1990s. What made lifestyle such an ideal discursive tool to navigate changing class relations and to offer new forms of identification in the 1990s was the concept's semantic fluidity. Lifestyle is a "blending of income, generation, marital status, and gender into a soup of geographical and psychological profiles" (Turow 2007, 24), but more commonly it is understood as a statement about who one is in society and who one is not (Solomon 2008). Although fraught with ambiguities, lifestyle is an appealing tool for marketers because it suggests to consumers that they can freely choose social selves for themselves while excluding as a basis for identity the position they hold within the system of production (Twitchell 2000).

However, class is not simply an affiliation of identity that designates the place of an individual in the social order based on her occupation or consumption habits; it also expresses an individual's identification with a group of people who are united by mutual interests (Williams 1976). Thus, by substituting class for lifestyle, media professionals also realign the parameters within which new collectivities can be imagined. Robin Andersen (1995) has observed that lifestyle, as a strategy to unite consumers in terms of shared buying patterns and attitudes, does not correspond to sociological categories such as real social communities defined as interest groups. Marketers invite consumers to join new collectivities by offering them a sense of belonging by virtue of sharing the same good taste. Yet these lifestyle collectivities can only masquerade as real communities, for their members are not socially interdependent and are not allied by shared interests. Put differently, lifestyle communities are collectivities without any form of authentic solidarity.

In the 1990s, the televisual rhetoric of lifestyle that celebrated difference in terms of individualism helped absorb anxieties over growing class differences. Indeed, Prime Minister Obuchi Keizo's *Commission on Japan's Goals in the Twenty-first Century* seems to resonate with televisual and marketing constructions of the new classless society.[7] It attacks mass middle-class society as the archenemy of individualism and stresses that egalitarianism impedes individuals' willingness to take risks and to use their creativity. Instead, it calls for systems that are capable of adequately rewarding "the efforts of those who take risks and display excellence underpinned by a pioneer spirit."[8] Thomas Lemke's analysis of neoliberal governmentality helps us to understand the relationship between the report's attack on

egalitarianism and its silence on growing structural inequalities. According to Lemke (2001, 200), "The neoliberal program seeks to create neither a disciplining nor a normalizing society, but instead a society characterized by the fact that it cultivates and optimizes differences. It is therefore neither necessary nor desirable for a society to exhibit unlimited conformity." Similarly, Jean and John Comaroff (2001, 15) note that the neoliberal condition "render[s] ever more obscure the rooting of inequality in structures of production." When individualism is sanctioned as the foundation of selfhood, they surmise, class comes to be understood as yet another lifestyle choice.

In the context of a shift toward a neoliberal form of governance, the trendy dramas' lifestyle rhetoric was key in reconciling the growing dissonance between new governmental discourses on personal responsibility and older respect for hierarchy, social consensus, and mainstream consciousness. Lifestyle, individualism, and personal responsibility are keywords in the vocabulary of neoliberalism, and in the 1990s these concepts served to mobilize youth to accept new consumer and labor regimes, as well as shifting structures of exploitation (Arai 2006; Driscoll 2007). In this period, commercial television networks did not simply mediate socioeconomic changes. They simultaneously capitalized on them and were affected by them. The development of the trendy drama suggests that the revitalization of television in the recessionary 1990s was not simply a matter of ideological adjustment. In the wake of dramatic socioeconomic changes, television networks were struggling with their own problems. Thus, to preserve commercial television's central role in the domestic service economy, networks had to adjust their operations, the ways in which they pursued audiences, and the textual and stylistic norms they employed in their programs. Social and industrial factors were intimately intertwined in the development of trendy drama, and they played equally important roles in determining the ways in which these serials performed their transformational work on social anxieties and fantasies.

Television in the Era of Market Fragmentation

Television production remained a profitable business throughout the recession. The three largest commercial networks—Fuji, Tokyo Broadcasting System (TBS), and Nippon Television (NTV)—all invested fortunes in ex-

panding their headquarters in the 1990s, suggesting that the economic slump left the television industry's finances largely unaffected. Indeed, market fragmentation, which was a major headache for Japanese broadcasters, predated the recession. However, this is not to say that the economic slowdown had no impact on the television industry. The recession intensified the stratification of purchasing power, a trend that gave networks an additional incentive to listen more carefully to marketers who had already begun investing in media platforms that, unlike television, were capable of reaching more narrowly defined market segments. In the second half of the 1980s, television networks realized that the economic imperative of reaching the largest possible audience by offering them middle-of-the-road narrative entertainment was no longer a viable business strategy in the face of new demands for more versatile and customized entertainment. The challenge posed to mass media by market fragmentation was by no means unique to Japan. In the 1980s, the U.S. television industry was plagued by the same problem. (These are the two largest television industries in the world, and both are self-sustaining.) A brief critical analysis of the industrial context from a comparative perspective will illuminate how industrial structures become vital in determining which stories television professionals will tell, which character portrayals they will privilege, and which audience segments they will prioritize.

Although Japanese viewers have always had a significant preference for domestic programming, media globalization has posed an additional challenge to the Japanese television industry in the condition of market fragmentation. In the late 1980s, transnational media were increasingly interested in gaining a toehold in the lucrative Japanese market. As market diversification was intensifying, domestic networks faced the danger of losing to transnational media certain audience segments to which they could not offer more customized programming. Thus, to protect the Japanese market from transnational media, the Japanese television industry could not avoid undergoing structural adjustments to enable it to cater to more diversified domestic audiences. This is exactly how the Taiwanese television industry lost the lucrative local youth market to Japanese trendy dramas. Operating as a rigid system of mass production ill equipped to cater entertainment to the splintering local market, the Taiwanese television industry was slower than its Japanese counterpart in responding to market diversification and continued to produce family-oriented television

dramas for middle-aged housewives. In this context, young female Taiwanese viewers, who had become dynamic consumers to a degree similar to that of their Japanese peers, found themselves without local programming to watch.[9] It was in this vacuum that they turned to Japanese (and American) television dramas that carried fashion- and leisure-related information of interest to them.

A corresponding example is the favorable reception of the Korean drama *Winter Sonata* in Japan in 2004. It was broadcast on the national public broadcasting channel (NHK) in late-night hours, and its high ratings perplexed Japanese media critics because no foreign program had been successful in competing with domestic programming since the early 1960s. The most plausible explanation for the success of *Winter Sonata*, I have heard from Japanese media practitioners, is that this drama was popular among middle-aged women who felt marginalized in the 1990s, when most networks focused their attention on young single women. The popularity of Japanese drama serials in Taiwan and the sympathetic reception of a Korean serial in Japan confirm that, in the wake of market fragmentation, transnational media pose a very real threat even to self-sustaining national television industries.

The conflict between the diversification of consumer demands and the television industry's Fordist system of production was not specific to Japan. Fordism, the dominant mode of capital accumulation between the mid-1940s and the mid-1970s, designates a particular strategy that safeguards economic growth by integrating mass consumption and mass production. In the context of the United States, Fordist system of production also refers to a particular type of vertically integrated corporation in which a company maintains control over every aspect of the production process. For the Hollywood film industry specifically, this meant that the major studios controlled film production and distribution, in addition to owning the cinemas where their films were screened (Gomery 1986). Because these vertically integrated corporations held monopolies, they did not need to worry about consumer demand. This system, however, collapsed as a result of the antitrust ruling of 1948, which forced the studios to sell their theaters. The emergence of television at the same time offered a cheap and convenient alternative to going to the movies. This expansion in media entertainment, along with changes in lifestyles such as suburbanization, has engendered a simultaneous diversification in consumer taste

(Schatz 1997). While access to global markets arguably expanded the lifespan of Hollywood's Fordist production line of entertainment that was "the least objectionable to the largest number of viewers," mass-produced fare started losing its appeal for consumers with increasingly individualized tastes in the 1980s.

Hollywood's response, as Michael Wayne (2003) suggests, took the form of post-Fordist decentralized accumulation—namely, a shift from vertical to horizontal integration and the cultivation of synergies tying together different types of media and non-media industries within one parent company. Hollywood began as a single-sector industry (film only) and transformed into a dual-sector media industry (encompassing both film and television). Today it is the center of a multi-sector, integrated culture industry producing films, television programs, videos, books, comics, music soundtracks, computer games, theme parks, and merchandise. For example, by 2001 Disney—the third-largest media and entertainment corporation in the world after Time Warner and News Corporation—owned television and cable channels;[10] parks and resorts; studio entertainment in the realm of film, television, and video;[11] and consumer products, including merchandising and licensing of Disney products.[12]

In the mid-1980s, in response to the progressive splintering of audiences, the U.S. television industry started to experiment with horizontal integration, as well.[13] In the context of the television industry, horizontal integration takes the form of multi-channel narrowcasting. The Discovery Network, for example, now comprises the Learning Channel, Discovery Health, Animal Planet, the Science Channel, Discovery Kids, Discovery en Español, Planet Green, the Military Channel, Investigation Discovery, Turbo, HD Weather, and FitTV. This type of horizontal integration and niche targeting would not have been possible without the deregulation of program production and distribution, the first step toward which was the abolition of the so-called fin-syn (financial interest and syndication) rules in 1995. These rules prohibited networks from holding a stake in program ownership and having a financial stake in syndicating the programs they aired. It also limited the number of hours of programming per week that they could produce. The fin-syn rules were a way to separate program production and distribution and to create an environment in which networks made decisions about what to air based purely on content and not on their financial interests (Lotz 2007). As soon as the rules were eliminated, networks began

populating their schedules with shows purchased from studios they owned (e.g., NBC owns NBC Universal Television Studio) or from their affiliates. By allowing the networks to coordinate production and distribution again, the abolition of the fin-syn rules prepared the ground for horizontal integration, which in many respects is not unlike vertical integration (Schatz 1997).

Horizontal integration was the solution for Japanese commercial broadcasters, as well. Curiously, however, in the context of the Japanese television industry it did not come with the deregulation of program production and distribution. In many ways, Japanese television networks have retained their vertically integrated structure. Japanese networks own the production facilities where they produce what they air. These programs remain the property of the networks and will not be syndicated to other domestic networks. While Japanese broadcasters order feature-length narrative films from independent production studios, the films are also co-produced with television networks that assign their own producers to oversee the entire process, from casting through postproduction editing. Instead of the deregulation of program production and distribution, Japanese commercial broadcasters adopted horizontal integration in the late 1980s by expanding their business tie-ins and cross-branding practices with other media and leisure industries. Networks drew on older industrial practices to advance horizontal integration. On one hand, they capitalized on the *tarento* system—celebrities who perform in various media genres simultaneously—which worked miracles in increasing the appeal of television in the 1990s. On the other hand, networks redesigned their system of program slots (*wakugumi*), which enabled them to target distinctive subsets of viewers in particular time slots. The remodeled system of program slots also helped networks renegotiate the terms of domestic competition among themselves. In addition, they could make the argument to advertisers that while they offered them smaller segments of the consumer market, these segments were more precisely defined. Further, they stressed that while the target groups shrank, they consisted of loyal consumers, for "as you get narrower in interest, you tend to have more intensity of interest" (Mark Edmiston, the former president of Newsweek Inc., cited in Curtin 1996, 190). The tarento system and the system of program slots will be explored in chapters 1 and 3.

While the Japanese and the U.S. television industries adopted different

forms of horizontal integration to accommodate market fragmentation, some of the newly emerging textual norms, stylistic features, and audience priorities were strikingly similar in the two contexts. In both media environments, erosion of the audience (along with commercial-skipping technology such as TiVo and other digital video recorders) has made advertisers more concerned about the efficiency of conventional commercial formats. This skepticism, in turn, pressured networks to experiment with redrawing the line between advertising and entertainment content. Branded entertainment, for instance, refers to producers' embedding products into the content of a show, weaving messages of commercial nature within the script and scenery of the program (Sandler 2007). An example is the use of GMC Yukon Hybrids in the CBS series *CSI Las Vegas*. Instead of an intrusive promotion shoved in the face of audiences, this type of advertising is believed to be more appealing to viewers because it is seamlessly integrated into the content. Curiously, a particular version of branded entertainment —as we will see in the context of the development of the trendy drama— had become a mainstream practice in Japan in the late 1980s, as well. In both contexts, branded entertainment was accompanied by a more general emphasis on style over content. John Caldwell's theory of televisuality— the televisual culture of stylistic exhibitionism in the late 1980s United States—is pertinent here. He writes: "In several important programming and institutional areas, television moved from a framework that approached broadcasting primarily as a form of word-based rhetoric and transmission, with all the issues that such terms suggest, to a visually based mythology, framework, and aesthetic based on an extreme self-consciousness of style" (Caldwell 1995, 4). Caldwell sees stylistic opulence characteristic of late 1980s Hollywood as a strategy by which primetime producers tried to protect market share in the face of audience fragmentation and an increasingly competitive national market.

In the Japanese context, the new emphasis on style was also a strategy to draw to television style-conscious young women—the new affluent segment of the population that advertisers became interested in reaching in the late 1980s. This indeed is another commonalty between the U.S. and the Japanese television industries. In Amanda Lotz's opinion, the proliferation of female-centered dramas in the 1990s United States suggests that U.S. television networks started addressing the problem of market fragmentation by producing programs for *women* "because of the extent to

which they are and are not a niche" (Lotz 2006, 28). However, in the Japanese context, trendy dramas did not just target *women*. Rather, they were produced for *young single women*. In the late 1980s the primetime targeting of such a micro-niche by Japanese broadcasters seemed like a significant risk to take for large commercial broadcasters. In chapters 4 and 5 I explore why targeting this segment was the most reasonable way to introduce flexibility into the television industry's Fordist system of production. Although this section aims to attest to the relevance of a political economy approach to anthropological studies of television, chapters 4 and 5 will also highlight some of the limits of this approach and propose its integration with an ethnography of the socioeconomic context in which television is produced and consumed. In particular, these chapters will highlight that in the late 1980s Japanese commercial networks started targeting young women not simply because these viewers had appreciable disposable incomes. An equally pertinent factor in the networks' focus was that during this period young women occupied a privileged position in the discursive renegotiations of national subjectivity.

As with branded entertainment in the United States, style in trendy dramas, which had been "a mere signifier and vessel for content, issues, and ideas," itself became the "privileged and showcased signified" (Caldwell 1995, 5). The stylistic excess of trendy dramas spurred a shift in program production from an emphasis on stories (signification) to one on lifestyles (affect). Lifestyle-driven programs were not only more appealing to style-conscious young viewers; they were also more conducive to new forms of marketing. Just as important, lifestyle-driven shows played an important role in mediating the problematic of class in the 1990s—a period that witnessed the erosion of mass middle-class society. Trendy dramas not only forged new selves by offering new character portrayals; they also fostered new types of collectivities through new ways of pursuing viewers such as adopting psychographic targeting. While helping networks to acclimate to market fragmentation in the 1990s, the trendy drama was also vital in reestablishing television as a central cultural producer.

Fieldwork: Methodological and Theoretical Considerations

This book builds on twenty months of fieldwork among television professionals in the three largest Japanese commercial networks (Fuji, TBS, and NTV) and viewers of trendy drama in Tokyo between October 2001 and May 2003. I spent four years in Tokyo—from 1995 to 1997 and from 2001 to 2003. During my stay between 1995 and 1997, the popularity of the trendy drama peaked, and the fieldwork I started in 2001 corresponded to the period in which the phenomenon started to wane. The creator of the genre, Ōta Tōru (2004, 82), characterized the state of drama production in a 2001 interview: "the sea remains calm for a while after a big wave. I think now it is that windless time." I conducted my fieldwork during that windless time.

For a study with a focus on drama production, curiously, the eclipse of the genre turned out to be an advantage, because for television professionals the windless time was also the time for industrial self-analysis and self-reflection. As television producers were pondering how to increase ratings for their primetime programs, they were also heavily invested in analyzing the success of trendy dramas. As my interest lay in understanding how the trendy drama reinvented the Japanese television industry by mediating and capitalizing on the socioeconomic changes of the late 1980s and 1990s, the timing of my fieldwork turned out to be ideal. At the same time, research on a televisual genre whose popularity was waning prompted me to reconsider the adequacy of conventional fieldwork methods of gathering data for an anthropological study of television. To analyze the development of the trendy drama as rooted in a specific social and historical formation, I complemented traditional ethnographic fieldwork with collecting data from less conventional sources. Specifically, for this project I complemented structured and semi-structured interviews with television professionals with interviews with television professionals published in trade journals and popular magazines. Similarly, I complemented structured and semi-structured interviews with television viewers with comments posted by viewers about dramas on Internet bulletin boards and blog sites. In the course of my fieldwork, I conducted interviews with fourteen television professionals, each of whom worked as a producer or director for one of the three largest commercial networks. I also interviewed five freelance scriptwriters. In addition to the interviews, I conducted partici-

pant observation at TBS, where I was introduced to the structure of the television industry and to the basics of program production. Finally, I observed the creation of a drama serial by attending brainstorming sessions (*uchiawase*) one of my writer informants had with the producers.

Caldwell has noted that the tremendous labor television professionals invest in producing and distributing industrial self-analyses to the public complicates the practice of fieldwork in the context of the television industry. He writes: "The fact that the new industrial narcissus places so much of this self-consciousness on the screen, outside, and in public makes traditional scholarly questions about 'behind-the-scenes' or 'authentic' industry 'inside' seem rather beside the point" (Caldwell 2008, 1). Indeed, I have derived much inspiration and many ideas from trade journals; newspaper articles on dramas; interviews with television professionals that appeared in daily newspapers and weekly or monthly magazines; memoirs; and essay collections written by scriptwriters and producers. I gleaned bits and pieces of information on dramas and their makers not only from respectable trade journals but also by leafing through thousands of tabloid pages featuring sensationalist stories of celebrity scandals.

My study of audience reception was based on a sample of thirty-four female viewers and twelve male viewers, whom I met numerous times. I limited my sample to the target demographic, but my conversations with my informants were not confined to television dramas or to television more broadly. Because their informational value expires rapidly, and because their main selling point is not the story but information on the latest trends, trendy dramas are produced for one-time viewing. Reruns of trendy dramas are generally avoided and never occur during primetime; the dramas are rebroadcast only as promotions—for instance, as vignettes in a retrospective on the works of a particular celebrity cast in a new drama. By offering a rich archive of viewers' opinions on dramas over time, the Internet compensated for the fact that I was unable to interview viewers while they were watching the serials. I used Internet sources by assembling comments about particular dramas that I analyzed for recurrent themes and for commonalties with themes that emerged in my interviews with television viewers.

While many anthropologists have highlighted a rupture between scholarly work in their native countries and fieldwork somewhere else (see Marcus 1998), in many respects my fieldwork among television practi-

tioners was continuous with my life as an academic. Writing letters to producers asking them to meet me was not so very different from writing proposals requesting funding to conduct research. These letters had to be carefully crafted; they had to give a clear explanation of my project and highlight the aspects I wanted to discuss with interviewees. My interviews with television professionals took weeks to prepare. My interviewees wanted to receive my questions in advance, and I watched and re-watched their dramas to write questions that both advanced my research agenda and convinced my informants that it would be rewarding for them to carve time out of their already overloaded schedules to meet me.

I learned from my informants in drama production not only about their work, but also about their survival strategies in a highly competitive industry—an environment not dissimilar to that of North American academia. While I anticipated that fieldwork among people in positions of power would be stressful, contrary to my expectations I genuinely enjoyed working with television professionals. Television production in Japan is an environment in which only the smartest and toughest people endure. Most of the television professionals with whom I met were exceptionally bright. Going far beyond what I asked them to do, which was to provide me with information, they constantly pushed me to discuss my thesis with them. Some of them sent me long e-mails after our meeting, presenting me with new perspectives from which I could examine this complex business. For a fieldworker, it was an ideal working environment.

Similarly, the scriptwriters I met—all of them women—were remarkable individuals. I particularly admired the grace with which they negotiated the contradictions involved in doing creative work while striving to turn a profit. While producers and directors were full-time employees of television networks, scriptwriters were freelancers. Without any institutional safety net, writers were required to be not only extremely creative but also tremendously hardworking. One scriptwriter told me that once when she was working on a drama, she did not leave her apartment for a whole month. Most of my informants had similar stories of endurance, including eleven-hour brainstorming sessions, unstoppable nosebleeds, hernias, nervous breakdowns, and depression. Many of these female scriptwriters were very different from their target audiences. While female viewers seemed to appreciate stories concluding with the heroine's marriage to a socially

successful and handsome man (implying that they would become full-time homemakers), all of the scriptwriters I met lived on the income they earned. One of them told me that she found the Cinderella story, on which many trendy dramas were based, just pathetic. These women did not have trouble relating to me. They perceived us as similar: women who do not think about their work as an interim phase in life, eventually to end their careers to become stay-at-home mothers. (This has been the dominant life course for middle-class Japanese women in the postwar period.)

My research on television reception was a somewhat different experience from gathering information from television professionals. While drama workers were comfortable with interviews and typically came to our meetings prepared, many female viewers I met did not understand, at least at the outset, how someone could do serious research on something as unserious as television dramas. In other words, many of my informants wondered about, and in some cases straightforwardly questioned the suitability of, television dramas as the subject of academic research. They reasoned that work in general was boring and tedious, while dramas were fun and enjoyable. In other words, dramas were supposed to make one forget about work. It took me a while to understand that my relationship to my work was a sensitive issue to some of my informants. Most of my female interviewees had graduated from two-year women's colleges, which meant that the work available to them was not necessarily appealing. These women had no choice but to leave the business of moneymaking to their husbands. I realized that to be able to connect with my viewer informants, I had to be careful about how I spoke about work so as not to antagonize them and remind them of their vulnerability.

Although audience reception is not the focus of this study, I have learned crucial lessons from my conversations with viewers. My most pertinent observation was that viewers did not seem to enjoy discussing the stories of trendy dramas with me. They seemed more comfortable chatting about the tarento who were also the center of drama discussions on anonymous blog sites and other Internet-based drama forums. Indeed, I never ceased to be surprised by the massive amount of knowledge viewers acquired about the tarento. I was struck by the sheer volume of detail my informants could command about the personal and public lives of media celebrities. It was precisely this aspect of my reception research that directed my

attention toward the importance of lifestyle in trendy dramas and the ways that television professionals capitalized on the tarento system to heighten the emphasis on lifestyle.

Deriving inspiration from the anthropology of media that enjoyed some sort of a boom while I was designing my project (Ginsburg et al. 2002; Mankekar 1999), I began my fieldwork with an interest in how primetime dramas reproduced a sense of national community in the wake of dramatic socioeconomic changes in the 1990s. However, the first realization I reached was that this approach was not as seamlessly applicable to commercial television networks as it was to the government-controlled media on which anthropologists have primarily focused. Additionally, this analytical framework was not very helpful in a period in which the television industry itself was undergoing a transformation. The fact that television's industrial system was changing required me to step outside the field of anthropology and borrow analytical tools from other disciplines such as media studies. Yet an interest in how television produced certain subjectivities coupled with an understanding of media consumption as always embedded in a wide web of other social practices persistently distanced me from media studies. This position and this approach were less common among media scholars, who tend to be interested in people only insofar as they are engaged with media.

Anthropological studies of television, on the other hand, tend to privilege an interest in the viewers (and less often producers) of media, stressing that it is exactly a focus on "people and their social relations—as opposed to media texts or technology" (Ginsburg 1994, 13) that distinguishes an anthropological approach to media from other disciplinary approaches. Because "the strength of anthropology lies in its concern with people and lived practices" (Askew 2004, 2), even when anthropologists study people's engagement with media, they emphasize that media consumption is only one aspect of individuals' lives and it thus has to be analyzed in dialogue with other aspects of their informants' experiences. In anthropology, however, this focus on the consumers of media often comes together with a perception of media institutions as static entities that function as ideological apparatuses of governments.[14]

At the same time, anthropological studies of media assume television to be a mass medium and attribute much of its importance to this characteristic. Lotz (2007, 33) has noted that this understanding has had quite a

broad appeal in media and cultural studies, as well: "The notion of mass media and the scale of such businesses are important to political economy approaches examining the assemblage and distribution of labor and capital, while the mass audience was crucial to cultural approaches because of the necessity for programs to be widely shared within culture." Anthropologists have adopted this understanding, arguing that the significance of the medium was exactly that—as Michael Curtin (1996, 181) put it—it provided a common hearth where people gathered "both to be warmed by popular entertainment and to reflect upon the most pressing issues of the day" (see also Askew 2004; Dickey 1997; Ginsburg et al. 2002; Spitulnik 1993). For instance, in mapping the field of what she calls the anthropology of culture and media, Faye Ginsburg (1994, 9) considers "visual media as distinctive artifacts through which the societies and cultures that produce them are reproduced and contested or changed." Inspired by Benedict Anderson's work on the role of print media in the construction of imagined communities (1983)—most notably, the nation-state—anthropological projects on television often draw on the assumption that the study of television is also the study of the nation (Mankekar 1999; Abu-Lughod 2005; Wilk 2002). It seems to me, however, that Curtin (1996, 185) has a point when he argues that television as a mass medium is "a symptomatic expression of a social order built upon a historically specific form of capitalism." This observation brings me to an obvious but nevertheless noteworthy claim: television is not static. Further, as media scholars have emphasized, television's mode of production has had an impact on the politics of television (including stylistic and narrative forms and strategies of pursuing audiences) that we cannot neglect. "The production base," Caldwell (1995, 7) writes, "is both a product of shifting cultural and economic needs and a factor that affects how we receive and utilize television."

My argument that the development of the trendy drama was symptomatic of a shift from narrative- to lifestyle-oriented entertainment has derived from my observation that the tarento were not only central to drama producers; they were also the main source of pleasure for viewers. In other words, I would not have seen this connection without bringing the sites of drama production and audience reception into the same frame of study. By highlighting that the key source of enjoyment in watching dramas is not primarily the dramas' narrative arc but, rather, the information provided on consumer trends, I aim to underline the limitations inherent in the

popular approach that focuses on analyzing ideologies encoded in mass culture for understanding agency and pleasure.[15] In studies of television, agency is often equated with the power of television professionals to encode messages in their programs (Hall 1980 [1973]; Morley 1980). Agency is also understood as the ability of viewers to make choices in decoding meanings within the semiotic confines of televisual texts. In chapters 2 and 4, I aim to show that in a media economy in which the line between entertainment and advertising is increasingly blurred, agency cannot be understood without going beyond a focus on the text and without bringing audience reception and program production into dialogue with each other.

I alluded previously to the intimate relationship between Fordist media production and the approach that centers on analyzing mass culture for ideological content. Here, I want to suggest that in the same way that post-Fordist production strives "toward a continual interactivity or rapid communication between production and consumption" (Hardt and Negri 2000, 290), research on post-Fordist media requires a more dynamic analytical framework that links these two realms. Because it could count on stable demand, Fordism was based on a unidirectional flow of communication between production and consumption. Post-Fordism, on the other hand, is based on the idea that production planning is constantly informed by fresh data on market conditions, and commodities will be produced according to the most recent demands of the market. In the fields of media studies and cultural anthropology, television production and reception have been examined separately (Ang 1985; Davila 2001; Dornfeld 1998; Morley 1992). This trend reflects an understanding of television as a mass medium whose producers and consumers are not in dialogue with one another. My study of the trendy drama, however, illustrates that the growing need for mediation between production and reception leads to an increasing degree of interdependence between these realms.[16] Trendy dramas depart from their predecessors in that their producers increasingly engage viewers in program production. I will show that by involving viewers in drama production, television networks appropriate the power to draw the parameters within which viewers will find the programs pleasurable. I do not question the capability of viewers to decode televisual texts in ways unintended by their producers. I do, however, aim to highlight the fact that in the era of lifestyle-driven, post-textual televisual production, the crucial site of conflict over meaning—what Stuart Hall (1980 [1973])

called semiotic warfare—previously located between producers and viewers has moved to the realm of program production, which has become the primary ground where dominant values and subjectivities are contested and reproduced. Further, I suggest that the relationship between producers and viewers should be understood not as semiotic warfare but as a semiotic game.

Although a concern with Japan and Japaneseness is not as central to my study as it has been to many other ethnographic studies of Japan, I consider this book to be in dialogue with Japan studies.[17] The trendy drama is less amenable to a discussion of Japaneseness than other popular cultural forms such as *enka* (sentimental songs reminiscent of the traditional *min'yō* genre) or as the all-female Takarazuka Revue. The former has been more explicitly mobilized in the public construction of Japaneseness (Yano 2003), while the latter was deployed "as a powerful instrument in forging a national culture" (Robertson 1998, 91). In trendy dramas, Japaneseness is not invoked in the same way. In fact, the genre is produced for a segment of the population, young single women, who in the 1990s were commonly derided for their antipatriotic attitudes and were represented in the popular media as the nemesis of the salaryman—the emblem of national prosperity.

While this book does not prioritize a focus on the construction of a nation and its subjects, it does suggest that the trendy dramas generate a space where viewers gain an understanding of the communities to which they belong in terms of the codes they share as consumers. Néstor García Canclini (2001, 43) has written: "The definition of a nation, for example, is given less at this stage by its territorial limits or its political history. It survives, rather, as an interpretive community of consumers." In Japan, where protectionist trade policies tend to eradicate the distinction between the concepts of the nation-state and the national market, the consumption of information on local consumer trends presented by domestic media revives and reinforces membership in the national community. In other words, by enabling their viewers to participate in Japanese consumer culture, trendy dramas become venues for viewers to embrace a form of membership that resonates with García Canclini's (2001) notion of consumer citizenship. For instance, while abroad young women continue to watch Japanese trendy dramas to stay informed on the current consumer and cultural trends in Japan. This practice suggests that trendy dramas did enable young female viewers to think of themselves as members of the

Japanese national community and to cultivate an emotional connection to their homeland.

The Outline of the Book

Chapter 1 situates trendy drama within the postwar history of Japanese television broadcasting and highlights how television producers started capitalizing on the tarento system in tandem with the development of this new genre. The tarento perform in various entertainment genres simultaneously, and accordingly they are over-exposed to viewers, who thus enjoy "intimate" relationships with them. At the same time, they also serve as lucrative sources of profit for media corporations as they make top-down forms of media convergence possible; their cross-genre and transmedia deployment functions to expand revenue opportunities and reinforce viewers' commitment to media institutions (see Jenkins 2006a). Chapter 1 will thus argue that the Japanese television industry has reinvented itself for the post-Fordist era by producing a new type of flexible commodity (more precisely, image commodity[18]), the tarento. As the tarento gained primacy in media production, a new media economy emerged in which these celebrities became the links between media institutions. At the same time, the transmedia circulation of the tarento has generated an intimate televisual culture that viewers enjoyed as a source of stability in the wake of massive socioeconomic changes.

By analyzing the failure of a drama titled *Dokushin Seikatsu* (Single Lives; TBS, 1999), chapter 2 investigates the connection between the new emphasis on the tarento in drama production and the shift from story-based programming to lifestyle-oriented entertainment. *Single Lives* was based on one of the most controversial murder cases in Japan in the 1990s. In March 1997, a career woman was found strangled in downtown Tokyo. Police investigations revealed that she lived a double life: she was a female executive by day and a sex worker by night. This chapter shows that while the producer aimed to offer story-driven entertainment centering on a critique of gender discrimination, such a message did not appeal to or reach the target audience. My audience survey concludes that it was not the story line that drew women to the drama. Rather, the audience mainly focused on the tarento and whether their roles in *Single Lives* suited their private and screen personas. This chapter will examine why viewers find

the tarento to be the most appealing aspect of television dramas and how this post-textual pleasure forces us to reconsider the dominant understanding of agency in television studies.

Chapter 3 turns to the analysis of the "young female scriptwriter boom" in the 1990s. In parallel with the development of trendy dramas, an increasing number of young female scriptwriters entered the television business. I suggest that this trend illustrates the growing interdependence between drama production and reception. While the new target audiences were young single women holding non-career-track positions, producers and directors (overwhelmingly male) were career-track employees of elite media corporations. Young female writers were employed to serve as translators between male producers and young female viewers. In the fields of media studies and cultural anthropology, television production and reception have been treated as separate analytical categories, and agency has been analyzed in terms of how viewers negotiate or resist the meanings proposed to them by the culture industries. By contrast, this chapter aims to highlight the fact that in the era of post-Fordist televisual production, the crucial site of struggle for meaning, previously located between producers and viewers, has shifted to the realm of program production.

Chapter 4 centers on love dramas (*ren'ai dorama*), the most popular subgenre of trendy drama until the late 1990s. I argue that love dramas tapped into and reinforced the so-called parasite single subjectivity—young single women who live with their parents to maximize their disposable income. As these young women have "grown up" to become the wealthiest and savviest consumers of the past two decades, they have also become the target of an impassioned neo-nationalist discourse that blames them for the dwindling birthrate, the crisis in the construction business, and, ultimately, the economic recession. At the same time, the service sector, including the television industry, is making enormous profits targeting these young single women. This chapter demonstrates that trendy dramas reproduce the contradictions within which single women are enmeshed in contemporary Japan: while these dramas encourage their viewers to become elite consumers, in reality young women nonetheless remain marginalized from the normative world of work and wage labor. However, I will also show that female viewers are quick to learn how to benefit from the new post-Fordist media economies. They enjoy love dramas via the tarento, who become positive role models of social success for them by

suggesting that style (a function of consumer professionalism) is indeed the key to self-determination.

Chapter 5 examines another subgenre, the so-called work drama (*oshigoto dorama*) that networks started to produce more intensively in the late 1990s. By then, the love dramas' portrayal of young men and women preoccupied with their love lives seemed increasingly incongruous with the prolonged economic recession and the concomitant socioeconomic transformation, both of which produced much anxiety and uncertainty about the future. A common thread in interviews with the producers of workplace dramas is that this new subgenre aimed to reintroduce the notion of "socially responsible entertainment" (*shakaisei wo obita entāteinmento*) into commercial broadcasting. Although this seems to challenge my claim that trendy dramas are emblematic of the massive commercialization of the televisual medium in the 1990s, in chapter 5 I argue that what producers called "social responsibility" was indeed a successful strategy to draw a new audience segment to television—namely, young male viewers, who previously had not been keen on watching trendy dramas. Here I focus on the highly popular workplace drama *Shomuni*, whose heroine, I assert, became a positive role model for many male viewers, mainly because she was persistent in making the best of her job and having fun while doing it. I argue that the heroines of workplace dramas reconciled a deepening conflict between the old work ethic of the postwar period and the new spirit of consumerism of the 1980s. Specifically, while employers expected young men to devote their lives to their companies, marketing discourses, especially from the mid-1980s, encouraged self-centeredness. Workplace dramas managed to draw a new audience segment to the medium precisely because they successfully mediated the breakdown of the dominant postwar divide between the "female consumer" and the "male producer." Equally important, by reintroducing values such as fun and individualism into the realm of wage labor, workplace dramas such as *Shomuni* offered labor fantasies that made neoliberal initiatives for individual responsibilization more palatable in conditions in which corporations were increasingly forced to reform the country's unique human-resource-management system.

Chapter 6 explores the overseas travel of trendy dramas. Here I probe the central argument of this book within a global context. I suggest that market fragmentation not only has transformed national television industries, but it has also reconfigured transnational cultural power by greatly diversifying

the transborder flows of television content. I demonstrate this by analyzing the global circulation of *J-dorama* (trendy drama abroad). I argue that the globalization of Japanese cultural commodities in the 1990s reflects a marked shift in Japan's place in the U.S. and European imagination at the dawn of the new millennium. Unlike earlier generations of Japanese popular-culture commodities that Western audiences consumed without knowing or caring much about the programs' origins, what characterizes the Japanese cultural exports of the 1990s (such as J-dorama) is that their consumers cultivate an interest in the place and context of these programs. My case study of the transnational distribution of Japanese dramas thus sheds light on a new configuration of global cultural order. At the same time, the dominantly illegal overseas reproduction and distribution of J-dorama illustrates an under-explored aspect of cultural globalization. Namely, it shows that in the wake of rapid developments in media distribution technology and intensifying flows of people across national boundaries, de-centered and alternative (bottom-up) practices of media circulation have come to complement the centralized (top-down) mode of distribution that had previously characterized international television trade.

Finally, in the epilogue I revisit my discussion of the image commodity. While the book analyzes the development of the image commodity in a particular national framework, the epilogue will resituate my discussion in a broader context. It argues that the development of the image commodity in Japan in the 1990s was not an isolated phenomenon but an example that illuminates how intangible commodities are gradually succeeding tangible goods as the new motors of advanced capitalist economies. Previous chapters describe various reasons that intangible commodities became the new center of economic gravity in recent decades. The epilogue focuses on a particular aspect of the image commodity—its capacity for affective capture. It highlights that while the mobilization of affects has always been paramount to the operation of the culture industries, the centrality of the image commodity to post-Fordist media economies suggests that the culture industries are less and less timid about exploiting the potential for value to be produced from the manipulation of affective capacity. Here, at last, I stress that this trend calls for new analytical tools that, unlike theories of signification, are capable of registering and theorizing the primacy of affect in the production and reception of televisual entertainment.

One

Intimate Televisuality

TELEVISION DRAMAS AND THE TARENTO IN POSTWAR JAPAN

Scholars have argued that Japanese television networks' success in creating a "partial substitute for vanishing communal forms of entertainment turned Japan into the ultimate TV culture" (Morris-Suzuki 1994, 195).[1] As a particular feature of this televisual culture, Japanese tarento serve as hosts, guests, and contestants in game shows; participate in variety shows; perform in television dramas; release compact discs; and endorse commodities in commercials. Producers fortify the transmedia employment of the tarento by commonly casting them in dialogue with their earlier performances. For instance, the television drama *Keizoku* (Beautiful Dreamer; TBS, 1999) features a detective sidekick whose hobby is ballroom dancing. This aspect does not add much to the drama's plot except the pleasure of recognizing that Tokui Yū, the actor playing this character, had previously been cast in the hit movie featuring ballroom dancing *Shall We Dance?*[2] This cross-genre and transmedia employment of the tarento turns

television watching into a process of moving between programs and leads to the production and reception of meaning in a network of texts, genres, and media forms. The game of encoding and decoding not only renders program production more enjoyable for the producers, but it also makes participation in domestic media culture more pleasurable for the audiences. Further, the cross-genre and transmedia circulation of the tarento creates a culture of intimate televisuality,[3] participation in which generates a vital sense of membership in a nationally based televisual community.

As a new global division of labor was emerging in the media economy and media ownership was becoming more concentrated in the 1990s, nationally based television production and consumption declined worldwide. However, the Japanese television industry has not only managed to reinforce its self-sustaining business structure; it has also joined the ranks of global cultural exporters. (I analyze the latter phenomenon in chapter 6.) This chapter explores how Japanese commercial networks reinforced their self-sufficient system of production and centrality in the Japanese media economy in a business environment destabilized primarily by market fragmentation and secondarily by globalization. While Japanese viewers started demanding more custom-tailored entertainment, the domestic television industry could not easily adopt niche targeting, because it depended on large-scale consumer markets to finance its highly capital-intensive system of production. However, with conventional primetime formats such as family-oriented, historical, or mystery dramas, the local commercial networks were decreasingly able to unite the viewers in front of their television screens and thus to deliver the ratings their sponsors expected.[4] By the mid-1980s, audience erosion and the concomitantly shrinking viewing rates had led to a structural crisis in the television industry.

The development of a new primetime genre, the trendy drama, played a key role in resolving this crisis. By placing the tarento system at the heart of program production, trendy dramas succeeded not only in reviving a general interest in domestic televisual culture, but also in keeping transnational media out of the domestic market. The tarento made domestic programming more appealing to Japanese viewers than international shows available on cable channels whose celebrities did not carry the same informational value to them. As the tarento gained primacy in television production, a new media economy emerged in which these celebrities be-

came the links through which new tie-ins were established between media institutions.[5] Thus, by accelerating the flow of media content and integrating formerly unrelated markets,[6] the tarento system helped networks reinforce viewers' commitment to local television networks and other local media producers. The collaborative relationships between media institutions operated on the logic of cross-media branding in which endorsement by the tarento at once served the interests of client brands, host media, and the client tarento.

By exploring how and why the television industry adopted the tarento system as the new center of its economic activities, this chapter examines how the subsequently emerging media economy mediated social realities and relationships and forged new kinds of subjectivities in the process. As the tarento system gained primacy in television production, programs increasingly became vehicles for the transmission of information *about the tarento*. It is through such practices of accumulating knowledge about the local celebrities that a culture of intimate televisuality has evolved. I argue that in the wake of the prolonged economic recession, intimate televisuality has offered a sense of comfort and familiarity that effectively compensated for the erosion of older forms of solidarity and community. At the same time, I will suggest that as the tarento became more important to rendering everyday realities intelligible, the culture of intimate televisuality has simultaneously reified human relationships and social life.

Television Broadcasting in Japan

Japanese television networks became self-sufficient in the postwar period, and such independence was an important precondition for the development of the tarento system. Nippon Hōsō Kyōkai (Japanese Broadcasting System; NHK) and Nippon TV (NTV) began broadcasting in 1953. Black-and-white television sets were among the first three privileged items of mass consumption in the 1950s,[7] yet in 1957 only 5.1 percent of the Japanese households owned television sets. As the price of a set was twenty times higher than an average monthly income, few households could afford one. In the 1960s, the rapid increase in television ownership was partly the result of NTV's aggressive efforts to popularize the medium. NTV placed television sets in railway stations and plazas, where crowds congregated; giant television screens are still a prominent feature of downtown land-

scapes in Tokyo. Steady economic growth and rising wages encouraged the development of a mass consumer market that, in turn, brought down the price of television sets. In 1964, when the eighteenth Olympic Games were held in Tokyo, 87.8 percent of Japanese households owned black-and-white television sets, and by 1975, 91.7 percent of the population's households had color television sets.[8] By 1975, the total amount of advertising fees paid to television had surpassed advertising spent on newspapers, and television had become the leading medium in advertising. It has held that position to the present. By the mid-1970s, Japan had become the second-largest television market outside the United States (Iwabuchi 2002). Currently, 49 million Japanese households own 100 million television sets, which mainly provide their viewers with domestic programming.

Japanese television broadcasting consists of two types: commercial and public. NHK, the main public channel, is legally independent of the government and covers its operational costs from subscription fees.[9] NHK is divided into two networks, one of which, NHK Sōgō (General) broadcasts news, cultural, and entertainment programs. The other, NHK Kyōiku (Educational), airs mainly educational programming such as language classes, cooking programs, and shows for children.[10] This book focuses on commercial television broadcasting, the main networks of which in Tokyo are Fuji TV, part of Fuji News Network; Tokyo Broadcasting System (TBS), part of the Japan News Network; Nippon TV, part of Nippon News Network; TV Asahi, part of the All-Nippon News Network; and TV Tokyo, part of TV Tokyo Network. Each television network has a nationwide network and a key station based in Tokyo. The majority of the 127 terrestrial television broadcasters nationwide are affiliated with these five stations.[11]

The domestication of program production was a relatively rapid process in Japan. Until the early 1960s, television networks had lacked sufficient expertise and facilities to produce their own programs; they relied instead on imported programming and on domestic film studios such as Tōhō, Shōchiku, Daiei, Tōei, Nikkatsu, and Shin-Tōhō. Yet with the growth of contracts for television subscriptions, the popularity of cinema declined, and in 1956 this trend prompted the Japan Motion Picture Association to foreclose the transference of broadcasting rights for domestically produced films to television networks.[12] Film studios also stipulated that actors and actresses who were under contracts to them could not appear in television programs without permission.

As a result, television networks lost a precious source of programming and had no other choice but to import television programs, mainly from the United States. American television programs such as *Father Knows Best* (broadcast by NTV from 1958) and *I Love Lucy* (broadcast by NHK from 1957) formed a large part of primetime broadcasting in the late 1950s and early 1960s. Beginning in the 1960s, however, television networks began to develop their own programming. The five major film studios did not hold out long in the face of the rapidly growing popularity of television. As early as 1963, they resumed selling films to television networks, and began to subcontract their actors and actresses to them. By 1981, Japan imported less than 5 percent of programming annually, 90 percent of which was from the United States. By the 1990s, television networks imported less than 3 percent of their programming. The primary source of program imports has remained the United States (Hara 2004; Iwabuchi 2002, 2004).

Satellite and cable broadcasting have not succeeded in challenging domestic television networks. Japan Satellite Broadcasting (JSB) launched its service in 1984 and commenced full-scale broadcasting in 1991, but it did not turn a profit until 1995. Since that time, the increase in the number of subscribers has remained slow. As of 2000, JSB had only 2.5 million subscribers. SKY PerfecTV, another cable-television provider, started full-scale digital broadcasting in 1996 and provides access to more than sixty channels. In 2000, SKY PerfecTV had 2 million subscribers. In 2000, cable-television suppliers were serving a total of 9.5 million households—that is, 20 percent of households nationwide.[13] In many cases, however, this system has been used primarily to improve the reception of regular TV channels in areas suffering from interference. As mountainous areas occupy most of Japan's territory, bad television reception has long been a problem for many households. In sum, it is the public television service, NHK, and the five commercial television networks that most viewers watch.

The genre of the serialized television drama has played a vital role in developing and maintaining a self-contained televisual culture, for it has been the backbone of primetime entertainment throughout the postwar period. In the next section, I will map the postwar history of television drama to foreground my investigation of how the tarento began to gain primacy in television production in the late 1980s. Here I depart from anthropological studies of television that have analyzed this medium predominantly as an ideological apparatus of the state (Abu-Lughod 2005;

Mankekar 1999). Arguing that in Japan the television industry is a vibrant sector of the national economy, I situate my analysis of the history of television dramas at the intersection of culture and capitalism. By centering my analysis on drama production in postwar Japan, I aim to show that ideological and economic interests are intricately intertwined and implicated in the ways in which television has mediated social realities and forged new subjectivities. Television producers commonly strive to portray realities in ways that are most agreeable to the broadest cross-segments of the audiences. They also try to feature characters in their programs that the largest number of viewers will find appealing. By reinforcing dominant visions of normalcy, television fulfills an ideological function. Yet this objective also serves an economic end, for it functions to maximize viewership (and raise the ratings).

Television Dramas in the Postwar Period

Television dramas are mainly produced for the primetime slots. Networks invest the most capital in these programs, for they are aired in the hours when the most viewers are available to watch television and networks gross the largest revenues from advertising. This is when commercial fees are the highest. At the same time, primetime programs provide the most cultural cache (Lotz 2007) and hence serve as a powerful vehicle for branding. Working on the premise that primetime television dramas were a space where the dominant values and role models were contested and reworked, histories of this genre blended into social histories of the postwar period (Hirahara et al. 1991; Sanuka 1978; Toriyama 1993). Similarly, feminist analyses have used television dramas to trace changing gender roles and relations by analyzing how women are represented in these programs (Iwao 2000; Muramatsu and Gossmann 1998). I draw on these works, but my interest in the genre is different. I am concerned with the ways in which the televisual production of certain subjectivities is also an effect of how the television industry adjusts its business structure in response to changing patterns of consumption. The key questions are thus: who are the preferred audiences, and what thematic or programming strategies are engaged to reach these viewers?[14] By analyzing changes in thematic foci and programming strategies, I will concentrate on the shift from offering story-intensive entertainment to wide-ranging audiences to at-

tracting diversified audiences by offering them lifestyle-based programming that capitalizes on the tarento system.

In Japan, television drama was recognized as an art form in 1959, when the Art Festival established a separate category for this genre. Contemporary drama professionals often speak nostalgically, pointing out that in early television dramas the entertainment value and the imperative to maximize markets did not enjoy primacy over educational content. A case in point is *Watashi wa Kai ni Naritai* (I Want to Become a Shellfish; TBS, 1958).[15] The drama portrays a small-town barber who is arrested by American occupation authorities on a wartime murder charge. He confesses that he did kill an American soldier, but in his defense he argues that he was following orders, which at the time had to be obeyed as if they had come directly from the emperor. In the end, he is convicted and executed. Undoubtedly, this story line was not meant to provide lightweight entertainment to draw broad cross-segments of the audiences to the screen. The producers emphasized that their goal, first and foremost, was to educate viewers on the social ramifications of Japan's involvement in the Second World War (Sanuka 1978, 13–16).

Television had become a mass medium by the beginning of the 1960s, as Japan entered a period of high economic growth and the number of television subscriptions (to NHK) rose to ten million (Hirahara et al. 1991).[16] Consequently, business interests and corporate politics started to take precedence over artistic expression. In the 1960s, an upheaval in television censorship supported by rightist social groups, politicians, and commercial sponsors took place. An example is *Hitorikko* (Only Child; RKB [Radio Kyushu Broadcasting, now RKB Mainichi Broadcasting Corporation], 1962),[17] which portrays a family that lost a son to the war. The ultranationalist father takes pride in his loss, while the mother secretly believes that her son's death was a waste. Family tension reaches a fever pitch when the second son announces that he will enter the National Defense Academy, a decision the mother opposes. Responding to pressure from the Japanese Self-Defense Forces, Toshiba withdrew its sponsorship of the drama.[18] For the period 1962–66, Hirahara Hideo lists twenty-six more cases of canceled episodes, postponed broadcast schedules, and censorial editing (Hirahara et al. 1991, 61–65).[19]

I understand the development of home drama from the early 1960s as the maturation of the genre into a full-blown mass commodity. The early

home dramas peaked in 1964, when *Shichinin no Mago* (Seven Grandchildren; TBS) and *Tadaima Jūichinin* (Now Counting Eleven; TBS) were broadcast.[20] Borrowing heavily from narrative formulas of imported American serials such as *Father Knows Best*, in which the father character was at the center of the program (Hirahara et al. 1991, 113–16), both serials portray the everyday lives of large families with strong, central father characters who play crucial roles in resolving family conflicts (Painter 1996; Sakamoto 1997). These dramas were clearly out of sync with social realities that were determined by the massive youth migration to urban centers that had led to the decline of extended families, the decrease in the birthrate, and the increasing absence of fathers—the primary wage earners—from the domestic sphere.

I suggest that the reason for the discrepancy between reality and televisual fiction lies in the shifting mode of drama production and consumption—namely, in the maturation of mass production and consumption. In 1964, the Olympic Games were held in Tokyo, triggering a rapid increase in the sales of television sets. By that time, television had become the largest mass medium, and television professionals had to find ways to satisfy the rapidly increasing demands for programming. As a result, in 1964 prime-time dramas went from a half hour to an hour long; the doubling of the broadcasting time for each program necessitated more complex and easy-to-continue stories to fill the extended airtime. A viable strategy to raise the number of conflicts, climaxes, and story lines was to increase the number of characters (family members, number of children) featured in a drama. At the same time, portraying multigenerational families enabled producers to address and target diverse generations of viewers by featuring characters of different ages. In these ways, the home drama was capable of uniting the whole family in front of the television screen.

Reflecting on the absence of fathers in the domestic sphere in the period of high economic growth, the new dramas managed to shrink the gap between reality and televisual fiction by placing the mother at the center of the family. In *Kimottama Kāsan* (Mother Intrepid; TBS, 1968–72),[21] the heroine is a widow running a noodle (*soba*) shop and raising her son alone. In *Ohayō* (Good Morning; TBS, 1972), the heroine's husband has disappeared, but she continues to take care of her mother-in-law and run the family's restaurant alone.[22] *Jikan desu yo!* (It's Time! TBS, 1965, 1970–71, 1973–74) is set in a public bath.[23] The heroine is married, but she is the

main breadwinner. Portraying women-centered households was more in sync with postwar social tendencies. These included a gendered division of labor mandating that men work outside the household to earn a family wage and the expectation that women would become full-time homemakers assuming full responsibility for the upbringing and education of their children. While making programs that felt somewhat more realistic to viewers than the earlier dramas had was an important selling point, I believe that this thematic shift in drama production was the first sign of the feminization of the genre, which was itself a response to women's growing role as consumers. While these home dramas addressed multiple generations simultaneously, their primary target audiences became housewives, and they featured the same segment of the population in the lead roles.

Histories of television drama have labeled the 1970s the period of "anti-home dramas," in which dramas increasingly became preoccupied with the dissolution of the family. I understand this phenomenon as the last attempts of television networks to recuperate television drama as a mass commodity, a genre targeted to families as viewing units. Yamada Taichi's *Sorezore no Aki* (Everyone's Own Autumn; TBS, 1973) portrays the Niijima family, who seemingly live an average, middle-class life. But it turns out that no one in the family is what he or she appears to be. The father is involved with the mafia, while the eldest son gets his girlfriend pregnant but does not take responsibility, leading her to attempt suicide. The second son molests girls on trains, and the youngest daughter joins a gang of female delinquents. Similarly, in *Kishibe no Arubamu* (Riverside Album; TBS, 1977), Yamada, the scriptwriter, portrays a family that fulfills its dreams to own a house on the banks of the Tama River. Yet only material goods (such as a house) bind the family together. The house is destroyed in a typhoon, and the fragility of the familial institution that it housed comes to the surface. The mother is cheating on the father, the father is about to be laid off, and the daughter is pregnant with the child of a foreigner who does not wish to assume the role of father. Even while these dramas capitalized on the crisis of the family, they nevertheless continued to target families as their audience.[24]

The scriptwriter Kamata Toshio's *Kin'yōbi no Tsumatachi e* (For Friday Wives; TBS, 1983) is said to be one of the earliest forerunners of the trendy drama. Familial relationships are absent from the drama's representational system, and it is the first that is not intended for family viewing. The

drama portrays the lives of three women living in a suburban apartment complex (*danchi*), and the main themes are friendship, love, and adultery. Similarly, Yamada Taichi's *Fuzoroi no Ringotachi* (Odd Apples; TBS, 1983) centers on the lives of college students. Finally, Kamata's *Danjo Shichinin Natsu Monogatari* (The Summer Story of Seven Men and Women; TBS, 1986) was also aimed at younger viewers, as it dealt with themes such as friendship and love and featured young characters.

Producers for the Fuji Network often point out that *The Summer Story of Seven Men and Women* gave them the idea to produce trendy dramas (Ōta 1996). The new dramas originally aimed to appeal to women from the ages of eighteen to thirty-four, but curiously, the ratings went up to 30 percent, indicating audience interest far beyond the primary targets. One explanation is that young women came to occupy a privileged position in the popular imaginary in the late 1980s. Watching trendy dramas was to enjoy —if only vicariously—the lifestyle young women represented, which embodied attributes such as a relaxed attitude toward work and a vigorous enjoyment of life. This, however, is just a partial explanation for the success of the new dramas. The producers of trendy dramas also integrated various business strategies to make the new genre appealing to viewers. As producers replaced a mass commodity with a niche product, they made sure that they would reach a wealthy segment of the audiences whose smaller numbers were offset by their well-above-average purchasing power. (In the late 1980s, young women were the most dynamic segment of the consumer market; thus, they were the viewers most highly prized by advertisers.) At the same time, the growing number of cross-media partnerships facilitated by the tarento was also an efficient strategy to reach viewers beyond the target audience, as these new forms of synergy helped to develop predictable and lucrative economies of scale. While the new dramas did not entirely supplant older genres such as mystery, historical, and home dramas, they attracted the largest capital investments and garnered the highest ratings.

Trendy Dramas: Toward Flexible Accumulation?

David Harvey's analysis of the shift from Fordist to post-Fordist production helps to understand the dilemmas Japanese television, a quintessential system of mass production, has faced in the era of progressive market

fragmentation. Fordist production, the dominant mode of capital accumulation between 1945 and 1973, entailed the rationalization of technology and division of labor that yielded dramatic gains in productivity. In the Fordist system, mass production was coupled with mass consumption; wages were raised to a level that allowed workers to purchase the commodities they were producing, which, in turn, brought down their prices and created mass demand for them. While this system was predicated on steady growth, the rigidity of long-term and large-scale fixed capital investments in mass-production systems would in time slow growth, leading to a crisis in the early 1970s that would pave the way for flexible accumulation (Harvey 1990).

In the case of Japan, Tessa Morris-Suzuki (1988) describes a shift from large-scale, standardized production systems and mass consumption to small-scale, diversified production and the fragmentation of markets. During the 1950s and 1960s, the steady high growth (annual gross national product above 10 percent) was a result of a number of factors, such as a large and flexible source of wage labor from the agricultural sector; the relatively small ratio of dependents to a large workforce; access to ready-made technology from the United States and Western Europe; and favorable trading agreements (Bretton Woods and the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade) that gave Japan access to large Western markets. Morris-Suzuki argues that it was because of the simultaneous crumbling of all of these factors that the Japanese economy started to slow down from 1965 onward. Automation and computerization were strategies to overcome the recession, as they were crucial to link the previously separate areas of planning, control, production, and distribution into a total system.[25] As a result, much more flexible relationships could be established between demand and supply, and the age of mass production gave way to small-scale manufacturing of a wider variety of goods for diversified markets.

While mass consumption and television once coexisted symbiotically, the fragmentation of consumer markets has undermined the primacy of mass marketing and, by extension, of the television industry.[26] Marketers are aware that television is less capable of demographic targeting than, for example, the Internet. Since the Internet is interactive, it enables marketers to gather personal information directly from consumers and adjust their sales pitches accordingly. In other words, when marketers use the Internet as an advertising platform, they have a better understanding of

what they are getting for their payment. Television can only deliver the ratings (i.e., how many people watched a program) as opposed to more accurate consumer profiles (i.e., who actually watched a show). At the same time, the excessive costs of primetime-program production (especially that of scripted dramas) make advertising on television more expensive than advertising on any other content-providing medium. However, for the spiraling commercial fees—networks have to charge to offset the spiraling production costs—advertisers demand high viewing rates, preferably over the 15–20 percent range (15 million–20 million viewers). These figures are hard to deliver, as it is less and less viable to make programs that will be equally enjoyable for different generations, genders, and taste groups of viewers who are increasingly vocal in demanding their own niche entertainment. For these reasons, market diversification had become a crucial dilemma for television networks by the mid-1980s.[27]

At the same time, in the era of flexible accumulation, advertising has grown to be a dynamic sector of the economy due to the proliferation of goods whose lifespan was gradually decreasing. Thus, to tap the booming advertising business, television producers had to find ways to unite viewers with diverse taste preferences in front of the screen so that they could deliver ratings to their sponsors that justified the skyrocketing fees they charged for commercial time. It was clear that stories were too thematically specific to appeal to various cross-segments of the audiences simultaneously. In this context, lifestyle-oriented programs such as the trendy drama seemed to be a reasonable alternative to story-driven entertainment.[28] I use the term "story-driven" to describe fiction in which a preconceived story line is the main thrust.[29] For instance, Japanese home dramas were dominantly story-driven. The plot lines tackled relationships between individual and society or between individuals, and they were always situated in particular social contexts. Home dramas told stories for the sake of a clear-cut point that pertained to the reinforcement of values and behaviors that were crucial to the reproduction of the national community.

By contrast, in trendy dramas the emphasis is not on the story but on the characters who, essentially, become plot functions.[30] Trendy dramas interrogate how the individual can attain happiness. These serials are less concerned with the individual's place in society or with the reproduction of social order. Rather, they follow the path of individuals into individuality

divorced from the actual social contexts within which they live.[31] These serials pursue certain *themes* such as friendship and love rather than *stories*. An aspect of trendy dramas that testifies to this tendency is the fact that they often defy summarizing. These serials seldom offer unequivocal ideological messages other than encouraging individuals to live self-centered and self-fulfilling lives. The main themes they tackle are love and friendship that they recycle in inexhaustible (and repetitive) configurations. In trendy dramas, characters develop through conflicts with other characters. The sense of suspense generated by the possibility that the conflicts between characters may not be resolved or the love relationship may not be consummated is a source of pleasure to the viewers. Yet, I argue, an equally important source of enjoyment is to watch pretty young people clad in stylish outfits hanging out in trendy places. To put it differently, the programs' terrific visual and sonorial form overwhelms the content. These dramas are similar to music videos in that their primary goal is not so much to educate the viewers as to elevate their mood.[32]

The breakdown of signification—an instance of which I am laboring to capture here—is a central theme in theorizing the condition of postmodernity. Scholars have long suggested that under late-capitalist conditions, mass culture no longer engages its viewers primarily on the level of ideology (Tetzlaff 1991). Instead, it tries to capture their attention with programs in which the increasingly spectacular form (presentation) replaces an earlier emphasis on content (Andersen 1995; Caldwell 1995). Fredric Jameson (1991) has lamented the trend that, in the condition in which culture has fallen prey to the massive forces of commodification, cultural producers are less and less capable of making political or critical statements. I would highlight that the issue is no longer simply that cultural producers have lost the capacity to make critical statements. Rather, the development of Japanese trendy dramas sheds light on a new trend—namely that, in certain contexts, mass cultural producers avoid making statements altogether. Yet rather than interpreting this trend as proof that the postmodern culture of depthlessness has reached its pinnacle, I would like to offer a situated analysis by contextualizing this trend in the concrete socioeconomic condition within which it has evolved. Specifically, I suggest that in Japan in the 1990s, the new preoccupation with affect, surface, style, and lifestyle should be understood both as a response to the erosion of mass middle-class society and as a strategy to reinvent tele-

vision, a quintessential mass medium, in an era in which the traditional balance between mass and niche consumption was profoundly upset.

I am not suggesting, however, that the move away from signification to affect is a new trend, and even less that it is specific to televisual entertainment. Rather, I claim that in the 1980s and 1990s a trend intensified that is indeed intrinsic to the logic and operation of capitalism. Karl Marx (1977) described this trend as mystification, while more recently Jameson (1991, 18) interpreted it as the generalization of exchange value to the point at which "the very memory of use value is effaced." In the mid-1980s, management theorists began suggesting that it was more lucrative to produce brands than actual tangible commodities. Since then, a growing number of manufacturers have switched to buying products and branding them, as opposed to producing goods and advertising them (Holt 2004; Klein 2000). In this condition, consumers increasingly choose certain commodities over others not because they believe that they offer better use values, but because they more compellingly express the lifestyles with which the buyers identify. In other words, practices of branding draw on an understanding that identity is nothing more than an attitude in a world in which only affective commitments matter (Grossberg 1989). Ueno Chizuko (1992) compellingly captures the logic of our growing indifference toward the use value of commodities. She muses on the strangeness of the situation when a shop attendant turns to ask her what she is looking for. She highlights the absurdity of the question, as the only true answer is, "I'm looking for myself."

Branding, a strategy and process whereby the exchange value renders the use value obsolete, began expanding to the realm of televisual entertainment in the late 1980s. Viewers (especially younger generations) now expect television programs not only to entertain them but also to resonate with their taste preferences and lifestyles. Thus, lifestyle-oriented programs are more lucrative for television networks than story-driven entertainment not only because they simplify the problematic of identity, but also because, like brands, they help individuals confirm their sense of self (and status or aspiration to a certain status). Equally important, lifestyle-oriented programs provide a sense of belonging to a community of individuals who share (or aspire to share) certain lifestyles. These shows reproduce economies of scale—that is, they appeal to broader cross-segments of the audiences than story-driven television serials—because they are capa-

ble of cutting through the boundaries of specific demographics. In the language of marketing, lifestyle-oriented dramas do not target specific demographics (defined by gender, age, and income ranges); rather, they aim to reach various psychographics—an extension of demographics that define target markets by lifestyle characteristics.

Lifestyle in this context refers to a practice whereby individuals reinforce and cultivate their individuality through taste preferences and define their identity through lifestyle choices. In the context of U.S. network television, Robin Andersen (1995) interpreted the new televisual preoccupation with lifestyle in the late 1980s (i.e., roughly the same time as in Japan)—coupled with a celebration of individualism—as the latest manifestation of the contradiction that, whereas manufacturers strive to maintain economies of scale, consumers expect to be treated as individuals. In the Japanese context, the tarento, who serve as carriers of information on lifestyle trends, were essential to the production of lifestyle-oriented programs. As I will elaborate later in this chapter, "lifestyle-oriented" and "tarento-intensive" have become synonymous in the context of trendy drama, for these serials are just as much about fictive characters as about the tarento who personify them.[33] Again, drawing on the tarento system was an efficient strategy to adjust the television industry's system of mass production in the wake of market fragmentation, and the trendy drama is a format through which the tarento system has come to occupy a central place in program production.

Shifting the emphasis from content to lifestyle (and the tarento representing it) was a step-by-step process. In the first trendy drama, *Kimi no Hitomi wo Taihō Suru* (Those Eyes of Yours Are under Arrest; Fuji, 1988),[34] the theme of love (which producers believed to be the most pertinent theme for young women) was complemented with mystery (*keiji mono*), an evergreen genre in the sphere of mass consumption. As *Those Eyes of Yours Are under Arrest* received good ratings, Yamada Yoshiaki and Ōta Tōru, producers at Fuji, plotted the next drama, this time leaving the mystery element out of it. *Dakishimetai* (I Want to Hold You; Fuji, 1988) was also warmly welcomed.[35] As a result, in 1988 the Fuji network launched the first program slot reserved exclusively for trendy drama, called *getsuku* (*getsuyōbi kuji*), on Monday from 9 to 10 P.M. (Satake 1997).[36] Getsuku is still among Fuji's top priorities in terms of financial investment. The dramas aired in this program slot are overwhelmingly love stories, and have

been since the inception of the getsuku slot in 1988.[37] TBS quickly reacted to the spectacular success of the new dramas and reassigned its drama slot on Friday from 10 to 11 P.M. to trendy dramas.[38] Many of TBS's most popular dramas in the 1990s were broadcast in this slot.[39] The unprecedented popularity of the new genre prompted programming departments to open new program slots and to reassign older ones to trendy dramas. In the 1990s, commercial television networks, led by Fuji and TBS, produced more than 550 trendy-drama serials. In the fall season of 2003, for example, seventeen new primetime drama serials were broadcast.

In trendy dramas, the loosely crafted stories of romance provided only a narrative shell for the main agenda, which was to offer information on the latest lifestyle trends. The first dramas were also called "catalogue" dramas, as their main agenda was clearly to catalogue fashion trends for their young female viewers.[40] Trendy dramas are produced for one-time viewing, since their informational value expires rapidly. The *kūru* system—or four seasons within one broadcasting year that overlap with the natural seasons[41]—secures flexibility to respond to consumers' demands in a timely manner. Episodes are produced merely a week ahead of broadcasting, so that dramas are filmed in the same season that they are watched, and the characters wear clothing that reflects the latest fashion trends. This lends trendy dramas a sense of realism insofar as individual episodes closely resonate with what viewers see in their immediate environments.

Since the main selling point of trendy dramas is not the story but information on the latest trends, it comes as no surprise that primetime reruns are avoided.[42] There is a certain temporality to the branding value of tarento, which is another reason to avoid rerunning the dramas. When tarento appear in a drama, they come to brand not only the drama and the television network, but also the commodities they are simultaneously endorsing in commercials. Moreover, in parallel with the drama serials, spin-off programs (variety and game shows) are produced employing the same tarento, which cross-brand the dramas and intensify the branding value of the tarento. Primetime reruns would disrupt the intertextual temporality of trendy dramas. In other words, reruns stop functioning as sources of information on current trends (i.e., they lose their informational value), and the story lines of these dramas are not so interesting that their value as narrative entertainment can be the primary (or sole) selling point. Trendy dramas focus on character development, and the portrayal of char-

acters dovetails with these dramas' heavy reliance on the tarento system. Trendy dramas become an effective way to elaborate the personas of tarento and to refine their branding value.

Tarento as Image Commodity

Since the late 1980s, the tarento have become indispensable to the success of the trendy drama; in turn, this genre is increasingly about the tarento. In this section, I will trace how celebrities underwent the transformation from professional entertainers (actors, singers, and so on) to tarento, or all-powerful currencies whose circulation produced a culture of televisual intimacy in Japan in the 1990s.[43] In its contemporary version, the tarento system is particular to Japanese televisual culture, and its distinctiveness lies in the multifunctionality of the tarento. Until the 1960s, Japanese actors and actresses were trained and contractually bound by the major film studios. In the 1950s, television networks had to subcontract stars from the film industry, but the supply was cut off when cinema box office sales started dropping as a result of television's growing popularity. Television networks turned to theater—both kabuki and modern theater—for performers. Theater sources, however, could not satisfy the growing demand, and agencies were established to recruit new stars. Yet the new actors could not be trained quickly enough to meet the demand. Thus, the growing number of actors without acting talent dates back to the rupture between the film and the television industries in Japan. Indeed, it was at this point that smart marketing and overexposure to viewers were institutionalized as practices that could compensate for lack of talent.

At the same time, talented actresses from an earlier period provided models for how stars could be exploited. For example, Kusabue Mitsuko, who came from the Shōchiku Kagekidan Theater Group and later became a Tōhō film star, was not solely an actress. She also danced and sang in the 1950s.[44] Histories of Japanese broadcasting also point out that using professional entertainers and celebrities in commercials to endorse particular commodities had started as early as the late 1960s.[45] By the late 1980s, it had become a common practice to employ tarento in dramas (instead of or in addition to trained actors mainly from theater), variety shows, game shows (instead of non-celebrities), commercials (instead of models), and even in documentaries in the role of the narrator (instead of reporters).[46]

Although the tarento system preceded the trendy drama, this new televisual genre revitalized and reinforced it by its massive demand for celebrities not so much with talent but, rather, with significant brand equity.

The word "tarento" is transliterated from the English word "talent," but commonly tarento are not blessed with special talent in any particular entertainment genre. For example, there is a widely shared agreement that Nakai Masahiro, a member of SMAP, the most sought-after male band in the 1990s, is so tone deaf that he can barely carry a tune. While he often becomes an object of mockery, this deficiency has never cast doubt on his professionalism as tarento. Numerous scholars of Japanese mass culture have suggested that the tarento's lack of talent is exactly why the audiences can identify with them so easily (Aoyagi 2004; Yoshimoto 1996a). Their appeal lies in their "ordinariness." They are not especially different from an average person. While the adjectives most commonly associated with them are "cool (*kakkō ii*)" and "cute (*kawaii*)," one also often hears that they are "like anyone else (*tōshindai*).[47]

The crucial factor in making and marketing the tarento is their constant exposure to the viewers' gaze. Tarento are excessively exploited; some of them "commute" to television networks daily, as they appear on some program every day. Mitsuhiro Yoshimoto (1996a, 133) has written, "Presented as an image of workaholics, tarento may provide reassurance to many Japanese workers who themselves are working around the clock and sacrificing their health for the sake of their companies." Audiences encounter the tarento in so many different contexts that they become familiar with both their on-stage and off-stage personas and lives. As a result of their intense exposure to the viewers' gaze and the consequent gossiping about them, the boundary between the public and private personas of the tarento further erodes. Dramas and other television programs capitalize on this aspect of Japanese televisual culture and employ the tarento in dialogue with their media careers and relationships with each other. In most cases, producers cast tarento in particular roles after careful consideration of their performances in other dramas and their personal and private reputations. An example is the tarento Mizuno Miki. She studies kung fu, which often determines how she is cast: not only is she given parts in feature action movies, but her hobby becomes watching Bruce Lee on videotape in love dramas, and the fact that she is a big fan of Lee is fre-

quently emphasized. In *Hatsutaiken* (First Experience; Fuji, 2001), she was cast as a veterinarian, which played to her other private hobby: animals.

In the course of their intense cross-genre and transmedia circulation, the tarento become image commodities. It was by means of the production of this particular type of commodity that the television industry could introduce flexibility into its system of mass production. The production of tarento entails smaller-scale investments and more flexible labor processes. The first crucial point is that tarento, as an intangible commodity, are not manufactured from raw materials that have to be purchased at competitive prices on the market.[48] As looks are the most important criterion for becoming a star,[49] no investment is necessary in auditions to identify talent. Tarento scouts resemble treasure hunters, who *find* treasure. In other words, tarento agencies do not usually invest in training young people to acquire acting or singing skills. Rather, the production of tarento is based on the indirect exploitation of the labor of everyone involved in the process of raising and educating children who become tarento. To put it differently, managers of tarento appropriate "public labor," such as the labor of parents (who raise and invest in their children who are then scouted by tarento agents) or the labor of teachers (who educate and polish them), into private profit.[50] Agencies invest in tarento only by circulating them[51]—that is, by selling them to advertising agencies, music and publishing companies, and television networks. Tarento are produced and produce value in the process of their circulation. Agencies only launch the careers of tarento; as soon as tarento are set into circulation, every party that employs them further refines their media personas while simultaneously extracting profit from them.

Tarento agencies assume a central role in engineering the public images of tarento by retaining control over their circulation. As tarento are not trained professionals, they are initially sold to advertising agencies as models. Audiences become familiar with the tarento through their appearance in commercials, which is considered a key to their future success. This is, however, only one pattern. The most famous agency, Johnny's, which specializes in young male tarento, follows a different path by launching the careers of tarento by way of all-male bands in which members only sing and dance.[52] Never mind that these tarento are not trained musicians; superior Japanese audio technology can correct the absence of singing

skills. Only after these young male stars acquire a reputation are they offered jobs in television variety shows or dramas. The situation is similar for female tarento. First they are employed as models, and only after they have become so popular that articles about them appear in women's magazines are they offered jobs in dramas.[53]

Tarento and Intimate Televisuality

I noted at the beginning of this chapter that the intertextual employment of tarento was a successful strategy to revive a general interest in televisual culture, as it made television watching a more interactive and multilayered experience for viewers. The intertextual character of celebrities is not unique to Japanese televisual culture. Keith Reader (1990, 176) has written, "The very concept of the film star is an intertextual one, relying as it does on the correspondence of similarity and difference from one film to the next, and sometimes too on supposed resemblances between on- and off-screen personas. Thus, Sergio Leone's *Once Upon a Time in the West* ironically inverts Henry Fonda's normal heroic role to make of a particularly sadistic villain." In Japanese televisual culture, however, the intertextual function of the tarento is intensified and strategically deployed. As a result of the intense intertextual employment of the tarento, not only does their branding value grows enormously (they activate associations to certain lifestyles), but they also become intimate entities to viewers, who accumulate a considerable amount of knowledge of their personas by seeing them in various television programs simultaneously.

Trendy dramas played a key role in elaborating the personas of the tarento by providing them with a performing space where—as some cynically remark—they performed not fictive characters but themselves. To appear in serialized television dramas is the peak of a tarento's career. Correspondingly, Yoshimoto (1996a) has observed that the appeal of game shows featuring tarento as contestants in Japan is that they expose them in nonfictional settings, which gives the illusion that it is their private selves that are revealed to the viewers. In the game-show setting, tarento are asked not only to improvise and act spontaneously but also to show vulnerability in the heat of the game or to even be humiliated when unable to perform well in the competition.

Viewers also learn about the tarento from promotional programs. An-

other particular feature of Japanese televisual culture is that programs constantly become promotions for each other. For instance, in the late 1990s *Waratte ii to'mo* (Laugh If You Like; Fuji) started devoting special editions to advertising its network's new dramas. Special editions are aired a week before new drama seasons begin. These specials follow the game-show format; the teams, which consist of the actors and actresses starring in the new series, carry the titles of Fuji's new dramas. While the game element is an important source of enjoyment for viewers, I suggest that the primary source of pleasure is the firsthand opportunity to check out the chemistry between the actors and actresses matched up for the new dramas. While these tarento will play in fictitious dramas, the chemistry among them is very real, and viewers' pleasure comes from sliding between these different registers of reality and fiction. It is precisely this slippage that transforms television watching into an intimate experience for them.

The personas of tarento are also subtly given narratives in documentaries that feature tarento in the role of the narrator.[54] Unique to Japanese televisual culture, these documentaries are about both a particular theme and the tarento featured in them. In addition, these two themes articulate with each other. To show how these programs elaborate the personas of tarento, I cite the example of *Sūpā Terebi, Gekidō no Afuganisutan wo iku* (Traveling to Violent Afghanistan; NTV, 2002), a documentary about poverty and its impact on children's lives in Afghanistan that starred the tarento Fujiwara Norika, who is known for her philanthropic sentiments.[55] NTV broadcast the feature-length documentary in September 2002, as a commemoration of the September 11, 2001, terror attack in New York City. Fujiwara, the narrator/traveler, was among the top three female tarento in 2001–2. She was also scheduled for drama roles in every successive season and was featured in an overwhelming number of commercials.

In terms of genre, these programs straddle the line between documentaries and travel shows. Allegedly, these programs are not scripted; rather, they exploit the very idea of spontaneity (the idea of unmediated reality) in front of the camera. Japanese viewers have seen Fujiwara shedding tears on the television screen countless times in the fictional settings of trendy dramas. However, seeing Fujiwara's *real* tears as she holds the hands of Afghan orphans is a new experience and a "bonus" to the viewers. She does not wear makeup and is not clad in designer clothes. While her pretty face has been unabashedly scrutinized on Japanese television screens, in this

1 Fujiwara Norika, profile photograph. Courtesy Someday Talent Agency.

program she is wearing a scarf, after the local custom, which makes it more difficult to gaze at her face. Because Fujiwara is employed in a context starkly different from the ones in which the viewers are used to seeing her, viewers are offered a choice: whether to be informed about the impact of poverty on Afghan children or to learn more about Fujiwara's true self (and humanity).

Once tarento become the center of program production, they have a tendency to overwhelm and even subsume the content and the format of programming. A result of this tendency is that the boundaries between televisual genres are breaking down. Although genres used to be classified according to the primary functions of television broadcasting (information, education, and entertainment), in parallel with the growing importance of the tarento in program production these functions started collapsing into each other, giving birth to new, composite genres such as edu-tainment, info-tainment, and adver-tainment, in which the tarento were indispensable components. For instance, the tarento are essential to

the subtle blurring of commercials and dramas into each other, resulting in the commercialization of dramas and the concomitant dramatization of commercials. Commercials and dramas are synchronized in various ways to make the former more appealing to viewers and the latter more successful for networks. It is primarily the tarento who connect the two genres, but production know-how plays an increasingly important role, as well, in blurring the boundaries between them. As for the former strategy, the characters tarento play in dramas are coordinated with the values, behaviors, and lifestyles associated with them in commercials. In addition, it is common that tarento who played together in a particular drama are also cast together in commercials. Kamikawa Takaya and Zaizen Naomi, for instance, who played in *Omizu no Hanamichi* (Bar Hostesses on the Central Path; Fuji, 1999, 2001), are also cast together in a pharmaceutical-company commercial that advertises digestive pills. Seeing them in a different, allegedly less fictive context is a source of intimate pleasure to the viewers. As the viewers accumulate knowledge on the tarento, they are stimulated to watch more dramas and commercials.

The serialized and collaborative commercials have a comparable effect. An example is the commercial for Suntory's canned coffee (Boss), which stages a chase scene featuring Nagase Masatoshi and Hotei Tomoyasu.[56] Nagase is a salaryman doing business in the city. On the way back to his office, he stops at a vending machine to buy a Boss canned coffee. As he is drinking it, a man collapses at his feet, handing him a briefcase. Immediately a gangster, played by Hotei, shows up wanting the briefcase. Nagase starts to run, and the scenario is extended for approximately ten more "episodes." Through the chase scenes, Nagase finds himself in the middle of the concert of the rhythm-and-blues duo Chemistry and meets another top tarento, Nakai Masahiro, on the way, thus engaging other tarento in the semifictional world of the commercial.

Nagase's running character not only connects the episodes of this commercial serial, it also blends into other commercials, such as one for KDDI Corporation's AU cellular phones and two for Fuji Film, thus creating the so-called collaborative commercial. In the Fuji Film commercial, the first shot is a New Year's celebration in front of a Fuji Color shop. In the store, three women check freshly developed pictures. Nagase runs into the shop, and Hotei follows him. One of the women, Kiki Kirin (the lead "star" of the Fuji Color serialized commercial), takes a snapshot of Nagase and Hotei,

and as they rush out through a back door, the three women follow them with cameras. In the next episode, as the New Year's celebration is continuing in a shopping district, Hotei and the women are chasing Nagase. The women wish Nagase a good run for the next year. The scene ends at a shrine, where Nagase gets a new can of Boss coffee.

The collaborative commercial provides an illustration of how the intertextual employment of the tarento becomes constitutive of televisual intimacy by destabilizing the boundary between reality and fiction and bringing to life a world of phantasm that is maintained by the circulation of the image commodities, the tarento. What makes this commercial powerful is that the original, pre-collaboration commercials defer their respective connections with reality by alluring the viewers into a phantasm produced in between the two respective commercials and create a meta-reality that is suspended between reality and fiction. While the story line of the commercial is pure fiction, it has an effect of realism that is not (or not only) the reality of the Suntory and Fuji Film commodities but, rather, the very concreteness of the way the viewers are seduced into the intricacies of production. In the moment when they make the connection between two fictional story lines and associate them with certain commodities and tarento endorsing them, they join the encoding–decoding game. Thus, these commercials not only provide information about particular commodities but also call on the viewers' literacy in a particular televisual culture and thus reinforce their sense of belonging to this televisual community. Understanding the relations of production and the capability of decoding (and thus enjoying them) means that one is "in the circle."

This intimate televisuality, generated via the intertextual employment of the tarento, is crucial in stimulating viewers to watch *more* television. It is increasingly difficult to enjoy Japanese television programs for what they are. The tarento are pretty and stylish, but the scripts are often not creative due to a cautious avoidance of taking business risks with unconventional and non-formulaic shows. Watching television in Japan is thus more and more an intertextual experience that is generated, maintained, and mediated by the tarento. The act of watching a show is not confined to that particular program; rather, it becomes a process of activating connections between various television programs and tarento personalities. Television watching thus equals a general participation in televisual culture, as it becomes a process of moving between a program and all of the other

programs to which it refers and relates, moving out from the independent television text into a network of textual relations.

As a new mode of media entertainment, televisual intertextuality calls for new viewing strategies that disrupt the linearity and integrity of particular programs. These new strategies are most similar to what George Landow (1994) calls hypertextual reading in his theorization of how users read and write Internet novels. I find this comparison especially useful because it highlights the tenuousness of the arguments that predict the demise of television in favor of new media that are believed to be more capable of offering interactive entertainment. In hypertextual reading, the reader may break the linear flow of a text by activating links or adding commentaries, making author, text, and reader into joint participants in a plural, intertextual network of significations and potential significations. While the effective participation viewers are given in Japanese televisual production is limited, they are invited to a game of decoding the intertextual references that television producers encode into the programs. Enjoyment in participating in this televisual meta-reality is contingent on the viewers' effective knowledge of Japanese televisual culture and of the tarento and their media careers and relationships with each other.

The tarento and the intimate televisuality their circulation generates managed to revive and maintain viewers' interest in the televisual medium in the 1990s. In other words, by simply watching any particular program, viewers were able to tap into the complete participatory experience of Japanese televisual culture and its network of information on cultural and consumer trends. Decoding and enjoying programs in their intertextual contexts requires intensive and regular participation. As encoding becomes ever more sophisticated, decoding requires greater and greater exposure and "training." By way of the encoding–decoding game, television is becoming increasingly indispensable for rendering social realities intelligible and human relationships meaningful in contemporary Japan.

Conclusion: Image Commodity and Image Fetishism

I have argued in this chapter that the Japanese television industry used the tarento system to adapt its mass-oriented system of production to market fragmentation, and I have situated the changes in the context of a broader shift in late-capitalist economies from manufacturing tangible goods to

producing intangible commodities—an example of which are the tarento. What concerns me in the conclusion is how the tarento as image commodities mediate social realities and relationships. In other words, I am interested in how commodity fetishism operates in the condition in which the privileged commodity in circulation is the image. Marx (1977) shed light on the mystical nature of the commodity, which he described as an ability to mask real relations between people as relations between objects. He explained that under the regime of the market, labor power (the ability of humans to transform nature), for instance, is converted into labor time, which in that "objectively" measurable new form becomes quantifiable, sold, and purchased in the market. As such, the abstraction of labor power from its natural conditions is an example of how the commodification of relationships between people results in the emergence of a reified reality. Put differently, commodity fetishism originates in the displacement of use value by exchange value.[57] This brings forth a fundamental split between reality and phantasm, as the use value is not completely eradicated but remains buried under exchange value. The image, however, is a type of commodity that does not have use value. This becomes clear if we examine the tarento as image commodity. The only form of value the tarento have is exchange value that they acquire in the processes of their circulation. As the television, film, and advertising industries cast them in new roles across media platforms and genres, meanings and feelings are associated with them, and their media personas evolve. In other words, they become image commodities.

How, then, do these image commodities mediate everyday realities and relationships in contemporary Japan? I claimed earlier that literacy in Japanese televisual culture feeds a sense of membership in new lifestyle collectivities and affective alliances. While the groundedness of this community in a nationally based media culture gives it a sense of reality, the community in which televisual literacy gains viewers' membership is phantasmatic. Walter Benjamin's analysis of the role of the commodity on display in producing an aura of modernity is pertinent here. In Benjamin's view, what produced an urban modernity was not so much the commodity in the market as the commodity on display, since the majority of people could gaze at commodities, even if they could not purchase and own them. Commodities on-display represented a modernity that people otherwise could not fully grasp. It was clear that modernity had powerful bearings on

people's lives, granting new privileges to some and further marginalizing others from valorized forms of power. Modernity was a source of both excitement and angst, yet when it was displayed in the shop window and presented in the form of commodity images, modernity stood exclusively for a positive future. Commodities on display came to represent the new times that promised new possibilities to people who gazed at them (Benjamin 1999).

By extension, the transformation of the tarento into image commodities was a symptom of an emerging new economy characterized by a shift of production away from material things to immaterial commodities, such as image or affect. In the context of the American celebrity system, Stuart Ewen (1999 [1988], 100) has written that, "although their pay is enough to make them the uncontested 'aristocracy of labor,' their status as commodities, is more visible than in other areas of employment. They, literally, are the commodity being sold; fabricated, most of the time, on an elaborate cultural assembly line." Yet this is not how viewers experience the tarento. Literacy in tarento culture plugs viewers into a network within whose boundaries members are intimately connected with one another. Literacy in tarento culture and membership in this televisual community, however, have also further reified relationships among people, not only because they have come to stand between people, but also because image commodities generate an income for virtually everyone who participates in their circulation and facilitates their flow. Let us consider two final examples to examine how surplus value is produced and human relationships are reified in the process of the circulation of the tarento.

On Japanese Internet auction sites, sellers often advertise items with references to tarento. A seller, for example, offered for sale a "pre-owned" cardigan for $670 (60,000 yen), stating that the top-ranked tarento Kimura Takuya had worn an identical cardigan in a given scene of a drama.[58] That the cardigan was warm or that the color or design was unique were not deemed to be salient in the description of the item. The cardigan sold for more than $770, and this is hardly an extreme case. It is common for sellers on Japanese auction sites to try to stimulate the interest of potential buyers by listing which tarento were wearing identical brands of clothing in various commercials and television programs. What is curious in the case of the cardigan is that the emphasis on the object's utility value (i.e., a cardigan keeps its wearer warm) or exchange value (i.e., the de-

signer's name can evoke values reminiscent of use value such as high quality, comfort, or durability) was displaced by its affiliation with the tarento, and the worth of the cardigan was conferred by the lifestyle of the tarento with which it was associated. It is in this sense that the cardigan becomes an example of the virtualization of the commodity form.

The second example is the package tours to Tokyo that Taiwanese travel agencies organize for Taiwanese youth. Trendy dramas are highly popular in Taiwan and have generated growing interest among young Taiwanese in Tokyo as a phantasmatic space of televisual fiction.[59] The package tours do not guide customers through Tokyo's traditionally renowned tourist destinations, such as the Ginza or Tsukiji; instead, it leads them through the sites where the favorite Japanese dramas of Taiwanese youth were shot. Tokyo Tower, for instance, is introduced to tourists as the place where Kanji first kissed Rika in *Tokyo Love Story* (Fuji, 1991). Again, a site is filled with a new, fictional relevance generated by the tarento, while its original meanings for tourists are suspended. That is, surplus value is produced through the circulation of the tarento. The tarento as image commodity sheds light on the further virtualization of the commodity form (and, by extension, capital); in search of profit, it further reifies reality and people's relationship to it.

A commercial advertising a digital camera by Panasonic evocatively encapsulates the logic of the image commodity. It portrays a crowd of small children who are lined up for the opening of a school's sports day (*undōkai*). A sentence in the middle of the screen reads "*Aidoru wo sagase!*" (Search for Celebrity!; "aidoru" is the teenage equivalent of tarento). The background music is a song from the 1960s carrying the same title.[60] The commercial suggests that parents are (capable of) associating their children with tarento by chasing them everywhere with digital cameras, in the same way that fans follow their favorite idols. In this process, parents turn their children into images, which is equivalent to social intelligibility (exchange value) that will ultimately translate into social capital.

Digital cameras record phases of a child's life so they can be remembered. Yet in the commercial, the written message, and the background music from the 1960s, redirects the viewers' attention from the past (i.e., remembering) toward the future (i.e., imagining/imaging), and the message becomes more radical. It suggests that digital cameras are to be used to not remember phases of childhood but to actively "produce" children to be-

come meaningful social beings. By turning children into images, one invests in them. It is not only that filming a child becomes a way to improve her self-esteem; the more children become images, the more they become commodifiable (i.e., intelligible human beings). Yet the nostalgic mood of the 1960s background music puts the phantasmatic, over-imaged contemporary Japanese life into a perspective. Perhaps it is reminiscent of an earlier stage of capitalism with less intricate forms of commodity fetishism. In the next chapter, I will analyze the relationships of image fetishism and agency through the production and reception of the TBS drama *Single Lives*.

Two

Imaged Away

AGENCY AND FETISHISM IN TRENDY DRAMA PRODUCTION AND RECEPTION

In March 1997, a woman's strangled body was found in an empty apartment in the red-light district of Tokyo. The victim's business card, found in her wallet, identified her as "Watanabe Yasuko, Tokyo Utilities, Department of Development, Assistant Manager." She was thirty-nine years old and single. Police investigations disclosed that she had lived a double life: by day she worked for Tokyo Utilities (Tōden), and by night she was a prostitute. The stark contrast between her identity as a member of the corporate elite and her identity as a sex worker befuddled the public, and Watanabe's double life exercised a powerful hold on the popular imagination. The murder case became the ground for impassioned debates on themes ranging from single women's sexuality and the breakdown of the family to the socioeconomic vitality of the nation. It was not only the news media that tenaciously scrutinized the "Tōden elite OL murder case." Nonfiction writers also produced bestsellers based on the story (Asakura 2001; Hisama

2000; Sanō 2000, 2001) and, in 1999, Nariai Yuka, a female producer at Tokyo Broadcasting System (TBS), adapted the motif of Watanabe's double life into her debut drama serial *Dokushin Seikatsu* (Single Lives).

Although the murder case did not conform to the criteria of good taste and light entertainment that viewers had come to expect of trendy dramas, Nariai saw it as an intriguing story with the potential to make a progressive statement on gender discrimination against female employees in the corporate world. Yet despite the popular interest in the murder case, the ratings of the drama plummeted to 12 percent, and eventually the serial failed to meet its political and financial objectives. By analyzing the production and reception of *Single Lives*, I will continue to explore the social ramifications of the shift in program production from an emphasis on stories to a preoccupation with lifestyles. I will suggest that the drama failed because it subordinated the image commodity to an intriguing story. I claimed in chapter 1 that the development of the trendy drama was emblematic of a trend toward the tarento becoming indispensable for the achievement of high ratings. By the late 1990s, this tendency had escalated to the degree that it was no longer celebrities who were selected for certain roles. Rather, it had become common for the tarento to be contracted for certain drama slots, and the scripts were being written *for them* in dialogue with their earlier performances and media personas.

This chapter aims to further my analysis of the recent changes in the television industry by focusing on the issue of agency. Specifically, I will examine the implications of the primacy of the tarento in program production for the dominant understanding of agency in the anthropology of television. While Nariai aimed for a commentary on the evils of gender discrimination,[1] my reception study concludes that it was not the story line (the vicissitudes of a female career-track employee in the corporate world) that interested viewers. What viewers overwhelmingly discussed was whether the roles assigned to the tarento in *Single Lives* suited their private and screen personas. The actual story line of *Single Lives* was subordinated to the public personas of the tarento, and it was the intertextual story woven from the personal histories and media careers of the tarento that became the primary source of pleasure to the audiences. While watching *Single Lives*, viewers forgot about the Tōden murder case, and their attention was channeled toward the lead tarento, whose media persona thus subsumed the anxieties evoked by the murder victim.

In anthropological, cultural, and media studies of television, agency is equated with the power of television producers to encode messages in their programs. It is also understood as the ability of viewers to make choices in decoding meanings within the semiotic confines of televisual texts. In terms of this analytical framework, the production and reception of *Single Lives* would be read as failures of agency. Yet I claim that both the producer and the viewers succeeded in encoding and decoding messages they found agreeable and pleasurable. Whereas the text—understood as a bounded entity—enjoys unwarranted privilege in this analytic framework, my case study suggests that interpreting agency as the ability to encode or decode textual meanings is no longer a productive way to make sense of how viewers experience pleasure in televisual culture in conditions in which stories are subordinated to information on lifestyles. In the case of *Single Lives*, viewers' pleasure was predicated on a rejection of the text, as demonstrated by the fact that they evaded the socially progressive message the producer encoded in her drama. As the viewers' enjoyment is increasingly mediated by the tarento system, it is more and more bound to image fetishism. This chapter thus also continues to explore how the tarento—as image commodities—mediate social realities and how they simplify the problematic of identity by suggesting that it is nothing more than an attitude.

In what follows, I will revisit three social sites where I aim to recapture three parallel stories. As I see it, these are parts of a puzzle that will help us understand why *Single Lives* was a commercial failure. My argument is that the drama failed because the producer did not comply with the demands of the new tarento-based media economy. However, I wish to emphasize that this was not the only reason for the drama's failure. Trendy dramas were primarily targeted at single "office ladies,"[2] the majority of whom worked in non-career-track positions. The producer's assumption that non-career-track office ladies were interested in the vicissitudes of career-track female employees' lives was not necessarily on target. Despite this miscalibration, the programming department agreed to sign off on the producer's proposal, arguing that it is the top-tier cast that matters and not the theme. The failure of *Single Lives* illustrates that the move away from story-driven dramas toward lifestyle-based serials had become a mainstream business practice by the late 1990s.

First, I visit the site of the Tōden murder case, where my goal is to unveil

what was so captivating to the public about a career woman who was flirting with danger in her nightlife. I then move on to my second site of television production, where I will explore what Nariai wanted to achieve by adopting the Tōden murder case as the theme of her drama. Here I want to foreshadow the reasons why the dramatic adaptation of the Tōden office lady's life failed. More concretely, I ask why the narrative—which had been the main source of pleasure in televisual entertainment before the 1990s—started to lose its privileged position in program production. Finally, I visit the site of drama reception, where I ask why viewers failed to appreciate the drama as a progressive statement on gender discrimination. I am interested in establishing what it is that viewers found pleasurable in their engagement with the tarento. I argue that in a post-textual era in which stories are increasingly being supplanted by information on lifestyle in television production, we are forced to reconsider the dominant understanding of agency in studies of television.

The Discreet Charm of the Corporate Elite: The Tōden Murder Case

What do we know about the life and death of Watanabe Yasuko, whose double life stirred up such emotions? Watanabe came from an upper-middle-class family living in a posh suburb of Tokyo. Her mother was a housewife, and her father worked for Tokyo Utilities. Watanabe started her career in the same company as if to follow in her father's footsteps. She suffered her first bout of anorexia when her father died during her university years. After graduating from the prestigious private Keio University, Watanabe entered Tōden and was one of the first women at the company to be accepted into a career-track (*sōgō shoku*) position. She was a competitive employee; she suffered another bout of anorexia when a female colleague—considered her rival—was chosen to study at Harvard University under company sponsorship.

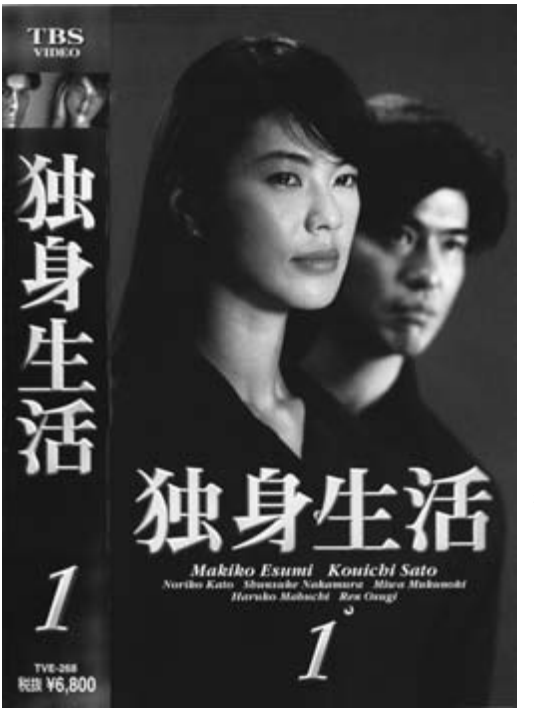
Sometime around 1992, Watanabe started her night work, which she continued until her death in 1997. In the early years, she worked for dating clubs that catered to a high-end clientele of salary men, but she drifted toward the margins of organized prostitution as she got older. Well into her night career, Watanabe was reputed to be undiscriminating about where to hook up and with whom. Witnesses reported having seen her having sex in

parking lots and dark hallways. According to other witnesses, she was regularly urinating in the streets or munching on convenience-store snacks on the train home. Yet curiously, Watanabe kept up appearances in her daytime life; she was always dressed in the latest designer fashions, took the last train home, and left for work on time the next morning.

Watanabe kept meticulous notes about her customers. She recorded not only her clients' names and their meeting places (hotel names, room numbers) but also the amount of compensation she received. From all appearances, she was just as ambitious in her nightlife as she was in her daytime career. According to her notes, she set the norm of four clients per day for herself and she performed her evening work daily—even on Saturdays and Sundays. Yet her night work was not—or not only—about money: her highest fee was $450 (40,000 yen), but if a client could not pay such rates, she traded sexual favors for as little as $23 (2,000 yen). Allegedly, Watanabe had no relationships that were not mediated by money; she had no friends, and from the age of twenty-two she had to fill her father's shoes as the main provider for her mother and younger sister. She lived a lonely life. Both her family and her colleagues knew about her nightlife, yet no one intervened. Her murder case remains unsolved to this day. The only suspect in the case was an illegal guest worker named Govinda Mainali, a citizen of Nepal, with whom Watanabe had hooked up in the street the day she died. The prosecution, however, could not produce conclusive evidence to find him guilty.

Many Japanese women remember Watanabe as a victim of patriarchy, and to express their sympathy, they take flowers to the site where she was murdered. She looked like the career women in *Glamour* magazine—she was work-oriented, pretty, and always clad in upscale designer clothes—but her life was not that glamorous. While some tried to recast her involvement in prostitution as fueled by an excessive enjoyment of sex without strings attached (to establish her image as that of the quintessential modern woman), she was not a high-end sex worker. Mainali, the murder suspect, reported to the police that the first time he met Watanabe he had invited her to the one-bedroom apartment that he shared with two other guest workers. Yasuko had slept with all of them, charging them twenty to twenty-five dollars each.

Watanabe's story is complex and unsettling. Many would argue that it does not lend itself to televisual entertainment, for it does not conform to



2 TBS drama *Single Lives*, featuring Esumi Makiko and Satō Kōichi. The drama aired in the Friday, 10–11 P.M., slot between July 9, 1999, and September 17, 1999. Courtesy Tokyo Broadcasting System.

the fundamental principles of "good taste" and light, intellectually undemanding entertainment. Nonetheless, Nariai decided to adapt the story as the basis for her debut dramatic serial. In her proposal she explained her agenda and the relationship between the drama and the murder case:

> Toward the end of the century, Japanese society is in a state of flux and anxiety, and we have no clear hope or prospect of a bright future. The present drama, which breathes the same air as the viewers in contemporary Japan, is a story about men and women who are seeking meaning in their lives. . . . As this story unfolds, it reminds us of the Shibuya murder case of the Tōden office lady. Similarly, she had to put up with too many expectations as a female executive and as the main breadwinner of her family. In the midst of these multiple expectations, it somewhat made sense that she chose the path she did. Kyōko from this drama is modeled after her.[3]

One might wonder why this story did not translate into a successful television drama. Clearly, there was a discrepancy between the viewers' expectations and the producer's understanding of what the essential ingredients of a popular drama were. While Nariai considered a good story to be the foundation of a good drama, young viewers came to expect trendy dramas to be mood enhancers and a source of lifestyle information. Nariai wanted to grab viewers' attention with an intriguing story, but that was not what the viewers expected from a trendy drama. To conform to the guidelines of primetime-serial drama production, the murder case was repackaged as an "adult love story," a decision that was in itself reasonable, as the drama was made for a program slot that targeted single women from the ages of twenty-six to thirty-four. Yet *Single Lives* did not become a mainstream love story. The drama featured two love relationships that unfolded simultaneously, but neither of them followed the conventional representation of love in primetime drama serials. (More will be said about this in chapter 4, which analyzes the love drama, the main subgenre of trendy drama.) Kyōko's love affair with Yamagishi Shin'ichi (Satō Kōichi), a tabloid journalist, was complex. First he blackmailed her; then they became friends. Their friendship grew into affection, and in the end he proposed to her, but she turned him down. The other love relationship was between a non-career-track office lady named Sugihara Ayumi (Katō Noriko), who worked in Kyōko's bank, and Shimamura Naoki (Nakamura Shunsuke), who was involved in the adult-video business.

The theme of prostitution—derived from the Tōden murder case—helped Nariai advance her agenda, for she presented prostitution as a result of gender discrimination. In the 1990s, the Japanese media cast prostitution as an increasingly alarming social malaise that was spreading among teenage girls, office ladies, and housewives. To make the theme of prostitution more palatable to viewers who were unused to being confronted with such "distasteful" social phenomena in trendy dramas, the production staff transformed it into part of an intricate suspense plot organized around the tarento Ōsugi Ren,[4] who played Yoshikawa Jiro, the master of the dating club with whom Kyōko had signed up.

Nariai had difficulties assigning the role of the villain to Ōsugi, who was

one of her favorite actors. Yet, she was conflicted about the portrayal of the heroine's engagement in prostitution. She did not want to endorse it; nor was she inclined to adopt the popular explanation that sex work was a means for Watanabe to punish herself and her mother. The nonfiction writer Sanō Shin'ichi (2000, 2001) has highlighted the fact that Watanabe adored her father, whom her mother constantly belittled because he was not from a family of high social status, as she was. Sanō stressed that sex work for Watanabe was an act of masochism. In contrast to this view, Nariai interpreted Watanabe's involvement in prostitution as an act of subverting the expectations of her mother, who wanted her to be a "good girl" and a successful career woman.

The first episodes thus moved in the direction of portraying Yoshikawa as a gentleman—the only person who understood how Kyōko felt—and his dating club was presented as the only space of redemption for her. These episodes depicted Yoshikawa's character as a good person who did not take advantage of, but instead helped, the heroine to "liberate another self within herself." By the middle of the series, however, the production team attributed the dwindling ratings to the lack of a clear opposition between good and evil characters. Nariai had no choice but to transform Yoshikawa into a villain. As the story unfolded, it turned out that he was involved in a loan scam that the father of Yamagishi, the tabloid journalist, had been dragged into; that he had blackmailed a high-ranking executive in Kyōko's bank; and that he had murdered a sex worker.

In addition, the character of Shimamura Naoki, who was involved in a romance with Kyōko's colleague Ayumi, helped Nariai make the point that it is often vulnerable young people with limited career opportunities who resort to making a living through sex work. To get close to Ayumi, Shimamura posed as an advertising designer, but in reality he scouted women for prostitution and jobs in adult videos. His story became a subplot in the drama. To be with Ayumi, he had to give up his lucrative scouting job—a transition that was not easy because he did not have proper educational and employment records. The only job he could find was in a noodle (ramen) shop. He was used to wearing designer clothes and visiting upscale bars, and this physically demanding and generally unpleasant labor was too high a price to pay for love. In the end, he managed to leave his scouting career behind, but the path to this decision was long and full of temptations.

Ayumi, Shimamura's love interest, furnished the opportunity for Nariai

to advance her second agenda: gender discrimination within the corporate world. Ayumi was the opposite of Kyōko: without career ambition and devoted to finding a suitable husband. Ayumi was a naïve contract-based (*haken*) office lady. Her father, a schoolteacher in the countryside, arranged her employment in the hope that working in a top financial institution would enhance her chances to marry an elite salaryman. At the bank, Ayumi's main responsibilities were copying, faxing, and mailing; the only way she could retaliate against her sexist boss was to mix mold into his tea. She was the only non-career-track office lady who was not hostile to Kyōko, and their relationship existed to emphasize that female career-track employees are bullied not only from above (by their male colleagues and bosses), but also from below (by the non-career-track office ladies, who are eager to sabotage their work as retribution for their higher salaries).[5]

In the drama, work-related stress and her relationship with her mother were presented as reasons for Kyōko's anxiety disorder and turn to prostitution. The motif of the overbearing mother came from the media coverage of the murder case, which portrayed Watanabe's mother as having devoted her life to her daughters' upbringing. (The murder victim had a younger sister.) The mother character in the drama was an exaggerated, obsessive version of Watanabe's mother; her life centered on her daughter, whose wallet and agenda she checked every day. She attempted to kill Yamagishi because she was afraid that Kyōko might run off with him. When she learned that Kyōko had worked for a dating club, she set fire to the house and tried to force Kyōko to commit suicide with her. These scenes were intended for dramatic effect. During the extended media coverage of the case, Watanabe's mother did not reveal any such aspects of her relationship with her daughter, and it is thus not known why she failed to stop her daughter. Her silence, however, paved the way for wild speculation about her role in driving her daughter to live a double life. The mother figure in *Single Lives* evoked great hostility among viewers, many of whom commented that she was extremely frightening (*kowasugiru*).

Yamagishi was injected into the story because Kyōko needed a love interest. Although the character did not advance Nariai's agenda, the subplot that his presence generated helped develop the suspenseful story line. In the drama, a loan scam in which Kyōko's bank and the dating-club owner Shimamura were involved caused Yamagishi's father's business to go bankrupt. He committed suicide, and his son and wife were left with huge loans

to repay. Yamagishi's adult life revolved around investigating the reasons for his father's suicide and plotting to avenge his death. He met Kyōko accidentally while gathering information for an article about dating clubs and learned that she worked for the bank involved in his father's death. He blackmailed her for information about his father's case, which turned out to be part of a huge corporate scandal. The drama ended with Yamagishi's success in publishing a breakthrough article on the scandal—with the help of Kyōko, who thus betrayed her company.

Kyōko's character was the center of the narrative; she connected the various subplots and characters. She was a graduate of the University of Tokyo and a talented and competent employee, but she did not get much support from her colleagues. Instead, they were jealous of her and tried to get her fired. As a result of the hostility she faced at work, Kyōko developed an anxiety disorder. Once, she collapsed in front of Yoshikawa's dating club. The charming owner, the only person who really wanted to know how Kyōko felt, convinced her to sign up with the club to liberate "another self within herself." Kyōko agreed to work for the dating club but withdrew after a while.[6] Unlike Watanabe's life, Kyōko's story ended on a positive note. She resolved her psychological drama and was "looking forward to learning how high she could fly." She became independent of her mother and quit her job to find another in which she could live up to her potential.

The Producer's Agenda and Agency

In terms of building the story and the choice of characters, there are a number of points to be made. *Single Lives* was the debut drama serial of a female producer who shared with the murder victim, and the drama's heroine, the frustrations of being a career-oriented female employee in the male-centered corporate world. Nariai recounted to me that the drama was a way for her to deal with her own stress.[7] At the same time, the viewing rates were particularly important to her, as this was the serial that introduced her into the drama department of TBS. She was under a great deal of pressure and believed that the more subplots she included, the more chances she had to modify the story to attract and maximize audiences.

Viewing rates are available in one-minute increments, rendering it possible to tell which tarento or subplots are popular with the audiences. When viewers massively change the channel in certain moments, it indi-

cates to producers that a particular tarento or subplot is not appealing to them. Viewers tune back in when their favorite subplot or tarento returns. As tarento have seasonal contracts with television networks, they cannot be let go in the middle of a series if their ratings decline. However, producers can freely change the plot lines or play down unpopular tarento in response to the viewing rates. By the time the first episode is aired, no more than three episodes have been produced. The remaining episodes are written and filmed during the broadcasting season in conjunction with the ratings. (In industry language, this is called "ad lib" production.)

Following in the footsteps of mainstream trendy dramas that center on the development of love, *Single Lives* promised to be a love story, but it did not pass as one. Instead, it veered off in the direction of suspense. (Indeed, before she was reassigned to the drama department, Nariai had been responsible for feature suspense dramas that the programming department handled and ordered from small film-production companies.) Yet this was not a genre in which young women were interested. At the same time, viewers claimed that they did not like the fact that so many things were going on in the drama. The producer had no prior experience in serial-drama production, and as the show was foundering she resorted to introducing more subplots. Clearly, Nariai believed that the story line was the most important factor in determining the drama's appeal and the viewing rates. As the ratings plummeted to 12 percent, the production staff tried to make the story more and more intricate, transforming the love theme into a suspense plot—an evergreen formula that traditionally was perceived as capable of uniting the largest number of viewers in front of the television screen. It does not appear to have worked in this case.

What were the additional challenges that the producer was unable to overcome and that eventually rendered her project unprofitable? A particular feature of drama production in the 1990s that was incompatible with Nariai's agenda was the new system of program slots. From the late 1980s onward, as commercial networks moved away from producing programming targeted to broad cross-segments of the population toward catering to particular audience segments, program slots transformed into genres whose formulaic nature started to precondition the expectations of the audiences. The Friday, 10–11 P.M., slot for which *Single Lives* was produced, aired mainly love stories, as the target audiences were women in their late twenties and early thirties. Thus, Nariai was expected to make a

love story. She gestured toward accommodating the love theme in *Single Lives*, but as I indicated earlier, the suspense theme ended up overshadowing the love stories. Nariai was explicit about not wanting to center her drama on romance, because that would be incompatible with her goal of criticizing the all-too-common stereotype that most young women simply want to marry men with decent paychecks and become homemakers. After all, her heroine was a career woman whose primary goal in life was not to become a housewife but to move ahead in her career.

This, however, was not Nariai's toughest challenge. The greatest obstacle she faced in making a drama about gender discrimination was that she did not have full control over the selection of her cast.[8] Esumi Makiko, the lead actress, was contracted by TBS's programming department for the season, and Nariai was asked to make a drama that was suitable (*fusawashii*) for her to star in. A year earlier, Esumi had become famous in a drama (*Shomuni*; Fuji, 1988) in which she had played a non-career-track office lady whose only interest lay in making company life more fun for herself. Both viewers and drama critics agreed that Esumi was a perfect match for the *Shomuni* role. The programming department expected Nariai to craft her heroine in dialogue with the character from *Shomuni*, who was a positive survivor type. This was incongruent with Nariai's plan to craft a heroine who struggled with an anxiety disorder because her male colleagues made company life hell for her.

The continuity in the media personas of the tarento is important to advertisers, because in Japan it is the tarento who endorse commodities in commercials. The maintenance of a positive (and coherent) public image is likewise important to the tarento themselves, as this is what they sell to television networks or advertising agencies. If a tarento's image is compromised, marketers and television networks will no longer want to associate their names with him or her. Thus, in an effort to maintain positive and consistent media personas, tarento often veto roles that they believe may harm their images. Although Esumi saw the dangers inherent in playing the Kyōko character in *Single Lives*, she had her own reasons for accepting the role. At the same time, she had nothing to lose, because she had already been contracted for a new season of *Shomuni*. Nariai explained to me that Esumi was worried that after *Shomuni* she would be typecast as a comedienne.[9] She was interested in taking up new challenges, and the role of Kyōko seemed to be just that. In the beginning of her career, Esumi was

often labeled a "hardworking girl" who had come to Tokyo from the "remote" Shimane Prefecture and who did not want to end up a typical tarento (i.e., a celebrity without real talent). On the contrary, she was perceived as determined to learn and improve her acting skills.[10] At the same time, because the role in *Single Lives* required her to play a character that was exactly opposite of the one she had played in *Shomuni*, she thought that it might be a chance for her to modify her media persona and add versatility to it. She saw the role as an opportunity to maximize her potential (and marketability) and prove that she could be successfully employed across a wider range of roles. Esumi thus agreed to the project of producing a socially critical (*shakaiha*) drama.

The themes Nariai wanted to tackle in the serial had remained on the margins of trendy drama. In bringing those themes to the fore, *Single Lives* was an exceptional drama.[11] As described earlier, Nariai was committed to portraying prostitution realistically instead of unequivocally denouncing or endorsing it. To that end, she engaged Sakai Ayumi, a freelance writer and former sex worker who had published numerous books on prostitution in Japan, in the production. One of the directors, Todaka Masataka, has commented on the difficulties involved in portraying prostitution: "there was certain danger inherent in *Single Lives*. It's easy to churn up the viewing rates by offering the audiences such an outrageous story that an elite office lady morphs into a prostitute. It is very hard not to endorse prostitution in trendy drama that tends to show everything in better light. We had to make sure that we would not approve it and we chose to do it by placing a strong emphasis on acting. We had the characters (Kyōko and Shimamura) convey unequivocally that they were deeply conflicted about their own involvement in prostitution."[12] The tension inherent in portraying prostitution is present in the drama. Yet the representation slips into romanticization, as most of Kyōko's clients are respectable salarymen who pay her to listen to them. (The one scene that deviates from this softer take on prostitution, in which a client beats Kyōko up, upset many viewers.)

Yet it was not prostitution but gender discrimination that Nariai was primarily interested in. She shared the feminist interpretation of Watanabe's double life that explained it as primarily a response to her frustrations related to work. The feminist labor sociologist Ōsawa Machiko has elaborated this reading of the Tōden murder case:

> How much could a woman really accomplish in a work environment oriented completely to men? The fact that the murdered woman in the Shibuya incident had been a member of the corporate elite was what really titillated public interest. . . . Many working women are quick to recognize the similarities between themselves and the murder victim. . . . Hers was the story of the frustration and the dilemmas faced by any woman of talent and ability who attempts to pursue a career in a male-centered society.[13]

Drama production is teamwork, yet Nariai took *Single Lives* as her own personal project: gender discrimination is prevalent in the corporate world, and as a career woman, she was also exposed to it. Because the programming department was running behind with scheduling the drama, staff was assigned to the project at the last minute. Ōsaki Masaya was the only scriptwriter available to take the offer. He had worked previously as a substitute writer, and *Single Lives* was his first independent script assignment. Nariai told me that the match was not perfect between her, the writer, and the dramatic theme. Ōsaki was not only inexperienced; he was also relatively uninterested in matters pertaining to gender discrimination. Nariai, moreover, had emphasized that the drama was based on *her own* experiences as a career office lady at TBS. Indeed, the script had turned out to be rather "feminine," and viewers remarked that they had thought the scriptwriter was female.

Nariai, like the murder victim Watanabe Yasuko, was an *ikkisei*—among the first women admitted to career-track positions at TBS. She told me that some of the dialogue from *Single Lives* was taken directly from her own experience.[14] She had graduated from the prestigious Waseda University with a law degree and joined TBS in 1984. She worked in news production until 1993, when she was transferred to the programming department (*hensei kyoku*). There she was assigned to produce feature mysteries, which achieved high ratings (around 20 percent). As a result, she was reassigned to drama production in 1998. She was asked to create a drama for the time slot on Friday at 10 P.M., for which she proposed *Single Lives*.

Nariai's career in the drama department was short-lived. TBS had scheduled the dramatic adaptation of the work of the famous comic artist Saimon Fumi, *P.S. Genki desu, Shunpei* (P.S. I'm Good, Shunpei), to air on Thursday at 9 P.M. during the same drama season, and because no other

producer was interested in the production,[15] Nariai also accepted that assignment. Another TBS producer told me that Nariai's decision to produce two dramas in the same season, with no prior experience in producing serial dramas, was suicidal. By the end of the season, Nariai had been hospitalized with a hernia. Eventually, she requested reassignment to the communications department.

I should stress that at the textual level, Nariai succeeded in her political agenda. *Single Lives* was one of the most progressive and critical dramas made in the 1990s. Not only did it encode progressive gender politics; it also provided a meta-commentary on recessionary Japan. It drew a bitter portrait of the social conditions that weighed heavily on the characters—namely, the crumbling of the corporate structure (i.e., the system of lifetime employment), the growing number of dysfunctional families, and the break-up of middle-class Japan. In the drama it was no longer a given, but a privilege, to identify as middle class. Most characters were flexible laborers without job security, health insurance, or pension plans. (In Japanese, these individuals are called "*freeters*," a term coined from the English word "free" and the German word "Arbeiter [worker].") The Yamagishi and Shimamura characters in *Single Lives* lacked the educational background to qualify for white-collar jobs, while marriage was the only way for Ayumi to secure a stable future for herself.

Kyōko was struggling to gain recognition in her company and to take pride in her corporate identity. Yet there was an ironic twist to her efforts to "identify" with a company that was incapable of offering her lifetime employment and that even forced her to contribute to the unethical management and financial malpractices to which it resorted as the economic slowdown foreclosed its chances for growth. Kyōko's colleagues were not portrayed in a positive light, either. In the company, the only pleasure for non-career-track office ladies was to annoy their superiors by sabotaging work. Similarly, the male employees, who were constantly under stress, took out their frustrations on their female colleagues or on sex workers. I highlight that the drama was a dark portrayal of post-bubble Japan, and the female characters' pervasive anxieties were not vanquished by marriage, the evergreen happy-ending formula for heroines in trendy dramas.

While Nariai was determined to make a socially important drama, the critical edge in commercial television production can also be understood as

a new selling point. To want to do something "slightly different" (in this case, something that is more realistic and critical than trendy dramas in general) and to want to win the race for high viewing rates are intentions that cannot be clearly separated from each other. Nariai was a highly competitive employee, one of the very few women who had made it to the drama production department, the most coveted department within the television network. She wanted to make a critical drama, but she was also concerned with the viewing rates—especially because she used to work in the programming department. Indeed, Nariai adapted the Tōden murder case into a drama serial not only because the double life of an elite career woman exercised a hold on her, but also because she thought that the serial would benefit from the media hype the murder story had generated. When I met her four years after the drama had been made, Nariai still remembered the ratings as broken down by each individual episode, and she was quick to explain their fluctuation (average, 12.1 percent; first episode, 16.4 percent; last episode, 14.2 percent). As an overall assessment of the low ratings, she surmised that she was wrong in her assumptions about the expectations of the target audiences.

Viewers' Desire: From *Single Lives* to the Screen Lives of the Tarento

The four bestsellers and the unceasing media interest showed that the murder case had wide popular appeal. Why is it then that viewers were not interested in the Tōden murder case in the format of television drama? What was it that they expected to get from this genre? To answer this question, I bring into play the viewers' responses to the drama, focusing on the discrepancies between the agenda of the producer and the expectations of the viewers.

Viewers' responses suggest that while the producer aimed to engage them at the level of the story line, they were more interested in the tarento and the fit between their real personalities and the characters they played. I infer from their comments that they resented the fact that the narrative functions of the tarento repressed their media personas—that is, that their roles were not continuous with the meanings, lifestyles, and attitudes the tarento represented as image commodities. Websites were my main source for analyzing viewers' responses to the drama because it was aired three years before I conducted my fieldwork research. I also asked my informants

about the serial—mostly women from the ages of twenty-six to thirty-five with whom I met on a regular basis to talk about television dramas during my two-year stay in Tokyo. However, only three in twenty-four women had seen some episodes of *Single Lives*. All of them knew about the Tōden murder case, but none was aware that it was employed as a motif for the drama. On the other hand, Japanese viewers commonly post their opinions on dramas on Internet sites such as individuals' blogs or bulletin boards (BBS) that are maintained for viewers to exchange opinions on dramas. I analyzed thirty-two viewers' opinions on *Single Lives*.

As I stressed earlier, it was not the story line but the *tarento* with which viewers were primarily concerned. What they discussed were mainly issues such as how the roles tarento played in the drama related to their roles in other dramas and which characters were best suited to their media and private personas. A viewer wrote, "This drama was interesting until the middle, but since then it's been going in a weird direction. Quitting her work and separating from Satō Kōichi [the actor playing Yamagishi], Esumi [the actress's real name] decides to live her life alone. Her refreshing laughter in the former drama [*Shomuni*] was the best. It seems to me that laughter fits her a lot better." Similarly, another viewer's comment illustrated how viewers relate the public and private personas of the tarento to each other: "Esumi Makiko just overplays her role. There is discrepancy between the role and the real person. It's getting harder and harder to watch her performance."[16]

A quote from another viewer illuminates how, in serialized dramas, it is primarily the tarento that attract the most attention and invite the most criticism:

> Basically I don't like Esumi. Her way of acting . . . but as a role it fits her better. She does have a strong aura, and the fewer the dialogues, the less obvious it is that she is a bad actress. . . . This drama fits Esumi better than *Overtime* [Fuji, 1999]. She has to use her aura. Satō Kōichi didn't get too many chances to demonstrate his acting talent. It's a pity. However, he conveys well the weirdness of the character he is playing. Katō Noriko. She has become much smarter along the way. It's quite a development. Cute performance and much more natural intonation. Nakamura. He plays the same character as in *Naomi* [Fuji, 1999]. He is always the moderate man.

3 Fans seem to agree that laughter fits Esumi better than roles in which she plays serious characters.

Viewers' criticisms tend to center on the relationships (articulations) between the roles tarento play and their "real" personalities (i.e., what viewers glean from their media appearances to be their real personalities). Another viewer wrote:

> This time, Aijima Kazuyuki [Kyōko's colleague and rival] plays an obnoxious character. This is a role that will invite much hostility especially among female viewers. Please don't forget that he is just an actor and don't be angry with him. At the same time, isn't it a mark of the actor's very success if the viewer gets angry with him? . . . In talking about his performance in this drama, what I have to mention is that this was Aizawa's first sadomasochistic scene in his career. I guess there are a lot of people who were shocked to see it. But I believe that he did a good job of conveying the fact that it was just a game into which he was invited.[17]

Viewers enjoy a sort of intimacy in their engagement with tarento. It is indeed curious how easily they slip between calling the drama's fictive characters by their real names. A viewer commented: "I hate Satō Kōichi [the name of the actor who played Yamagishi]. He takes revenge on Esumi Makiko [the name of the actress who played Kyōko] just because he is mad at the bank she is working for. I hate that freak [one of Kyōko's customers] too. He delivers a diatribe on the evils of prostitution, then beats up the prostitute [Kyōko]. It seems that the CEO at Esumi's bank will be her next customer. Esumi Makiko will be in deep trouble. I hate Katō Noriko [the name of the actress playing Ayumi] too. Her father controls her. She is like a bulldog; it seems as if she were to grab a man, she would never let go of him again. Yet Esumi Makiko is the most miserable of all. She is discriminated against in the bank and her mother is a freak."[18]

Most characteristically, viewers do not analyze the story line or relate the drama to social realities. Instead, they are interested in the characters. This corresponds to the fact that in trendy dramas characters *are* the story. Viewers are critical, but their criticism is channeled toward the tarento, whose fictitious and real personas they do not readily separate from one another. Even if they comment on the story line, it is mainly in the context of whether the roles assigned to the tarento in the narrative suit their public and private personas. In other words, it is mainly the performance of the tarento that viewers evaluate, which is a response that neatly dovetails with journalistic discourses on the drama.

The twenty-six articles I found on *Single Lives*, published mainly in weekly women's magazines, align with viewers' opinions and criteria for evaluating dramas. The overwhelming majority of them analyzed the performances of the tarento and reiterated their careers in trendy drama, emphasizing what the present drama added to each tarento's career: how it was different from and what it had in common with former appearances. A smaller number of the articles analyzed the dramas broadcast in the summer season and identified commonalties among them. Some of the critics were trying to guess which tarento would gross higher viewing rates. An essayist in the women's weekly *Josei Jishin*, for example, emphasized the competition between Esumi Makiko and Koizumi Kyōko (*Ren'ai Kekkon no Rūrū* [The Rules of Marrying for Love]), both of whom were playing career-track office ladies in the season.[19]

Even those articles that mentioned the connection between the drama and the Tōden murder case ended up stressing the difference between the office lady roles Esumi played in *Shomuni* and *Single Lives* and tried to guess whether the drama would be as popular as *Shomuni*.[20] One of the articles that compared the dramas, published in *Shūkan Posto*, called attention to the fact that three dramas that season featured career women. Quoting Shimamura Mari, an essayist who publishes widely on the culture of office ladies, the article emphasized the frustrations career women experienced at their workplaces as they were exposed to gender discrimination and sexual harassment.[21] This, however, is the only article that analyzed the dramas not primarily for their casts but for their themes and their relationship to social realities.

In chapter 1 I described how the mobilization of intertextual relations via viewing a television program designed to be in dialogue with other programs is a rich source of pleasure to the viewers. By playfully engaging viewers in the web of intertextual allusions, producers invite them into a game, and performing well means that viewers are "in the know." In contemporary Japan, television programs are often enjoyed less for their own merit than as building blocks of Japanese televisual culture. Understanding and enjoying a particular program in its relation to other programs offers viewers a whole participatory experience in Japanese media culture. In this way, televisual intertextuality functions to make viewers more committed to domestic media. In chapter 1, I argued that this game of televisual intertextuality derived from a deliberate strategy on the part of commercial networks to revive viewers' interest in the medium. To achieve this goal, networks started to produce programs that were more closely aligned with the sensibilities of particular audience segments. This trend has led to growing interdependence between television production and reception. (I will analyze this aspect of Japanese television in the next chapter.) This trend, in turn, calls into question the dominant approach in studies of television that understands viewers' agency in terms of accepting, negotiating, or resisting the proposed meanings (Abu-Lughod 2005; Ang 1985; Hall 1980 [1973]; Mankekar 1999; Morley 1980).

The prevailing models for analyzing viewers' engagement with television were developed in a context in which television operated as a mass-oriented (Fordist) system of production striving for audience maximization by producing programming that broad cross-segments of the audiences

could enjoy. It was reasonable to study reception and production as separate analytical realms in this context, as there always have been audience segments that are excluded from or misrepresented by mainstream mass culture. For audience research, Stuart Hall's essay "Encoding/Decoding" (1980 [1973]) offered a semiotic model describing the movement of the media message from producers to consumers. According to this model, the meanings in popular-culture texts are structured in dominance; producers encode a preferred reading (usually trying to please the most lucrative audience segment) that some viewers accept, while others negotiate or resist. Ien Ang's study of Dutch viewers of the Hollywood nighttime drama *Dallas* (Ang 1985) and David Morley's research on how class affiliation determines reading positions (Morley 1980) further refined this model. Yet these models remained grounded on the assumption that production and reception did not have a formative impact on each other. This approach worked well in these studies. While Ang examined the Dutch reception of a program that was produced in the United States and was not intended for Dutch audiences, Morley studied the reception of a news program that was intended not to entertain viewers but to provide them with information (i.e., unbiased accounts of events).

In the present day, the pre-eminent paradigm in theorizing viewers' agency focuses on how viewers accept, negotiate, or resist the proposed messages encoded in televisual texts. While this model assumes that meaning is enclosed in the text, my case study illustrates that meaning is generated not (or not only) from a single text but, rather, from a web of (inter)textual relations. Japanese viewers relate dramas to each other by analyzing the roles tarento have played in various dramas and produce meanings at a level organized above the individual text. Understanding agency as accepting, negotiating, or resisting encoded messages is less and less applicable in a context in which the intertextual game between producers and viewers blurs the line between production and reception. Japanese drama producers and viewers are in dialogue with each other, and the success of a television drama—as my case study suggests—largely depends on whether the producers manage to engage the audiences in a game. Hence, I suggest that while the model of encoding and decoding textual messages has not entirely lost its relevance to understanding agency in post-textual media production and reception, the relationship between producers and viewers is better conceptualized as a semiotic game than as

semiotic warfare. The trope of warfare that is part and parcel of the conceptual separation of production and reception as autonomous realms presupposes a divide between producers and viewers who are fixed in the positions of winners and losers. While in the cultural studies models television producers possess the power to encode meanings in their texts, my case study of *Single Lives* shows that producers prove increasingly powerless to encode meanings when the imperative is to please the audiences, regardless of what is required to do so. Just as the notion of the powerless viewer has been persuasively analyzed, I ask whether the problem of the "powerless culture industries" should not be considered.

For instance, Henry Jenkins (1992) introduced the concept of textual poaching to argue that although fans were powerless against the cultural industries, there was an ongoing struggle between writers and readers for the control of meaning. He analyzed fan fiction, in which female fans borrowed male characters from mainstream mass culture and transformed their relationships into stories of homosexual romance and porn. (This genre of fan fiction is called slash fiction.) Jenkins interpreted this subcultural practice as proof that viewers were not acquiescent recipients of messages proposed to them by the culture industries. Instead, they actively reworked texts to serve their interests. Jenkins's notion of viewer agency is grounded in the assumption that texts produced by the culture industries tend to be ideologically conservative and aim to reestablish the status quo (heteronormative sexuality in his study), while slash writers envision a world in which conventional sexual identities are redefined in a more fluid, less hierarchical fashion. In my analysis of the production and consumption of *Single Lives*, this relationship is subverted: it is the producer who is progressive, while the fans' interpretations are conservative and inflexible on three counts. First, we do not find criticism that links the story to contemporary social realities. Second, no viewer makes the connection between the Tōden murder case and the drama. And third, viewers do not predominantly analyze the drama in terms of career women's position in the corporate world, which, according to the producer, is what the drama intended to convey.

Why is it that the tarento draw viewers' attention and not the themes tackled in the dramas? Why is it that viewers did not make a connection between the Tōden murder case and *Single Lives?* Finally, why is it that viewers evaded the progressive gender politics the serial encoded? What Theodor Adorno (1991) describes as regressive listening in his essay on the fetish character in music is pertinent to understanding what is lost in translation between the producer and the viewers. Adorno (1991, 32) wrote, "The delight in the moment and the gay façade becomes an excuse for absolving the listener from the thought of the whole, whose claim is compromised in proper listening. The listener is converted, along his line of least resistance, into the acquiescent purchaser. No longer do the partial moments serve as a critique of that whole; instead they suspend the critique which the successful aesthetic totality exerts against the flawed one in society."

What, then, is "the delight in the moment" and "the gay façade" in *Single Lives* that distracts the viewers' attention from the political intentions of the producer? I have shown that viewers' responses and drama criticism overlapped in the sense that they both expected *Single Lives* to be an elaboration of the tarento and not a space where social problems were engaged. In this way, it is the tarento that becomes the gay façade distracting the viewers from the producer's agenda, as it is *their* intertextual histories and relations that viewers enjoy over the narrative. Viewers' attention is channeled into the tarento playing in *Single Lives*, and the tarento ultimately function to reinsert the viewers into consumer culture, as I will argue in chapter 4.

These reactions articulate well with processes of production. *Single Lives* was supposed to be tailored to the tarento Esumi Makiko. She was booked by TBS for the season, and Nariai was asked to make a *suitable* drama for her. In Hollywood film production, it is more common to create a story, then to audition actors for the roles; Japanese producers, however, started favoring the opposite order in parallel with the emergence of trendy drama and the concurrently rising importance of the tarento system in program production in the late 1980s. The tarento has the greatest impact on the story line, and the failure of *Single Lives* was due to the producer's rejection of this new trend. Nariai told me that she was not particularly interested in

making a drama for Esumi. Indeed, she proposed casting Katō Noriko (who played Ayumi) in the role of Kyōko, but the programming department did not endorse her idea, saying that Katō was an unknown actress who was unlikely to draw viewers to the serial. Ultimately, Nariai insisted on her own agenda, and instead of writing a story that fit the media persona of Esumi, she forced the tarento into her agenda (with her consent). I would argue that this is where the producer's investment did not pay off.

To conclude this argument, I will use the example of Esumi Makiko, who played the protagonist of *Single Lives*, to illuminate how tarento evolve into image commodities and how this trend affects drama production and reception. At the outset, we have to remember that the term "tarento" is not equivalent to the English term "celebrity." Mitsuhiro Yoshimoto (1996a; see also Aoyagi 2004) has pointed out that, while the Hollywood celebrity system is based on a separation between the stars' public personas (their screen lives) and their private lives, tarento are "amateur professionals" who supposedly show us only their true selves. My examples of viewers' comments support the idea that the line between the public and private personas of tarento is blurred. When viewers comment on the tarento, they discuss the authenticity of their performances in terms of how their roles suit their real selves (as if their true selves were an open book to the viewers). By mapping the trajectory of Esumi Makiko's tarento career, I will trace how she acquired her media persona and became an image commodity. A brief description of Esumi's career, in turn, will clarify why *Single Lives* failed as a result of its misappropriation of Esumi as image commodity. Before turning to her career, however, I briefly revisit the theme of why the image had become the privileged commodity in the Japanese television industry by the turn of the millennium. This reiteration is necessary to foreground my discussion of how the recent shift in emphasis from story-driven entertainment to lifestyle-oriented programming altered practices of televisual production and reception and reconfigured notions of agency in the 1990s.

Tessa Morris-Suzuki's definition of information as a new form of commodity is highly evocative of the ways in which the image was produced and consumed as a commodity in Japan in the 1990s. In contrast to the manufacturing of tangible goods, the production of intangible commodities such as information draws on a different source of profit. The main raw material is information itself in that new ideas are formed by combining existing

ideas in ways that are often only superficially different. Thus, the private expropriation of social knowledge becomes the new source of profit. This information, which is owned by society as a whole, becomes raw material for corporations to generate private profits that are far larger than those that could be obtained from the exploitation of their workforce. Morris-Suzuki (1988, 80–82) concluded that "information capitalism, therefore, does not only exploit the labor of those directly employed by the corporations, but also depends, more than any earlier form of economy, on the indirect exploitation of the labor of everyone involved in the maintenance, transmission and expansion of social knowledge: parents, teachers, journalists—in the end, everybody."[22]

In a similar vein, the raw material for producing image commodities is the image itself, which is not purchased on the market but simply discovered by tarento scouts and distributed (or set into circulation) by tarento agencies. In this process—which Brian Massumi (1992, 199–200) calls "reterritorialization"—the image becomes capital. In the production of tarento as image commodity, profit is generated not so much from the exploitation of labor power as from the very process of commodity circulation—that is, from the endless cycles of reinvesting them as capital. This is but one aspect of what Massumi (1992, 199–200) has identified as a shift in the functioning of capitalism, in that "the circulation of objects replaces their production as the motor of the economy." The tarento are reterritorialized or reappropriated by tarento scouting agencies that sell them to advertisers and to music and television companies that will further invest them as capital, thus refining their exchange value. It is an important point that the viewers also become a part of the production process, as they become fans of tarento, maintain websites promoting them, and serve as a constant source of feedback to inform image producers about how to modify the image to best please the audiences.

The priority given to the tarento over the story was thus a phenomenon that evolved in tandem with the development of trendy drama. This is evident in a diatribe by Ōta Tōru (1996, 188–89), a producer for Fuji, against scriptwriters who are not familiar with contemporary tarento and televisual culture:

> These days there are a great number of people who want to become scriptwriters. Accordingly newer and newer scenario schools are estab-

> lished. Occasionally I'm invited to give a talk and I always ask the students: If you have to make a drama for the Fuji Monday, 9–10 P.M., program slot and Fukuyama Masaharu [the top musician and actor in the mid-1990s] is cast in the lead role, what would you make for this combination? Students usually cannot answer this question, not because they are not smart, but because they are nerds. They are not familiar with current television programs and they don't know what dramas are broadcast in the Monday, 9–10 P.M., program slot. What disturbs me even more is that they don't know who Fukuyama Masaharu is. *This is nonsense*. If someone wants to be a scenario writer, she has to be familiar with the characteristics of primetime program slots of each television station, and she has to know who the most popular tarento are and what drama she could make for that tarento.[23]

In Ōta's explanation, it is clear that the tarento enjoy the utmost importance in drama production. Similarly, Suzuki Masayuki, another director for Fuji, compared the employment of tarento to capital investment. He said that when he was asked to make a drama (*Hero*; Fuji, 2001) for Kimura Takuya, the most popular tarento in the second half of the 1990s, he thought of him as precious capital that had to be invested with great care, because a good investment would yield him profits and fame (Uesugi and Takakura 2000).

In a similar vein, Nariai, the producer of *Single Lives*, was asked to make a capital investment—in 1999, Esumi was ranked among the top-three most popular actresses—but she did not make a good decision. She did not honor the fact that Esumi was not an empty signifier that could be freely filled with meanings but was, instead, a carefully engineered image commodity.

Let us now turn to tracing how Esumi Makiko evolved as an image commodity to understand better how the producer of *Single Lives* failed to invest the capital that was Esumi wisely. Esumi acquired her exchange value in the course of a mainstream tarento career. She was a volleyball player who became a model in 1990. Before her first dramatic performance in 1995, she had performed in fourteen commercials endorsing a range of products. Her repeat commercial performances included ads for Shiseido (cosmetics), Ōtsuka Seiyaku (energy drinks and health food), Morinaga Seika (sweets), and Canon (digital cameras). In terms of exchange value,

what she sold as an image commodity was a highly energetic and positive modern woman whose beauty stemmed from naturalness and whose signature characteristic was her courage to be different from the mainstream. It was cheerfulness that determined her advertising persona. Correspondingly, many viewers claimed that laughter fit Esumi better than the agony she was assigned to perform in *Single Lives*. Her career in advertising was steadily developing from the 1990s onward, gearing up in the second half of the 1990s in parallel with her career as an actress. Between 1995 (after her dramatic debut) and 2004, Esumi appeared in fifty-four commercials.[24]

Between 1995 and 2004, Esumi played in twenty-five television serials and feature films. Her dramatic debut was in the Sunday feature drama *Kagayake Rintaro* (Lighten Up, Rintaro; TBS, 1995). A year later, she was cast in a Friday drama, *Garasu no Kakeratachi* (Shards; TBS, 1996) as a supporting character. She got her first lead role in *Konna Watashi ni Dare ga Shita no* (The Hit Manager; Fuji, 1996), in which she played a self-employed manager of *manzai* (a style of stand-up comedy) artists who was unable to gain recognition in the professional entertainment world because she was too outspoken. She played a single woman who lived in a messy apartment and whose diet consisted mainly of instant noodle soup. Her character was reminiscent of Kuruma Torajiro (Tora san), the bohemian hero of the veteran director Yamada Yōichi's *Otoko wa Tsurai yo* (It's Hard to Be a Man!) series. Tora san was the opposite of middle-class Japan: his education ended in junior high school, he did not have a stable income, and he was not married. Instead, he was tirelessly roaming the countryside searching for love and adventure. Each film ended with Tora san being heartbroken and setting out on a new journey. (In Esumi's advertising career, the mobility theme is up front. She endorses travel agencies, cars, and digital cameras, which are important accessories for travel.) The commonalty between Tora san and Esumi's character in *The Hit Manager* is that they both remain on the margins of society.

It was *Shomuni* that had the most decisive impact on Esumi's televisual persona. The series achieved the highest viewing rates (28.5 percent) among the dramas she appeared in. Viewers and producers agreed that in this drama there was a perfect match between the role and tarento, because the role was in alignment with her media persona. In *Shomuni*, Esumi played a non-career-track office lady working for the general affairs department, also referred to as the graveyard of loser employees. In that position,

she could freely criticize whatever she pleased. Her signature characteristics were her laughter and her bohemian behavior. *Shomuni* continued the bohemian character of *The Hit Manager*,[25] which manifests itself in the fact that the female protagonist is not bound by obligations to parents or husbands. The bohemian nature of the *Shomuni* protagonist, Chinatsu, came from the character's past: before entering the corporate world, Chinatsu was a star in the adult video world. This feature of her past was deployed in the drama only as proof of her courage to be different from the mainstream—which, again, was the main thrust of her media persona. In contrast, *Single Lives* departed from Esumi's media persona. The producer agreed that office-lady drama (*OL mono*) suited Esumi's character best, but she decided not to follow Esumi's televisual persona. Esumi had initially been identified as a highly energetic, positive, and bohemian character whose lifestyle did not conform to middle-class norms but who gained popularity by molding her outsider position into the role of the critic. Quite the opposite, Nariai assigned Esumi to play a character whose deviation from the ideal, normatively valorized female life course led to her marginalization. The ratings indicate that viewers did not find these adjustments stimulating. Many viewers were even annoyed by the damage the drama inflicted on the televisual careers of these tarento. Viewers seemed less interested in a drama about women's struggles in the corporate world than in how the new roles suited the real personality of the tarento. By arguing that a certain role did not fit a tarento, viewers discerned a misreading of the tarento as image commodity.

Conclusion: Image, Fetish, and Agency

The double life of the Tōden murder victim, Watanabe Yasuko, brought a number of disconcerting issues to public attention. Why did an elite employee of a prestigious company become a prostitute? What was going on in her professional and private lives that compelled her to labor in two starkly different worlds of work? What touched a nerve with the public was that she had transgressed a very strictly maintained boundary between the educational elite and the underclasses of the sex industry. In a context in which the erosion of mass middle-class society was having wide-ranging effects, Watanabe's transgression was especially disconcerting, for it highlighted the fragility of class boundaries and intensified fears of downward class

mobility. Two aspects of Watanabe's story were especially unsettling: First, she was a woman; and second, she did not buy sex but sold it. Her address book contained phone numbers for more than sixty clients, and most of these "returnees" were respectable white-collar salary men. However, buying sex is forgivable for men. As Anne Allison (1994) has described, the major revenue of hostess clubs comes from the corporate budget; companies encourage their employees to visit these premises, where they can bond with each other and as a result become more committed employees. On the other hand, women's sexuality is dominantly constructed within the domestic sphere, because they are still expected to quit their jobs once they have married and to become full-time homemakers (Allison 1996; Ogasawara 1998). The problem was not only that Watanabe did not retire to the domestic sphere, but also that she was defiantly sexual in the public sphere. Moreover, she did not separate her daytime and nighttime activities. Rumor had it that she used her Tōden business card to introduce herself to new clients in the sex industry. Some interpreted this as an act of revenge to stain the reputation of the company (Sanō 2000).

Watanabe's story alarmed many Japanese career women. Among them was the young female TBS producer Nariai Yūka. Her debut serial drama, *Single Lives*, was a contribution to wider efforts to find meaning in Watanabe's life and death. Nariai's proposal was explicit about the drama's connection to the Tōden murder case, and as I have argued in this chapter, *Single Lives* did succeed in producing a critical commentary on gender discrimination against women in Japanese workplaces. Furthermore, I have argued that *Single Lives* was one of the most progressive and critical dramas produced in the 1990s. Yet it apparently was not a story that viewers expected or welcomed in a trendy drama. Indeed, stories are not the major source of pleasure for viewers who watch trendy dramas. Instead, viewers derive enjoyment from information on lifestyles and participation in another story organized *above* the textual level of the drama. Such meta-narratives are woven out of the histories of individual tarento as image commodities and representatives of particular lifestyles they have come to be associated with in the process of endorsing commodities in advertisements. Trendy dramas capitalize on tarento power. Drama professionals can maintain only partial control over the production process, because tarento agencies and advertisers (in addition to viewers) expect that drama roles should be consistent with the exchange values of tarento

as image commodities. This is imperative for them, because tarento agencies sell tarento as commodities, while advertisers employ them as image commodities to endorse other commodities. The narrative in trendy drama is not simply subordinated to the screen lives of tarento. Rather, stories are tailor-made for the tarento. As my case study illustrates, if a producer evades this rule, her drama is unlikely to succeed. That viewers did not draw connections between the Tōden murder case and *Single Lives* can be explained by the fact that, in tandem with the emergence of trendy drama, the tarento were gaining primacy in drama production.

The viewers' attention was diverted from the drama's story line (i.e., a commentary on the murder case) and channeled into a detail—Esumi's public persona—which in turn overwrote the murder case. Esumi commodified the drama, and the drama further commodified her, polishing her as an image commodity. The tarento is identified with her role, and the distinction between image and reality is effaced. The Tōden murder case was dissolved in the drama, which became an extension of Esumi's own publicity. The viewers' lives were enriched not with a new perspective on social problems (brought to the surface by the murder case), but with more details about Esumi Makiko: did laughter or agony suit her more, or did the uniform of the non-career-track office lady in *Shomuni* or the haute couture of the career-track character in *Single Lives* fit her better? The tarento as a fetish object is characterized by its capacity to absorb into itself the sociocultural ideals it is supposed to represent and so serve as the emblem of a particular lifestyle or attitude.

Because tarento are key to the success of television programs, they are increasingly becoming indispensable in mediating realities for Japanese audiences. Thus, television is becoming ever less capable of preserving and conveying the immediacy and complexity of social realities. Marilyn Ivy (1993, 255) has called attention to the ways in which television in Japan "has increasingly blurred the line between a stable, external 'reality' and an imagined one." This process seemed to have intensified by the end of the twentieth century, as television networks sought to re-attract viewers in the wake of rapid audience fragmentation. In this process, television underwent massive commercialization, and networks started to produce tarento at an ever faster rate. Via the circulation of these image commodities, Japanese television produces and maintains a meta-reality, participation in

which is a source of pleasure—one that is tied to image fetishism. In chapter 4, I will analyze the ways in which viewers appropriated image fetishism as a source of empowerment. Before doing so, however, I will take a closer look at the ways in which the new emphasis on the tarento has altered the relationship between drama production and reception.

Three

Dream Labor in the Dream Factory

CAPITAL AND AUTHORSHIP IN DRAMA PRODUCTION

Ōta Tōru, the birth father of the trendy drama, could barely hide his jealousy when, in a magazine interview, he commented on the so-called young female scriptwriter boom (*wakate josei kyakuhonka būmu*). "This is the golden age of scriptwriters, isn't it? Until now producers, directors or writers had equal chances to get into the limelight, while these days, it is young writers who attract the most attention from the production team" (Ōta 1994, 376). In parallel with the development of trendy drama, a growing number of young female scriptwriters entered the television business, and by the mid-1990s they had become the "public face" of trendy drama. Interviews with young female scriptwriters have been collected and published (Komatsu and Matsumoto 2000; Satake 1997, 2000), and many of them, in turn, became celebrated columnists for weekly and monthly magazines, ready to give advice to women on such themes as dating, falling in love, and conflicts in marriage and at work. At the same time, hundreds of

individual interviews graced the pages of women's magazines portraying young female writers as new lifestyle icons, with accompanying images posing them as celebrities clad in pricey designer fashions. By the mid-1990s, being a television writer had become one of the top-five most coveted professions among young women.

By focusing on the changing labor conditions in the television industry, this chapter will continue to document and analyze the strategies commercial television networks employed to reinvent their system of mass production in an era marked by the declining importance of mass consumption and the demise of mass middle-class society (*chūkan taishū shakai*). I argue that young female writers played a crucial role in reconciling the conflicts between a mass-oriented television industry, viewers who were less and less interested in programs with mass appeal, and advertisers who demanded either audience maximization or more precise demographic targeting. The Japanese television industry has remained a highly capital- and labor-intensive system of production, with significant costs of operation covered for the most part by primetime advertising. Unlike most fields of manufacturing, where automation or outsourcing can reduce the demands for expensive human labor and, thus, the costs at which goods are produced, television production entails creative labor that cannot be automated or always outsourced. To offset the skyrocketing production costs, networks charge astronomical fees for commercial time, for which advertisers demand either high ratings (preferably at least 15–20 percent) or more precise demographic targeting to guarantee that their commercial messages will reach the intended segment of the population.[1] The question for commercial networks, then, was how to readjust their system of mass production to cater to new demands in the wake of eroding mass middle-class society and in the face of the waning power of middle-class consciousness to orient aspirations.

Media economists have noted that capitalizing on star power and concentrating on wealthy audience segments have always been fundamental strategies to fall back on in volatile business conditions (de Vany 2004). In previous chapters, I discussed the ways in which local networks drew on the tarento system to re-attract viewers to television. Here, I argue that the young female scriptwriter boom was an effect of the trend in which networks started to seek out new "wealthy" audience segments that fetched top dollars from advertisers. In the wake of the growing tensions between

advertisers, viewers, and networks, producers at Fuji identified a new demographic: single women from the ages of eighteen to thirty-four who by the mid-1980s had become the most dynamic consumers. In the 1980s, the fashion, cosmetics, and leisure industries primarily relied on magazines to reach young female consumers. In the second half of the 1980s, however, these sponsors became interested in advertising on television, and it was in response to this new interest that television producers began developing the trendy drama to attract young women to the medium.

While the new target audiences were young single women holding non-career-track clerical and secretarial positions (office ladies), producers and directors were (overwhelmingly male) career-track employees of elite media corporations. Because of their social proximity to the new target audiences, young female writers could serve as translators between male producers and young female viewers. This translation, however, was not a smooth process, and the conflicts between these female writers (who were freelancers) and male producers (who were full-time employees of television networks) were enduring. According to scriptwriters' accounts, producers were frequently perceived as violating the scriptwriters' authorship and pride in their work. Producers, meanwhile, blamed scriptwriters for "being unprofessional (*puro dewanai*)." By this, of course, the producers meant that the young female writers did not understand that the ultimate goal was to win in the "ratings game" with other networks. In other words, they accused young writers of not sharing in the corporate identity. Indeed, corporate identity was exactly what was denied to them, for they were not on the corporate payroll as the producers were.

I suggest that these conflicts shed light on an important characteristic of television production in an era in which the traditional balance between mass and niche marketing has been fundamentally upset—namely, the scriptwriter phenomenon illustrates the growing interdependence between production and reception. In this context, programs have to be "engineered" to the tastes of particular audience segments, and this specific targeting calls for new forms of mediation between production and reception. As I noted in earlier chapters, in the fields of media studies and cultural anthropology television has been analyzed dominantly as a mass medium that has traditionally drawn on stable mass markets. As a corollary, television production and reception have been treated as separate analytical categories, and agency has been analyzed in terms of how

viewers negotiate or resist the meanings proposed to them by the culture industries. While this chapter does not question viewers' capacity to decode televisual texts in ways unintended by their producers, it aims to highlight the fact that in the era of post-mass television production, the crucial site of conflict—what Stuart Hall (1980 [1973]) calls "semiotic warfare"—previously conducted between producers and viewers and waged over meaning has moved to the realm of program production.[2] Program production, in turn, has become a primary ground where notions of identity and womanhood—of particular interest in this chapter—are negotiated.

Attracting Young Women to Television

Because young female writers were capable of portraying the lifestyles and desires of young women with psychological realism, engaging them in drama production was a strategy to make these programs appealing to the new target audience. Young female writers, however, entered the drama scene only after the initial strategies networks employed—that is, embedding the trendy drama in consumer culture and transforming program slots into genre slots—were no longer sufficient to maintain young women's interest in the genre. The young female scriptwriter boom is thus indicative of the fact that the trendy drama is inherently a high-risk commodity. A cursory comparison with Japanese game shows helps explain why primetime dramas are such risk-laden business investments and how these risk factors affect the labor relations in drama production.

Game shows, which featured tarento not only as hosts but also as contestants, were an alternative response to the shrinking primetime ratings—a result of the waning power of television as a producer of programs with mass appeal. As was the case with earlier home dramas, game shows offered an effective strategy for maximizing audiences because they featured tarento of various ages. In Japan, tarento tend to draw viewers from the same age groups to which they themselves belong. Thus, these programs can be watched by anyone for the game element and by particular segments of viewers who watch the shows to see their favorite tarento. While drama production entails long-term planning and large-scale capital investments, game shows are capable of circumventing the rigidities of drama production. On the one hand, the producers of game shows contract

tarento for individual programs. On the other hand, the program theme does not need to be reinvented in every new season, as is the case with drama serials. Each new serial requires a new character set and theme, whose novelty involves risks each time. In contrast, the format of the game show is preset, and depending on the ratings, minor adjustments can easily be made. Moreover, the costs of the production are low: these programs are filmed in studios, and the footage (documentary-style clips) used in the programs are often purchased from small production companies or obtained from transnational media libraries, sparing television networks the expense of production.

Drama serials, by contrast, entail long-term, inflexible booking schedules and contracts with tarento agencies. Tarento have to be booked for three months (an entire drama season), and damaging deficits are accrued if a drama is canceled in the middle of a broadcasting season due to failing ratings and the withdrawal of sponsorship. The production costs, of course, are also higher: shooting on location is more costly than filming in a studio, and although minor adjustments can be made to the characters or the story, nothing can be done if viewers do not like the articulation between the role and the tarento playing it—as chapter 2 showed. That is to say, the inflexible production processes have made trendy drama a high-risk commodity that is not ideal for flexible accumulation. Yet producers at Fuji could not crank out a viable alternative to this entertainment form. The other available genres of primetime programming—game shows and variety shows—were indeed only moderately popular with young women. And because it was young women that commercial sponsors became interested in reaching, the Fuji Network took a big risk and launched the trendy drama, hoping that it would be more appealing to young women than game shows had been.

As mentioned, in the late 1980s the fashion and leisure industries became interested in investing in primetime advertising targeted to young women. Throughout the 1980s, these industries had relied on women's magazines as their primary advertising platform, making the decade the golden age of magazine publishing (see Moeran and Skov 1995; Rosenberger 1996; Sakamoto 1999). Magazines were quick to follow social trends, such as young women's turn to consumption as a means of self-expression, and provided a relatively inexpensive space (compared with television) where advertisers could deliver their messages to this demo-

graphic (Matsubara 1998). In addition, unlike television, the magazine industry was capable of targeting its readership in small age groups distinguished from each other by two to three years. To put it differently, television responded to young women's privileged position in consumer culture in the late 1980s—much later than magazines did—after this segment of the population already had been molded into a clearly defined marketing category. It was only then that the fashion and leisure industries perceived it to be safe to invest in television advertising.

Young female scriptwriters were engaged only in the early 1990s, when it became clear that initial strategies were insufficient to maintain young women's interest in the new genre. Before these scriptwriters were engaged, producers of trendy dramas deployed two strategies to make the new programs attractive to young women. First, they embedded their new dramas in consumer culture; second, they capitalized on the time-slot system. I will elaborate on the former aspect in chapter 4, where I will describe how exactly producers transformed their new dramas into showcases for consumer trends. Here I wish to emphasize only that making lifestyle a focal point of these shows was a key strategy for networks to draw young women to television. Yamada Yoshiaki, a producer at Fuji, highlights this point in his explanation of the launching of the new drama:

> Until 10 years ago, . . . there were no dramas addressing young women from eighteen to twenty five. We realized that it was a precious market and we did not understand why it was not covered. . . . In the beginning, many people argued that in the bubble period, young women actually did not return home to watch television. Audience research concluded that young women were more likely to hang out with friends after work; they went to discos, attended English language classes and pursued hobbies. We started producing new dramas (later labeled trendy drama) in the midst of this general pessimism suggesting that young women were simply not interested in watching television. We decided that we wanted to make dramas that would gratify young women and make them return home early so that they could watch dramas. . . . It was important that these dramas should be *a source of information* to the viewers. With these guidelines in mind we . . . made proposals for *Kimi no Hitomi wo Taihō Suru* [Those Eyes of Yours Are under Arrest] and *Dakishimetai* [I Want to Hold You]. (Satake 1997, 189–90; emphasis added)

By "information," Yamada meant not so much that commercials would air during the broadcast of the trendy dramas (as that was obvious) as rather that information (on consumer trends) would be integrated into the dramas to make them more appealing to young women. Ōta (1996, 22) is less equivocal in explaining the connection between consumerism and trendy dramas:[3]

> We came up with the basic concept for trendy dramas, but we didn't know how to get young women to watch them. I leafed through women's magazines to learn about popular trends among young women, and we've adopted all of them into the new dramas, so that they would attract young female viewers. It seems ridiculous now how meticulously I discussed the fashion section of women's magazines with staff (hair stylists, makeup artists, and so forth) in order to craft characters appealing to young women. In the early trendy dramas we paraded around protagonists with fancy, foreign-sounding professions and reconstructed the latest trends in cuisine, fashion, and interior design. . . . We measured the success of our dramas by the number of phone calls we received inquiring about fashion and other items featured in the drama.

To attract young women to television, the producers of trendy dramas not only embedded their programs in consumer culture; they also started to exploit the system of program slots (*wakugumi*) more systematically.[4] As I described in the introduction, in the late 1980s networks had started transforming program slots into genres identified with specific thematic and representational foci. The notion was that in particular time slots, networks would feature shows that shared the same topics, characters' lifestyles, and modes of representation.

The new genre slots have enabled the networks to target entertainment to different segments of a fragmented audience. The system has also served to attract a new range of sponsors interested in reaching particular audiences, such as young women. Because television advertising was much more costly than advertising in other media, the major advertisers during primetime programming were producers of mass commodities such as Kao (toiletries), Matsushita/Panasonic, Toyota Car, Suntory (beer and carbonated soft drinks), Shiseido (cosmetics and hair care), Honda, Asahi Beer, Sapporo Beer, NEC (electronics), and Mitsubishi Car. While television could deliver the largest number of viewers to commercial sponsors, it could not

guarantee that the messages of particular sponsors would reach the desired target audiences. This is what the system of genre slots aimed to achieve: a more precise demographic targeting.[5] Indeed, trendy dramas further compartmentalized their target viewers in the 1990s with even more precise niche marketing. While dramas aired in Fuji's Monday 9–10 P.M. program slot primarily target women from the ages of eighteen to twenty-five, TBS's Friday 10–11 P.M. drama slot is designed mainly for viewers from the ages of twenty-six to thirty-four.[6]

In sum, television drama production is capital-intensive, and the risk in launching trendy dramas was that it tailored programming to a demographic that had not been committed to the medium. At that point, producers could not anticipate whether it was possible for young women to incorporate television watching into their leisure practices. This is why producers at Fuji capitalized on the system of genre slots and decided to embed the first dramas in the consumer culture with which young women felt so familiar. In the first phase of trendy dramas, young female writers were not yet part of the scene: more established, male scriptwriters wrote the "catalogue dramas." The dramas achieved good ratings, but the ratings were not increasing, and the overall response was that the shows offered dreams without having sufficient roots in reality (*rearitī no nai yumemonogatari*). On hearing such responses, producers recognized that *realism* was something they could cash in on. To that end, they engaged young female scriptwriters to help them portray women's culture, aspirations, and fantasies in a more down-to-earth, realistic manner.

The Producers' Story

By the early 1990s, it had become clear that mediation was necessary between female viewers and male producers. This, indeed, is not surprising. While the new audiences were young, non-career-track office ladies, drama producers were high-flying, career-track male employees. These two groups occupied starkly different spaces in the social geography. In his book, Ōta (1996) describes attending concerts and exhibitions where young women congregated to observe their behavior. A scriptwriter noted to me that Ōta did take his research (*shuzai*) very seriously; he was very diligent about taking young women out to dinner to learn about their lifestyles. Male producers believed that it was the Cinderella fairy tale (see Koizumi 2000),

and ever new configurations of it, that female viewers wanted to watch. In other words, male producers perceived young women as vulnerable and weak individuals who are unable to succeed, or even survive, in society without the support and protection of men.[7]

In this section, I explore the producers' positions to understand why they held this perception of the viewers and the degree to which they had the power to impose their ideas on other members of the production staff—mainly the writers. Most Japanese television producers and directors come from top private universities (e.g., Keio and Waseda). Many, however, are graduates of the most prestigious national universities, the University of Tokyo and the University of Kyoto. In the television business, this means that producers- and directors-to-be are not graduates of professional schools; they start their careers as assistants assigned to older colleagues under whose guidance they master the profession.[8] Particular to Japanese enterprises, this method of in-house training serves to secure the loyalty of employees to the network that launched their careers. This is why it is highly unlikely that producers or directors would seek employment at a network other than the one that trained them.[9] This said, most television employees do not retire from the section in which they began their careers. Even though it takes years to learn the craft of producing a particular televisual genre, such as drama, news, or variety shows, producers are commonly reassigned to other departments within the same network or transferred to the network's branch offices overseas or in the countryside. These practices serve to ensure a degree of flexibility in the rigid system of lifetime employment—another key characteristic of the Japanese corporate structure in the postwar period that television networks managed to preserve even in the wake of the economic recession. Reassigning employees among departments or branch offices is a strategy both to reward talented employees by allowing them to move up in the corporate hierarchy and to demote employees who fail to live up to the expectations of their senior colleagues. As a result of these corporate practices, many producers think of themselves as something in between salarymen and artists (*geijutsuka*).[10] Nevertheless, many admit that "authorship" and "creativity" would be equivocal terms to describe their work for three reasons: first, policies of reassigning employees among departments and branch offices circumvent the development of artistic consciousness; second, freshman employees cannot choose which department they will be

assigned to; and third, drama production involves teamwork with a subtle division of labor.

Most producers do not wear neckties, which distinguishes them from salarymen, and experience it as a shock when they are expected to don them (e.g., if they are transferred to the programming department). While some consider themselves artists and others identify as businessmen, in my opinion they are closer to athletic coaches, whose primary goal is to set new records for their sponsors and companies (i.e., to win the race for the highest audience ratings both within their networks and against other networks). When talking to producers, I found it curious how often they used sports metaphors—primarily from golf and baseball—to explain their profession. In his book, Ōta (1996) insisted that the distinction was enormous between ratings of 29.9 percent and 30 percent. This illustrates that producers can be intensely competitive, as mere fractions of ratings points would not have made a difference in a network's ranking in a particular genre.

Unlike freelance scriptwriters, producers are paid monthly salaries and two yearly bonuses from their affiliated television networks. When their dramas achieve high viewing rates, they receive additional bonuses. However, the financial incentive is by no means the only one encouraging them to achieve high audience ratings. In the headquarters of TBS, for instance, daily ratings charts are posted in front of the elevators. A producer told me that if his viewing rates were low, he felt ashamed to get into the elevator and would take the stairs instead. Another example of this mentality further illustrates this point. I was told that within the drama department (*dorama seisakubu*), producers did not offer opinions about their colleagues' dramas before the viewing rates became available. The reason for this was that if their opinions were not in alignment with the audience ratings, they might be accused of not being able to assess properly what is interesting to the audiences, which is considered an essential skill for their profession. That is, pressure from colleagues is just as relevant a motivation for producers to achieve high ratings as financial rewards.

Being a producer is highly demanding, both mentally and physically. Stories of mental breakdown and suicide are not rare in the business. In the 1990s, star producers such as Ōta Tōru (Fuji) and Ueda Hiroki (TBS) were mocked as the "ghosts" of the network, for they ate, slept, and lived there (Kitagawa et al. 2001; Ōta 1996). Ueda's career is exemplary of the

intensity of working in the drama department of a commercial television network. The first drama he was in charge of as the producer in chief was the detective drama (*keiji mono*) *Keizoku* (Beautiful Dreamer; 1999). The drama turned out to be a hit, and Ueda was suddenly celebrated as the young star producer at TBS. As a result he was assigned to TBS's top investment dramas *Beautiful Life* and *Good Luck*, both featuring the most sought-after tarento, Kimura Takuya. The star writers Kitagawa Eriko (*Beautiful Life*) and Inoue Yumiko (*Good Luck*) were contracted to write the scripts, and the viewing rates reached record highs: the series finales achieved 41.3 percent and 37.6 percent, respectively. However, Ueda's career in drama production was only four years long. In 2001, at thirty-five, he was transferred to the programming department because of his failing health.

In parallel with the growing tensions between the expectations of viewers for more custom-tailored entertainment and the demands of sponsors for high ratings, the work of producers has become incomparably more stressful. They are the ones who have to coordinate the division of labor within the production team and who have to negotiate with the sponsors, the programming department, and the tarento agencies. The producer works out the character set and drama plot together with the scriptwriter and the tarento cast in the lead roles. The consent of the tarento to give their name to a particular story is indispensable for the programming departments to approve the drama plan. I have noted earlier that in parallel with the development of the trendy drama, tarento have gained unprecedented influence in drama production. As producers believe that tarento are essential to achieve high ratings, they all want to cast some of the twenty or so most popular celebrities, whose booking schedules are finalized two to three years in advance. In other words, because top tarento are booked two years in advance, replacing them is close to impossible. Producers and writers have to craft roles for them that the tarento find agreeable. Moreover, their casting of other tarento for supporting roles has to meet the approval of the lead tarento (who is cast for the protagonist's role).

During fieldwork, one of my informants, the scriptwriter Nakazono Miho, engaged me in the research for her new drama, *Hakoiri Musume* (Innocence in Bloom; Fuji and KTV [Kansai Telecasting Corporation], 2003). Inspired by the Hollywood blockbuster *My Big Fat Greek Wedding* (2002), Nakazono planned to draft a drama based on the theme of international

marriage. In her mind, marriage to a foreign man was a playful but effective way to criticize patriarchal gender relations in Japan. The drama is the story of two sisters, thirty-four-year-old Hana and her twenty-year-old-sister, Akari. While Akari believes that the key to happiness is marriage to a wealthy man, Hana insists that the only person who can make her happy is herself. Hana finally finds true love when she meets an American tourist who is visiting Mount Takao, the place of her parents' home in Hachioji, a suburban area in the western part of Tokyo.

I helped Nakazono by interviewing some of my foreign male friends regarding their lifestyles in Japan, the places they were likely to frequent, and their perception of Japanese women. While the actual shooting began after I had left Japan, I followed the vicissitudes of crafting the characters and of casting—with the latter posing a huge headache for the production staff. Iijima Naoko, the tarento cast for Hana's role, did not feel comfortable with the plan that she would have a foreign love interest and kept vetoing the candidates who auditioned for the role. Although she finally settled on a neophyte Caucasian actor from the United Kingdom, at one point the production staff contemplated abandoning the theme of international marriage altogether.

Aside from the tarento, who frequently veto casting plans or refuse to play certain characters, the producer, assistant producer, director, assistant director, and scriptwriter have to discuss and agree to the plan for the drama. It is generally held that if one person on the team (i.e., one in five members) does not like the script, it translates to a 20 percent loss in the target audiences. Yet it is the producer whose opinion carries the most weight, and ultimately the scriptwriter will be required to do as many rewrites as necessary to ensure that the producer finds the script agreeable. When the negotiations between the producers and scriptwriters are concluded, the scriptwriter can start writing the script itself, although the producer closely supervises the writing process.

The pressure to come up with a good idea (an interesting character or theme) for a drama can be inferred from the ways scriptwriters complain about producers. When Kitagawa was asked whether she had had experience with sexual harassment in the context of being surrounded by male production staff, she answered that she thinks of the consultations (*uchiawase*) with the producers as something very close to sexual harassment.

A significant majority of the production staff is male, and they rip her scripts apart and nonchalantly say things like, "This is not interesting at all (*zenzen omoshirokunai*)" (Kitagawa 2000b). By relating a corresponding observation to me, the scriptwriter Nakatani Mayumi confirmed my understanding that these tensions are generated by the growing difficulties producers face as they try to deliver the desired high ratings to their sponsors in the era of market fragmentation: "Often producers ask me to change the whole plot after they have already approved it. Two types of producers do this. The first type cannot envision the drama from a proposal, while the other type simply changes his mind way too often. In these cases, I end up investing an unreasonable amount of time into something that is doomed to be *boring*."[11]

The adjective "boring" suggests that the tedium of repeated rewriting is terribly unsatisfying for the scriptwriter; as I will illustrate later, however, such conflicts often result in scripts that are ultimately not interesting to the audiences, either. If this is the case, the audience ratings will naturally be low, and the entire production team has to take responsibility. Sometimes drama workers mention that one of the most important dimensions of teamwork is that team members share success and failure. Yet scriptwriters remain the most vulnerable members of the team. Since they are freelancers, they simply will not continue to be hired if their scripts do not achieve high ratings. Producers are punished for low viewing rates by being deprived of additional bonuses sometimes having to take the stairs instead of the elevator, but their monthly paychecks are unaffected by the ratings their programs receive.

Keeping producers and directors on the corporate payroll means that Japanese television networks have preserved the corporate structure of the high-growth era (i.e., lifetime employment, adherence to the seniority system). By contrast, in Hollywood the production of narrative drama is not monopolized by certain networks. While the broadcast networks are typically allied with production studios, independent studios also produce serialized narrative programs. Competition in Japan in the realm of serial-drama production is confined to the broadcast networks. In other words, it is not only the skyrocketing salaries for tarento that make the production of television programs expensive in Japan, but also the system of lifetime employment, as well as the limited scope of competition.[12] This means, in

turn, that in Japanese drama production, flexibility is demanded exclusively of scriptwriters, who are the only freely disposable and replaceable components in the production process.

While scriptwriters vehemently vilify producers, producers constantly and bitterly complain about scriptwriters. Producers often wax nostalgic about older generations of scriptwriters, emphasizing that until the 1980s scriptwriters worked more autonomously, and there was no need for supervision by producers to get them to craft high-quality scripts in a timely manner. A TBS producer recounted to me:

> These days very few scriptwriters can write high-quality scripts. Writing cool dialogue or having a fresh eye for the current fashion trends does not make a drama good. Talent and fitness are not enough for this job. One has to practice writing and composing plots, as well. Among young scriptwriters, many have a good sense of what is trendy with youth, but the scripts they write are poorly composed. They should study much, much more. These days there are very few really good scriptwriters, and this is why we have no choice but to use them in a disposable (*tsukaisute*) system. When the veteran writer Hashida Sugako [born in 1925] was young, she worked for a film company for more than ten years, where she learned the basics of filmmaking. That makes a huge difference.[13]

In other words, in the producer's opinion, scriptwriters cannot keep up with the rapid pace of drama production and create scripts of sufficiently high quality because they lack experience.

It is curious how both producers and scriptwriters translate a structural problem into a lack of professionalism on the other's part, and neither talks about the uneasy position of a mass medium in an era in which individualized consumption has challenged the dominance of mass consumption. At the same time, neither side contextualizes the changing labor conditions in relation to broader changes in the business structure of the television industry. When trendy dramas turned out to be popular, demand for them rose sharply. By the mid-1990s, dramas had taken the leading role in the audience ratings from variety shows. Accordingly, many program slots maintained for variety shows were switched to dramas, and the demand for scriptwriters increased rapidly. It is indeed true that scriptwriters did not have enough time to master the profession, which takes years of writing and experimenting until one distills one's own style.

Tessa Morris-Suzuki's (1988, 144) analysis of the transformation of employment patterns in flexible accumulation is pertinent to an understanding of the new conflicts. She has analyzed how flexible production tends "to reduce the useful lifespan of work-related knowledge to a length shorter than the normal working life of human being." That is, the new genre called for workers with new expert knowledge, and young female writers were not the only ones who were inexperienced in drama production. Producers were also navigating uncharted territory. Programming departments tended to assign their youngest producers and directors to make these dramas, because they did not want to entrust the astronomical budgets drama production required to middle-aged producers, who were not believed to be sufficiently familiar with youth culture.[14] Many of the producers—in their early forties now—are grumbling that they are no longer assigned to produce trendy dramas, even though this is the only genre in which they have any expertise. In sum, flexible accumulation in drama production resulted in the shrinkage of the productive life span of producers and writers; producers are transferred to other departments in their early forties, while writers are simply disposed of.

The Scriptwriters' Story

Although scenario writing was the first aspect of drama production to be outsourced, the turnover rate of scriptwriters was much less rapid before the mid-1980s. Until then, an average productive lifespan for a television writer was more than twenty-five years. These days, only the luckiest writers remain in the business for more than eight or ten years. Once young writers reach their mid-forties, they are no longer contracted to write serial dramas, where one earns prestige and the big money. What is left for them is to write books, articles, or scripts for feature dramas. These jobs pay much less handsomely, because feature dramas are produced by small companies that run on much smaller budgets than the drama departments of commercial television networks.

Kitagawa has poignantly summarized the difference between older generations of professional scriptwriters and young female newcomers to the drama business. "I'm a type of person that is common among office ladies but very rare among scriptwriters. For a while, I had an inferiority complex for being different from most scriptwriters, who were in their late fifties

and thought of themselves as artists. Yet it seemed that I was in the closest position to the viewers and currently [in 1995] that is a great advantage [*ima wa sore ga buki da to omoimasu*]." In the same interview, Kameyama Chihiro, a producer at Fuji with whom Kitagawa made hit dramas such as *Asunaro Hakusho* (Asunaro White Paper; Fuji, 1993), *Kimi to Ita Natsu* (The Summer I Spent with You; Fuji, 1994), and *Long Vacation* (Fuji, 1996), complemented this by saying that Kitagawa writes only what she thinks. But Kameyama does not view this as selfish individualism (*sakkasei wo oshitsukenai*). Rather, Kitagawa is writing scripts that are the easiest for the viewers to identify with (Shimazaki 1995).

The demand for young writers appeared suddenly and increased rapidly. In response to this, "scenario schools" were established to train the supply. These writing schools boomed in the 1990s.[15] Enrolling in a scenario school became the most common way for young women to try their luck in the television business. Attending lectures was useful not only to learn the basics of scenario writing but also to make connections in the business, as the lecturers were established scriptwriters and producers active in drama production. These connections provided some of the students with small jobs, such as serving as stand-in writers (*sabu-raitā*), who write episodes when the main writer misses a deadline, or as plot writers (*purotto-raitā*), who write rough story lines for feature dramas (the actual dialogue is written by a more established scenario writer).

The majority of people who attend writing schools are housewives or "dropouts" from the corporate world, predominantly former office ladies. In addition to their social proximity to the target audiences, a reason that women constitute most of the participants in such schools (and in the scriptwriting profession) is that the work does not provide a stable income. It is often noted that women have the option to marry men with stable incomes, whereas the opposite is a less common choice in Japan. The writing schools advertise their courses by emphasizing the fun side and lucrative nature of the profession, as well as ease of learning the basics of scriptwriting.

To understand why housewives enroll in scenario schools in great numbers, one has to look at prevalent gendered patterns of employment in Japan. In Japanese companies, office ladies are expected to quit their jobs when they marry (*kotobuki taisha*) and become homemakers. This is a reasonable system for companies; as women retire in the second half of their

twenties, companies can replace them with younger female employees, and it is less disturbing that women's salaries increase much more slowly than those of their male colleagues—if they increase at all (Ogasawara 1998). Because these women do not have any expert knowledge, they can re-enter the workforce only as part-timers employed in low-paying jobs.[16]

That it to say, housewives enroll in scenario schools hoping that they will find re-employment in a more creative and versatile business than the parcel-delivery or convenience-store work that is most commonly available to them. These housewives, however, almost never make it to the television business. It is the other category of students, the dropout office ladies, who are the main supply of labor for television networks. For many women, marriage and child rearing are not the best career choices. These women postpone marriage and extend their tenure, despite the unwelcoming atmosphere of their workplaces. Many struggle in the corporate world until they recognize that it is a dead end and drop out. Among the well-known, currently working scriptwriters are such women as Nakazono Miho, who worked for an advertising company for two years, and Inoue Yumiko and Takahashi Rumi, who both worked as office ladies for small film-production companies.[17] Inoue's goal to become a director was not fulfilled, and Takahashi felt increasingly uneasy with long commuting hours and ineffective work patterns in the company. Takahashi explains: "I didn't know what I wanted to do, but I was sure that the office lady job did not fit me. I thought that I could easily finish the week's five days of work within one day and I did not understand why I had to go to my workplace five days a week. . . . I preferred to do work at my own pace and my colleagues started accusing me of being deviant. Now that I think of it, it's nice if someone is paid for her work on a monthly basis, but as time was passing by, I started feeling uneasy about receiving my salary [whether I did my best or not]. I increasingly felt that I wanted to get paid for what I have actually completed" (Satake 1997, 131–32).

Takahashi, like the two other scriptwriters I mention, are examples of office ladies who could not make careers in the mass media as full-time employees. Office ladies enter the scenario schools in the hope that these institutions will provide connections to start their careers as freelancers in the television business.

Another route to becoming a professional scriptwriter is to win a scenario-writing competition. Institutions such as the Shinario Sakka Kyōkai (Asso-

ciation of Scenario Writers), Nihon Hōsō Sakka Kyōkai (Japanese Television Writers' Association), and Fuji Network started organizing annual scenario-writing contests about the same time that trendy dramas were being developed. On average, the Fuji Network receives 2,500 scripts per year in its Yangu Shinario Taishō (Young Scriptwriter Award) competition. The prizewinning script automatically becomes a serial drama, and the nine other finalists are offered the chance to work in the industry, commonly debuting as sub-writers (Satake 1997).

Scriptwriting is an extremely competitive profession, and its cutthroat nature does not diminish even after a young writer manages to debut in the business. It is not only the financial instability that is hard to put up with; the job is also physically and mentally grueling and carries excessively tight production schedules. From the first consultation (*uchiawase*) with the producer to the production of the last episode, it takes approximately six months to complete a serial drama. The producer designates the theme for the drama; it then takes two months for the scriptwriter and producer to conduct research, set the plot, and develop the characters. The scriptwriter starts writing the script two months before the scheduled airing and completes it in parallel with the actual broadcast of the drama. There are various reasons for this tight schedule. The scriptwriter Nobumoto Keiko (*Hakusen Nagashi* [Those Were the Days]; Fuji, 1996) explains: "It is said that to write a good script for a three-month-long serial drama takes six months. However, it often happens that the drama plan or the casting changes, and the script for a three-month-long drama serial has to be completed in three or four months. This is a huge burden for the scriptwriter. These days, it is the casting that determines the drama, and the proposal is prepared in alignment with the profile (i.e., earlier television performances) of tarento cast in the lead roles" (Komatsu and Matsumoto 2000, 162).

Another reason the scriptwriter does not start writing the script earlier is that the earlier she begins, the more grueling the rewriting process will be. Drama-production staff are always running late and often end up shooting the last episode the same day it is scheduled to be aired. Thus, the less time left for writing the scripts, the less difficult the rewriting and consulting with other drama staff become.

Although there were male scriptwriters in the 1990s,[18] they were far outnumbered by women. Nakazono has commented on the gender imbalance in the profession:

> Scenario writing fits women better. The script has to be rewritten countless times, depending on the sponsors' wishes or actors' capriciousness. Rewriting is much more grueling psychologically for men. They think too much about authorship (*sakkasei*) and their own politics (*jibun no porishii*). Women just vehemently curse male producers, but they hang on until the end. From the male producers' point of view, what is important is that they have to spend half a year with a scriptwriter—and during these six months they see her more often that they see their wives. They are better off with female writers, whom they might even find pleasant, than with argumentative male writers with too much pride. (Satake 2000, 198)

Correspondingly, many male producers use the metaphor of marriage to describe the relationship between producers and scriptwriters. Ōta (1996, 132) writes: "The relationship between a producer and scriptwriter is like a relationship between a husband and wife. As they are working on the same project, they have to support each other. It is natural that they argue with each other from time to time. These fights are exactly as if they were between a husband and wife."

Clearly, young female writers are not only responsible for creating interesting characters but also for performing emotional labor. Drawing on the work of Arlie Hochschild (1983), Nicki James defines emotional labor as "the work involved in dealing with other peoples' feelings, a core component of which is the regulation of emotions," whose "value lies in its contribution to the social reproduction of labor power and the social relations of production" (James 1989, 15, 19). Emotional labor is part of the labor female writers are required to perform, but it is not a form of labor for which they are compensated. Yet, as the next section illustrates, this is only one of the ways in which they are exploited.

Struggles between Authorship and Capital

Ōta casually likens the relationship between scriptwriters and producers to an argumentative but comfortable marriage. Female writers, however, often find it more difficult to see an easy, familial nature in their relationship with producers. I will offer two examples to illustrate how producers exert their power over scriptwriters and how it affects the plots of dramas

and the ways young women are portrayed in them. The first is from my interview with Takahashi Rumi, writer of the mega-hit series *Shomuni* (General Affairs Department 2; Fuji, 1998, 2000, 2002). Takahashi told me about her experiences writing *Hikon Kazoku* (Unmarried Family; Fuji, 2001), which was produced for the Thursday, 10 P.M., slot and targeted at women between twenty-six and thirty-four. She had bitter memories of writing the drama,[19] which was based on the work of the famous *manga* (graphic novel) artist Saimon Fumi. (Most commonly, it is the plot or the main characters that are derived from the original comics.) Beginning with *Tokyo Love Story*, which has become a cult drama throughout East Asia and an all-time hit in Japan, Saimon's graphic novels have been adopted for a number of dramas. Television networks have earned huge profits from her dramatized manga, and she was a highly respected author. Accordingly, it must have been a nightmare for scriptwriters to work with her graphic novels, because issues of authorship were likely to spark conflicts. Takahashi was not allowed to rework Saimon's manga for *Unmarried Family*. The producer, Koiwai Hiroyoshi, instructed her to keep the original text as it was written, down to the last punctuation mark. The required strict allegiance to the manga's text was especially difficult for Takahashi because she could not relate at all to the story of the original work.

Unmarried Family centered on a triangular relationship between a laid-off salaryman and his first and second wives. In the first episode, the main character, Matoba Yōsuke, lost his job, and his second wife, Hikaru, left him in search of meaning for her life. One day, he ran into his first wife, Chikako, who had become a successful editor at a women's magazine. Having no income, Matoba had no choice but to accept the first wife's offer to move into her apartment with his son. Later, Hikaru joined them. While the viewers were channeled toward the expectation that Matoba would reunite with his first wife, in the end Chikako chose to marry one of her young colleagues. Takahashi found the story hard to identify with. She has never been married or divorced and felt uneasy writing the script without changing the original.

The limitations on Takahashi's authorship and her inability to identify with the drama's characters were not the extent of her dissatisfaction while working on *Unmarried Family*. Top tarento such as Sanada Hiroyuki (Matoba Yōsuke), Suzuki Kyoka (Chikako), and Yonekura Ryōko (Hikaru) were cast in the main roles. Takahashi told me that not only the producer,

4 Sanada Hiroyuki in *Unmarried Family*. The Fuji Network aired the drama in the Thursday, 10–11 P.M., slot between July 1, 2001, and September 20, 2001. Sanada, a talented actor who played Tasogare Seibei in Yamada Yōji's *The Twilight Samurai* and Ujio in *The Last Samurai*, rarely appeared in trendy dramas. Courtesy Fuji Television Network Inc. and Libra International Talent Agency.

Koiwai, but also Sanada made her work difficult. (Later, Sanada played in the Hollywood blockbuster *Last Samurai*. Moreover, he was cast in the lead role in the Japanese director Yamada Yōji's internationally renowned film *Twilight Samurai*.) Sanada continually vetoed the dialogue Takahashi had faithfully copied from the original comics, following Koiwai's instructions. Takahashi found herself between two "enemies." She was supposed to mediate between the producer, who was worried about Saimon, and the actor, who was concerned with his own media image. In the end, the drama was a flop (the ratings for the last episode were 11.4 percent, which meant a deficit in revenues for the network), and both parties blamed the scriptwriter for the failure. (Among the 113 serialized dramas that the Fuji Network produced between 1988 and 2003, *Unmarried Family* ranked at 101.)

The second example of a conflict between capital (the network producer) and authorship (the scriptwriter) is from my interview with Nakazono Miho.[20] This anecdote also shows that, while the expertise of young female writers in women's culture is crucial to the success of the dramas, the final

word in determining what will appear on the television screen is never theirs. Among Nakazono's scripts, the drama *Yamato Nadeshiko* (Ideal Wife; Fuji, 2000), which aired in the Monday, 9 P.M., time slot, achieved the highest viewing rates (34.2 percent). As such, it ranked as the sixth-most-popular drama on Fuji's all-time trendy drama hit list. The drama's main character, Jinnō Sakurako, was a young woman who wanted to marry a wealthy man of high social status as compensation of sorts for a childhood spent in poverty. Sakurako became a flight attendant and moved to Tokyo, where she rented a tiny, dilapidated apartment so she could spend most of her income on high-end designer outfits. Her "philosophy" was that a woman could never wear the same dress twice, because she never knew when she might meet the same man while wearing the same outfit. At a friend's wedding, she met Nakahara Ōsuke, whom she believed to be rich, and fell in love with him. She then learned that Nakahara was a dropout graduate student who had studied mathematics at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology but currently was running his mother's small fish shop.[21] Sakurako soon recovered from her disappointment, broke up with Nakahara, and set out to find her prince on a white horse. She met a much less handsome doctor who would soon inherit his father's hospital. Sakurako was determined to forget about Nakahara and marry the doctor.

Toward the end of the drama, however, Nakahara's former adviser arranged a job for him at a prestigious university in New York City on the condition that he completed his dissertation. Nakahara was deeply conflicted about whether to accept the position, because his memories of graduate studies in the United States were overshadowed by the loss of his fiancée, who died in a car accident for which Nakahara felt responsible. However, he overcame his contradictory feelings, finished his dissertation, and started teaching in New York. Sakurako, in turn, fled her wedding ceremony with the rich doctor and joined Nakahara in New York, where they were married. The drama ended with Sakurako dragging her husband from one designer boutique to another. Nakahara, loaded with shopping bags, was following Sakurako with a defeated and bitter smile on his face.

Nakazono, a very competitive career woman and single mother, explained that the main aim of the drama was to criticize young Japanese women's fascination with the Cinderella story. The drama was replete with sarcasm and irony, and it explicitly made fun of young women's fixation on brand names and status marriages (*tamanokoshi ni noru ganbō*). The Cinderella-

esque ending and closing shopping scene are puzzling, however, because they appear to endorse precisely what the scriptwriters initially sought to criticize. I asked Nakazono about the contradiction between the drama's argument and its ending. She agreed that the last scenes contradicted the overall message she had intended to convey and explained that scriptwriters have the least control over the season finale. The last episode tends to draw the highest ratings, so producers are extremely fastidious in crafting it. In this case, the producer, Iwata Yūji, determined the episode's "happy" ending by appropriating the role of chief writer himself. He acted as a representative of his company, whose main task was to please the sponsors with high ratings. The last scenes of shopping for high-end designer goods—on Nakahara's assistant professor salary in New York City—were not in Nakazono's script. The producer was convinced that happiness for office ladies, the viewers of the drama, equates with moving up in class and financial status and with being able to hop from one designer boutique to another. Nakazono told me that she felt defeated, because she did not regard the Cinderella story as a happy one for women. But it is always the producers who determine the ending of dramas, and they do this according to their own imaginings of how young female viewers construct—or ought to construct—the meaning of happiness.

Conclusion: Authorship, Agency, and Television Studies

Previous television studies commonly centered on analyzing how viewers have decoded the meanings producers encoded in programs (Hall 1980 [1973]). This chapter illustrates that in conditions in which networks are juggling the conflicting interests of sponsors and viewers, the primary site of negotiation has become televisual production itself. A strategy to craft dramas that satisfy young female viewers is to engage them in the production of the dramas via young female writers, who are close in age and value orientation to the target audience and thus capable of mediating between the still dominantly male drama producers and female audiences. Yet this is not an unproblematic process of translation. On the contrary, it has become a crucial terrain where meanings of identity are struggled over.

The growing need for mediation between production and reception sheds light on a new trend: the increasing interdependence between these realms. In both media studies and cultural anthropology, televisual produc-

tion and reception have been separated from each other and studied as distinct analytical spheres of cultural production. For instance, anthropologists have studied television's role in the ideological construction of the nation in postcolonial and post-socialist contexts (Abu-Lughod 2005; Mankekar 1999; Rofel 2007). These studies considered the production and consumption of television programs in the dichotomy of (homogeneous) state power and individual agency (resistance or negotiation). In the past decade, however, the globalization of the media, fragmentation of the audience, and concomitant commercialization of the televisual medium have led to the transformation of national television industries. While serving the interests of both state power and commercial advertising are by no means mutually exclusive functions of television production, I highlight that the newly emerging cultures of televisual production and reception require new analytical frameworks. Approaches that blend ethnographic research with political economy, I suggest, will enable us to understand how television is produced and received at the intersection of culture and capitalism. Such an approach best equips us to analyze the ways in which the television industry mediated, and simultaneously capitalized on socioeconomic changes and, concomitantly, emerging consumer and labor subjectivities in the 1990s. I will focus on these new subjectivities in the next two chapters.

In the context of the Japanese television industry, the strategy of engaging young women in drama production turned many of these programs into mega-hits. The effects of the dramas spread like ripples in a pond, as they not only drew other audience segments to the television screen but also revived the medium's prestige for viewers and marketers. As translators between producers and viewers, young writers also came to play a crucial role in the promotion of dramas. Due to their permanent presence in women's magazines and on television screens, many of them became well known to the audiences. Scriptwriters were not on corporate payrolls, however, and thus lacked an institutional safety and support net. They were in desperate need of media publicity. The interviews with them in magazines and television programs served as a means for self-promotion. At the same time, in the process of promoting serial dramas, scriptwriters endowed these programs with a human face; their personal narratives about why they had raised certain issues in their dramas and their thoughts on love, work, and friendship sutured over the increasingly elaborate and

intricate mechanisms of engineering trendy dramas and concealed the growing anonymity and profit motivations of the culture industries.

The young female scriptwriter boom epitomized a new trend in that, in parallel with the development of trendy dramas, authorship started to take an increasingly important role in popular discourse about television dramas. I would argue that the new visibility drama producers and directors received in the media was a calculated promotional strategy on the part of television networks. In the 1990s, producers such as Ōta Tōru and Kameyama Chihiro became household names. As popular magazines and newspapers began to talk about them alongside their dramas, drama professionals helped their networks cut through the clutter by branding them. Equally pertinent, the new preoccupation with authorship was a response to marketing discourses that emphasized the importance of custom-tailored, high-quality products for young women. As I will show in the next chapter, marketing discourses commonly portrayed young women as *consumer connoisseurs* who—compared with the general population, marketers believed—were more concerned about quality than price or convenience. Authorship in drama production played an essential role in fueling audience distinction by treating young women as special customers who deserved "high-quality entertainment" with high production values and top-notch celebrities. In other words, authorship served to suggest that television was no longer an anonymous mass medium that was unable to deliver high-quality tailor-made entertainment to its customers.[22]

However, the engagement of young female writers in drama production was not the only strategy commercial networks used to produce a new market for a new product. To draw young women to television, television professionals complemented the particular character portrayals and narrative configurations young female scriptwriters encoded in trendy dramas by co-branding partnerships with other media and with the leisure industries. In the next chapter, I examine the ways in which these new representational and industrial practices contributed to the production of new subjectivities in the 1990s.

Four

What's Love Got to Do with It?

LOVE DRAMAS AND BRANDED SELVES

Unmei no koi wa totsuzen yattekuru. Dakara, koi no sensu wo migaiteokō!

(The love of one's life comes unexpectedly. Thus we have to polish our sense of love to be ready for it!)

KITAGAWA ERIKO

In an interview with *Cosmopolitan* magazine, Kitagawa Eriko, the "goddess of love stories" in the 1990s, argued that she wrote love dramas as a refusal to accept the intensifying rationalization that increasingly came to determine everyday realities in recessionary Japan. She stated that her mission was to reintroduce love, an outmoded affect, into her viewers' lives, for love was a powerful means to stitch together a self that was lost in the world and felt alienated in its socioeconomic environment (Kitagawa 2001a). Love dramas (*ren'ai dorama*) were the most popular subgenre of trendy drama, and they seemed to have resonated with viewers' sensibilities, as many of them achieved ratings higher than 30 percent—extraordinary figures for primetime television programming in advanced capitalist countries. While Kitagawa conceptualized love as a redemptive space immune to capitalism, I will argue precisely the opposite. I will claim that in the 1990s, love dramas played a key role in accommodating their female viewers within the

logic of a changing socioeconomic order. These dramas encouraged young women to become a "lifestyle elite" by accumulating consumer-cultural capital even as this segment of the population was increasingly marginalized from the normative world of work and wage labor.

In earlier chapters, I analyzed more broadly the ways in which trendy dramas redefined postwar forms of sociality, subjectivity, and human relationships. By focusing on two subgenres of the trendy drama—the love drama and the workplace drama—chapters 5 and 6 will take a closer look at the ways in which these serials dismantled the dominant subjectivities of the postwar period and formed new individuated selves by deploying lifestyle to reconfigure the normative links between gender and class. This chapter looks at the role of love dramas in forging subjects of a new era in which consumption has become the center of economic gravity. Chapter 6, on the other hand, investigates how workplace dramas participated in the production of new labor subjectivities in the wake of labor market deregulation. Anthropologists have analyzed television serials principally as government projects that have aimed to produce modern citizens (Abu-Lughod 2005; Mankekar 1999). In Japan, television networks are legally and financially independent of the government. In the 1990s, certain televisual constructions of subjectivity resonated with governmental projects of engineering selves—manifested, for example, in health-care and educational reforms. In other cases, however, these discourses articulated cacophonous visions of the nation's future or they simply devolved into discursive warfare waged over the soul of the citizenry.

These erratic configurations of dissonances and convergences in the concurrent social-engineering projects of the 1990s marked not only the relative withdrawal of the government from the ideological construction of nation and citizenship, but also broader-scale transformations in the form of sovereignty—namely, that in late capitalist societies, sovereignty is increasingly de-linked from the nation-state and is re-emerging as a composite of national and private (often supranational) entities (Hardt and Negri 2000). In this condition, the role of the private sector (i.e., corporations such as commercial television networks) is gradually expanding beyond the production of commodities and services. These entities are becoming powerful political forces that are gaining strength in hegemonizing their own understandings of citizens as consumers (García Canclini 2001) and nations as guardians of the free market or of protectionist trade policies.

These definitions stand in contrast with earlier interpretations of nations as entities with particular territorial boundaries, political and cultural legacies, and citizenship "as imagined political identity, as the right to equal rights" (Ong 2006, 15). At the same time, market maximization and national integration are coupled in a virtuous liaison. Therefore, in contexts in which television networks operate as mass-market media, their interests tend to be allied with those of the government. In the late 1980s, however, Japanese television networks joined other domestic media industries that had shifted to niche targeting as early as in the mid-1970s in response to the fragmentation of consumer tastes and the stratification of purchasing power. The development of the trendy drama illustrates that in the wake of economic restructuring and the erosion of mass middle-class society, Japanese television networks have moved away from the role of consolidating the nation and toward offering a sense of belonging to new types of communities. In this process, strategies of branding played a central role.

With the development of the trendy drama *branding* had become central to the operation of television. Branding is a strategy for corporations to secure consumer loyalty (and thus guarantee sources of revenue) by creating an empathetic relationship with their customers, who in turn are less easily poached by the competition (Holt 2004; Klein 2000). Corporations can achieve this goal by offering their customers highly emotionalized products whose appeal lies not so much in their use value as in their capacity to serve as vehicles to communicate a sense of belonging to a community of individuals who share the same lifestyles and attitudes. Trendy dramas were "emotional products" because they offered not only use value (i.e., content or entertainment), but also a sense of membership in lifestyle and attitude communities. These serials have largely simplified the problematic of identity—which was arguably a source of comfort in the face of dramatic socioeconomic changes—by emphasizing the importance of lifestyle and suggesting that identity was nothing more than an attitude in a world in which only affective commitments mattered. In this context, branding also served to accommodate viewers in a new form of rationality within which affect management has become central to the production of subjectivity and to the reproduction of social order.

In this chapter, I show that in the 1990s, love dramas forged consumer selves and mobilized their viewers into consumption not only at the level

of the text by prioritizing certain characters and narrative configurations over others, but also at the level of production by using branding practices that emphasized the importance of lifestyle over other forms of identification, such as class or citizenship. At the same time, by analyzing viewers' responses to a love drama I will show that the ways in which dramas work on their viewers have become immensely more complex. I will highlight that these serials have engendered new modes of identification and pleasure that draw *equally* from the trendy drama's unique mode of production and representation. In the first section, I will examine how co-branding partnerships with other media and the leisure industries helped networks to simultaneously multiply their sources of revenue and produce a new market (composed of young women) for a new product (trendy drama). I will highlight that, while processes of branding are primarily strategies for television networks to introduce new forms of rationality to unstable media economies, they have also become highly effective means to acclimate viewers to a condition in which consumption has become the motor of the economy.

Television and Consumer Culture

While the directive to create programs that do not contradict the world of consumerism has always been part of the structure of commercial television (Andersen 1995), the producers of trendy dramas pushed this tendency to a new level by aggressively blurring the line between televisual entertainment and commercial information. The father of the genre, Yamada Yoshiaki, sheds light on this tendency by revealing that his original idea for the trendy drama was to furnish the programs with subtitles informing viewers about the brands, prices, and availability of outfits the tarento wore in given scenes (Koiketa 1999). Indeed, the changes in the magazine industry—from which Fuji producers adopted the idea of making the link between content and advertising more seamless—are helpful in understanding the direction in which the producers of trendy dramas steered the television industry in the late 1980s. By the mid-1980s, this medium had transformed into a powerful advertising platform that offered a feature interview with a Japanese celebrity and filled the rest of the pages with fashion and leisure advertisements. In other words, what originally was a source of entertainment, with more emphasis on celebrities,

lifestyle advice, and serialized novels or comics, became instead a catalogue for designers, a shopping guide wed to the culture of celebrity.

Because magazines were highly popular with the young women television networks wanted to reach, producers believed that making consumer trends the focal point of trendy dramas was an effective way to market these dramas to young women. At the same time, by producing new dramas that presented an overall look compatible with the ideals of the image-conscious fashion and cosmetics industries, networks offered an attractive deal to their new sponsors. They promised not only more precise demographic targeting (i.e., to deliver a "wealthy" segment of the population to advertisers), but also a more efficient form of advertising (i.e., one that was not confined to the commercial breaks but was seamlessly integrated into entertainment). Here I trace how producers embedded consumer culture in their dramas and how this original idea to integrate information about consumer trends into program content evolved into a new business model that draws its force from co-branding partnerships with tarento agencies and the fashion, leisure, and music industries.[1]

Producers at the Fuji Network claimed that they used three specific strategies to reinforce the link between trendy dramas and consumer culture: they capitalized on the tarento system; they incorporated trendy music in the serials; and they shot the serials in fashionable locations (Ōta 1996). First and foremost, trendy dramas integrated entertainment and advertising via the tarento. In chapter 1, I described the ways in which tarento and dramas mutually brand each other. Here I will focus on how the tarento economy brands viewers via trendy dramas. In most trendy dramas, tarento are clad in meticulously matched designer outfits and hang out in trendy places (even when they play ordinary people whose incomes realistically would not allow them to cultivate such lifestyles). In fact, wardrobe stylists and makeup artists attained utmost importance in trendy-drama production because they were crucial in crafting the tarento as models of style.[2] While television programs have always been a commercial showcase for fashion, trendy dramas intensified this tendency by promoting the idea that style is an intimate component of identity.

I noted in earlier chapters that the tarento not only perform as actors in fiction-based television programs; they also appear as contestants in game shows and as participants or hosts on talk shows. Moreover, many of them develop careers in the music industry as singers, and they often endorse

commodities and services in advertisements. This simultaneous cross-genre and transmedia deployment of the tarento would not be possible if talent and skills (in particular entertainment genres) were requirements to gain celebrity status. Precisely because the tarento are not talented, style (including not only fashion sense but also attitude) comes to play a vital role in their production. I would even go a step further: it is professionalism itself in the realm of style that earns the tarento status and fame. Viewers enjoy the tarento not only because they offer reference points in trendiness as to what to wear or where to spend their leisure time. The tarento are also attractive to their fans because they represent a model for upward social mobility in which expertise in matters of style and lifestyle is vital. In other words, tarento themselves derive their power from their professionalism in consumer culture. This is a relevant point that I will return to in my analysis of viewers' responses to love dramas.

The use of trendy pop music was another important strategy to reinforce and naturalize the link between television and consumer culture. Music is very important to the trendy-drama medium—as it is to the young female target audiences. When a proposal for a new trendy drama is prepared, the third most important task, after securing the cast and hiring a freelance scriptwriter, is to choose the theme song. Dramas use orchestral music and a particular theme song composed and performed by a musician from the front lines of the Japanese music industry. The title and lyrics of the theme song have to capture the theme and atmosphere of the drama, just as the title does. The theme song frames the drama; a video-clip version of it is produced in which the drama's main protagonists act out an abridged version of the drama, usually concluding with a cliffhanger. This video plays in the background while the credits roll during the introduction and conclusion of the dramas. The scenes of the drama are accompanied not only by orchestral music, but also by the theme song, which starts to play every time the program enters a climactic scene. This music composition is very effective in engaging the viewers emotionally in the drama.

Arguably, the centrality of music in the trendy drama played a vital role in driving the genre away from the tradition of story-driven entertainment and closer to what music television represented in the late 1980s—a particular genre of commercial television that sold lifestyles, forged a commitment to consumption, and, most important, served as a mood enhancer. Lawrence Grossberg (1988) has noted that MTV not only makes a direct

appeal for viewers to purchase particular products, but it also creates a mood within which consuming products becomes sensible and even desirable. Grossberg argues that music television is not as concerned with communicating meanings as with providing the energy and attitudes to lift one's mood. He writes, "The uniqueness of music television's communication is defined by the fact that the construction and dissemination of moods is increasingly separated from the communication of any particular meanings and values" (1988, 262). Trendy dramas are similar to music television, and the more they serve as mood enhancers, the farther they drift away from the conventional role of television serials that entertained their viewers with compelling stories.[3]

At the same time, the collaboration of the music and television industries functions as a new co-branding partnership. As noted earlier, many tarento perform not only as actors but also as musicians. Involvement in the music industry plays an important role in defining the tarento as emblems of particular moods, attitudes, or affects—roles that blur the boundary between their real and media personas. Grossberg's analysis of MTV is helpful once again. He writes, "By embracing this broad communicative strategy, music television creates a series of images of stars who embody not authentic instances of subjectivity and political resistance, but temporary attitudes and moods that can be appropriated by fans as possible identities, strategies by which they can continue to make a "difference" —if not in the world, at least in their lives—even though "difference" has become for them impossible and irrelevant" (1988, 266).[4] Even if tarento do not have full-fledged performing careers in the music business, most of them release singles. Sometimes the composers or performers of the background music act in the drama, and the single is advertised after the individual episodes.[5] In other cases, the background music is released before airing the drama, so that by the time the new drama season begins, viewers will be familiar with the music. Simultaneously, dramas will counter-brand certain record labels, thus boosting sales in the music industry. The main song of *Tokyo Love Story* (Fuji, 1991) sold 2.58 million copies, while the theme music from *Hyakuikkaime no Puropōzu* (The Hundred and First Marriage Proposal; Fuji, 1991) sold 2.820 million singles (Aso 2000).

Last but not least, the trendy drama signals a marked increase in the co-branding partnerships between the television and the leisure industries. Ōta Tōru (1996) of the Fuji Network designated popular locations as the

third constitutive and distinguishing feature of trendy dramas and a key strategy to draw young women to television. It is through location shoots that trendy dramas brand leisure practices—particular sites within Tokyo such as trendy cafes and restaurants. Again, this is grounded in the logic of co-branding, often with no fiduciary relationship between the parties. Kawake Shunsaku, a director for the Fuji Network, has commented that location shoots lend a sense of realism to trendy drama; the characters are not confined to studio settings but inhabit the very same spaces where "ordinary" viewers spend their free time (Koiketa 1999). The preferred locations include Shibuya, Daikanyama, Tokyo Tower, and Inokashira Park—neighborhoods that are highly popular with Japanese youth and that in turn further brand dramas.

Advertising leisure activities by weaving them into the narrative of television programs is not an approach limited to trendy dramas. In fact, this trend started with feature mystery shows, which are commonly filmed in the countryside. In these programs, the signs of train stations are always clearly displayed to inform the viewers where they are "virtually" traveling, thus boosting the domestic tourism industry. For example, hot springs are favored sites of criminal investigations, because they are popular leisure destinations among the older generations whom detective dramas target. Even more explicitly, some feature television programs such as *Stewardess Keiji* (Stewardess Detectives; Fuji, 1997–2003) have become undisguised strategies for advertising their sponsors, tourism agencies, and airlines via the means of product placement. This show features three flight attendants traveling to tourist destinations that are popular among the Japanese and investigating murder mysteries on their way. In these programs, subtitles inform viewers about the visited countries and their cultures, customs, local food specialties, and entertainment forms. Thus, these television programs can be watched both as mystery dramas and as travel documentaries.

Because trendy dramas are serialized programs, foreign locations are avoided as they would largely increase the production budgets. Trendy dramas do, however, introduce their viewers to hip Tokyo restaurants, cafes, and sometimes to famous domestic tourist spots and hot springs.[6] While these dramas cannot be translated into theme-park rides as unequivocally as, for instance, *Jurassic Park*, the analogy is not too far-fetched. It is not an exaggeration to argue that these shows have turned

5 In the 1990s, trendy dramas transformed the Tokyo Tower from an ordinary tourist destination into a symbol of love and a number-one dating spot. Courtesy Eckhard Pecher.

the whole of downtown Tokyo into a theme park not only for young Japanese living in suburbs and the countryside,[7] but also for youth in Southeast Asia generally, where Japanese trendy dramas have great currency. In chapter 1, I mentioned the Taiwanese package tours that guide young tourists through places in Tokyo where famous drama scenes were shot. For example, the Tokyo Tower is introduced to tourists not as a famous landmark of the city, but as the place where Kanchi first kissed Rika in *Tokyo Love Story* (Fuji, 1991). Trendy dramas have indeed reappropriated the Tokyo Tower as a symbol of love because so many dramas were shot in its neighborhood where Fuji's headquarters was also once located. In the 1990s, the Tokyo Tower became the number-one dating spot, followed by Odaiba, where the Fuji Network relocated and drama producers started shooting romantic scenes.

In sum, before the late 1980s commercial television networks produced primetime programs in which the entertainment value was autonomous from the commercial messages, which were confined to the commercial

breaks. Trendy dramas departed from this tradition. To attract the trend-conscious fashion and cosmetics industries to invest in television advertising and their young female customers, producers used the tarento, trendy pop music, and fashionable locations to create a format that was more conducive to the commercial messages of the new sponsors. The three strategies to achieve this goal in turn have driven television away from the exclusive role of providing entertainment, education, and information. Now, in addition to fulfilling these more traditional demands, television serves as a marketing machine that is highly efficient in inserting viewers into consumer culture. In the next section, I will examine the social discourses on young women and consumerism that supported the producers' conviction that these lifestyle-oriented love dramas would resonate with young women's sensibilities. I will explore dominant social discourses on how the position of young women has changed in Japanese society in the past two decades to foreground my analysis of how trendy dramas tapped into and reinforced these discourses (and changes).

The Parasite Single Phenomenon: Discourses on Women and Consumerism in the 1990s

The target audience for trendy dramas was women between eighteen and thirty-four. Within this demographic, love dramas concentrated on single women, who held primarily non-career-track jobs and lived with their parents to maximize their disposable income. Yamada Masahiro (1998, 1999) named these women "parasite singles." His analysis of the phenomenon was a faithful encapsulation of the dominant marketing discourses on the growing number of singles in Japan. A brief summary of these academic and marketing discourses will help contextualize the assumptions television producers held about this demographic.

Yamada's goal was to explain a sharp decline in the birthrate, and he refuted the idea that it was a consequence of women's advancement in society. Rather, he attributed it to young women's changing attitude toward marriage. His statistics support the magnitude of the phenomenon: in 1970, the percentage of unmarried women among twenty-five- to twenty-nine-year-old women was 18.1 percent. This had risen to 48 percent by 1995. At the same time, the percentage of unmarried women aged thirty to thirty-four rose from 8.2 percent to 19.7 percent. What Yamada found

most important about this sharp decline in the number of marriages was that 80 percent of unmarried women in their twenties lived with their parents, while this figure was 70 percent for single women in their early thirties. Yamada concluded that young women enjoyed a high standard of living and a great deal of free time because their fathers covered their basic expenses and their mothers performed the household chores. Young women not only had comfortable lives; they could also keep most of their earnings as disposable income to be spent on designer fashion, gourmet food, entertainment, and overseas travel.

Yamada highlighted that young women did not choose to remain single and childless because they wanted to pursue professional careers. On the contrary, it was still the full-time housewife who modeled the most desirable life course for them. Moreover, very few Japanese women thought of work as a means of self-realization. Rather, their reason for not getting married was that their expectations toward marriage were idealistic, and they were willing to marry only those men who were capable of providing the same luxurious lifestyle that their parents had. Yamada emphasized that when women in the survey were asked about their most important criteria for choosing a husband, personality and income scored equally in the answers. Women postponed marriage because they had difficulty finding men they would be willing to marry—especially since fewer and fewer men qualified as competent providers during the economic slowdown. According to Yamada's survey, women wanted to get married only if marriage did not cause financial difficulties; they were willing to bear children only if they had adequate financial resources to provide them with the best education; and they did not want to split themselves between work and motherhood, because that would be difficult. Yamada concluded that the common element in these conditions was the anxiety evoked by the perspective of hardship (*kurō*), and women avoided marriage because it was very likely to compromise the comfortable lives and high disposable incomes they enjoyed while living with their parents. He obviously regarded these young women as spoiled and called them "parasites." Ultimately, Yamada blamed young women not only for the decreasing population, but also for the economic recession, arguing that the decreasing number of marriages was responsible for the slump in the construction business, one of the most important forces of economic growth.[8]

Yamada's study of the "parasite single" phenomenon encapsulates popu-

lar sentiments about young unmarried women in the 1990s. By summarizing his portrayal of single women, my goal has been to identify a key source from which television producers drew their assumptions about this demographic. However, I would like to stress that Yamada's is but one position among many that attempted to interpret women's changing status in Japan during the 1990s. The growing number of single women in Japan can be explained by conceptualizing this phenomenon as a *consequence* of the economic slowdown rather than as the *cause*. In the prolonged economic recession, the system of family wage and job security started to crumble, and an increasing number of women had to keep working after marriage. Marriage imposed a double burden on women: in the absence of sufficient child-care facilities, they remained responsible for raising their children even while they were forced to work outside the home.[9]

At the same time, women have limited opportunities on the Japanese labor market, and gender discrimination is prevalent in workplaces (Brinton 1993; Ogasawara 1998).[10] Corporations still expect female employees to quit working once they marry so they can be replaced with younger female workers who are less expensive to employ. In this condition, the number of single women is growing, as more and more women find themselves suspended between two stages of their life course in the wake of the changing economic conditions. Young women continue to live with their parents because their salaries are barely high enough to sustain themselves independently. Thus, the relatively high disposable incomes they enjoy are, in fact, side effects of their disadvantaged position in the changing socioeconomic context. Consumption is one of the few means they have at their disposal to express and realize themselves.[11]

Equally important, and resonating with neoliberal theories of the rational subject, these discourses conceptualize young single women as economic individuals whose private decision-making processes are nothing more than cost–benefit calculations. Thomas Lemke (2001, 201) has noted that the neoliberal rationality blurs the line between a responsible person, a moral individual, and an economic-rational actor: "[Neoliberal rationality] aspires to construct prudent subjects whose moral quality is based on the fact that they rationally assess the costs and benefits of a certain act as opposed to other alternative acts. As the choice of options for action is, or so the neo-liberal notion of rationality would have it, the expression of free will on the basis of a self-determined decision, the consequences of the

action are borne by the subject alone, who is also solely responsible for them." As noted earlier, the emphasis on young single women's "free will" to calculate costs and benefits is problematic precisely because it does not understand the dilemmas of young women as rooted in specific social and historical formations (i.e., the erosion of mass middle-class society and the prolonged economic recession). I will develop this connection further in the next chapter as part of an analysis of the role played by trendy dramas in neoliberal labor mobilization.

Let me now turn to examining how marketing discourses articulated with Yamada's diagnosis. By the mid-1980s, young Japanese women had gained unprecedented autonomy as consumers and as a marketing category. Until the mid-1980s, the term "female consumer" signified the smart housewife who was on the top of the new detergent brands or mortgage plans and knew which bonds to invest the family's savings into. In the late 1980s, however, this image was superseded by that of the young female consumer for whom shopping had become the prime source of entertainment. Marketing discourses too easily juxtapose the married housewife and the single office lady as the extreme poles of spending behavior. In these discourses, the married housewife is posed as a consumer who values careful spending and prioritizes future goals such as financing her children's education, while the single office lady is portrayed as a consumer who is much less invested in saving. It is emphasized that even if the office lady saves money, she is likely to spend her savings on a yearlong homestay program overseas to learn a new language (*OL ryūgaku*) or on tuition for a foreign master's program in which she earns a degree that will not benefit her when she returns to Japan (see Kelsky 2001). The single office lady is a "fashionista," a frequent visitor of high-end department stores who dines in gourmet restaurants and travels abroad. Some call her the "single aristocrat" (McCreery 2000). In Japan, marketers played a crucial role in crafting this new image of the female consumer in the 1980s; at the same time, women's magazines took a leading role in defining, refining, and compartmentalizing this segment of the population.

From the early 1980s onward, an increasing number of freelance writers, social scientists, and demographers have joined marketers in scrutinizing young Japanese women's habits and lifestyles. Mitsuhiro Yoshimoto (1989) has pointed out that so-called booms, such as the "female high-school student boom (*kōkōsei būmu*)," the "female university-student boom

(*joshidaisei būmu*)," and the "Hanako boom (*hanako-zoku*)," increasingly have come to structure the massive forces of commodification at work in Japan, whose aim has been to create differences on which marketers can capitalize. Such "booms" were newly created categories under which young women could be targeted with new product lines. They were also categories that academics used to try to make sense of the changing position of young women in Japanese society.

The growing number of unmarried women has produced a "single market" in Japan, and marketers have helped to identify the desires, needs, and lifestyle preferences of this population bracket. McCreery (2000) describes the new categories Japanese marketers created to divide and target this segment of the population. For example, "high singles (*kō shinguru*)" are women who do not find their place in society; although they do not want to be alone, they cannot find proper matches for themselves. High singles, a major category within the expanding single market, are further divided into "pure singles (*junshin*)," or women "who are lost in their worlds and live in their dreams" (26.3 percent), and "pseudo-singles (*gishin*)," or women who are defined as "cold-blooded, thoroughbred, forward looking, and self-confident, but tend to think too much of themselves" (10.2 percent). There are also low singles—women who have singles attitudes but are more conflicted about being single than high singles are. Low singles are likewise divided into two groups: "muddled singles (*mishin*)," or "the ugly ducklings that want to become the swan" (23.7 percent), and the "unsingles (*mushin*)," who are attached to both family and company but remain savvy consumers (39.8 percent; McCreery 2000, 150).

The tendency of young women as a demographic to evolve into new, increasingly specific marketing categories within the broader framework of Japanese capitalism is a phenomenon social scientists have called the birth of the fragmented masses (Ivy 1993; Kozawa 1989; Yamazaki 1987). In the early postwar years, the unprecedented economic growth rate, in conjunction with steadily rising affluence, generated the phenomenon of the mass middle-class society: 90 percent of the Japanese population located themselves in the middle class. Marilyn Ivy (1993, 241) notes that mass media were crucial in incorporating the Japanese population "into a series of strikingly uniform and standardized taste groupings [that] were appropriately differentiated in terms of gender and generation but much less so in terms of class or regional affiliation." Identifying as middle class meant

sharing in "mainstream culture"—reading the same newspapers, watching the same television programs, and aspiring to own the same fundamental electric appliances (refrigerators, washing machines, and the television sets in the 1950s; cars, air conditioners, and the color television sets in the 1960s; see Geron and Maclachlan 2006; Partner 1999).

In the wake of the first economic crisis in the postwar period, in the early 1970s, the nature and composition of consumption started to change. Japanese marketers heralded the new times as the advent of individuality, an era in which the dominant pattern of consumption shifted from "I want to be normal" to "I want to be special." While they capitalized on the birth of the fragmented masses (*bunshū)* by emphasizing the individual's entitlement to celebrate her own difference, unique sensibilities, and taste, it is important to note that the erosion of mass middle-class identity, as well as the diversification of consumption practices, were not simply the result of a rise in the level and quality of consumption after the mid-1970s. Consumer demands started to fragment in two ways: through "diversification of preference and stratification of purchasing power" (Ozawa 1985, 53).

This shift from mass-marketing to target marketing has run parallel to a larger-scale transformation in the constitutive relationship of consumption and production in the highly industrialized world in the past two decades. As production increasingly has been outsourced due to the spiraling costs of domestic manufacturing (of both labor and raw material), it has been superseded by less tangible ways to generate value, such as ever more creative forms of retailing that intensify the circulation of new goods. What I wish to stress is that, in the condition in which consumption has gained the highest importance as a generator of surplus value, young women's role in the economy has been re-evaluated, and their professionalism as consumers increasingly has been tapped. In the next section, I will analyze the textual strategies (dominant character portrayals and narrative configurations) through which trendy dramas played a crucial role in endorsing women's expertise in consumerism and their participation in consumer culture.

The New Sassy Heroine and the Marriage Ploy

Fuji's drama department produced two love dramas for the network's Monday 9–10 P.M. time slot that ranked among the top-ten most popular dramas in the 1990s and achieved record-high viewing rates for primetime

programming in the First World: *Long Vacation* (36.7 percent) and *Love Generation* (32.1 percent).[12] I will first describe the dominant portrayal of female protagonists in these dramas, then analyze the narrative function of marriage in love dramas in general. Earlier I argued that the development of the trendy drama was emblematic of a shift away from signification (story-driven entertainment) to affect (lifestyle-oriented shows). *Long Vacation* and *Love Generation* demonstrate how the characters in love dramas tend to compensate for the waning of the story. In other words, the characters *become* the story. The predictability of the plot's advancement makes it increasingly hard to argue that a preconceived story line is the main thrust in these dramas or that their stories are told for the sake of a clear-cut point. On the other hand, in dramas that integrate content with information on consumer trends, an emphasis on characters becomes convenient as they embody attitudes and serve as suitable conduits for information on lifestyles. The extremely thinly drawn line between the characters and the tarento playing them (i.e., the tendency for the tarento to often "play" themselves) further intensifies this trend.

Long Vacation, which aired in 1996, starred many tarento who were at the top of the popularity charts: in the lead roles were Kimura Takuya and Yamaguchi Tomoko, while Inamori Izumi, Takenouchi Yutaka, Matsu Takako, and Ryō played supporting characters. Kimura's character, the twenty-four-year-old male protagonist Senna, worked as a piano instructor at a cram school but he had not given up his dream of making the big time. Yamaguchi's character, the thirty-one-year-old Minami, was an indecisive, single former model who still was not sure what to do with her life. In the opening scene of the drama, the camera followed Minami running through Tokyo in traditional Japanese wedding attire and rushing into the apartment of her fiancé, who had not shown up for their wedding ceremony. She learned that he had fled the country with another woman, taking her savings with him. Senna, the groom's roommate, offered to let Minami move in, because she had no money to pay her rent.

Senna had feelings for another character, Ryōko, who was also a pianist, but did not have the courage to ask her out. Ryōko liked Senna, too, but a series of misunderstandings prevented their love from being consummated. Slowly, Senna realized that Minami loved him, but the development of a relationship between them was continually put off by misunderstandings and narrative digressions, as when Minami started to date Senna's

employer. Despite his teacher's constant encouragement, Senna lost his faith in his piano career; encouraged by Minami, however, he agreed to enter a piano contest whose first prize was a scholarship to study at a prestigious music school in Boston. Indefatigably supported by Minami, Senna won the piano competition, and in the drama's concluding scene, the camera followed Minami and Senna running through Boston to get to the church for their marriage ceremony, where their friends were waiting.

Fuji aired *Love Generation* a year later. It featured Kimura Takuya and Matsu Takako, both of whom had played in *Long Vacation*. In *Love Generation*, Kimura starred as a twenty-four-year-old advertising designer named Katagiri Teppei, and Matsu played the twenty-two-year-old office lady Uesugi Riko. The drama opened by following Teppei as he ran to catch the last train, late at night. The next scene showed him sitting on a curb in Shibuya. As he figured out where to spend the night, a car stopped in front of him and unloaded Riko, the heroine, who was fighting with her fiancé. The car then sped off. Teppei, who witnessed the scene, consoled Riko, and they spent the night at a hotel.

The following day, Teppei learned that he had been transferred from the advertising department to the sales department, where Riko also worked. At the same time, his high-school sweetheart, Mizuhara Sanae (played by Junna Risa), whom he had never gotten over, moved to Tokyo; Teppei discovered, however, that Sanae was involved with his brother, a high-flying prosecutor. Riko and Teppei, both on the rebound, became friends and tried to help each other move on. Similar to *Long Vacation*, misunderstandings postponed the consummation of love between Riko and Teppei, with the story line advanced by the couple's fights and reconciliations.[13] This advancing, however, did not amount to narrative development: it was not the story line but the characters that were moving toward a resolution.

As a contrast, consider the narrative structure of police dramas. Commonly, they open with a scene that describes an act of murder or with the discovery of a dead body. The plot develops through the investigation of the homicide and concludes by identifying and morally deriding the offender. The characters do not change as the plot moves toward a solution. In love dramas, plot development takes place within the "single woman finds happiness in marriage" scenario, and the characters undergo remarkable psychosocial metamorphoses.

In love dramas, the characters (*tōjō jinbutsu*) become narrative elements

or plot functions, and their development via solving their conflicts with other characters advances the plot. When a scriptwriter is asked to draft a plan for a new trendy drama, she is expected to write not so much an intriguing story as an appealing personality or an interesting conflict between two opposing personalities. Commonly the conflicts between people stand for the inner conflicts of the self, for love dramas essentially center on self-development. Ultimately, what is at stake is that the self overcomes the deficiencies (*jibun jishin to mukiau*) that foreclose its happiness. These dramas do not present character development in concrete sociocultural contexts (*shakaisei no nai terebi bangumi*) and do not deal with conflicts between individuals and society (i.e., community, family)—themes that are relevant in Japanese family-oriented dramas. Trendy dramas, in fact, reject the idea that social institutions impose structural constraints on the individual.

Love dramas work with a limited number of characters; parents rarely appear in the genre. This is an interesting point to emphasize, for this is how the characters become free-floating individuals divorced from the constraining ties of kinship and family. They are on their own to find meaning in their lives. I would cursorily note that this message was not simply a response to marketing discourses in the early 1980s that began to valorize the notion of individualism. The message that individuals should rely on themselves to realize their potential also resonated with popular discourses of self-responsibility in the wake of neoliberal transformations. In the 1990s, the televisual discourse that emphasized the responsibility of individuals to care for themselves neatly dovetailed with government initiatives such as welfare reform—that is, the government's withdrawal from providing social services and benefits.

Love is not an entirely new element in primetime Japanese serials. Love dramas, however, clearly depart from earlier television dramas not only in the ways in which they talk about love, but also in the narrative structures they employ, in which love is the *only* theme addressed. Characters develop exclusively in the context of love affairs and relationships. Most love dramas start with showing an unhappy woman and end with the same woman finding happiness in marriage to Mr. Right. The consummation of love and its conclusion in marriage are treated as corrections to the personal weaknesses and flaws that stood in the way of happiness.

Lila Abu-Lughod's insightful analysis of how Egyptian melodramas pro-

duce certain subjectivities is pertinent to my argument. She argues that, in a social context in which family, kinship, and religion are the primary sources of identification, Egyptian melodramas produce modern subjects by creating a modern sensibility and emotionalizing the quotidian world. This "in turn works to enforce a sense of the importance of the individuated subject—the locus and source of all these strong feelings" (Abu-Lughod 2002, 122). By focusing on "how the representations of characters' emotions in Egyptian melodrama might provide a model for a new kind of individuated subject," Abu-Lughod perceives melodramas as a technique for producing new kinds of selves because they encourage the individuality of ordinary people (2002, 117).

Egyptian melodramas, Abu-Lughod (2002, 116) concludes, become a means to mold the national community "in the overt projects to produce national citizens in a society in which kinship remains important and other forms of community and morality—most notably religious—exist." In her argument, melodramas play a key role in individualizing viewers to convert them into subjects of the nation-state. I contend a similar process of subjectivization is at work in trendy dramas. Yet there is a crucial difference in its effects. Principally, trendy dramas produce subjects of the market. First and foremost, it is important to remember that Japanese commercial television networks started to target young women with new primetime programming because these women had become a lucrative market segment, and a prime target of marketers, by the 1990s.

Love dramas interpellate the subject to come to terms with its desires. I argue that what is produced in this process of subjectivization is the ideal—self-centered and pleasure-seeking—consumer. In love dramas, the most common personality flaw (inner conflict) is irresoluteness (*yūjūfudan*). Note that this is also the greatest obstacle to becoming a savvy consumer, as a person who does not know what she wants and cannot make up her mind is not likely to become a spontaneous shopper. Within love dramas, irresoluteness is often scrutinized within the framework of the rebound theme.

Another personality flaw is self-sacrifice (*jikogisei*), which, blurred into notions of femininity, is a quality that commonly has been attributed to female homemakers in the postwar period. Self-sacrificing characters appear in love dramas as "the traditional woman" (i.e., the postwar ideal of femininity and womanhood) and the opponent of the dramas' heroines. In

the framework of love dramas, these two women compete for the hero. In love dramas, self-sacrificing behavior is examined in relation to the heroine; she knows that she wants the hero, but she temporarily renounces or sacrifices her desires and surrenders him to her opponent, the traditional woman, toward whom the hero would naturally gravitate. The traditional woman is denounced in love dramas because she is not a carefree spender. Hers are the flaws the heroine must overcome to be happy. Happiness, in this context, is defined as the courage to break free of the constraints of postwar institutions, such as the family (understood as a conjugal unit of a male breadwinner and a female homemaker who depend on each other for survival and maintain a rigid division of labor within which gender roles and responsibilities are not negotiable).

What is fundamentally an inner conflict is thus mapped onto an opposition between a traditional type of woman, who is soft-spoken (*monogoshi no yawarakai*), feminine (*kateitekina*), submissive (*jūjunna*), and self-sacrificing (*taeru onna*), and the new type of woman, who is not flirtatious (*kobinai*), independent (*jiritsushin no aru*), selfish (*wagamama*), outspoken (*namaikina onnanoko*), and impulsive (*migatte*).[14] The juxtaposition of these types was a feature of the two dramas I discussed earlier. In *Long Vacation*, Minami and Ryōko were pitted against each other, and in *Love Generation*, Riko competed with Sanae for the attention of the male protagonist. While love dramas denounce the hold of postwar social institutions on the individual, in positing marriage as the main condition for happiness, they seem to offer a conservative fantasy to women. This appears to be a contradiction, for marketing discourses encourage women to remain single and enjoy their freedom. However, I argue that, in actuality, the discourses of love dramas, of marketers, and of Yamada about young women neatly dovetail with one another.

Examining the function of marriage in the narrative development of love dramas shows that it becomes just another important venue through which these dramas endorse participation in consumer culture. A key point is that the marriages that end these serials also conclude the competition between the self-centered woman and the self-sacrificing woman, whose prize is "the prince on the white horse (*hakuba no ōjisama*)." Marriage, therefore, represents not the binding social contract that one must enter to be recognized as a mature member of society; nor does it end the period of self-absorption and self-centeredness. On the contrary, I argue that in

love dramas marriage becomes the master trope for consumption per se because it signifies commodity acquisition par excellence—the hero being the ultimate commodity.[15]

The ways in which male protagonists are represented in love dramas reveal what makes the hero such a coveted commodity. In love dramas, the ideal partner for the heroine is the sensitive and understanding man that female scriptwriters love to create but male producers and directors do not usually find realistic.[16] Male producers, says Kitagawa Eriko, the scriptwriter for *Long Vacation*, often find her male characters "passive like a plant." Instead, they prefer to see men who are "predators," because "real men don't like being chased by women, but prefer chasing them" (Kitagawa and Tanaka 1994). Kitagawa finds it the hardest to work with older producers (whom she calls "abhorrent geezers [*iyana oyaji*]") because they want male protagonists who take the lead role and women who follow them like a shadow (*"kage wo shitaite" taipu no josei wo motomeru*). This attitude reminds her of her father, she says, who rang a bell when he wanted his wife (Kitagawa's mother) to change the television channel for him: "My mother wasn't a dog—to call one's wife by a bell is unacceptable" (Kitagawa and Tanaka 1994, 26).

Clearly, Kitagawa is resentful toward Japanese patriarchal gender norms. Yet her gender politics are not indisputable, in my opinion. Her heroines want both a weak-willed man whom they can control and a powerful man who will provide for them. Kitagawa's male hero is conflicted: on the one hand, he is shy and sensitive, and on the other hand, he is a successful man with an elitist flair.[17] Her male protagonist is not a predatory type: he is too shy to take the initiative in asking a woman to marry him, but after marriage he will be the ideal husband, for he will serve as a non-exploitable source of (emotional and financial) support. He is an ego-booster—the closest friend of a self-absorbed woman. In Kitagawa's dramas, relationships between men and women never develop around passion and lust. Instead, she interrogates the borderline between male–female friendship and love and always decides in favor of friendship (Kitagawa 2000b, 2001b).[18] Invariably, the heroines of love dramas are portrayed as women who are willing to marry men who can provide for them but whom they can also control. A self-reflective trendy drama, *Kimi wa petto* (You Are My Pet; TBS, 2003), went as far as to claim that young Japanese women want partners they can treat as pets. *You Are My Pet* told the tale of a beautiful and

successful career woman who was dumped by her boyfriend for being "perfect." She then found a pretty young man in a box in front of her home and she took him in, calling him "Momo," the name of a pet she once owned. The episodes then showed the "owner" and the "pet" gradually developing feelings for each other.

Apparently, the producers and writers of love dramas subscribe to Yamada's interpretation of the parasite-single phenomenon and marketers' celebration of the savvy and wealthy young female consumers. The televisual, the marketing, and the social scientific discourses neatly dovetail with one another in that they all understand the postponement of marriage by young women as deriving from an anxiety that marriage will compromise their self-indulgent lifestyles—unless the conjugal bond is to a pet husband whom the woman can control but who will also provide for her. Kitagawa has argued that her dramas were popular because they *realistically* addressed young women's fantasies and has boasted that she draws only on her own experiences in writing them (Kitagawa 2000b). The popular novelist Hayashi Mariko concluded that the most valuable source of inspiration for Kitagawa was her own past of being an ordinary girl: "We are so lucky that not only can we put those teenage-year anxieties into a perspective—we can make money out of them" (Hayashi 1996, 48). The question then arises: was textual realism (or the character portrayal per se) the main source of pleasure for women in watching love dramas? In an analysis of viewers' responses to *Love Generation*, I will show that the new portrayals of dramatic heroines were not the only, or the primary, source of pleasure for the viewers. Responses to *Love Generation* suggest that viewers identified another source of pleasure: the post-textual world of the tarento economy, which they found just as empowering as the text, if not more so.

Magical Hair: Tarento and Pleasure

Via particular character portrayals and narrative configurations, dramas endorse a model of self-development toward a destination of the ideal consumer. By examining the ways in which viewers experience pleasure by watching love dramas, I assess whether they accept their textual interpellation as *frazzled and self-absorbed girls* who, through consumption, seek escapist pleasure and quick fixes for their frustrations. It is at this point that I return to the relationship between tarento, consumer culture, and

trendy dramas to illustrate how conceptualizing agency as a process of negotiating textually constructed ideological messages does not necessarily help one understand the effect television dramas have on viewers or how viewers experience pleasure in watching serial dramas. Although this approach is common in anthropological studies of television, it fails to grasp that dramas work on their viewers not only at the textual level, but also at the level of production.

As noted earlier, I was struck during my conversations with young women by the fact that they were more interested in talking about the tarento than about the story lines of trendy dramas. Moreover, in discussing dramas, viewers did not make clear distinctions between the fictive characters and the tarento impersonating them; they appreciated tarento both as fictitious characters seeking happiness and as real people with sophisticated fashion sense and lifestyles. As stated earlier, tarento often lack outstanding acting skills. Thus, it comes as no surprise that it is not their performances that viewers appreciate. Rather, viewers enjoy the tarento as symbols of upward social mobility who suggest to their female fans that self-determination through style is a crucial means to achieve social recognition. The tarento, after all, were once like the viewers and acquired fame and prestige as a reward for their looks and professionally engineered styles.

Love Generation aired four years before I began conducting fieldwork in Tokyo, so I complemented interviews with informants (most of whom had seen the serial) with an analysis of blog and chat room entries collected from Japanese websites, as well as with commentaries by journalists published in youth-oriented popular magazines. What I found conspicuous was that many viewers discussed a particular scene that I did not even remember. Later, I learned from interviews with the staff that the scene had been carefully crafted to be a climactic moment in the first episode, in which Teppei and Riko met and began to commiserate over their failed relationships.

In the scene in question, his new boss scolded Teppei for having long hair. To conclude the ensuing fight between Teppei and his boss, Riko snuck up behind Teppei and cut off his ponytail. The haircutting scene was the third gesture portrayed in the episode (the first involved a fight over a photograph of Teppei's former girlfriend; in the second, Teppei threw away Riko's engagement ring) that showed the lovers-to-be helping each other move on with their lives. After my informants called my attention to this

scene, I searched popular magazines and Internet chat boards for further commentaries on it. To my surprise, I learned that Kimura's hairstyle had been a hot topic of popular discourse since his dramatic debut in 1993. After Kimura's shearing was aired, viewers saturated chat boards with comments; magazine articles offered interpretations of the shift in the tarento's image; and radio programs opened fax hot lines to allow their audiences to voice their opinions on Kimura's new look.[19] Kimura's hairstyle had been of great interest to fans since the early 1990s, but *Love Generation* was an important milestone in the "hair talk." As a viewer stressed in his summary of the drama, "What was really memorable . . . was Kimura's haircut in episode one. The scene in which Matsu cuts Kimura's long hair has earned this show a place in the history of television dramas."[20]

Why were the viewers so thrilled about a scene that centered on Kimura's ponytail?[21] I argue that its significance lies in a strategic collapsing of the tarento's public and private personas. In the producer's commentary, Koiwai Hiroyoshi attributed the drama' success to its realism, by which he meant the realistic portrayal of ordinary people (i.e., salarymen and office ladies) grappling with ordinary problems: "Perhaps the young generation could empathize with Katagiri's problems at work because they experience similar difficulties in their own lives."[22] However, in another interview the scriptwriter Asano Taeko provided a contradictory explanation:

> The request I received was to draft a story for Kimura Takuya and Matsu Takako. In the case of *Mrs. Cinderella* [Fuji, 1997], we had the story idea first, and the casting was decided after that. [For *Love Generation*], the casting was decided first, and the dramatic roles Kimura and Matsu had played before determined the characters I could make out of them. . . . The two lead tarento had enough power to draw high ratings, so it was obvious that I could not think of drafting adventurous or unconventional plots. . . . Instead of doing an intriguing story, we had to follow the policy of showing them as they were. (Satake 1997, 73–74)

Koiwai attributed the drama's popularity to its realistic portrayal of the problems and pleasures of youth, yet the two superstars in the lead roles were more important in drawing the extraordinary ratings and in

serving as a source of pleasure to the viewers than was any story line, no matter how realistic. Koiwai emphasized that Kimura and Matsu were playing *ordinary* characters in *Love Generation*; it is all too evident, however, that they were the hottest stars on Japanese television, and there was *nothing* ordinary about them. Japan's best stylists designed their makeup, clothes, and hairstyles; they were unusually attractive and loaded with self-confidence. The only ordinary—"realistic," if you will—aspect of them was that they performed themselves, for they played ordinary people who were as attractive, well-heeled, and sophisticated as their real-life personas. In fact, it was not the realistic portrayal of Katagiri's work frustrations that viewers enjoyed watching. My informants emphasized that, indeed, there was nothing enjoyable for them in seeing the same dullness they were exposed to in their own workplaces during the day. On the contrary, when they watched dramas they expected to see something radically different that made them forget about their tedious and monotonous work or frustration with incompetent bosses. In contrast to Koiwai's statement, my informants found the fictitious character Katagiri Teppei realistic not because of his work problems but because Kimura played himself faithfully. In other words, viewers did not make a distinction between the fictitious Katagiri Teppei and the tarento Kimura Takuya. Who they saw and enjoyed on the screen—and who they judged for makeup, fashion, and speech style—was Kimura the tarento.[23]

Correspondingly, the discussions that followed episode one centered on analyzing the implications of the haircut for Kimura's public and private personas. "According to the storyline," a viewer remarked, "Kimura had to have a haircut, because his long hair did not fit his new role as an employee of the more conformist sales department. However, it's not that he got a new conservative look. His hair is still long, isn't it? I love (*aishiteiru*) Kimura, so I don't care how long his hair is. And this new hairstyle is cool anyway. It makes him look younger and highlights his handsome face."[24] By pointing out the discrepancy between the narrative function of Kimura's haircut and the tarento's new image, the viewer confirms that there is no clear boundary between Kimura's public and private personas.

According to Koiwai, Kimura's nonconformity was symbolized by his long hair, and his shearing signified an alleged social maturation within the framework of the narrative. Cutting Kimura's long hair was a significant

moment for viewers because it was an important moment for Kimura. His long hair had long been his trademark; thus, the cutting of his hair was the moment when something essential changed in both his image and in himself simultaneously. The ponytail was severed from the fictitious character to finalize his transition from the advertising department to the sales department—that is, from the artistic, non-mainstream world to mainstream society. As I suggested earlier, the blurring between the fictitious and real personas of the tarento was a strategic choice made by the production staff. Koiwai highlights the importance of this scene by arguing that it was both a fictitious transition within the drama's narrative and a real shift in Kimura's media image. Until *Love Generation*, Kimura had been cast as not-yet-grown-up, metrosexual, manga-esque characters such as the student in *Asunaro White Paper* (Fuji, 1993) and the young adult in *Wakamono no Subete* (All about Youth; Fuji, 1994) and as flexible laborers (freeters) such as the freelance piano teacher in *Long Vacation*, a model scout in *Boku ga Boku Dearu Tameni* (I Always Keep Control of Myself; Fuji, 1997), and a deliveryman without a memory in *Gift* (Fuji, 1997). He also played an exceptionally talented architect in *Kyōsōkyoku* (Concerto; TBS, 1996). His difference from the mainstream was symbolized by his long hair. The haircut signified his alleged social maturation.

The producer highlighted that it was a brave move to link Kimura with the corporate world and to have him play an ordinary salaryman for the first time in his career. Cutting his long hair was a significant moment for the viewers because it was also an important moment for Kimura: it was the moment when something essential changed simultaneously in his image and in his self. This is how the tarento come to serve as a source of pleasure to the viewers as positive examples of the self in the making. While textual analyses have suggested that dramas tend to reinsert their audiences into consumerism by selling them the role model of the pleasure-seeking self, audience research reveals that young women see not only immediate and escapist pleasure in consumption, but also a potential in self-determination through style. So we see that viewers of television dramas derive pleasure not only from the particular character portrayals and narrative configurations (textual level), but also from the branding practices in which trendy dramas participate via the tarento system (production level).

Honing one's sense of love (*koi no sensu wo migaiteokō*) was the agenda of love dramas and love philosophy (*ren'ai ron*) in the 1990s (Kitagawa 1996; Saimon 1996; Saimon and Kitagawa 2000). Love serves as a means to emotionalize and individualize the subject, thus placing her into the center of her own life. The love dramas discontinue the tradition of Japanese home dramas, which addressed the relationships and conflicts between individuals and communities—most notably, family, workplace, and school. Love dramas measure the subject against its "true self" in that self-development concludes when the subject is freed from embarrassment over confessing and acting on her desires. I have argued that this is equivalent to the making of the ideal consumer. At the same time, for the viewers of trendy dramas, it is not primarily the fictitious characters that are interesting. Rather, viewers appreciate the tarento, who, in their reality, suggest to their audience that they too can craft and manipulate their selves (style and attitude) to be socially successful. Kimura Takuya can play any role, from a high-flying architect to an ordinary hairdresser. Viewers identify not so much with the fictitious problems he is grappling with as they do with his individual style, which made him famous as a tarento.

Scholars have highlighted how style (and consumption) has become the normative consciousness and how it has grown into an intimate component of subjectivity, intertwined with people's aspirations and anxieties (Campbell 1995; Miller 1995). While these theories tend to emphasize the empowering effects of fabricating selves with objects (that symbolize their aspirations), the Japanese case illustrates that consumption is but another site of struggle between marketers, television producers, and viewers to define self and pleasure. This is more true for media entertainment produced in the wake of growing demands for "customized" entertainment than it has ever been before. Brian Massumi (2002, 43) notes that "the media are massively potentializing, but the potential is inhibited, and both the emergence of the potential and its limitation are part and parcel of the cultural-political functioning of the media." This is certainly true; yet in this chapter, I have attempted to show that the reality of how television producers and marketers assess viewers' desires and the pleasures that viewers experience in these serials are often more complicated than formu-

laic understandings of the relationship between these social actors in a realm in which happiness and profit are affiliated in an apparently virtuous liaison.

In their analysis of the role psychoanalysts played in marketing research in the early postwar period, Peter Miller and Nikolas Rose (1997, 31) wrote: "This was not a matter of the unscrupulous manipulation of passive consumers: technologies of consumption depended upon fabricating delicate affiliations between the active choices of potential consumer and the qualities, pleasures and satisfactions represented in the product, organized in part through the practices of advertising and marketing, and always undertaken in the light of particular beliefs about the nature of human subjectivity." Psychoanalysis no longer enjoys a privileged position in marketing research, for marketers no longer conceptualize their customers in terms of abstract universal human needs. Instead, they work with precise psycho-sociological profiles of the individuals they want to reach. As Japanese television producers were engineering their new commodity, the trendy drama, they were also making up the consumer. Yet in a "political economy of subjectification," participant observation, marketing, and academic discourses not only helped television producers assemble a new consumer of primetime dramas; they also offered "new ways of inciting and regulating emotional economies, relations of identification and forms of sociality" (Miller and Rose 1997, 32).

Love dramas put forward a material conception of self: they measure the self in a matrix of corporeal practices, such as the leisure activities in which the self participates, the goods it consumes, and the clothes it wears. Stuart Ewen has (1999 [1988], 77) explained the preoccupation with style not as evidence of power but as an act of claiming power that is not there: "A central appeal of style was its ability to create an illusionary transcendence of class or background." Similarly, in the context of Japan in the 1990s, lifestyle expertise transcends socioeconomic position, and the consumer and producer selves are no longer mirror images of each other, as Pierre Bourdieu theorized in *Distinction* (1984). His analysis of the correlation between class (i.e., position in the mode of production) and lifestyle is pertinent here. By the late 1980s, young Japanese women had become the new lifestyle elite. As I have elaborated, trendy dramas not only made enormous profits by exploiting this phenomenon; they also reinforced it. Bourdieu has argued that economic power is powerless in itself, and for it

to be legitimated it must be converted into symbolic power. Classes are distinguished not solely by their specific place in the mode of production, but also by their distinct styles. Lifestyles, he continues, are resources in a class contest for honor, which is won by displaying the greatest distance from economic necessity. To appreciate status goods, individuals have to possess the necessary schemes of enjoyment that Bourdieu calls cultural capital. In contemporary Japan, this translates into *consumer* cultural capital—that is, familiarity with brand names in clothing and cosmetics, gourmet food, and leisure activities. In Bourdieu's argument, status goods are accumulated with the intention of exercising and perpetuating social power.

This, however, does not work for Japanese women, as a wide gap remains between their status goods and their relative marginalization from socioeconomic power. Still, one of the most commonly available ways for women to acquire status is through marriage, and this is exactly the scenario love dramas echo to their viewers: single office ladies living with their parents. Most of these viewers do not hold career-track positions and do not own property. The reality is that many of them could barely make do without their parents, as they cannot sustain themselves independently on their own earnings. At the same time, the idea of women who are financially independent from their parents or husbands still evokes social angst. By replacing parents with husbands, love dramas offer conservative fantasies to their viewers. Closely resonating with academic and marketing discourses on young women's investment in consumer culture, love dramas serve as "social shock absorbers" (borrowing from marketing language) to suture over the contradictory expectations young women face in a changing socioeconomic condition. At the same time, as professional consumers young female viewers are quick to learn how to benefit from trendy dramas by enjoying them by way of the tarento, who serve as positive role models for social success in which style (consumer professionalism) is the key to self-determination. After all, style is not always the surrogate for action as Ewen (1999) claims. In the following chapter, I examine how the politics of style articulates the politics of gender and class.

Labor Fantasies in Recessionary Japan

Five

EMPLOYMENT AS LIFESTYLE IN WORKPLACE DRAMAS OF THE 1990S

In the first episode of the *Shomuni* series (General Affairs Department 2; Fuji, 1998), Tsukahara Sawako (played by Kotomi Kyono) is transferred to the department of general affairs—the "graveyard for office ladies (*OL no hakaba*)"—as retribution for having an affair with a married employee in the sales department.[1] Located in the dim basement of the trading company Manpan Shōji, the general affairs department (*shomuni*) is home to unsold and useless merchandise, a male department head who cannot complete a sentence without garbling his words and his plus-sized cat, and four other "loser office ladies (*ochikobore* OL)" who similarly have been disposed of for being too old, too outspoken, or otherwise ill-suited to the higher-profile departments of the corporation. The general affairs department is a parody of the company's organizational structure, and Sawako's problems are far from over once she is transferred to her new post. She faces her next hardship when she is assigned her place in the department's

rather unconventional hierarchy. As the seating order is determined by the number of sexual partners one has had, she gets the darkest spot in the room and is relegated to the lowest rank that space entails. At the climax of the episode, when she teeters on the verge of a nervous breakdown, the spiritual leader of the department and the protagonist of the series, Tsuboi Chinatsu (Esumi Makiko), reveals her philosophy to Sawako: "You don't exist to serve your company or your male colleagues; it is they who exist to serve you. What matters is that you have fun; the rest is irrelevant."[2]

Chinatsu, the bohemian heroine, and her unorthodox attitude toward her company made the serial wildly popular, earning it a mega-hit status (ratings higher than 28 percent), contracts for three additional seasons, and two feature specials. It epitomized a new genre of primetime drama serials, the so-called workplace drama (*shokugyō dorama*) that television professionals have developed in reaction to love dramas. As I have described in chapter 4, love dramas entertained their viewers with stories of "love affairs between who-knows-what-they-do-for-a-living characters dwelling in fashionable flats" (Ōta 2004, 72). However, in the second half of the 1990s, television professionals started lamenting the downfall of television in its new obsession with consumer trends packaged in trite, scripted dialogues about love. These producers voiced their concerns that offering the viewers Cinderella stories in the face of the prolonged economic slowdown was irresponsible escapism. They suggested that the steady degradation of commercial television could be reversed by revitalizing the tradition of "socially responsible entertainment (*shakaisei wo obita entāteinmento*)" in program production. While these producers denounced love dramas and stressed that television serials should address concerns beyond the happiness of the individual, I will argue that there were more commonalties than differences between love dramas and work dramas. Whereas love dramas advocated the importance of self-centeredness in one's love life, work dramas promoted individualization in the realm of work. Based on my case study of *Shomuni*, I show that, by introducing the idea of individualism into the realm of wage labor, these dramas played a key role in neoliberal labor mobilization in Japan in the late 1990s.

In 1998, when the first *Shomuni* series aired, the economic crisis was severe. The 1.8 percent decline in gross domestic product had resulted in the Japanese economy's worst single-year performance since the first oil shock in 1973; the 4.3 percent unemployment rate was a postwar record,

as well (Lincoln 1998; Uriu 1999). Rather than abandoning the system of lifetime employment, corporations acclimated to the economic slowdown by freezing recruitment, transferring workers to subsidiaries, and encouraging early retirement (Vogel 2006). However, by the end of the 1990s it had become clear that large-scale corporate restructuring was unavoidable because the national economy did not seem to be recovering from the recession. *Shomuni* was a product of this particular moment. The heroine of the drama series insisted that no job was worth pursuing if there was nothing enjoyable about it. This is a curious response to changes in labor conditions that included the crumbling of the lifetime employment system, the wide-scale loss of job security, and growing demands for flexible employment—conditions that were hardly conducive to self-realization.

By reintroducing values such as fun and individualism into the realm of wage labor, workplace dramas such as *Shomuni* offered labor fantasies that served as sugar-coating to make neoliberal initiatives for individual responsibility more digestible in conditions in which Japan was increasingly pressured to introduce free-market principles into its government-guided economy.[3] Jacques Donzelot (1991) has argued that, as work is becoming less and less meaningful under neoliberal conditions, the transfer of responsibility to the individual and his or her invitation to autonomy become auto-generating sources of compensation. Similarly, while job security was diminishing in Japan in the late 1990s, work conditions were becoming more exploitative as production was rationalized to increase profitability. In this context, workplace dramas played a crucial role in making the changes in labor conditions agreeable to individuals. My analysis of *Shomuni* aims to show that ideological efforts to provide the individual with a feeling of autonomy in relation to work serve to compensate for the waning meaning of work for the worker. Further, workplace dramas strive to blur the line between the world of wage labor and the world of pleasure.[4] By doing so, these serials mobilize workers into a new model of rationality within which the pursuit of greater efficiency (at lower labor costs) corrupts resistance by presenting the changes in labor relations as a necessary precondition to freedom and pleasure.

I have argued in this book that at the turn of the 1990s, the Japanese television industry shifted from producing narrative entertainment to offering lifestyle-driven shows in which information on consumer trends was a key source of pleasure. Drawing on interviews with the producers and

viewers of *Shomuni*, I probe this thesis and further examine the relationship between consumer culture and television programming. Workplace dramas marked a return to narrative entertainment. These dramas do not appeal to viewers with images of stylish young people who are spending their time in trendy leisure sites. Instead, the characters of workplace dramas don work uniforms and interact in workplace settings. Yet there is reason to doubt that workplace dramas succeeded in weakening the link between television programming and consumerism. After all, this new subgenre of trendy dramas drew a new audience segment to television that had not been keen on watching trendy dramas: young male viewers.

Male viewers have claimed that it was the heroine of *Shomuni* who evoked their sympathy. She became a positive role model for them mainly because she was persistent in making the best of her job and having fun while doing it. I will argue that by reintroducing values such as fun, originality, and individualism into the context of work, these dramas not only mobilized viewers into new neoliberal labor regimes. They also reconciled a deepening conflict between the old work ethic of the postwar period and the new spirit of consumerism of the 1990s. Specifically, while employers expected young men to sacrifice their lives to their companies, marketing discourses—especially from the mid-1980s on—encouraged self-centeredness. Because workplace dramas successfully mediated the breakdown of the dominant postwar divide between the "female consumer" and the "male producer," they managed to draw a new audience segment to the medium.

On the one hand, realism can be understood as a discursive trope through which television professionals negotiated their increasingly limited agency in the wake of the massive commodification of the medium. On the other hand, realism as a trope also functioned to distinguish these dramas from the love-oriented serials that, by the second half of the 1990s, had largely alienated male viewers from primetime television. Promoted as primetime entertainment that was more realistic than love dramas, the workplace dramas aimed to appeal to male viewers and thus forge male consumer subjectivities by establishing continuity between men's roles as producers and consumers—not unlike the love dramas had done in reinserting women into consumer culture. This chapter, therefore, offers a case study to illustrate that the ways in which commercial television networks mediate external realities are inextricably intertwined with the ways in which they pursue their audiences. After discussing how the primetime genre of

workplace drama evolved in the late 1990s, I will trace how the new dramas mediated and capitalized on socioeconomic changes while producing new labor and consumer subjectivities in the process.

Workplace Dramas: Love Fatigue and Social Realism

The workplace itself is not an entirely new setting in Japanese television dramas. In detective serials (*keiji dorama*), the institution of police, for example, was a typical workplace setting that provided rich ground for developing story lines and articulating values vital to the reproduction of the dominant socioeconomic order (e.g., *Taiyō ni Hoero!* [Howl at the Sun! NTV, 1975–82]). The school drama (*gakuen dorama*)—preoccupied with the perennial conflict between individual and society—was another type of workplace drama (e.g., *Sannen B Gumi Kimpachi Sensei* [Third Year B Group Head Teacher Kimpachi; TBS, 1979–80, 1982–90, 1995, 1998–99, 2001]). Workplace dramas lost some of their appeal in the 1990s largely in response to the spectacular success of love-oriented trendy dramas. In the first half of the 1990s, they were relegated to half-hour daytime slots that were targeted to housewives.

In the second half of the 1990s, workplace dramas were picked up again partly in response to their success in graphic novel (*manga*) culture,[5] and partly as a consequence of the growing discrepancy between the euphoric world of love dramas and the gloomy realities of everyday life in the recession.[6] While commercial television had always served marketers by providing them with a programming environment suitable to advertising their products, the launching of trendy dramas marked a new phase in the commercialization of the medium by breaking down the boundary between entertainment and advertising. In the second half of the 1990s, television professionals commented profusely and bitterly on this trend, pointing out that primetime drama serials had lost touch with reality and hence had lost the capacity to engage issues of social relevance. Producers of workplace dramas defined the new genre in opposition to the love dramas that they considered to be unrealistic fairy tales (*rearitī no nai yumemonogatari*). In emphasizing that workplace dramas were realistic, they referred to a particular notion of realism that I find resonant with social realism. In relation to British soap operas, Ruth Mandel (2002) defines social realism as a strong assumption on the producers' part that

television can raise consciousness and shape the beliefs of the viewers through didactic means. A long-running social-realist soap opera on BBC Radio 4 in the United Kingdom is *The Archers* (1951–), which was launched with the goal of teaching modern techniques of agriculture and animal husbandry to its audience. Other social-realist soap operas raised such important issues as domestic violence; these aimed not only to educate audiences, but also to help victims by providing hotline numbers at the end of the programs (Mandel 2002). Similarly to their British colleagues, many Japanese television professionals in the late 1990s increasingly resented that television had lost its role to serve the public sphere as a forum for the discussion of socially relevant issues. They reasoned that making programs of social import would reverse the process of steady degradation in the quality of televisual entertainment.

In postwar Japan, television—which had become self-sustaining by the mid-1960s—played a key role in producing and maintaining a sense of "national" community in the wake of rapidly vanishing communal forms of entertainment. While love dramas of the 1990s were preoccupied with the happiness of the individual, postwar television dramas were concerned with the socioeconomic vitality of society: they played a key role in reproducing the ideological foundations of mass middle-class society. As they portrayed average people learning to be useful members of society, these television dramas encoded the ideals of social-realist entertainment. The social-realist mode of representation insists on the realistic; on creating believable characters and showing their everyday activities and surroundings. For instance, while the heroines of love dramas are dressed and coifed far beyond the means of the particular characters they play, the characters in workplace dramas are commonly clad in office attire, police uniforms, or scrubs. (My informants, however, never failed to remind me that real Japanese workplaces are not as cool as the ones that appear in workplace dramas.)

Yamaguchi Masatoshi, the producer of *Kirakira Hikaru* (Shining Brightly; Fuji, 1998–2000), has commented:

> Fuji TV is strong in the trendy drama genre. Trendy dramas portray characters as if they spent ten hours out of a day's twenty-four hours thinking about love. Apparently, these dramas are very popular, and I admit that it is difficult to make high quality love dramas. It's just that in

> my environment there is no one who would spend that much time on managing his or her love life. Isn't it rather the case that most of us don't spend more than daily fifteen minutes on our love-related problems and personal conflicts? Grownups spend most of their time making money and worrying about their work. (Komatsu et al. 2000, 111)

Yamaguchi concludes that because primetime dramas are so popular, they are a great chance for commercial television networks to address issues of social relevance and reflect on changing socioeconomic conditions. While in most cases this effort has remained an unrealized ideal, the televisual discourse on social responsibility has been efficient in serving other interests and producing other effects. I interpret the ways in which producers used the notion of social responsibility as a discursive trope to negotiate their agency in a period in which their artistic aspirations were increasingly constrained in parallel with the massive commodification of the medium. At the same time, I stress that the strategy of making primetime serials that imparted a sense of realism also served to draw, package, and deliver new audience segments (most notably, young men) to advertisers. By stressing that workplace dramas were different from love dramas, producers aimed to interpellate audience segments that did not like love-oriented serials.

This is not to say, however, that no workplace drama succeeded in embracing the idea of social realism. The scriptwriter Nakazono Miho's *Dear Woman* (TBS, 1996), for example, pioneered the trend of educating female employees about gender-based discrimination in the workplace. The serial followed the story of a young woman, Tsuno Reiko, who was trying to find employment in Tokyo but was always rejected when it came to light that she was a single mother. Finally, she decided to lie about having a child, which earned her a non-career-track job as an office lady. In her new workplace, she was assigned to a project that aimed to monitor gender-based abuses within the company and to address complaints. While sexual harassment was pervasive in Japanese companies in the mid-1990s, no public discourse addressed the issue. The serial thus filled a crucial gap by discussing cases that ranged from recruiters hiring female employees solely on the basis of their looks to male employees bullying their "aging" female colleagues (women in their late twenties!), pressuring them to quit so they could be replaced with younger employees. Nakazono recounted to

me in an interview that many of the letters she and the network received claimed that viewers used *Dear Woman* as a reference point to fight sexism in the workplace (see also Nakazono 2001, 2002).[7]

Dear Woman, however, was an exception. An early forerunner of workplace dramas, it targeted primarily female viewers by blending a love story with plot lines that revolved around the vicissitudes of office ladies in the masculinist corporate world. In other workplace dramas, the deployment of a more realistic mode of representation was not so much a means of raising social awareness as it was a promotional marquee to draw new audience segments to television by making these serials somewhat distinct from love dramas. A brief survey of the strategies producers employed to make their dramas more realistic supports this claim. Commonly, producers mention three strategies. They claim that (1) these dramas do not capitalize on the Japanese celebrity system; (2) their selling point is the well-crafted stories; and (3) they discuss character development not in a social vacuum but in the context of work. It is important to note that these features were precisely the opposite of those that had defined love dramas and had distinguished them from the television dramas they succeeded in primetime programming slots from the late 1980s on.

First, producers of workplace dramas believed that by not capitalizing on the tarento system, their dramas could relax the link between television and consumerism. By placing the tarento at the center of drama production, love dramas were increasingly embracing the self-referential world of the tarento system, and, in parallel, they were growing ever more estranged from external social realities. The Fuji producer Yamaguchi Masatoshi has emphasized that in their capacity to mobilize references to consumer culture, the tarento posed the greatest challenge for producers seeking to make socially relevant dramas.

Second, Yamaguchi has noted that, unlike love dramas that exploit celebrity power, the strength of workplace dramas lies in the carefully crafted stories. In the production of workplace dramas, tremendous research is invested into the scripts to ensure the accuracy of details and the integrity of the narrative, for the success of these shows depends on how compelling and convincing the stories are (Komatsu et al. 2000).[8] A focus on the story in serial-drama production tends to correspond to a narrative style that considers the individual episodes both as independent units and as parts of a serialized program. This means that the episodes are enjoyable as dis-

crete units, without requiring the viewers to commit themselves to watching the entire series. The producers of love dramas had counted on a commitment to the series on the viewers' part. To keep viewers hooked, producers relied on cliffhangers and the so-called ever-expanding middle (Modleski 1982), a narrative strategy that postpones conclusions until the very end of the season finale. This aspect, however, discouraged viewers with less flexible work schedules from watching love dramas. These viewers appreciated work dramas, as they could enjoy single episodes independently without having to watch the entire series.

Finally, love dramas discuss questions of identity (such as the meaning of happiness for individuals) in a social vacuum. Their characters are not members of particular social communities; we do not know their family background and do not always get a clear sense of what they do for living. In contrast, workplace dramas contextualize characters as social beings who spend the majority of their time in their workplaces. In work dramas of the late 1990s, the workplace is not simply a background for the unfolding story line; it is the primary site for character development. In these new work dramas the work environment is described in detail and the characters' attitude toward work is scrutinized. These dramas were in dialogue with media and government discourses on the need for institutional restructuring in the wake of the recession (*Shiroi Kyotō* [The Great White Tower]; Fuji, 2003–2004);[9] their primary target of criticism was the rigidly hierarchical institutional structure (e.g., seniority system) that they identified as a major source of inefficiency and one of the principal causes of the economic recession. Accordingly, one of the main conflicts of workplace dramas was the clash between junior and senior employees, since it was in the course of their struggles with their superiors that characters matured. To ground my analysis of the effects workplace dramas produced in the late 1990s, I describe some of the postwar conditions, ideologies, and problems concerning wage labor from which Japanese television professionals drew ideas for dramas.

Work and Subjectivity in Trendy Dramas and in Recessionary Japan

Viewers have commonly claimed that an aspect they particularly enjoyed in workplace dramas was the refreshing portrayal of the characters and their relationship to work.[10] To understand why viewers found the charac-

ters in these dramas appealing, I briefly elaborate on the differences in the representations of women and their relationship to work in love dramas and workplace dramas. I focus on female characters because most workplace dramas (including *Shomuni*) centered on the character development of young women. Further, in this section I also explore why male viewers could more easily identify with these female protagonists. After discussing the dominant differences between the portrayals of heroines in workplace and love dramas, I move on to examining how these representations relate to and rework socioeconomic realities in Japan of the late 1990s.

Work was not a privileged theme in love dramas, mainly because producers believed that office ladies—the target demographic of the genre—were not interested in watching stories that revolved around issues of labor after a hard day of unrewarding clerical or secretarial work. In love dramas, women's relationship to work was represented in two dominant ways. One was the attitude of the non-career-track office ladies who consider their employment an interim period between school and marriage and quit their jobs when they have children.[11] This is the typical heroine of love dramas. This character did not have a strong commitment to her profession or to her company. The other dominant—yet in reality, much less common—type of working women portrayed in love dramas was the die-hard thirty- to forty-something, single career woman who devoted herself to her work at the price of giving up family plans (Suzuki 1999). The series *Single Lives* (TBS, 1999) and *Brand* (Fuji, 2000) featured this type of female protagonist.

Producers of workplace dramas have commented that, by the end of the 1990s, this binarism in the representation of women reflected the realities of working women's lives less and less. Both portrayals were exaggeration, according to the scriptwriter Inoue Yumiko:

> Th[e] drama [*Kirakira Hikaru*] was made before *Shomuni*, and there were not many dramas in which women were doing something together in a team. I personally badly wanted to see a drama in which four individualistic women (*koseitekina kyarakutā*) vigorously worked, dined, and drank together. . . . When watching dramas I often had the feeling that they were made from a male perspective. Basically, you could see two types of women: the non-career-track office lady, who mostly wanted to get married (*kekkon ganbō no tsuyoi koshikake* OL) and the career-woman

> type, who spent most of her time fighting her male colleagues. Real working women don't conform to these stereotypes. Career women have more pride than to fight men all the time, while it's false to assume that non-career office ladies spend most of their time thinking about love. My impression is that it is flawed to make that hard divide and put out a message that women do either work or love. Instead I wanted to show that women indeed work just as hard and responsibly as men do. I wanted to portray women who took pride in their professional identities. (Satake 2000, 41)

Takahashi, the scriptwriter of *Shomuni*, also has commented on the unrealistic portrayal of women in television dramas: "The office lady of television dramas, who has a lot of money and a rich lover and spends most of her life having fun (*asobimakutteiru*) originates in women's magazines. . . . The everyday lives of ordinary office ladies are far less joyful. They work hard for the 3 million to 4 million yen ($33,000–$44,000) they make a year, and when they get home from work late in the night, often their only pleasure is to watch television in their tiny studios while eating some instant food that they picked up on the way home" (Satake 2000, 141–42).

This dominant binarism between women as future homemakers who are not invested in pursuing a job outside the home and women as career women who devote themselves to their professions and are not interested in having their own families had become increasingly discrepant with social realities by the second half of the 1990s. Marriage to a prince charming who would provide for his sweetheart for the rest of her life—the idealized life course for middle-class Japanese women in the postwar period—was no longer a *desirable* route for the minority of women who wanted to pursue careers, and it was no longer a *viable* route for the majority of women by the late 1990s. In reality, many women would have liked to quit their jobs once they married, but during the recession it had become increasingly hard to find a husband whose salary would have enabled them to become full-time homemakers. At the same time, married women faced growing pressure to contribute to the household income against the backdrop of increasing competition in the labor market and inadequate welfare-state support (White and Kelly 2006).

I would argue that male viewers could empathize with these office lady characters because young men increasingly were experiencing the same

labor-market disadvantages that women had long experienced in Japan. In the postwar period, Japanese corporations relied on the systems of lifetime employment and seniority-based pay that entailed in-house employment training and constant transfers between remote branch offices. This system applied only to a stable core of male workers, who in return were expected to commit themselves to their companies (Rohlen 1979).[12] Female employees were not part of this core workforce, because in the absence of adequate social-welfare and child-care facilities, most women were forced to quit when their children were born. As a feminist labor sociologist has put it, women's role was to run the family: "while men work heart and soul for the company, women must do the same to ensure men can continue to do so" (Ōsawa Mari, cited in Broadbent 2002a, 7; see also Borovoy 2005; Kurotani 2005).

Most typically, female employees in the corporate world were office ladies—the primary target audiences and protagonists of love dramas—whose average tenure in their companies spanned three to eight years. They performed mainly clerical work such as filing, operating office equipment, accounting, reception, and document and data processing. These women could neither maintain a continuous labor history nor re-enter the labor force as career-track employees, because the systems of lifetime employment and seniority-based pay foreclosed their reintegration into the corporate hierarchy.

During the postwar period, the turnover rate among these female employees was high, which saved money for companies because they did not have to invest in training. Hence, companies employed a stable layer of clerical workers for minimum salaries that did not increase at the same rate as the salaries of male employees. In addition, companies did not pay social-welfare benefits or bonuses to their non-standard employees (Broadbent 2002b; J. Lee 2004; Ōsawa and Houseman 1995; Weathers 2001). Thus, the flexibility provided by women's underpaid labor helped to offset the high costs of the lifetime employment system and to sustain a core set of aging workers who received large wages that increased with tenure. The deficiencies of this system (such as the retention of incompetent male employees) were concealed by practices such as transfers to less important branch offices and the so-called *mado giwa* (moving these employees to "window seats" to keep them from causing too much damage to their companies). During the decade of 1990–2000, non-standard em-

ployment (such as the work of non-career-track office ladies) in Japan increased by almost 50 percent, and while 71.6 percent of all non-standard workers were women, the ratio of male employees also rose sharply in this period.[13]

Under the banner of the so-called freeter phenomenon, popular and social-science discourses have explored young people's changing opportunities in the labor market and their changing attitudes toward work. "Freeter" (a hybrid of the English word "free" and the German word "*Arbeiter*," or worker) refers to the twenty- and thirty-something young people who are unwilling to offer companies the same selfless loyalty their fathers had and who instead hop from one short-term job to another simply to finance the hobbies and foreign travel to which they devote themselves. The average freeter is reported to stay in a job for about nine months, during which he or she earns about $1,000 a month.[14] In 2001 Japan's unemployment rate reached a record 5.4 percent,[15] and the figure for men age fifteen to twenty-four was 10.7 percent. In 2001, part-timers made up 23 percent of the workforce. At the same time, the Ministry of Health, Labor, and Welfare estimated that 70 percent of junior-high-school graduates, 50 percent of high-school graduates, and 30 percent of college graduates quit their jobs within three years of leaving school (Brooke 2001).

Many top-ranking trendy dramas, such as *Long Vacation* (Fuji, 1996) and *Beach Boys* (Fuji, 1997), glamorized the freeters' flexible lifestyle and iconoclastic, anti-salaryman attitude. This celebration of freeters was part of a broader popular discourse on the changing attitude of youth toward labor. A Japanese journalist for the *New York Times* has written: "If the icon of the 1980s was the salaryman who sacrificed his private life for his company, today's icon is the freeter—the young Japanese who take odd jobs to make just enough money to enjoy their personal interest or choose their way of life" (Ōnishi 2004, A3). These social commentators have argued that the freeter phenomenon marked the breakdown of the dominant life course of the mass middle-class stratum of society and the concomitant proliferation of choices for individuals to realize their aspirations in new ways. They have claimed that, although there are so-called *no-choice* freeters, who wanted but failed to get regular employment, the two major groups into which freeters can be divided are the (1) *dream chasers*, who pursue a distinct and not always work-related dream and do not want to

become regular full-time employees; and (2) the *moratorium freeters*, who have yet (*itsuka*) to decide what kind of career to pursue and in the meantime (*toriaezu*) hop from one part-time job to another (see Kariya 2003; Kosugi 2002).[16]

Freeters are not only objects of celebration; they are also a source of moral panic. Yamada Masahiro (1999) has played a key role in feeding this unfavorable judgment. Yamada blames freeters for not making their state-pension contributions, putting further stress on a fund that is already burdened by a growing elderly population.[17] He also accuses freeters of exacerbating Japan's falling birthrate, as they marry later and have fewer children, if any at all. He refutes the image that freeters devote themselves to pursuing their dreams. On the contrary, he argues, freeters are just using such dreams as excuses not to work, because it is rarely the case that they give up full-time jobs to realize their ambitions. He concludes that freeters indeed have no dreams and characterizes them as weak-willed, lacking in ambition, irresponsible, spoiled, and self-absorbed.

Both of these approaches are problematic. Without situating freeters in the context of the economic slowdown that contributed to the emergence of this social trend (i.e., the end of the era of high economic growth and the decline of the socioeconomic structure that underwrote it), both the celebration and the critique of contemporary Japanese youth's changing attitude toward full-time employment read as mere finger-pointing. I agree with Genda Yūji (2005) who argues that the development of phenomena such as the growing number of freeters and parasite singles is the result of corporate policies that aim to preserve the jobs and wages of older generations of employees. One can interpret the sea change in Japan's workforce as part of a worldwide trend toward flexible accumulation, as companies seek greater efficiency in a business environment that becomes increasingly volatile as markets and industries continue expanding beyond national boundaries. It is not only that young people in Japan do not want to sacrifice their lives to their companies; they decreasingly have the opportunity to do so. The United States also has been adding temporary and part-time workers to its workforce. Similarly, in response to the serious economic downturn Japan suffered in the 1990s, companies are not only severely curtailing the hiring of regular employees fresh from school; they also prefer to employ part-time workers instead.

On the one hand, opportunities for secure employment in Japan were

shrinking in late 1990s and the available work was decreasingly likely to be meaningful. On the other hand, as companies were trying to increase profitability, their demands on their employees were changing for the worse. For example, by the late 1990s, take-home overtime work (*mochi kaeri zangyō*) had become a mainstream practice. The question then became how to secure the commitment and loyalty of the worker without restoring the postwar social contract and its main pillar, the system of lifetime employment. Workplace dramas such as *Shomuni* played an important role in reconciling these contradictions. The changing practices of corporate recruitment not only diminished the prospects of youths for secure employment; they also eliminated a familiar scenario for a predictable future. In searching for new directions, different social institutions imagined different possibilities for youths. In doing so they were not unaffected by their own political and economic investment in this segment of society. And although these visions were not necessarily consistent even within distinct institutional discourses, producers of dramas seemed to be in agreement in that they did not want to upset their sponsors by playing up concerns with the insatiable appetite of the new economy for flexible labor or ideas that freeters were indeed "a new economic underclass in the making" (Yoda 2000, 656). Instead, they suggested that young people should get the best out of their new freedom.

The producers of trendy dramas, however, conveniently avoided the question of where this new freedom came from; at best, they timidly suggested that it may have resulted from the diversification of choices as the high-growth world order with its inflexibly scripted life course came to an end (*Beach Boys*; Fuji 1997). Alternatively, they surmised that freedom may have been the result of a process whereby the service industries replaced the manufacturing sector as the motor of the economy and consumption practices came to play a more important role in defining identity than one's place in the system of production. For many, the idea that freedom was indeed the new dominant obligation (and the new obligatory life course) did not seem compatible with the expectations of commercial sponsors for television networks to create a consumption-friendly media environment—which would entail valorizing the link between freedom and choice as opposed to lamenting the connection between freedom and obligation.

This televisual indifference to the origins of freedom tended to conceal

the connection between freedom and neoliberal initiatives in the age-old liberal rhetoric of commitment to ideals of personal freedom. David Harvey (2005, 42) has noted that neoliberal initiatives, to which ideals of individual freedom were essential, have always been "backed up by a practical strategy that emphasized the liberty of consumer choice, not only with respect to particular products but also with respect to particular lifestyles, modes of expression, and a wide range of cultural practices. Neoliberalization required both politically and economically the construction of a neoliberal market-based populist culture of differentiated consumerism and individual libertarianism." In other words, while the encouragement of narcissistic consumerism in love dramas was merely supporting a neoliberal rhetoric, workplace dramas went a step further by mobilizing against hierarchical and highly bureaucratic institutional structures (i.e., forms of regulation other than the free market) that stifled the realization of freedom.[18]

Workplace dramas celebrated freedom as courage on the part of young people to steer clear of secure employment that would require them to sacrifice their individuality by becoming part of a homogeneous and highly disciplined workforce. (Note the resonance between this position and neoliberal theory that considers unemployment voluntary.) However, in the wake of diminishing pathways to regular employment and the proliferation of new irregular work options, the television industry's position does not seem all that socially responsible. *Shomuni* was appealing because it reconciled the contradictory expectations young viewers were experiencing in the late 1990s: on the one hand, as *producers* they were expected to keep sharing in the postwar work ethic that required them to subordinate their desires for fun-loving lifestyles to their companies' needs for a docile workforce that could revitalize the country's underperforming economy. On the other hand, as *consumers* they were encouraged to pursue their aspirations by experimenting with an expanding multitude of consumer choices. Viewers' responses suggest that workplace dramas—and *Shomuni* in particular—evoked their sympathy because the female protagonists transposed their "true" fun-seeking selves into their jobs. By bridging the gap between these different expectations, the office ladies of *Shomuni* represented a new breed of workers whose will to connect fun and work resonated with neoliberal initiatives to push individuals to become autonomous and entrepreneurial.

The *Shomuni* series was based on a comic (*manga*) written by the young artist Yasuda Hiroyuki, who himself lived a freeter life. It appeared in the comic magazine *Shūkan Mōningu*, which targets a male readership and was published between November 1995 and June 1997. An article in *Josei Jishin* has stressed that the manga was popular because it featured a new type of office lady who was different from the protagonist of love dramas. These female characters did not sacrifice their own interests to help someone else (in this context, the hero) advance his. Instead, they became powerful and autonomous. Moreover, they were courageous enough to defy corporate hierarchy. The article concludes that male readers found it liberating to see these characters refusing to abandon their personal values within the corporate setting (*jibun no kachi de ikiru*).[19]

While the popularity of the comics suggested that *Shomuni* might appeal to a young male audience, producers did not have high expectations, as young men did not constitute a demographic committed to primetime television. The serial's exceptionally high ratings thus pleasantly surprised both the production team and the programming department. The surprise was due to the fact that the serial did not feature any top tarento, without whom producers believed no drama could make it to the top of the popularity charts in the 1990s. The serial was hastily put together when a new slot for dramas (Wednesday, 9–10 P.M.) was created shortly before the start of a new season. Before 1998, this slot had been reserved for variety shows. The programming department decided to reassign it to dramas in response to the network's success in the genre.

The hit drama maker Ōta Tōru of the programming department—who was in charge of assigning staff and of casting tarento for *Shomuni*—did not want to devote a huge budget to a serial that did not have much chance to achieve high ratings. In the lead role he cast Esumi Makiko, who was not well known in 1998. (Indeed, it was *Shomuni* that earned her fame.) The supporting cast was similarly assembled from second- and third-tier tarento, who were recruited randomly depending on their availability. Ōta assigned the new serial to the producer Funatsu Kōichi, who was known for his affinity for the unconventional (e.g., more "art-house" programs tending to draw low to moderate ratings). He was also one of the producers

in charge of the more successful, but far from mainstream, *Yo ni mo Kimyōna Monogatari* (Weird Stories in the World) specials, which had been broadcast at the end of drama seasons since 1990. These feature programs are the outlet for drama-production staff to do something more in the realm of the absurd, the cynical, and the artistic.

Suzuki Masayuki, the director, was the most experienced member of the production staff. Like the producer, he had a flair for non-traditional dramatic formats. Because Suzuki was an accomplished director with strong credentials, Ōta entrusted him with the freedom to do whatever he pleased (Uesugi and Takakura 2001). At the same time, Suzuki had already been engaged in another project scheduled for the next season (*Sekaide Ichiban Papa ga Suki* [I Love Dad, He's the Best in the World]; Fuji 1998), which involved larger budgets and top-tier tarento, including Akashiya Sanma.[20] He concentrated on the preparation of *Sekaide Ichiban* because the network expected it to draw high ratings.[21] Not surprisingly, the two scriptwriters the programming department recruited for the project, Takahashi Rumi and, later, Hashimoto Yûji, were also neophytes in the field. Interviews with production staff suggest that a reason for *Shomuni*'s high ratings was that the drama was produced in a vacuum. The programming department had modest expectations and thus refrained from exerting pressure on the production staff.

What, then, are the other factors that turned the serial into a smash hit?[22] Three explanations emerged most commonly in my interviews and in the magazine articles and fan sites I reviewed. First, viewers found the portrayal of the office ladies appealing; they claimed that it was encouraging to see how they talked back to their male bosses. Second, the series was easy to follow, as each episode offered a whole story with a solution at the end. Finally, viewers enjoyed watching the office ladies wearing miniskirts. In this section, I will focus on discussing the first response. The second comment corresponds to producers' strategies to draw new audience segments with less flexible work schedules by making each episode independently enjoyable. While the third comment seems somewhat off the mark, it is indeed an interesting one. I suggested in my discussion of social-realist entertainment that featuring characters in work uniforms instead of high-end designer fashion aimed to loosen the link between television programming and consumerism. At the same time, female characters wearing uniforms—especially the ones that came with improbably short skirts—

were appealing to male viewers in particular. Here I will make only a cursory comment on the widespread reappropriation of work uniforms in the Japanese sex industry as a form of erotic costume play. I should also add that the more popular the serial became among male viewers, the shorter the skirts of the heroines were tailored, and the more frequently the main character was featured atop a ladder changing light bulbs while the camera filmed her from below.[23]

Fan sites, magazines, and my interviews suggest that *Shomuni*'s high ratings came mainly from viewers' enthusiasm about the new bohemian working heroine, Tsuboi Chinatsu, who became a cultural icon.[24] Takahashi, who drafted the drama plan and wrote the first episode, played a crucial role in creating the character of Chinatsu. Takahashi recounted to me that she did not follow the original manga closely. First, she could not avoid readjusting the characters because of the cast. Tsukahara Sawako was the protagonist in the original comic. Takahashi was more inspired by a supporting character, Tsuboi Chinatsu, however, and was convinced that this character was a better match for the lead tarento, Esumi Makiko, which is why she decided to place Chinatsu at the center of the drama.[25]

The other plot line in the original manga that Takahashi kept for the television drama was the opposition between Chinatsu and the elite office lady Misono. What turned these women against each other were their irreconcilable philosophies. While Misono believed that the value of a woman was determined by the status and financial background of the man she dated, Chinatsu held that it was the number of men a woman has dated that defined her worth. This conflict was reminiscent of the antagonism between the heroine of love dramas and her rival in their competition for the attention of the hero. While the former was the epitome of the *shōjo* (the young girl whose life centers on fun and consumer culture), the latter was the traditional woman, who conformed to postwar gender ideals and became a stay-at-home mom. In the workplace setting of *Shomuni*, the role of the traditional female character remained the same to emphasize the freshness of the new bohemian character. This conflict, however, did not become the central theme in the serial. Rather, the conflicts between these two characters degenerated into catfights—which some viewers, as their comments on fan sites suggest, found particularly sexy.

The juxtaposition of old-fashioned and "new" women of the love dramas was not completely abandoned in workplace dramas (as we can see, it

resurfaced in *Shomuni*). However, it was also replaced by a new conflict between progressive young women and older male employees (*oyaji*, *ojisan*)—"mainstream, reactionary, middle-aged men who cannot grow out of their old-fashioned identification with a work centered life" (Yoda forthcoming). The *ojisan* is also the enemy of young men (among them freeters) who prefer a more consumerism-driven lifestyle. These two groups come from starkly different planes: while the older male employees think that young women should follow the path of early retirement because women's place is in the home, young women claim that stupid geezers should all retire (*Baka oyaji inkyo se yo*) because they are good for nothing. What is important to note here is the gendering and "generationalizing" of an antagonism that is between not men and women but the values of the high-growth economic order and those underlying neoliberal restructuring.

The opposition between young, progressive women and old, retrograde men was the key conflict in *Shomuni* that survived not only from one episode to another, but also from one season to the next. This conflict translated into the basic narrative framework in which the manager of the human-resources department, Terasaki, was determined to liquidate the general affairs department. To prove that the department was an unnecessary expense to the company and that its members were incompetent, Terasaki and his assistant, Nonomura, cooked up new challenges, such as health examinations and fire drills to assign to the office ladies. Terasaki deliberately scheduled these drills for days when the company's executives were to sign important contracts and needed to impress new business partners with a cleaned-up version of the company suggesting efficiency and reliability. As Terasaki and Nonomura planned, the office ladies did turn the company upside down, but they did not succeed in getting them fired, because the women always ended up impressing the new partners with their efficiency in cleaning up the mess and with their capability of organizing the company into a single, task-oriented body. In each episode, the office ladies started to panic when they got their new assignments, but Chinatsu found the fun side in the challenges. She stayed level-headed, folded her arms, and concluded: "It sounds like a good adventure. Let's get some fun out of it."[26] Correspondingly, the director has commented: "These women made a mess of the company, but they won the hearts of not only women but male viewers as well with their message that one should have a little more fun with life."[27]

What was so compelling about the Chinatsu character? What kind of new agency did she propose that resonated with female viewers' and male viewers' imaginations of a positive role model? As the quote by the scriptwriter Inoue Yumiko illustrates, in workplace dramas the representation of the heroine has undergone significant changes. This resulted from efforts by producers to make more realistic dramas that featured larger-than-life characters who were developing by struggling with realistic problems, such as conflicts with bosses. The typical heroine of workplace dramas no longer found the meaning of her life in love and marriage. Some of these female protagonists devoted themselves to their careers (*Kirakira Hikaru*); others worked because of financial necessity (*Dear Woman*) or simply because they found work and company life entertaining (*Shomuni*)—but marriage never completed their personality development, as it did in love dramas.

Chinatsu is an extreme character in the original manga, though her life story comes to the surface only sporadically in the television drama. From the manga, one learns that she was disowned by her family after she embarked on a career in the adult-video business. She entered the corporate world as a career-track employee but she was transferred to the department of general affairs after knocking out her male boss for smacking her butt. A scene from the first season illustrates her brashness. Chinatsu and Sawako are having dinner at a ramen stall when a group of gangsters joins them. Chinatsu bets one of the gangsters that if she loses at arm wrestling, he can spend the night with Sawako. Sawako runs off, while Chinatsu (not surprisingly) loses. The next day, she tells Sawako that she owes her big time because she had to sleep not only with the gangster she lost to, but also with his friends. Sawako responds that she cannot believe what nonsense Chinatsu is capable of saying without shame.[28]

The only thing Chinatsu values is freedom, and she pushes her female colleagues to embrace a desire for autonomy. She often confronts Sawako for letting her male colleagues order her around and for not having a sense of her own self.[29] She is also at odds with Misono, the elite office lady, who spends her time in the company searching for a potential husband. Chinatsu criticizes these women for not being independent and relying on men to define who they are. The bohemian protagonist becomes a matured manifestation of the love-drama heroine who, I argue, also evokes the male freeter. What is distinctive about Chinatsu is that she does not expect anyone else to make her happy. Instead, she relies solely on herself to

define who she is and how she imagines happiness for herself. The character fully internalizes a healthy sense of self-orientation that marketing and social-science discourses associate with freeters in the late 1990s (and with the *shōjo* in the 1980s, who became the heroines of love dramas in the 1990s). Moreover, while the selfishness of the love-drama heroines invited criticism from male viewers, Chinatsu turned this personality trait into an attractive role model. She justified it as a source of the freedom, autonomy, and entrepreneurial spirit that she advocated as essential for survival in a recessionary economy. She represented a new type of labor subjectivity in that she rejected the hierarchical and group-oriented corporate structure for repressing individualism and forcing employees to give up their freedom and autonomy.[30]

Nakane Chie (1970) argued that, in Japan, it was the frame (institution, place) that became the major criterion for group formation, as opposed to the attributes shared among individuals that constituted groups in Western societies. She stressed that this principle of group formation came from the household structure (*ie*) of the Tokugawa period (1603–1867) that still persisted in various group identities, such as those of villages, educational institutions, and business corporations. This social structure was based on the principle of groupism (*shūdan shugi*) and the minimization of individual autonomy. She saw proof in the fact that Japanese employees identified themselves not by their occupation but by the institution (i.e., frame) itself (Nakane 1970).[31] Her study legitimized the postwar ideology of corporate management, which required employees to commit themselves to their companies, by arguing that the frame-based pattern of group formation was founded on historical precedents in Japan.

This is exactly the ideology Chinatsu defiles by constantly reminding her colleagues that the so-called *frame* no longer offers employees a stable sense of belonging and a scenario for a meaningful future. Chinatsu becomes the superego of the company in the era of corporate restructuring. It is her responsibility to replace light bulbs, so a ladder is a work tool she carries around in every episode. But this ladder is not just a ladder; it also serves as the "corporate ladder," the symbol of the old socioeconomic order of Japan Inc. (*kigyōka shakai*). She carries the symbol around to make everyone aware of its existence and of its impact on the employees. She pledges to denounce any efforts to climb the corporate ladder, because she

6 Esumi Makiko playing Tsuboi Chinatsu in *Shomuni*. Courtesy Kyodo Television / Fuji Television Network Inc. and Ken-on Talent Agency.

is aware that in the old-fashioned corporation, such efforts are equated with abandoning one's self.

An example of this came in the episode in which the office ladies in the department of general affairs vowed to help a career office lady win a competition against the star male employee, Ukyo Tomohiro, for the position of project manager. It turns out that the career-track office lady has abandoned her baby, leaving him entirely in the care of her divorced husband, so she can devote herself to work. The husband is unable to take care of the baby and returns him to his mother, leaving the baby with a note in the company's lobby. The mother, however, denies that the baby is hers because she knows that being a single mother will severely reduce her chances to win the competition. In the end, Chinatsu tells the young career woman that their efforts to help her are a waste if it means she has to become a man and compete like men who abandon their families for the sake of their work. If the shomuni women were to help her become a

soulless corporate cyborg in the process of building her career, their mission would be a failure.

Chinatsu claims that no career is worth losing oneself for.[32] One may wonder about the meaning of this insistence on the right to freedom in the condition of shrinking employment opportunities. Chinatsu's character has to be understood in the context in which young women came to symbolize social change. To identify with them was to approve of the values commonly associated with them, such as individualism and self-centered lifestyles. By the late 1990s, however, social discourses lumped together young women and male freeters, and they came to epitomize the same values in the popular imaginary. This is why *Shomuni* could so seamlessly blur the line between the identities of office ladies and male freeters. Chinatsu was garbed in the uniform of office ladies, but she had the spirit and attitude that sympathetic discourses attribute to freeters. This is curious, as freeters and corporations occupied opposite ends of a spectrum in popular discussions of Japan's future in the 1990s. While freeters represent the new Japan, corporations stand for the postwar order. By introducing a freeter attitude into the corporate world, Chinatsu became a reminder that a symbiotic dependence between corporations and employees was at odds with the demands of the new economy for entrepreneurial spirit, mobility, and flexibly reconfigurable work skills. By representing these values, Chinatsu epitomized a new worker subjectivity.[33] Yet the answer she offered was nothing more than a labor fantasy; an uncritical celebration of freedom that obliterated the fact that neoliberal economies thrive on the liberal rhetoric that recognizes freedom as an inalienable property of individuals. (In a neoliberal context, however, freedom is not only the freedom of the worker to flexibly employ or redefine her skills, but also the freedom of the company to dispose of workers as market and labor demands fluctuate.)

Takahashi recounted to me that she thought of *Shomuni* as a recession drama because the characters' main preoccupation was to redefine themselves in conditions in which they could no longer count on their companies to provide job security and welfare benefits. The message that "no work was worth doing if there was nothing enjoyable about it," however, reads not so much as a realistic strategy for youth than as a fantasy of agency and desire to be entitled to freedom in the wake of shrinking prospects for secure employment. Steven Vogel (2006) has argued that, in

the 1990s, the Japanese government and Japanese corporations aimed to reform the employment system not by completely abandoning existing institutions but by cautiously modifying or even reinforcing them. These choices, however, were made more to protect the aging workforce than to allow youth to enter the system of secure employment. *Shomuni*'s suggestion to link work and enjoyment is thus discordant with the demands of the new economy for flexible labor, which, one can argue, is often far from being enjoyable. Despite all of this, employers who hire employees for irregular work commonly require the same commitment from them as do companies that offer secure employment. The rhetoric of fun, I argue, plays a vital role in reconciling the discrepancy. According to Takahashi,

> In male-oriented workplace dramas such as *Sarariman Kintarō* (Salaryman Kintarō; TBS, 1999–2000, 2002, 2004) or *Kachō Shima Kōsaku* (Section Chief, Shima Kōsaku; Fuji, 1993–94, 1998), the main themes are how men climb the corporate ladder (*shusse suru*) or how they confront evil. Conflicts between junior and senior employees serve as the main sources of struggle. Ordinary office ladies in *Shomuni* have a lot of other problems than climbing the corporate ladder (which is way out of their league). . . . Of course, they are not in the position to fight evil. All they want is to make their jobs more fun for themselves. (Satake 2000, 142)

The message that "office ladies should get some fun out of their work" is by no means radical, given that non-career-track female employees have long been involved in what Ogasawara Yuko (1998) calls offstage resistance. She argues that acts of sabotaging work by deciding job priorities arbitrarily or by not taking initiative end up promoting stereotypes that women get carried away with emotions and thus are irresponsible employees. However, connecting the idea of pleasure and work opens a space of redemption to male freeters. Note that, unlike office ladies, male freeters cannot aspire to secure a stable future for themselves by marrying men in career-track positions. (In *Shomuni*, Misono represents this possibility for office ladies.) Thus, by introducing pleasure into work, *Shomuni* offers a possibility for positive self-identification to freeters who interpret their unemployed status as the realization of the very freedom to which they are entitled and a step toward finding meaningful and enjoyable work.

In other words, Chinatsu's character explains the flexibilization of labor

as a potential for freeters to enjoy their freedom (which is portrayed as a matter of choice). There is a curious gender politics at work here. While institutional discourses interpret the freeter phenomenon differently, they converge in viewing freeters—female and male—as collectively effeminate. *Shomuni* dissociates them from this image. Consider the claim that freeter lifestyles are deeply enmeshed in consumer culture and, more broadly, the discussion of young men's new interest in consumerism. Although it is becoming more socially acceptable for Japanese men to be consumers of lifestyle commodities and services, devoted involvement in consumerism is still coded as effeminate. Correspondingly, when discussing Japanese men's increasing participation in consumer culture, scholarly and popular discourses predominantly talk about the feminization of men—thus re-inscribing the postwar divide between male producers and female consumers (see Frühstück 2000; Miller 2003, 2006). In the 1980s, a consumption-led definition of selfhood defined by personal style became more characteristic. Yet this was discussed as a feminine trait in that it challenged the principle of unity and uniformity, the founding values of the masculine corporate structure of the postwar period. In this gendered binary, therefore, resistance to an earlier ideal of masculinity epitomized by the salaryman, "especially of images of short, stocky, dark-suited *oyaji* [geezer] with pomade-plastered hair" (Miller 2003, 52), is inextricably tied up with femininity. This is exactly why Chinatsu became popular with male viewers: in addition to refashioning the indecisiveness of youth as an insistence on one's right to freedom, she offered an alternative, more attractive ideal of masculinity. Although it goes beyond the scope of this chapter to elaborate this point, I will note that in recent years the heroine of *Shomuni*, Chinatsu, has become a gay icon. This not only illuminates the fluidity of Chinatsu's gender identity but also reveals how struggles for recognition of one's vision of a meaningful future open redemptive possibilities.

Conclusion: Workplace Dramas and Labor Fantasies

The prolonged recession has marked the end of Japan's rapid economic growth and all that it meant: steadily rising standards of living, low unemployment rates, mass middle-class society, and the system of lifetime employment (or for women and the self-employed sector, the possibility to

aspire to it for their children). On the one hand, although Japanese government officials and industry leaders agreed that introducing more flexible labor-market laws was unavoidable, they remained ambivalent about abandoning the postwar labor contract (Vogel 2006)—or, at least, its ideological support for formidable work discipline and workplace hierarchy.[34] On the other hand, the service industries pushed less hesitantly for neoliberal restructuring, flexibility, and new worker subjectivities. In these conditions, commercial television networks played an important role in reconfiguring the field of possibilities and mediating the tensions between young people's narrowing opportunities for secure and meaningful employment and growing desires to use their labor power to realize themselves in new ways.[35]

The televisual discourse on social responsibility was both a marketing strategy to sell workplace dramas to new market segments (most notably, young men) and a means for television producers to negotiate their own agency under the massive commodification of the medium in the 1990s. The televisual discourse on social responsibility, however, not only served the interests of producers but also produced new labor subjectivities while capitalizing on the socioeconomic changes of the 1990s. Workplace dramas reminded their viewers that their workplaces were no longer capable of securing predictable futures for them; they had, instead, become precarious institutions that had to be constantly saved from disintegration or bankruptcy. By portraying this reality as the order of things under a stagnating economy, workplace dramas such as *Shomuni* tended to naturalize the withdrawal of corporations from guaranteeing stable employment. Instead, workplace dramas encouraged individuals to redefine themselves as enterprising and autonomous subjects who were on their own to secure their psychological or economic well-being.

In a media environment in which not more than 5 percent of television programs are imported (Hara 2004; Iwabuchi 2000), television dramas play a vital role in reinforcing particular social orders by reproducing the socioeconomic structures and dominant subjectivities that underwrite them. Family-oriented home dramas from the 1960s, for example, valorized selflessness, a key behavior to organize the national community into an entity united under the desire to ascend to the ranks of the Western economic superpowers. Although producers of workplace dramas claimed that they aimed to revitalize the tradition of socially responsible entertainment

(as epitomized by home dramas) by reintroducing a concern for social issues into commercial broadcasting, work dramas in fact were not much different from love dramas. Both subgenres of trendy drama promoted self-centeredness as opposed to selflessness. While work dramas were more concerned with social issues that surfaced in recessionary Japan than love dramas were, a preoccupation with the individual and his or her happiness remained at the center of both genres of primetime entertainment. Whereas love dramas encouraged their viewers to be self-indulgent in their love lives, *Shomuni* conquered a new frontier (and the last bastion of the old postwar socioeconomic order): the corporate world. By linking pleasure and work, the series suggested that it was the individual's responsibility to make work enjoyable. While love dramas portrayed work as an unavoidable nuisance, in work dramas work became the very force field within which individuals could enact their freedom. Responsibility was outsourced to the individual, and the breakdown of the postwar socioeconomic order was perceived not as a result of the state's failure to regulate industrial and labor relations but, rather, as the responsibility of individuals. In the late 1990s, workplace dramas both mediated an ongoing recalibration of the social contract between individuals and postwar social institutions and produced new labor subjects in response to the demands of the new economy. In other words, workplace dramas offered labor fantasies that served to make neoliberal initiatives for individual responsibilization more palatable.

Chinatsu, the heroine of *Shomuni*, was a female stand-in for the male freeter. But why were young women garbed in mini-skirted uniforms chosen to relay the message to viewers that work should be a space where one realizes one's personal freedom? In the 1980s, young women's burgeoning power as consumers was part of a broader change in the popular imaginary. By the end of the 1990s, women had come to embody new values, such as a more robust enjoyment of life and a more relaxed relationship to work. While the service (mainly entertainment and leisure) industries have made enormous profits targeting these young women, other industries have also exploited them as a source of cheap and disposable labor. Mary Brinton (1993) has claimed that, in postwar Japan, gender served as a readily available criterion by which a reservoir of unskilled labor could be maintained or shut down as business cycles fluctuated. While women have been steadily supplying flexible labor, the demand for disposable workers has increased dramatically in the wake of the recession, and masses of young

men have been incorporated into a workforce that lacks a career structure, a right to lifetime employment, and the welfare benefits that this entails. In *Shomuni*, these socioeconomic trends served as the background to the story lines, but in the world of commercial television they were glazed over with a hypocritical message suggesting that there was no unrewarding job that could not be transformed into fun. This breakdown of the boundary between the realms of consumerism and wage labor marked a new phase in neoliberal restructuring and labor flexibility.

Six

Private Globalization

BOOTLEGGERS, FANSUBBERS, AND THE TRANSNATIONAL CIRCULATION OF J-DORAMA

Want Japanese Doramas to be made available to the U.S. Market? Write to: steven_glick@paramount.com. Glick is Paramount's Exec[utive] VP in charge of bringing international products to the DVD home market.

http://www.jdorama.com

In earlier chapters, I examined the ways in which trendy dramas tightened the link between television programming and advertising. I described how these lifestyle-oriented programs aided the Japanese media and advertising industries in their efforts to multiply sources of revenue by integrating formerly unrelated markets. In parallel with the fragmentation of the local consumer market in the 1990s, new media content and transnational programming began to challenge the hegemony of television as the main source of media entertainment. In this context, lifestyle-driven shows helped the Japanese television industry meet the challenge and reinforce its self-sufficient system of production. By anchoring these dramas in local consumer culture, television networks managed to make them more attractive to Japanese audiences than, for instance, foreign programming that could not provide the added value of information on lifestyle trends relevant to Japanese viewers. It would be logical to assume that international

audiences would not find Japanese trendy dramas appealing: they cannot participate in the consumer practices portrayed; nor can they purchase the outfits or visit the leisure sites featured in these dramas. This, however, is not the case. While Japanese networks were indifferent to the idea of exporting these programs overseas, illegal distributors—international media pirates and so-called fansubbers[1]—propelled trendy dramas onto the global scene in the 1990s.

By exploring this phenomenon, this chapter probes a key argument of this book in a global context. Earlier, I suggested that the principal dilemma the Japanese television industry faced in the late 1980s was market fragmentation. In this chapter, I argue that market fragmentation has not only spurred a transformation in the Japanese television industry; it has also reconfigured dominant patterns in the transnational flows of media content. While the recent rise in the global popularity of Japanese media entertainment has attracted considerable scholarly attention, the question of why this phenomenon occurred in the 1990s (and not before) has been left unanswered. What these studies suggest is that the recent global success of Japanese media culture represents the long overdue recognition of Japan as a non-Western representative of capitalist modernity on par with advanced Western nations (Iwabuchi 2002; Napier 2007). I complement this culturalist interpretation with a political-economic approach by stressing that, to understand Japan's shifting place in global culture, one has to take into account the transformation of local media markets in the past two decades. Specifically, from the 1950s to the 1980s, Fordist principles undergirded the structures of national television industries, meaning that a limited number of mass-distribution channels strove to amass the largest possible audience with mass-produced entertainment (Havens 2006). Although in different ways, national television industries underwent a structural transformation beginning in the late 1980s to accommodate fragmenting markets and diversifying consumer tastes. It was in the aftermath of these changes that the trendy drama entered global circulation. In other words, the segmentation of local markets was the key precondition of, and the main reason for, the global success of Japanese media entertainment in the 1990s.

By analyzing the globalization of what has come to be labeled J-dorama (i.e., trendy dramas in global circulation)[2]—an example of the bottom-up practices of transnational media distribution that exploded in the 1990s—

this chapter will also contest a popular theory in global media studies that understands cultural globalization as a concentration in media ownership. This theory posits that vertically integrated media conglomerates are better equipped to survive in the wake of converging media technologies and the erosion of the traditional market boundaries (Doyle 2002; Wayne 2003). Henry Jenkins (2006a, 155) calls this new business strategy "corporate convergence," which he defines as "the concentration of media ownership in the hands of an ever smaller number of multinational conglomerates who thus have a vested interest in insuring the flow of media content across different platforms and national borders." Scholars have generally understood Japan's entry into the Euro-American media market within this theoretical framework. Specifically, they have argued that the most expeditious way for Japanese media companies to gain a toehold in Western markets was to exploit the distribution arms of large, vertically integrated Western media companies (Iwabuchi 2000, 2002, 2004; Shimizu 1993). To make this point, they draw on the example of Disney's delivering Miyazaki Hayao's animation hits to international audiences and the global circulation of Japanese video games through collaborations with local partners.[3] In dialogue with recent studies such as Ian Condry's work on hip-hop in Japan (2006) and Susan Napier's research on the global circulation of anime (2007), this chapter argues that the illegal reproduction and distribution of J-dorama outside Japan challenges the understanding of media globalization as occurring through the increasing integration of markets and distribution arms. By contrast, a mapping of the global journey of J-dorama brings into focus an under-explored aspect of cultural globalization. It shows that in the wake of the fragmentation of local media markets, alternative (bottom-up) practices of media circulation have come to complement the centralized (top-down) mode of distribution that previously characterized international television trade.[4]

The Global Journey of Japanese Dramas I: Media Piracy and Fan Entrepreneurship

J-dorama started its global journey from Hong Kong, Taiwan, Singapore, and Malaysia, where Japanese television serials had been popular with urban Chinese youth since the early 1990s (see Davis and Yeh 2004; Hu 2004a, 2004b, 2005; Iwabuchi 2000, 2002, 2004). In the introduction

I noted that Japanese television networks did not find it reasonable to export their programs to Asia because it was difficult to make profits on these markets. The average budget of a one-hour drama production in Japan is about 30 million to 40 million yen ($330,000–$440,000), but the same drama can be sold to an overseas market for only 200,000 to 400,000 yen ($2,200–$4,400; Iwabuchi 2000). At the same time, even if local networks bought the copyrights for first broadcasts, idiosyncratic local copyright laws and rampant media piracy in East Asia and Southeast Asia foreclosed the possibility of developing copyright contracts for second and third broadcasts (Hu 2004a).

East Asian and Southeast Asian viewers, however, were eager to watch Japanese trendy dramas. They enjoyed the programs as repositories of information on the fashionable lifestyles and hip consumer trends of the regional metropolis, Tokyo (Ko 2004; M. Lee 2004; Nakano 2002; Siriyuvasak 2004). An equally important factor that explains the popularity of trendy dramas in Asia in the 1990s is that local television networks could not adapt to market diversification and were unable to cater to young viewers as quickly as Japanese networks could. Launched in 1992, the intraregional Star TV (Satellite Television Asian Region) was a pioneer in broadcasting trendy dramas in East Asia and Southeast Asia.[5] However, as local cable networks were obliged to go through the official channels to obtain copyrights, they were slower in relaying the new dramas to local audiences than local media pirates, who reproduced and distributed the serials virtually without delay after they were broadcast in Tokyo. Timeliness was key to distributing these dramas, as viewers watched them for information on ephemeral consumer trends.

Not only were bootlegged copies available almost immediately; they were also convenient. Viewers could watch them whenever they wished without adjusting to broadcasting schedules. At the same time, bootlegged dramas were duplicated on video CDs (VCDs), whose lower quality and poor recording capability made them much less expensive than the licensed media that were released on DVD. The VCD technology, which was specific to the region, was developed in 1993 by electronics manufacturers such as Sony and Panasonic. It gained a strong toehold in the Asian market, with the exception of Japan, where it never became popular.[6] Scholars have argued that VCD technology has always been closely associated with media piracy. In other words, watching Japanese programs in Taiwan in

the 1990s was inextricably linked to the experience of the low-quality VCDs. Scholars point out that when viewers in East Asia and Southeast Asia talk about Japanese television dramas, they are referring to an experience that involves the use of VCD rather than cable or satellite TV (Davis and Yeh 2004; Hu 2004a, 2004b). This is reminiscent of what Brian Larkin (2004, 291) calls pirate modernity, which, he argues, is characterized by a particular aesthetic—"a set of formal qualities that generates a particular sensorial experience of media marked by poor transmission, interference, and noise." As legal media production relies on pirate infrastructure, pirate aesthetic becomes the dominant presentational mode of legally produced media. While pirate modernity reassigns Nigerian media producers to a marginal position in the global media economy, in the context of East Asian and Southeast Asian piracy, it marks alterity.

Numerous factors explain why media piracy has become a booming industry in East Asia and Southeast Asia. The most important is that Hong Kong and Taiwan never joined the Berne Convention, the most comprehensive supranational regulation of intellectual property rights. Under the Berne Convention, the participants agree to guarantee the rights to the works originating in other member countries that its own laws grant to the works created in their own country. The fact that Taiwan and Hong Kong are not signatories to the Berne Convention makes the prosecution of media piracy a difficult task.[7]

While international regulations are ineffective in Taiwan and Hong Kong, local laws could still function to curb media piracy. However, local copyright regulations in East Asia and Southeast Asia also tend to be idiosyncratic. For instance, Taiwan extends copyright protection to Japanese cultural exports only if they were released in Taiwan within thirty days of their Japanese debut.[8] This prevents the legal VCD and DVD release of Japanese dramas, not only because Japanese serials run for three months, but also because it takes months for Japanese television networks to clear up issues of royalties with the cast and composer before they can sell television programs overseas.

In these conditions, local entrepreneurs developed a huge underground network of media piracy that not only caters to East Asian and Southeast Asian audiences but also supplies retailers worldwide. Bootlegged copies of J-dorama are commonly available on North American Internet trading sites, the largest of which is eBay. Many retailers who sell J-dorama

on eBay are fans of the genre whose businesses commonly have grown out of exchanging copies with other fans. The rapidly growing demand for Japanese dramas, however, has turned many of these fans into entrepreneurs. Selling counterfeit media is a highly profitable business: with a DVD burner, one can increase one's investment more than tenfold. Fans can build up their inventories from various sources: by buying Japanese drama serials from East Asian wholesalers; by appropriating them from so-called fansubbers (fans who subtitle and distribute media content on a nonprofit basis); or recording them from Southeast Asian cable networks or multicultural channels based in New York, Southern California, and Hawai'i.

The dramas that come from East Asian and Southeast Asian wholesalers are the most attractive because their packaging closely mimics the original. Media pirates pay particular attention to the quality of the wrapping, even to the point of forging holographic stamps of company logos or copyright information. Indeed, in the production of pirated J-dorama, professionalism is mainly channeled into the jacket design. The superior presentation that carries the promise of high quality can effortlessly mislead casual drama viewers. Only drama aficionados notice blatant mistakes, such as interior jacket designs that feature images of lead celebrities from different dramas. Ironically, the largest distributors of bootleg Japanese dramas have become labels in their own that signify quality and reliability within the universe of media bootlegging.

Some eBay retailers claim that they do not know that the copies they are selling are counterfeit. Buyers, for their part, are generally not aware that Japanese dramas that have English subtitles and are licensed for DVD or VCD distribution do not exist. Sellers present the factory-sealed quality of these media as proof of authenticity. An answer to my question illustrates this point.

> *Question:* Am I correct to assume that this drama serial is a fansub that comes on DVD-R format? If so, did you subtitle the series yourself?
>
> *Answer:* They are Chinese original, factory sealed.[9]

Orientalist underpinnings are explicit in the answer, which suggests that Japanese dramas imported from China must be authentic. Similarly, feedback from an eBay seller illustrates how sellers exploit the ignorance of buyers concerning the authenticity of their merchandise:

Feedback: Sold me fake goods. All his items are fake . . . very disappointed! Terrible quality.

Reply by Hargow0110: Items are not fake, all items are purchased from vendors from Hong Kong.

Although the packaging may look professional, the quality of the media ranges from superb copies of Japanese originals to copies with significant audiovisual flaws. Similarly, the subtitles on the VCDs range from decent to incoherent English translated from Japanese by native Chinese speakers or computer-translating software.

As I have mentioned, in addition to buying copies from East Asian and Southeast Asian wholesalers, fan entrepreneurs source their inventories from television captures and fansubs. While in theory cable networks and fansubbers are sources from which international viewers can obtain J-dorama, in practice these sources are less accessible to audiences. For one thing, cable channels that broadcast Asian media are available only in Southern California, New York, and Hawai'i. At the same time, fansubs are not advertised, so most people are unaware that they exist. Indeed, fan entrepreneurs capitalize on the fact that most viewers do not have access to these sources.

International cable networks that broadcast Japanese drama serials in the United States cover only regions in which Asian populations are concentrated. Kiku TV, based in Hawai'i, features more than thirty hours of Japanese-language programming per week; KTSF in the San Francisco Bay area airs programming in twelve, mainly Asian languages; AZN TV catered to Asian American audiences in the United States until April 9, 2008 when it ceased operations;[10] and KSCI LA-18 serves California's Asian populations.[11] Fan entrepreneurs record programming from these multicultural cable channels and sell them on Internet trading sites.

Fan entrepreneurs also supplement their inventories by downloading from file-swapping sites such as BitTorrent. Two quotes from an eBay seller's feedback illustrate the appropriation of fansubs for commercial purposes:

Feedback: Copied disks, poor quality—said "free fanwork" on screen, I've been cheated.

Reply by Hargow0110: Items are good quality and this buyer is lying, that no brain idiot!!!

Feedback: D rip-offs from JEM: says FREE FANSUBS on screen: No Refund = ripping you off.[12]

Reply by Hargow0110: Items are good and not fake like the buyer with NO BRAIN!!!!

Follow-up by AngelaJewell: You GOT your money—You have NO REASON to complain. I'm out $40+.[13]

eBay is the largest trading site through which fan entrepreneurs distribute bootleg dramas in North America. While intellectual property rights are protected by federal laws in the United States, and there are constant attempts to increase criminal enforcement against piracy, sales of unlicensed media that come from Asian countries are rampant on eBay, mainly because the site management does not consider itself liable for the actual transactions that are taking place on the site. Under the category of unauthorized copies one finds the following guidelines: "Do not list unauthorized (such as pirated, duplicated, backup, bootleg, and so forth) copies of software programs, video games, music albums, movies, television programs, or photographs on eBay. The following items may not be listed on eBay: Pirated copies of video games; VHS or CD-R copies of television programs taped off of television."[14]

The management at eBay does make clear, however, that the original copyright owners are primarily responsible for monitoring the site for counterfeit versions of their intellectual property and for requesting the removal of these items. To this end, it has set up the automated program (Verified Rights Owner Program), which provides copyright owners with a forum to state their copyright policies and to report unauthorized listings. However, international copyright owners such as Japanese commercial television networks are not included in the program. To keep Japanese television networks informed about the illegal trade of their copyrighted material on eBay would require active involvement on the part of the management beyond the routine of automated protocols and systems of formulaic mail responses.[15] The television drama professionals I interviewed in Tokyo were surprised to hear that their dramas were available in the United States. At the same time, fan entrepreneurs commonly sell more than 15,000 Japanese television serials, making a ten- to fifteen-fold return on their investment.

While media piracy is the most prolific bottom-up practice for circulating Japanese dramas globally, non-commercial distribution practices facilitated by international fans of J-dorama are used, as well. The most engaged of these fans are the fansubbers, who subtitle the serials, and the distros, who distribute them. Fansubbers are individuals who translate media that are not available in their local language and are not distributed legally in their countries. The main source of income for fansubbers is donations. They often form fansub groups or collectives.[16]

Like fan entrepreneurs, fansubbers and distros are key agents in the bottom-up processes of media globalization. While media pirates capitalize on the inflexibility of transnational media corporations to cater to niche audiences, fansubbers lobby to urge them to distribute these programs legally in North America.[17] Currently, multicultural cable networks are the only media corporations that legally import Japanese television dramas to the United States. However, they do not have the rights to release these serials on VHS and DVD. Thus, viewers who do not live in Southern California, New York, or Hawai'i do not have access to legal broadcasts of J-dorama. Like fan-entrepreneurs, fansubbers and distros cater to these viewers. The main difference between these two groups is the amount of profit they make in distributing J-dorama.

While fansubbing is just as illegal as media bootlegging, copyright owners tend to ignore it because they are aware that fansubbers do not make profits from their activities. Rather, fansubbers are regarded as serving the greater good by promoting the dramas overseas. Conversely, the fansubber ethic dictates that fansubbers must respect the licensing announcements of cable networks and stop distributing a title if a cable network decides to broadcast it. The following quote illustrates the most commonly accepted rules and etiquette for distributing fansubs:

> Agreement of use: These video files are for cultural and educational purposes only. By having these files you should understand that you are holding an illegal copy of copyrighted material. You are advised to buy the original DVD set. By downloading and watching any of these files you agree to hold the entire responsibility of its distribution. If not then you are advised to delete that file immediately. Nobody is allowed to sell,

> modify, or transcribe these files without the original author's permission. As for the videos the authors are their original releasers. As for the subtitles we are the original authors (except otherwise stated) and you should contact us before attempting to do anything with these subtitles. . . . Special attention is given to eBay and other auction sellers that repeatedly sell illegal copies of these files on DVD-R. We will take any possible action to prevent any of these copies sold to you. If you are a copyright owner of any material included in these files and you feel that our cultural and educational promotion of your videos is decreasing your profits, you might then contact us and we will immediately stop its distribution.[18]

Fansubs are accessible on websites maintained by fansubbers. However, prior to the widespread availability of the Internet and the spread of file-swapping sites, trading was the most common form of nonprofit exchange within the fan community. Similar to fan entrepreneurship, fan trading is an important aspect of the bottom-up media distribution that, this chapter argues, makes media globalization increasingly disjunctive and decentered. Because fan trading resides in a legal gray area, traders (or distros) are adamant in abiding by their own rules of media circulation. The most important rule is reciprocity. According to one website, for example, trading partners are expected to trade on a strict one-to-one ratio—one CD-R for one CD-R or one DVD-R for one DVD-R. If a person who requests a trade does not have any dramas that the supplier wants, the trading ratio becomes different. Commonly, traders request one burned CD-R for three blank CD-Rs, one burned DVD-R for three blank DVD-Rs, and one burned DVD-R for five blank CD-Rs.

Fans not only trade, however; they also distribute these serials on a nonprofit basis. This method of bottom-up circulation is commonly called distroing. The distros copy and distribute the serials for the cost of the media and shipping charges. Distro prices are about $3 per DVD-R and $1 per CD-R, including shipping and handling.[19] However, entrepreneurship often grows out of distro activities. A moderator of a popular J-dorama fansite, http://www.jdorama.com,[20] writes the following about distros: "Some traders will make copies of their dramas and mail them to you in exchange for money to cover the costs of blank media and postage. Some

people do it for very minimal profit or none, while others will blatantly make monetary profit. eBay sellers of fansubs or TV captures are definitely trying to make profit; otherwise they would not be auctioning. Others who do distro usually have websites, but you must decide for yourself if it is worth it or if they are trying to make a huge profit."[21]

In recent years, with the increased popularity and availability of broadband Internet access, digital fansubs (the so-called digisubs) have become an alternative bottom-up way to distribute fansubs. Peer-to-peer file sharing is a convenient (and inexpensive) method of circulating dramas online in digital formats. BitTorrent is the most popular software to download media via peer-to-peer clients.[22] Because these sites are illegal, they are constantly relocated. Information on them is available on websites that promote J-dorama. Peer-to-peer file sharing is supposed to be a nonprofit practice; however, cyber-realtors have started buying up and renting out cyberspace to host these activities for profit.

Similar to snail-mail trading, peer-to-peer exchange was based on the rule of reciprocity before site hosting became commodified. As BitTorrent sites did not have the capacity to store files, a person who had finished downloading a file was supposed to become a so-called seeder, without whom one could not complete a download. The tacit rule was that downloaders were expected to reciprocate for the upload speed they used and to let others download at least the same quantity from them that they had downloaded from others.[23] It is increasingly difficult to adhere to the rule of reciprocity and to keep this form of exchange nonprofit-based. As digisubs are easy to distribute, fansubbers can no longer prevent others from copying digisubs and selling them for profit on Internet trading sites.

Websites that promote Japanese dramas to English-language audiences also produce and maintain the guidelines of fair exchange and fan ethics. One of the most popular sites is JDorama.com,[24] a nonprofit online meeting place for fans, fansubbers, and distributors to exchange dramas or information on them. The "buy, sell, or trade" forum provides a space where fans can exchange dramas with one another. An important agenda of the site's owner is to facilitate the flow of information among international fans of Japanese television dramas and enable them to share their experiences. Because these bottom-up practices reside in a legal gray area, informal ways to expose fans who do not adhere to the ethics become

important. The site enables trading partners to post information on unfair traders, including their names, addresses, and user or trader names. In the context in which fans technically infringe on copyrights and violate intellectual property rights while pursuing a nonprofit mission (i.e., making Japanese dramas available to global audiences), online gossip serves to force members to be faithful to fan ethics.

Conflicting Views on Media Globalization: Struggles between Fansubbers and Fan Entrepreneurs

The underground distributors of J-dorama take different positions vis-à-vis national (and transnational) media corporations that try to control cross-border media flows and international media markets. While fansubbers lobby to push media corporations to be more responsive to global niche demands, media pirates and fan entrepreneurs capitalize on the inflexibility of large media corporations, which diminishes their capacity to cater to diversified audiences. I have argued that market fragmentation was a key factor in spurring a structural transformation in the Japanese television industry. At the end of the twentieth century, transnational media corporations faced the same dilemma: they were unable to effectively provide entertainment to global audiences whose interest lay beyond Hollywood and its mainstream offshoots.

The following question, posted at www.jdorama.com, illuminates the conflicting approaches to media globalization that pit fansubbers and fan entrepreneurs against each other. The question touched a nerve and generated one of the longest forum discussions on the ethics of distributing J-dorama: "I've never really used eBay; are these people selling other peoples rips for a lot of money? Or are they selling them for basic duplication costs [plus] small labor charge? Would the latter be OK? It seems like people who don't have a fast network connection could really use a service like that. Full attribution should be given, of course. If that's not the case, then they suck."[25]

The contributions of fansubbers to the discussion served an important educational purpose. As this quote illustrates, fans stressed that eBay (as the largest trading site) not only provided the most convenient access to J-dorama; it was also the only option for many who could not afford the technology needed to download programs via file-sharing networks and

who lived outside California, New York, and Hawai'i. This is how one fansubber explained the political economy of the global circulation of J-dorama:

> I think you're not visualizing the big picture here. You're basically thinking about your own needs and not the rights of those who actually make the stuff you're potentially stealing. . . . (1) the English-subbed dramas you see on eBay are all illegal, UNLESS the set is licensed by the company that produced the drama. However, Fuji TV, NHK, TBS, TV Asahi, and virtually all the other Japanese production companies and networks have never put a licensed product that includes English subtitles up for sale. And legal subbing companies like Nippon Golden Network or JN Productions have never released their works for retail sale. (2) Fan subbed dramas are also illegal. When you translate Japanese to English, the English subtitles are still linked to the Japanese spoken, which in fact makes the English subtitles also protected by the original copyright owner. Doesn't seem fair, but that's how copyright law works. So basically, if you buy English subtitled Japanese dramas, what you're buying is illegal, and in turn as a buyer you're also committing a crime in infringing on the copyright protection for that product.[26]

As this quote illustrates, fansubbers want the serials to be available legally. The quote from www.jdorama.com that I used to open this chapter supports this statement. Fansubbers are well aware that the only parties with the right to seek a legal remedy are the original copyright holders. They are also aware that Internet trading sites such as eBay are not as effective as they might be in removing counterfeit media from their listings. Thus, they launch their own guerrilla warfare against media piracy. A fansubber summarized her frustration with bootleggers to me: "Generally, when someone puts hard work into something, they do not want someone else to profit from their hard work. It's a shame the eBay isn't doing anything about it either."[27]

To curb the sale of illegal television captures on eBay, a fansubber proposed that buyers send letters to U.S. cable networks whose subtitled dramas had been "ripped." For example, the fansubber sent a letter to inform JN Productions that fan entrepreneurs were selling Japanese dramas with JNP subtitles on eBay.[28] She included the illegal listings and a link through which the management of JN Productions was able to file a complaint with eBay.[29]

Even though it is not the most effective method, the most common strategy among fansubbers is to report bootleggers to eBay's customer service, Safe Harbor. Another common practice is to expose bootleggers on fan sites such as www.jdorama.com. Exposure often includes real names, user names, and other information that fansubbers can gather about sellers. The following posting illustrates this practice: "Newest bootlegger!!!!!!!!!!! eBay seller name: xuefei82. . . . Welcome to the club, bootlegger!!!!!!!!! I've already filed several of your auctions with eBay Safe Harbor so that you won't feel left out."[30] As I have noted, fansubbing is technically copyright infringement. While fansubbers argue that they add value to the serials by subtitling them, they do not own copyrights to their subtitles. This is an important point to emphasize, as this is what ties their hands in their struggle against commercial appropriation of their fansubs on Internet trading sites.

Another fansubber told me about the following method of sabotaging online sales of her work: after following a routine procedure of asking sellers to remove her fansubs from their listings and filing complaints with eBay's management (neither of which yields a response), she sends e-mails to bidders, using the eBay message system, to inform them that the DVDs of J-dorama that they are about to purchase are fansubs that they can download from the Internet free of charge.

Another strategy this fansubber mentioned to me was to bid on her fansubs listed on eBay with no intention of paying. Entering unreasonably high bids (e.g., as much as $1,000) guarantees that the fansubber will be the highest bidder.[31] Because she will not go through with the transaction, she can prevent the seller from selling her work. And because the seller is involved in an illegal activity, he or she is not likely to report the nonpaying bidder. At the same time, until 2008 when eBay changed its feedback policies, leaving negative feedback about the fansubber risked getting negative feedback in return, which translated into public exposure of the seller and potential damage to his or her business.

A third strategy this informant described is to educate consumers. She frequently posts bogus auctions for her fansubs and in the listing directs the buyers to the website where they can download the serials for free. At the same time, she informs potential buyers that eBay sellers are profiting from fan work. She claims that this approach seems effective: the counters at the bottom of the listings indicate how many people have viewed the page.

Listing items for sale on eBay entails paying a fee at the time of the transaction. Thus, fansubbers not only invest labor in translating Japanese dramas (which remains uncompensated); they also invest money and precious time in disseminating their vision of media globalization. The conflicts between fansubbers and eBay entrepreneurs thus shed light on competing ways to understand media globalization. In the 1990s, globalization entered a new stage in the wake of intensifying flows of people across national boundaries, along with dramatic developments in technology that enabled users to participate in transnational media distribution. In the next section, I will consider how the bottom-up global distribution of Japanese television dramas contests dominant understandings of cultural globalization.

J-dorama and Cultural Globalization

Iwabuchi Kōichi (2002) understands Japan's entry into the business of international media trade in the 1990s as symptomatic of a new phase in media globalization. He contends that this phase is characterized by a new strategy in global marketing, localization, and by a concentration of media ownership that enables transnational media corporations to enter various markets simultaneously by establishing business ties with local media partners. Iwabuchi (2004, 6) suggests that the global success of Japanese animation and computer games testifies to the increasing interconnectedness of transnational media industries: "Japanese cultural industries and Japanese media products cannot successfully become global players without Western partners. The advent of Japanese animation and characters such as Pokemon clearly show that Japanese mass culture can become a global culture only by relying on partnerships with Western media industries in terms of promotion, distribution, and even localization of the content—to hide its 'Japaneseness'—as global marketing strategy."

No one would doubt that Japanese cultural exports have increased in the past decade. Examples include kids' shows such as *Sailor Moon*, *Mighty Morphin' Power Rangers*, and *Pokémon* (Allison 2006) or game shows such as the *Most Extreme Elimination Challenge* and *Iron Chef*. Scholars rightly point out that media importers were capable of marketing these shows in the United States on the condition that they were localized. Anne Allison's study describes how scenes that showed Japanese cityscapes were air-

brushed from animated films and programs were re-filmed to replace Japanese with American characters. Similarly, the popularity of the *Most Extreme Elimination Challenge* and *Iron Chef* owed to their local appropriation, which was accomplished by dubbing them in ways that made them sound funnier than the original programs. In these cases, dubbing was closer to being a commentary on the programs insofar as racial and cultural stereotyping became key sources of humor. Ultimately, *Iron Chef* became an instance of format trade when it was replaced by *Iron Chef America*.

These examples of media imports from Japan highlight the fact that foreign programs need to be localized to be accepted by North American viewers. It is implicit in this argument that the strategy of localization preserves the homogeneity of U.S. media culture. Thus, a position that theorizes localization as central to cultural globalization inadvertently reconfirms the power of the U.S. media economy by naturalizing its "impenetrability." In other words, discourses of localization translate into an understanding of cultural globalization as the global hegemony of Hollywood (Miller et al. 2001; Noam 1991; Olson 2004; Parks and Shanti 2003; Schiller 1969; Schiller and Nordenstreng 1979). There are two salient critiques of this position, both of which come from reception research. First, scholars have questioned the global dominance and impact of American mass culture by looking at local practices of appropriation and have theorized the global–local nexus in terms of indigenization, hybridization, and creolization (see García Canclini 1995; Hannerz 1992). In this context, media scholars have suggested that Hollywood is "localized" at the level of reception (Liebes and Katz 1990). Second, other studies have recuperated regional media flows to argue that cultural commodities no longer flow from "the West to the rest"; rather, they have become de-centered (Hu 2004a, 2004b; Iwabuchi 2002; Straubhaar 1991, 1997). For example, Kelly Hu's study interprets the popularity of Japanese drama serials in East Asia and Southeast Asia as an irony of cultural imperialism. She understands this particular intraregional flow of mass culture as a subversion of the conventional dichotomy of the dominant colonizer and the submissive colonized. Specifically, in this context the unequal power relationship between Japan and East Asia and Southeast Asia plays out in terms of an indifferent supplier and an insatiable demander (Hu 2004a).

I would highlight that these critiques are not much more helpful than the global Hollywood paradigm (which translates into an interpretation of

media globalization as a concentration of media ownership) to understand the bottom-up, underground practices of distributing J-dorama described in this chapter. The conventional top-down frameworks of theorizing cultural globalization draw on the center–periphery model. They assume that in the rest–West relationship, the rest is always on the receiving end, while the West is the supplier. The first critique of the global Hollywood paradigm cannot transcend an understanding of cultural globalization as a concentration in media ownership, as it centers on analyzing global and local interactions in terms of how the non-West responds to, resists, or appropriates what the West forces on it. The second theory, by contrast, questions the equation between cultural globalization and the global hegemony of Hollywood, but it does so by valorizing alternative regional cultural centers, such as Japan and Brazil, that were capable of serving as new suppliers of cultural commodities because of their large and self-sustaining media industries, some of which (e.g., Japan) are just as closed to foreign media imports as Hollywood is.

Equally important, both positions remain predicated on an understanding of transnational flows of media content in terms of mass production and consumption. By contrast, I propose that the underground transnational trade of J-dorama testifies to a new trend in media globalization. I have contended in this book that progressive market diversification spurred a transformation in the Japanese television industry. Here I argue that market fragmentation has also had a considerable impact on international television trade. Specifically, practices of underground media distribution illustrate that transnational media corporations are unable to satisfy the needs of global consumers because they are unable to cater to these consumers' progressively diversifying tastes. Thus, an exploration of the grassroots and illegal practices of media distribution—which satisfy global niche demands and hybridize national media landscapes—offers a critical counterpoint to the dominant understanding of media globalization as a concentration in media ownership and a consolidation of media markets.

In theorizing Japan's entry into the global media market, Iwabuchi has also noted that, with the exception of Hollywood, which sells by capitalizing on the cachet of an American way of life, the cultural commodities of nations cannot become globally marketable if their national character is not stripped off. Iwabuchi (2002 61) claims that Japanese media corpo-

rations, for example, can sell only those cultural commodities that are *mukokuseki* (have no nationality). However, there is no agreement among media scholars as to why Hollywood is popular with global audiences. While some scholars emphasize that Hollywood is appealing because it encodes values and lifestyles that represent the Unites States, others claim that Hollywood has become global culture because it offers culturally neutral entertainment. For instance, Eli Noam (1991) argues that Hollywood is well received worldwide because global audiences are factored into making these programs in the first place. Scott Olson (1999) confirms this point by attributing the global success of Hollywood to narrative transparency (i.e., the priority given to universal themes) that, he argues, is an essential characteristic of American mass culture. Similarly, Denise Bielby and Lee Harrington (2002, 215) claim that, since "the international market for programs is an extraordinarily lucrative source of profit for major production companies," television producers are aware of international audiences when they develop story lines. For instance, the head writer of *The Bold and the Beautiful*, the most popular U.S. soap opera in the world, has claimed that he omitted story lines that would have required him to introduce overseas viewers into the intricacies of the U.S. legal system. He believed that international audiences would not be interested in learning these details about American culture (Bielby and Harrington 2002).

The fact that Japanese producers embedded trendy dramas in consumer culture suggests that they did not intend these serials for audiences outside Japan. However, somewhat curiously, it is exactly the embeddedness of these dramas in everyday Japanese life that makes them interesting to and enjoyable for overseas viewers. Indeed, accounts of J-dorama fans suggest that they watch the dramas to learn about the lifestyles and attitudes of Japanese youth. In trendy dramas, speech styles are an important means to convey attitudes. Thus, it is a key requirement for fansubbers to provide accurate translations of the dialogue. Dubbing is not a popular method for making Japanese dramas available in foreign languages because it is costly (which is not justified by the small size of the market) and, more important, because fans generally consider subtitling the best way to remain faithful to the original content. Subtitles do not need to be rewritten to sync with lip movements and can be accurate translations of the original dialogue.

While theories of media globalization stress that localization is a domi-

nant trend in international television trade, it is precisely what overseas fans of Japanese popular culture reject. Resisting localization is militantly emphasized in the context of anime fandom, from which the practice of fansubbing derived. To localize television programs, editors often cut out scenes that they think will not make sense to a foreign audience. For fans, however, the encoded cultural references are an important source of enjoyment. In other words, fans prefer to watch programs in their original and unedited version. This is why fansubbers aim to produce translations as accurately as possible.[32] In the context of anime, fansubbers not only translate shows that are not licensed for distribution in their countries but also often retranslate licensed titles that have been significantly modified (Katsuno and Maret 2004). In some cases, fans take "literal translation" a bit too seriously, such as when they populate the screen with footnotes acquainting viewers with the difficulties they faced in translating certain Japanese expressions into English.

Programs that encode culturally specific information are hard to enjoy outside their context of production. The American situation comedy *Will and Grace*, for example, did not perform well on the global markets, because non-American audiences did not understand the intertextual references that served as the main source of humor in the program. While this rule is valid for programs that are targeted at broad cross-segments of audiences, the appeal of J-dorama, which has not become a mass commodity outside Asia, is their close connection to Japan. Studies of the reception of Japanese television serials in East Asia and Southeast Asia coincide in stressing that the high-profile consumerism trendy dramas represented was a key factor in explaining their popularity (Ko 2004; M. Lee 2004; Siriyuvasak 2004). I noted earlier that Japanese trendy dramas targeted young women with high disposable incomes and accordingly featured urban lifestyles, trendy leisure spots, high-end fashion, and the latest pop music. Like their Japanese counterparts, the viewers in East Asia and Southeast Asia who were most keen on watching these shows were style-conscious young men and women who looked to Japan for tips on fashion, food, and design. A journalist has commented on the role of these dramas to young people: "I like to see Japanese TV drama as a 'catalogue' of commodities. Everything that appears in it, such as the leading actor's clothes, mobile phone, handbag, cooking, eating, drinking, housing, and so on, is worth examining" (Kurotori, quoted in M. Lee 2004, 134). Japa-

nese dramas are thus interesting to foreign audiences as a virtual tour of Japan—a place of high consumerism. In other words, the rootedness of trendy dramas in a particular national locality and temporality becomes an important factor in overseas viewers' enjoyment of these shows.[33] While the majority of J-dorama fans are citizens of East Asian and Southeast Asian countries or are Asian Americans, an increasing number of fans have no direct ties to Asia. These "pop cosmopolitans," as Henry Jenkins (2006b) suggests, may have stumbled onto the dramas while visiting an international grocery store in search of ingredients for ethnic food or while flipping by an Asian cable channel.

The fact that these programs function as a reservoir of information on a particular locale is also important in understanding why Asian viewers in North America enjoy them. Jung-Sun Park's research on the media consumption of Korean Americans and Koreans residing in the United States shows that ethnic minorities maintain connections with their countries of origin by consuming media from the homeland.[34] Park (2004, 283) writes, "Besides clothing and hairstyle, the Korean American audience carefully observes interior decoration and color trends. This observation is soon reflected in consumers' tastes and choices; hence, Korean American businesses, especially those that are geared toward young clientele, such as cafes and clubs, tend to quickly adopt the latest interior decoration styles and color schemes portrayed in dramas in their businesses."

This corresponds to the responses I received from informants who claimed that they watched Japanese dramas while abroad because the programs helped them stay informed about the consumer and cultural trends of their homeland. In chapter 4, I mentioned a current trend among young Japanese women to spend time (ranging from a few months to a year) abroad. They spend their savings on such excursions; some pursue graduate degrees, while others participate in home-stay programs to learn a foreign language. Many of my informants explained that while they were overseas, they continued to watch Japanese dramas to keep up with consumer trends in Japan. They either rented the dramas from local Japanese food stores with rich inventories of bootlegged Japanese media or their family members sent them taped copies. Moreover, many of them told me that when they watched Japanese dramas abroad, they did not think of the commercial breaks as annoying interruptions. Commercials also carried information they hungered for and that they needed "to stay in the loop."

In the 1990s, exports of Japanese cultural commodities rose conspicuously. By the second half of the decade, it was no longer solely "culturally odorless" (Iwabuchi 2002) animation characters that represented Japan in global popular culture but also *real* Japanese artists, whose appeal was nonetheless rooted in their cultural background. The music composer Sakamoto Ryūichi won an Oscar and a Golden Globe for his score for Bernardo Bertolucci's film *The Last Emperor*, and his appearance in Madonna's music video *Rain* marked a shift in the transnational perception of Japan from that of a place of working automatons to a new source of creative energy. In the 1990s, the Japanese designers Issey Miyake, Yamamoto Yohji, and Kawakubo Rei appeared on the global fashion scene and conquered the world with their unconventional designs.[35] Dorinne Kondo (1997) has argued that, unlike those of Western designers, who shed their nationalities as they enter the transnational world of fashion design, the distinctive creations of Japanese designers were traced to the origins of their culture, and they were interpreted on the basis of national essence, not on the basis of individual artistic achievement. Kondo stresses that Orientalist discourses have essentialized Japanese artists by disconnecting them from the larger transnational context that nurtures their talent and by resituating them in terms of their national, and often racial, identities.

There is no doubt that popular journalism tends to orientalize Japanese fashion designers. Yet it seems to me that the tendency to understand the creations of these designers in terms of their nationality is also emblematic of a new curiosity about Japan. However, I need to quickly add that *Japan*—the "J" in J-dorama—becomes a flexible signifier when it enters global circulation: it is endowed with different meanings in different contexts of reception. Napier (2007) has traced the history of Western fascination with Japan to French impressionism, stressing that the global interest in Japanese culture in the 1990s has to be understood in a broader historical framework. She notes that while Orientalism may have underwritten Western artists' turn to Japan in their search for alterity, the recent increase in the global popularity of Japanese culture is different. According to Napier, today's global consumers of Japanese culture cultivate an interest in the country itself and simultaneously acknowledge Japan's familiarity to and difference from their own cultures. Yet, along with other

scholars (e.g., Allison 2006), I am skeptical of the assertion that it is really *Japan* in which global fans of Japanese popular culture are interested.[36]

Napier makes an important claim by suggesting that the global success of Japanese culture in the 1990s was not without precedents. Her examples—French impressionists' fascination with Japan and the global success of the drama *Oshin* (Singhal and Udornpim 1997) in the early 1980s[37]—represent important landmarks in the evolution of the "J" brand (as in J-dorama and J-pop). The reception of J-dorama, however, suggests that the meaning of "J" expands beyond the boundaries of cultural proximity and alterity. It is likewise important to emphasize that the characteristics of particular media genres—the specific venues through which they enter global circulation and the demographic composition of their consumers—are but a few of the numerous factors that determine the parameters within which the meaning of "J" is anchored.[38] The global fans of J-dorama, for instance, do not seem to be interested in Japan in its reality and totality. Rather, what they find appealing in the genre is a particular aspect of Japanese culture—youth-oriented consumer culture—that trendy dramas so compellingly represented.

Even though J-dorama entered global circulation in the 1990s through both fan-based and illegal media-distribution networks, as well as through multicultural cable channels, the genre never made it to mainstream televisual culture in the Western world. Because J-dorama remained a commodity of global subcultural media consumption, corporate branding practices did not shape the ways in which foreign viewers derived pleasure from watching them. Trendy dramas represent the remarkable economic growth and wealth of Japan: they mark the end of a period in which the nation upgraded its export profile from low-quality consumer electronics to cutting-edge technology and became home to the most sophisticated consumer culture in the world. These dramas were not only the epicenter of the youth-oriented consumer culture within the domestic context; the same was also true of the genre when it circulated abroad. International fans watched the shows to engage with Japanese culture that they found cool—for the most part—for its high-profile consumerism.[39]

The link between the global popularity of trendy dramas and a new interest in Japan as a place of consumer connoisseurship is confirmed in the global debut of the *shōjo* (teenage girl), who appeared in blockbuster Western movies in the same period. Recall that trendy dramas originated

in shōjo culture. Two shōjo characters come most quickly to mind: Yoshimido Yumi (Hirosue Ryōko), the heroine of Gérard Krawczyk's and Luc Besson's *Wasabi*, and Go Go Yubari (Kuriyama Chiaki), the mace-swinging teenage bodyguard of the top dog of the Japanese underworld, Ishii Oren (Lucy Liu), in Quentin Tarantino's *Kill Bill: Volume I*. I understand these characters as tropes for "J": they are expressions of Western negotiations of the shifting meaning of Japan in global culture. What I find particularly curious about them is that they consolidate an image of Japan as a place where consumer capitalism has reached its pinnacle.

The heroine of *Wasabi* is a nineteen-year-old, "whirling, giggling, shopping doll,"[40] while Go Go Yubari in *Kill Bill: Volume I* is "a 17-year-old nutcase in a schoolgirl uniform" who "may be young, but what she lacks in age she makes up for in madness."[41] One can argue that these shōjo characters are transformational works on some of the key rhetorical elements in the repertoire of negotiating national subjectivity in the postwar period: Japan as victim, the only country to have suffered the atomic bomb. The consumption-crazed shōjo in *Wasabi* is marked for death; she is to inherit 200 billion yen when she turns twenty. However, gangsters, who want to lay hands on her inheritance, are after her life. And taking a particular gender spin on the dominant portrayal of the corporate soldier, Go Go, the shōjo in *Kill Bill*, is also a victim who does not hesitate to sacrifice her life for her master. Yet what I find more intriguing and pertinent to my argument is the connection between consumerism and the figure of the shōjo. While the heroine of *Wasabi* is an insatiable consumer, for Go Go Yubari, life (hers or someone else's) becomes but another commodity.

The logic of commodification—in this case, the communication of affective alliances and a sense of belonging through objects or through objectified human relationships—permeates the shōjo's world. This logic is encoded in trendy dramas, and it remained crucial to their appeal in the global contexts of reception. In other words, it was not simply cultural proximity or alterity that made Japanese media culture appealing to foreign audiences. "J" embodied different meanings in different contexts of global consumption. In the context of watching J-dorama, for instance, "J" signified Japanese consumerism. In the 1990s, "J" became not global culture but a global subculture. The evolution of "J" thus illustrates a new trend whereby the fragmentation of global markets facilitates the "subculturing" of national media cultures such as "J" for Japan.

Image Commodity, Value, Affect

Epilogue

It has long been portended that, in an era in which the Internet allows for more interactive and customized media experience, television would become an archaic reminder of our pre-digital past. However, the futuristic architectural marvels that came to house television networks in Japan in the 1990s testify to a different unfolding of events. Designed by Tange Kenzo, one of the most prominent architects of the twentieth century, the Fuji Network's new headquarters is anything but a monument to television's downfall. The building has become a point of gravity in the futuristic "cyber" district, Odaiba, that tourist brochures recommend to visitors in search of a taste of twenty-first-century Tokyo. Featuring a huge metal sphere suspended in its middle and an entrance designed as a high-tech tube illuminated by blue neon lights, the futuristic block of the Fuji Network has a surreal aura. Much like the 787 foot–tall DoCoMo Tower of Nippon Telegraph and Telephone Corporation (NTT) in Yoyogi (Tokyo),[1] the Fuji Network building

7 The new headquarters of Fuji Television in Odaiba, Tokyo. Courtesy Mark J. Nelson.

arrogantly reminds us that information- and communication-based accumulation has definitively superseded manufacturing, and television has emerged victoriously from the transformation.

In this book, I have argued that commercial television networks in Japan acclimated to market fragmentation by shifting their priority in program production away from plot-driven entertainment and toward lifestyle-oriented programming. In the wake of growing diversity in mediated entertainment, commercial television networks preserved their competitive edge by transforming the tarento into image commodities whose circulation generated a new culture of post-Fordist televisuality in Japan. I analyzed the development of the image commodity as a response to changing patterns in production and consumption in a particular national context. In the epilogue, I depart from this national context and resituate my discussion of the image commodity vis-à-vis global trends in television production and consumer capitalism. I emphasize that the evolution of the image commodity in Japan in the 1990s was not an isolated phenomenon.

On the contrary, it was an example that illustrates how intangible commodities have become the new center of economic gravity in the advanced capitalist world.

Because intangible commodities are far more profitable than tangible goods, the past two decades witnessed a conspicuous rise in their status in the hierarchy of commodity forms. As I described in chapter 1, the reasons for this shift are numerous. Intangible commodities are not manufactured from raw materials that have to be purchased at competitive prices on the market. They do not have to be stored and transported; thus, they are ideally suited for an environment in which companies compete in weightlessness. Their shelf life tends to be shorter than that of tangible commodities, and their turnover rate is correspondingly higher. Although human labor is necessary to fabricate them, it is not so much the exploitation of individual labor on which the production of intangible commodities draws. Rather, intangible commodities are the end products of social labor. For example, tarento are not so much trained as "discovered." Before scouting agents identify the tarento-to-be, these young men and women have been polished by various social actors—the parents who have raised them and the teachers who have educated them. After the tarento are discovered, several agents continue to shape their media personas, including tarento agents, television producers, and advertising professionals. Consumers also participate in the production of the tarento via fan activities, an example of which is blogging. In fact, the ability to seamlessly blur the line between production and consumption intensifies the value-producing capacity of intangible commodities. Finally, and most important, affect is central to the production and reception of intangible commodities. Because affect is capable of expanding the semantic and economic horizon of the exchange and use value of commodities, its value-generating potential is enormous.

Scholars have called for "a more fundamental reconsideration of the status of the image in television" (Caldwell 1995, 5) and for new analytical tools to succeed theories of signification that are incapable of apprehending the image, and of registering, the primacy of the affective in image production and reception (Massumi 2002). The mobilization and manipulation of affects have always been central to the operation of the entertainment and culture industries (Hardt 1999). Recently, scholars have argued that the potential for value to be produced from "the expansion or contrac-

tion of affective capacity" (Clough 2007, 25) has been recognized and increasingly exploited far beyond the boundaries of the entertainment industries. According to Brian Massumi (2002, 45), "The ability of affect to produce an economic effect more swiftly and surely than economics itself means that affect is a real condition, an intrinsic variable of the late capitalist system, as infrastructural as a factory."

So how, exactly, does affect become a source of value? A few examples may help answer this question. A brand, for instance, is an intangible commodity. In the 1990s, brand theorists confirmed that consumers were willing to pay more for brand-name commodities because they represented particular lifestyles and thus also functioned as communication tools (Holt 2004). Because of their affective capacity, brands are capable of bringing emotion into the relationship between corporations and their customers. This way they can impart a sense of loyalty in consumers and encourage them to conceive of their connection to corporations as something other than a transient interaction between buyers and sellers; the connection starts to feel more akin to something like friendship or even a love affair (Roberts 2004). Ideas are another example of intangible commodities. Take, for example, the idea of creating a shopping mall that offers its customers the experience of visiting a theme park. In this setting, the customers spend more money than they would in a straightforward transaction of commodity exchange, because shopping itself is emotionalized (and obscured) by being presented to consumers as entertainment (see Yoshimoto 1994). Another idea is to establish an online marketplace where buying and selling assume the format of an auction. In this context, buying an item goes beyond the plain act of purchasing a commodity. Bidding on items is also about competition between bidders. Buyers tend to pay higher prices for a used item on an auction site than they would in a local thrift store, because the entertainment—that is, affective—component of the transaction further distances them from the idea of the commodity's use value.

As intangible commodities started to proliferate, the meaning of value also started to diversify and to supersede Marxian notions of use value and exchange value. Intangible commodities are lucrative because there is practically no limit to the degree to which their value is ungrounded vis-à-vis materiality. Consider another example, from the world of online gaming: the game *Second Life* sells virtual real estate on which users can develop

anything, ranging from hotel resorts to mining concessions. A Chinese teacher based in Germany who goes by the name Anshe Chung is reported to have made $150,000 a year buying, improving, and reselling virtual homes in *Second Life* (Harford 2006). According to an article published in the *Economist*, a *Project Enthropia* player paid the game's creators $26,000 for an island in the game's virtual world. He hopes to recover the money through mining and selling plots to other players.[2]

Similarly to virtual real estate, advanced game characters are exchanged as real assets. Those who want a head start in *Star War Galaxies* can purchase a Jedi Knight on eBay for $700. Busy Western players outsource the production of these characters to young Chinese peasants, who can make significantly more money creating advanced game characters or harvesting artificial gold coins than farming their land (Barboza 2005). Seven hundred dollars is a lot of money for a character that exists only within a game, but this Jedi will give its user a more enjoyable game experience, much like owning a better golf club. The Jedi Knights are intangible commodities. What is curious is that they exist (i.e., they are produced and consumed) only inside the game world. Yet they generate real cash via someone's labor, as these characters are produced by spending long hours playing the tedious first rounds of the game.

As image commodities, the tarento are very similar to the virtual Jedi Knights. In the same way that gamers spend hours and hours transforming their characters into Jedi Knights, tarento agents invest their time and skills into transforming good-looking (and vaguely talented) young people into media personalities by assigning an image (composed of attitudes and lifestyles) to them that marketers, television producers, tarento agents, casting agents, directors, and fans further refine and distill, thus polishing their capacity for affective capture. Just associating a service or a commodity with a tarento allows it to be sold for more money, because by transferring their affective capacity onto commodities the images of the tarento also transform commodities from mere objects into emotionalized communication tools.

While programs produced by commercial television have always been showcases for style and lifestyle, the valorization of appearance and attitude has become shockingly overt in the past two decades, and trendy dramas were in the forefront of this global trend. In much the same way that they might peruse a fashion magazine, women watched these new

dramas to glean information about fashion and consumer trends. The tarento were crucial in relating this information to the viewers. They are the "faces" of Japanese culture; they are thought ostensibly to represent various sociocultural ideals. In this book, however, I have sought to show that the trendy dramas targeted the obsession with the tarento with a superficial outer image—the fashionable, attractive exterior of tarento as models of lifestyles in which style and attitude are of utmost importance. Moreover, I have argued that the obsession with images was so powerful that it suppressed all other aspects of the televisual medium. In most dramas, tarento wear pricey designer-label clothing. This stylistic opulence has helped television producers create an advertising environment that is more compatible with the ideals of the image-conscious fashion and cosmetics industries. Yet when tarento serve dual roles as fictive characters and product endorsers, character depictions are also unavoidably altered (see Andersen 1995). Celebrities must maintain an unfalteringly positive image to continue promoting products. Thus, when advertising and entertainment are integrated via the tarento, it is increasingly difficult to talk about mass culture as a battlefield where dominant sociocultural values and behaviors are contested and negotiated.

In the history of Japanese television, the boundary between televisual fiction and advertising was upheld until the late 1980s. Then the boundary started to break down, and the escalating unity of advertising and entertainment began to transform television from a mere platform for marketing into a branding machine. Ironically, this integration of entertainment and advertising was a strategy not only to attract new commercial sponsors to television, but also to respond to viewers who increasingly demanded entertainment that felt more "personal" than mass-produced fare. By offering viewers lifestyle-oriented programs, television producers were capable of generating the indelible illusion that they were, indeed, delivering custom-tailored entertainment to their customers. After all, good taste and consumer connoisseurship are sources of identification that can be much more flexibly mobilized and manipulated across mass and niche demands than other affiliations of identity, such as generation or class. By exploiting the semantic elasticity of the notion of lifestyle, trendy dramas were capable of uniting viewers into new affective alliances that, in turn, helped them sublimate anxieties over changing class relations.

By capitalizing on the affective capacity of the tarento, whose images

were intensively circulating across various media, television networks could establish branding partnerships with other media institutions and entertainment companies. The emerging synergy functioned to enforce viewers' commitment to domestic media institutions. At the same time, practices of cross-genre and transmedia branding further blurred the line between sponsor and sponsored. It is not unique to Japan that sponsorship has become a far more complicated process than the buyer–seller dichotomy that existed in previous decades. One study found, for example, that North American ninth-graders believed that Michael Jordan had paid the sneaker producer Nike to promote him rather than that Nike had paid Jordan to endorse Nike products (Klein 2000). Indeed, the young informants in the study pointed out an important aspect of the deterritorialized nature of image-based capitalism: while celebrities endorse commodities, commodities also endorse celebrities, and it is decreasingly clear who gains more profit from these branding partnerships. The shoe designer Manolo Blahnik did not sponsor the episode of *Sex and the City*, "A Woman's Right to Shoes," that celebrated a pair of Blahnik stilettos whose price soared to $900 after the show. Similarly, J. Crew and Warner Bros., the producer of *Dawson's Creek*, saved millions in marketing in a collaboration in which the Dawson's teens wore J. Crew outfits on the air and J. Crew devoted an entire catalogue to the show by featuring its actors (Lasswell 2004). This idea, in fact, could be credited to the producers of trendy dramas, who had begun capitalizing on this form of branding partnerships a decade before it occurred to U.S. television professionals to do the same.

Of course, it would also be difficult to confidently discredit a claim that trendy-drama producers had actually drawn their inspiration from Walt Disney and Disneyland. Resonating with the ways in which Disney movies had come to life in theme parks, trendy dramas contributed to the "Disneyfication" of Tokyo. I have described how love dramas re-signified the Tokyo Tower as a symbol of love and redefined it from a touristic landmark into the number-one dating spot in the city. Thomas Schatz (1997, 99) has argued that, while during Hollywood's classical era studios produced a singular commodity, the feature film, Hollywood now operates as a diversified entertainment industry. Studios still produce films, but they are no longer the primary source of revenue. Rather, the goal is to produce blockbuster-scale hits that serve as the new content necessary to renew

product lines in expanding franchise operations. This new business model, in which films are created to spawn merchandise and theme-park rides, has replaced the formula of producing films that viewers pay to see because they are well-crafted stories. "*Jurassic Park* may be lacking in terms of character and plot development and in thematic complexity," Schatz (1997, 99) writes, "but it is a wondrously well-crafted movie—a visceral theme-park ride (in fact, a preview of the ride itself) and a dazzling display of digital effects."

In the Japanese context, the new necessity to establish branding partnerships to stay afloat in a volatile economy has forced the television industry to go beyond producing entertainment and move toward gambling with the affective capacity of image commodities. Jean Comaroff and John Comaroff (2001) argue that the casino, where wealth is conjured without production, has become iconic of how capitalism operates in the twenty-first century. In fact, in conjunction with the diversification of the commodity form, new ways to generate value have begun to succeed older forms of production (Hardt and Negri 2000; Lazzarato 1996). In this way, the metaphorical casino has been left behind, and gambling itself has become generalized to the point that it is now recognized as one of the most lucrative forms of value production. A comment by Ōta Tōru (2004, 71) exposes this trend: "For Japanese dramas, it costs around 40 million yen (approximately $440,000) per episode. There are ten episodes in a series, which makes a total of 400 million yen (approximately $4.4 million) per series. This means that the company gave me 400 million yen and told me to make whatever I wanted. Although I am not a gambling man, this game was quite exciting. I used to wait anxiously for the ratings to come out the next day. The whole experience was like an emotional roller coaster."

The image commodity played an important role in transforming television networks in Tokyo into fortresses of casino capitalism by enabling television professionals to create a new source of value from expanding and contracting the affective capacity of images. The lobby of the TBS headquarters, for instance, is adorned with huge television screens that continuously show trailers for the network's most popular dramas. The network's cafe is open to visitors. Its shamelessly overpriced menu does not seem to deter young people, who hope to get a glimpse of a famous television personality. Yet the glamour and unwavering professionalism presented in the lobby stand in stark contrast with the anxiety-ridden, hard-core gam-

bling atmosphere that is evident once one passes through the checkpoint to enter the network's inside world. In the past two decades, networks have become high-tension spaces of casino capitalism where gambling has become the dominant form of value production. The inside world is haunted by lingering stories of suicide that television professionals are all too eager to tell the foreign anthropologist, as if to assure themselves that they—unlike the ones who could not hold up under the stress—are among the toughest who *have* survived in this business. The halls where the elevators are located are wallpapered with handwritten sheets recording viewing rates that are refreshed every morning. While the atmosphere of the lobby suggests that it is culture and entertainment that television networks are producing, the area around the elevators tells a different story. This space reminds the visitor of a stock market. While the security checkpoint demarcates these spaces from one another, affect—which runs high in both spaces in markedly resonant ways—reconnects them. Affect does not simply mediate the contradiction between these starkly different realms; it also makes the transition between these spaces seamless. And it is exactly the capacity to reconcile and naturalize incongruities between culture and commerce that, by the end of the twentieth century, had established affect as a privileged currency. Scripted or not, affects feel real. Branded or not, selves feel whole when they are protected within the boundaries of affective alliances.

Notes

Introduction

Unless otherwise noted, all translations are mine. Japanese names, except those of Japanese authors who are based abroad, are cited in Japanese order with the surname placed before the given name.

1 In Japan, the hours between 7 P.M. and 10 P.M. are called *gōruden taimu* (coined from the English words "golden time"). This is the Japanese equivalent of the U.S. term "super-primetime." *Puraimu taimu* (primetime) refers to the period between 7 P.M. and 11 P.M. To avoid confusion, in this book the term "primetime" refers to the broadcasting hours between 7 P.M. and 11 P.M.

2 A Japanese one-pot dish typically prepared during the winter months.

3 There is no agreement about whether youth-oriented primetime dramas produced from the late 1980s onward should all be called trendy dramas. Some consider the dramas produced after 1991 post-trendy dramas, arguing that they were not as "shallow, themeless, and frivolous as catalogue dramas" were (Ōta 2004, 70). I insist that the continuity between trendy dramas and post-trendy dramas is more persuasive than the differences between them. Therefore, I call all youth-oriented dramas that

commercial networks have produced since the late 1980s, and in which lifestyle, music, and location are of primary importance, "trendy dramas."

4 Hashimoto was in office between 1996 and 1998.

5 William Kelly (1986) has noted that, in the postwar period, more than 50 percent of married women worked; only slightly more than half of high-school graduates continued to college; and only 30–40 percent of workers enjoyed the security of the lifetime employment system.

6 The Japanese term "*sarariman*" is derived from the English words "salary" and "man." The term refers to male, white-collar office workers who are full-time employees of large and middle-size corporations.

7 Obuchi was in office between 1998 and 2000.

8 Editorial, *Japan Echo*, vol. 27, no. 2, 2001.

9 Later, when a local network produced the youth-oriented serial *Meteor Garden*, it became a smash hit, exceeding the popularity of any Japanese serials. (The Taiwanese hit was an adaptation of the Japanese manga *Hana yori Dango*, by Kamio Yōko.) *Meteor Garden* premiered on April 21, 2001, on the CTS channel in Taiwan. The success of the series' led to the broadcast of *Meteor Garden II* in November 2002.

10 They include the ABC Network, ABC Family, Disney Channel, ESPN, Jetix Play, SOAPnet, Playhouse Disney, Toon Disney, Disney Cinemagic, Lifetime Entertainment Services, and the A&E Television Networks.

11 Disney owns several production studios, including ABC Studios, Walt Disney Pictures, Touchstone Pictures, Pixar Animation Studios, Walt Disney Animation Studios, and Miramax Films, each of which specializes in making films for different audiences.

12 A similar phenomenon can be observed in the context of the television industry. To diversify the financing system that supports television, U.S. networks are increasingly drawing on DVD sales as a source of revenue. The decreasing number of reruns on television—just like the diminishing windows of theater screening in the context of the film industry—sheds light on this tendency. Also, the recent (2007) transfer of all Nickelodeon shows (e.g., *Dora the Explorer*, *Backyardigans*, and *Wonderpets*) from the commercial-free cable channel Noggin to the commercial-based Nick Junior suggests that Nickelodeon is increasingly using the cable context as a promotional platform to boost its DVD sales. (I can report from firsthand experience that the strategy works admirably.)

13 Networks are deploying new programming strategies such as "tent-poling" or "hammocking" to re-attract viewers and prevent them from switching to other channels. Tent-poling means that the network airs a highly rated show to bring viewers into the tent and schedules less popular shows around it. Hammocking is a strategy by which a new show is aired between two successful programs. A third tactic to transform casual viewers into committed customers is to offer

viewers the experience of interactivity through convergence between television and new media (Caldwell 2003).

14 My experiences with government-controlled television alerted me to the fact that the notion of television as an ideological state apparatus is problematic. In socialist Hungary, where I grew up, state censorship engendered its own opposition—a mode of cultural expression that drew its force from such stylistic devices as allegory and humor to evade censors' scrutiny.

15 Anthropologists working on Japanese popular culture have come to similar conclusions. Joel Stocker's study of manzai production, a style of stand-up comedy (2001); Ian Condry's research on the Japanese appropriation of hip-hop music (2006); and Brian Moeran's work on the Japanese advertising industry (1996) all call for a more integrated analysis of cultural production and consumption. These scholars highlight the arbitrariness of the dominant analytical divide between the powerful culture industries and vulnerable yet resourceful consumers.

16 Drawing on Brian Massumi (2002, 42), who has noted that "affective capture is endemic to late-capitalist, image- and information-based economies," Patricia Clough (2007, 20) writes: "Rather than an ideological interpellation of the subject, there is the deployment of 'generic figures of affective capture,' which provide a gravitational pull around which competing orbits of affect and thought are organized."

17 In this respect, Theodore Bestor's work on Tsukiji is a remarkable model for thinking about Japan in new ways. Bestor's study explores how Tsukiji, the largest seafood market in the world, is linked to national identity while being simultaneously embedded in a global economy (2004). Similarly, Condry's work subtly articulates how Japanese hip-hop artists use a "Western" genre of popular music to express issues with which Japanese youth are preoccupied while allowing them to imagine themselves as part of a modernity that goes beyond the boundaries of Japan (2006).

18 In his study of how Indian advertising professionals capitalize on their expertise in Indian culture to gain leverage vis-à-vis transnational advertising corporations, William Mazzarella (2003, 27) uses the concept of the commodity image "as a tool for theorizing advertising as public cultural commodity production." While Mazzarella applies the term to interrogate the *vulnerability* of the commodity form, I am interested in the *elasticity* of the commodity form, which I consider to be its main source of power.

Intimate Televisuality 1

1 See also Inoue 1987; Ivy 1993; Sanuka 1978; Yoshimoto 1989, 1996a.

2 Directed by Suo Masayuki (1996).

3 For a complementary analysis, see Painter 1996.

4 In the second half of the 1990s, viewership of 15 percent of the population (approximately 15 million viewers) defines a hit program. Ratings higher than 20 percent meant mega-hit status. Drama producers, however, aimed at ratings higher than 30 percent, and top dramas exceeded the 40 percent mark. This is a remarkable achievement considering that, in the 1998–99 season, the highest-rated series in the United States, *E.R.*, earned a 17.8 percent rating (Lotz 2006).

5 Saya Shiraishi (1997, 300) has described similar trends in the context of the animation industry, noting that, as character images circulate, they create a web of "image alliances" among producers of the print media, television, movies, and character merchandise: "The beauty of the image alliance is that each partner helps promote the others. The image is the central component of the alliance, and the copyright to the image is shared by the original artist, the publisher, and the television company. As character images circulate, in print, animation, and merchandise form, demand for the products of all members of the alliance grows. This in turn enhances the value and the revenue-generating potential of the copyright. The result of all this is a larger profit pie for all participants in the alliance to share in." See also Allison 2004; Moeran 1996, 19.

6 Here, I draw on Henry Jenkins's analysis of media convergence (2006a).

7 As discussed further in chapter 4, the three privileged items of mass consumption and signifiers of middle-class status in the 1960s were refrigerators, washing machines, and black-and-white television sets. They were called the three sacred treasures (*sanshu no jingi*), a parody of the three sacred treasures of the Imperial Household: the mirror, the sword, and the curved jewel. In the 1970s, the preferred consumer goods changed, but the television set was still among them. The three main items of mass production evolved into the three "Cs": car, cooler (air conditioner), and color TV.

8 On the saturation rate of television sets in Japan, see the official Web site of the Japanese Advertising Agency, Dentsu, available at http://www.dentsu.co.jp/trendbox/adnenpyo/r1964.htm (accessed December 21, 2009).

9 According to Ellis Krauss (2000), in the postwar period the government used unofficial means to limit NHK's journalistic freedom. In response, NHK tried to remain an objective news source by avoiding controversial topics and concentrating on neutral news.

10 NHK also operates BS2, a high-definition satellite channel.

11 In Japan, commercial television networks have partnerships with the five major Japanese newspapers: NTV and *Yomiuri Shinbun*; TBS and *Mainichi Shinbun*; Fuji and *Sankei Shinbun*; TV Asahi and *Asahi Shinbun*; and TV Tokyo and *Nihon Keizai Shinbun*.

12 Nikkatsu was not included in this alliance, but without much delay it followed the example of the other film studios.

13 In 1999, amendments were made to the Cable Television Law that withdrew some of the restrictions on foreign investment in broadcasting in Japan, yet

overseas capital is very slow to make inroads into Japanese media. In 2004, cable saturation was 5.6 percent (see the Web site of the Kinki Bureau of Telecommunications, available at http://www.ktab.go.jp/calc/catv/index.html), while satellite saturation was 13.3 percent (Information and Communications Statistics Database, available at http://www.johotsusintokei.soumu.go.jp/field/housou01.html), both accessed July 8, 2008.

14 In Japan, Video Research Inc. is the key entity that measures audience ratings. In the introduction, I alluded to the new demands of advertisers to reach more narrowly defined segments of the viewing public. I must note, however, that audience-measurement technology is not advanced enough to allow advertisers to push this agenda as effectively as they would like. The problems are numerous. Video Research Inc. is widely criticized for using small sample sizes (i.e., 300 households). In addition, audimeters are unable to provide information about the demographic attributes of the audience. Neither reading the tuning frequency nor reading a code embedded in the audio track of a program can provide information on who (if anyone) is actually watching television when it is turned on. While marketers encourage developments in audience-measurement technology, these developments do not necessarily serve the interests of television networks. Networks need high ratings to charge large sums of money for advertising time that, in turn, offsets the spiraling costs of program production. While detailed demographic data about the viewers would enable advertisers to target them with more custom-tailored advertising, these data would also force networks to create more custom-tailored entertainment, which would mean further audience erosion. What is believed to be an efficient method—individual-centered audience research—can also be a double-edged sword. The television practitioner Haba Kōichi (1996) has noted, for example, that while a women's marathon was sponsored by a cosmetics company, individual-based research revealed that the majority of the viewers were middle-aged men.

15 Script by Hashimoto Shinobu; directed by Okamoto Yoshihiko.

16 The public broadcasting channel NHK runs on subscription fees. Currently, the monthly charge per household is approximately $10.

17 Script by Ikei Miyoji and Terada Nobuyoshi; produced by Hata Yutaka.

18 Television commercials have two types: time advertisements (where sponsors pay for programs of a determined length) and spot advertising (where sponsors pay for commercials aired in the program breaks). In the 1960s, the dominant practice in television advertising involved only one corporation sponsoring a particular program. When a decade later single sponsorship was replaced by spot advertising as a result of the escalating cost of advertising (Moeran 1996, 247), it became more difficult for sponsors to exercise censorship.

19 For a comprehensive analysis of how mass media were controlled by the government, censored, and deployed for the purpose of war mobilization in the interwar period, see Kasza 1988.

20 *Shichinin no Mago*: script by Mukōda Kuniko; produced by Yamamoto Kazuo;

directed by Kuse Teruhiko. *Tadaima Jūichinin*: script by Tai Yōko, Hashida Sugako, Hayashi Hidehiko, and Shiina Toshio. Mobile cameras were not yet in use, which meant that location shooting was much more difficult. While it is more difficult to produce detective or samurai dramas in the framework of studio production, the home drama, which consists of scenes of conversations at the family's dining table or living room, was an appropriate genre for the technological capacities of the early 1960s.

21 Script by Hiraiwa Yumie; produced by Ishii Fukuko.

22 Script by Mukōda Kuniko and Kuramoto Sō.

23 Script by Hashida Sugako, produced by Ishii Fukuko.

24 Mizukoshi Shin (1999) also highlights the shifting position of television within family dynamics—namely, the television set has shifted from being a piece of furniture to being a gadget, one result of which is that most Japanese households own more than one television set.

25 Automation and computerization were not viable strategies for the television industry, which draws mainly on creative labor. Beyond a certain level of thematic schematization, program production cannot be automated.

26 The decline of mass media is not a new story. Primetime network ratings fell by 41.5 percent from 1977 to 2003 in the United States (Bianco et al. 2004), where the proliferation of digital and wireless communication and hundreds of narrowcast cable television channels are currently challenging the traditional mass media and their heavily ad-dependent business models.

27 The volatile business conditions of the 1990s encouraged fiercer competition not only between, but also within, television networks. In the 1990s, new production companies were established within television networks such as Fuji's Kyōdō Terebi and TBS's Dreamax. In addition, in the 1990s programming departments started to curb the spiraling expenses of drama departments by assigning independent yearly budgets to them. Note also that audience segments were increasingly divided among the domestic television networks; networks avoided producing programs that targeted the same audience segment in the same time slots.

28 Ōta (2004, 70) has said, "My idea was to produce a drama that did not deal with serious themes or social issues: a mere 'package' drama, which weighs setting, cast, and music more heavily than the content of the drama. . . . Many people in the television industry harshly criticized my drama as a shallow, themeless, and frivolous catalogue drama."

29 Here I draw on David Bordwell's work. He defines "plot" (*syuzhet*) as the actual arrangement and presentation of the story in the film. He defines the "story (*fabula*)" as a chronological cause-and-effect chain of events occurring within a given time frame and within given spatial dimensions. In this context, an event is a consequence of another event, of a character trait, or of some general law. At the same time, images and sounds contribute to narration (1985, 2006; see also Thompson 1981, 2008), which is a key characteristic of story-driven entertain-

ment. I emphasize that this feature is vital to understanding how trendy dramas depart from the tradition of story-driven entertainment. While trendy dramas present some form of a story (even if exceedingly predictable), the music and the overall presentation do not support the story but become a meta-text (enhancing the viewers' mood and informing them about consumer trends). This communicative model also bears resonance to what Roland Barthes (1977, 64) described as a film's "third meaning"—one lying beyond connotation and denotation: the realm in which images or music become "fellow travelers" of the story.

30 I am not, however, arguing that characters cannot play an important role in story-driven entertainment. For example, the CBS show *CSI* is both character-driven and story-driven, but it is not a lifestyle-oriented program. A show becomes lifestyle-oriented when the characters successfully subsume the story—or, in other words, when the characters *are* the story.

31 Robin Andersen (1995) has noted that a preoccupation with the happiness of the individual was also characteristic of primetime fictional entertainment in the United States in the late 1980s. She argues that consumer capitalism is dependent on self-preoccupation, which, in turn, accelerates the breakdown of community.

32 For a complementary analysis, see Grossberg 1989. The comparison between trendy dramas and music videos is indeed not far-fetched. As I will elaborate in chapter 4, music is very important in trendy dramas. The theme song is composed specifically for the drama (or, in some cases, the drama is tailored to a hit song), and the main characteristic of the theme song is that it has to capture the mood of the drama.

33 Correspondingly, Theodor Adorno (1991) has described how, in prewar Hollywood, the elimination of the distinction between image and reality advanced to the point of a collective sickness. He described how fans sent trousers to the Lone Ranger and saddles to his horse.

34 Produced by Yamada Yoshiaki and Ōta Tōru.

35 Produced by Yamada Yoshiaki and Ōta Tōru; script by Matsubara Toshiharu.

36 In the 1980s, Fuji's drama department was under increasing pressure because it had been unable to raise the ratings for its serialized television dramas. In drama production, TBS has led the rating charts since 1966; its legacy in the genre was unbroken and its authority uncontested. To compete with TBS's leading role in drama production, producers at Fuji realized that they had to look for a new niche that was not covered by TBS dramas. Ironically, their inspiration was the TBS drama *Danjo Shichinin Natsu Monogatari* (The Summer Story of Seven Men and Women; 1986), the first drama that addressed women in their thirties as a primary audience segment. Despite the high ratings (31.7 percent) the drama had achieved, TBS did not follow up on its success—as Fuji producers are keen to point out. Indeed, it was the trendy drama that secured Fuji network's break into the front lines.

37 Some of the greatest hits aired in this time slot were *Tokyo Love Story* (1991); *Hyakuikkaime no Proposu* (The Hundred and First Marriage Proposal; 1991); *Sugao no mama de* (Just the Way We Are; 1992); *Hitotsu Yane no Shita* (Under the Same Roof; 1993); *Asunaro Hakusho* (Asunaro White Paper; 1993); *Imōto yo* (Sister of Mine; 1994); *Long Vacation* (1996); *Love Generation* (1997); *Overtime* (1999); *Yamato Nadeshiko* (Ideal Wife; 2000); and *Hero* (2001).

38 This drama slot was established in 1972.

39 Examples include *Omoide ni Kawaru made* (Until You Become Memory; 1990); *Zutto Anata ga Suki Datta* (I've Always Loved You; 1992), *Kōkō Kyōshi* (High-School Teacher; 1993); *Aishiteiru to Ittekure* (Say That You Love Me; 1995); *Aoi Tori* (Blue Bird; 1997), and *Keizoku* (Beautiful Dreamer; 1999).

40 These dramas featured luxurious interior designs, yuppie lifestyles, and fancy, foreign-sounding professions. This excess eventually disappeared from dramas, and consequently some television critics call dramas made after 1992 post–trendy dramas (see Fujitake 1995). In contrast, I emphasize the continuity between trendy dramas and post-trendy dramas, arguing that the agendas, production process, and target audiences have remained the same. Examples of the first trendy dramas are *Anaunsā Puttsun Monogatari* (The Edgy Newscaster; Fuji, 1987); *Otoko ga Nakanai Yoru wa Nai* (Men Cry at Night; Fuji, 1987); *Rajio Binbin Monogatari* (Radio Go Go; Fuji, 1987); *Gyōkai Kimi ga Iku* (Go Go Television Man; Fuji, 1987); *Arano no Terebiman* (The Deadly Television Men; Fuji, 1987); *Papa wa Nyūsukyasutā* (Dad Is a Newscaster; TBS, 1987); *Seisaku Ni Bu, Seishun Dorama Han* (Drama Department 2, Teenager Drama Section; TV Asahi, 1987); *Koi wa Haihō* (Love Hurray; Nihon TV, 1987–88).

41 The spring dramas run from the beginning of April to the end of June. The summer dramas start in July and end in September. The fall dramas start in October and end in December, while the winter dramas begin in January and end in March. (In the United States, by contrast, the television industry is currently shifting from the September through May broadcasting season to a "fifty-two week" norm (Lotz 2007). In Japan, audience expectations are the highest with regard to the spring dramas: as April is the beginning of the financial yearly cycles and is the month networks start their new budget cycle, they tend to be most generous with their investments. The last week of the drama season is spent in a constant state of catharsis, as every single day audiences are delivered the final episodes, which overwhelmingly conclude with happy endings.

42 Fuji rebroadcasts its trendy dramas in the 3–5 P.M. drama slot, which is maintained for drama reruns, while TBS reruns its dramas in the morning from 10 A.M. to noon, in a time slot called *Okusama gekijo* (Theater for Housewives).

43 Similarly, Yoshimoto (1996a, 134) has written, "Japanese televisual culture invented the tarento as a monetary unit of late capitalism, and the circulation of the money sign maintains the cultural economy of contemporary Japan."

44 Kusabue Mitsuko was the host of the live music program *Mitsuko no Mado*, which was broadcast on Sundays from May 1958 to December 1960.

45 For example, Koga Sei'ichi established Oscar Promotions in 1970 to train female models who could also perform in movies and television programs. Koga claimed that the practice of employing models across media genres was an idea he borrowed from the European and North American image industries. He emphasized that the so-called image-up campaigns were crucial to transform these young women into tarento: "Subsequently, these girls developed a wide range of talent activities and became the first star talents who grew out of fashion models in Japan and they won recognition not only as visual models but also as talented performers" (Koga 1996, 116, cited in Aoyagi 2005, 132). Similarly, Johnny's, a tarento agency that specializes in producing young male idols, was established in 1967.

46 Sharon Kinsella claims that Fuji's program *Yūyake Nyan Nyan* (Sunset Kittens; 1985) was an important milestone in the process whereby the tarento system became the epicenter of program production. Unlike other television shows, *Sunset Kittens* featured tarento as "hosts, contributors, and ornamentation" (Kinsella 1995, 89).

47 Lawrence Grossberg's argument on how MTV produces stars is useful in understanding the tarento phenomenon in Japan: "It is less a matter of talent than promotion and visibility; talent is less a necessary prerequisite than a 'resource pool' available for corporate raiding. Stars need no origin or identity outside of their various appearances as stars" (1989, 261). He continues, "The star has to remain distant from any particular activity in order to be free to occupy the space of a particular mood or attitude. It is the star—the emblem of a particular mood or attitude—who is the major product promoted by music television; the star is a mobile sign which can be linked to any practice, product, or language, freed from any particular message or set of values. It is the star who is produced and promoted by the discourses of music television, sold to its advertisers and producers, and delivered over to its audiences" (1989, 262). Grossberg (1989, 265) calls this communicative strategy authentic inauthenticity that "refuses to locate identity and difference outside the fact of temporary affective commitments."

48 Tessa Morris-Suzuki (1988, 81) describes information capitalism as an economic system that "itself becomes a vast mechanism for converting the knowledge created by society into a source of corporate profits: profits which are then redistributed to the few on the basis of their financial stake in the corporate system."

49 Wolfgang Fritz Haug's argument is pertinent here. In his *Critique of Commodity Aesthetics*, Haug (1987, 54) interprets the growing importance of appearance in capitalist economies as the result of a need to conceal the growing contradiction between the interests of buyers and sellers—that is, while buyers are

interested in the use value of a commodity, sellers are concerned with the exchange value). To mask this split, appearance—which bears the promise of use value—becomes a vehicle of an economic function. Further, to increase turnover time, producers reduce the quality of products, which again is compensated for by appearance. Arguing that the technique of shortening a product's lifespan starts with investing in its aesthetics, Haug (1987, 54) has written: "For the ideal of commodity aesthetics is to deliver the absolute minimum of use value disguised and staged by a maximum of seductive illusion."

50 See Morris-Suzuki (1988) on the private appropriation of public labor.

51 One of the most powerful tarento agencies is Johnny's, which specializes in young male tarento. Many of the most sought-after stars of the 1990s, such as SMAP, Kinki Kids, V6, and Takki and Tsubasa, were under Johnny's control.

52 On the history of Johnny's, see Yazaki 1996.

53 It is said that the success of a television producer is contingent on his relationship with tarento agencies. Television producers are indeed in a delicate position, as they have to mediate between tarento agencies and programming departments. Even if they are convinced about the charms of some tarento, they cannot afford to cast them for dramas, because these shows are too large an investment to risk the viewing rates by hiring tarento who do not have the desired exposure to (or popularity with) viewers and are incapable of activating intertextual links. Especially for lead roles, only tarento who are well known and frequently appear in mainstream media are cast.

54 The tarento phenomenon is symptomatic of the commercialization of television. TBS has hired Ishii Akio, a well-known comedian, to serve as the anchorman of its news program *Evening Five*. Similarly, in 2004, TV Asahi hired Furutachi Ichiro, a popular talk-show host, to anchor its flagship evening-news program. The emergence of celebrity anchors is indicative of how news programs are moving in the direction of entertainment. At the same time, it is easier for the viewers to relate to these celebrity-comedian anchors, who ask questions that the viewers might ask and who have a sense of humor. These new alliances between news broadcasting and the tarento system also advance the commercialization of television. Ishii, for example, has done commercials for a large U.S. insurance company that have run during his show. TBS does not consider this a conflict of interest, arguing that the news division does retain editorial control (Kambayashi 2005).

55 See the official Web site of NTV, available at http://www.ntv.co.jp/supertv (accessed December 21, 2009).

56 Nagase became famous in Jim Jarmusch's movie *Mystery Train* (1989). After that, he appeared in many popular Japanese movies and dramas. In Japan his name is most associated with humorous television commercials. He has also released albums and is an active artist and photographer. An English-language Web site describes Hotei, who is six-foot-two, as "one of the most intimidating people in the Japanese music world. This image has also been put to good use

when casting him as the villain in movies and TV commercials, most notably as the sinister man in black chasing Nagase Masatoshi in the Boss coffee ads. Over a long musical career as a guitarist with one of Japan's legendary rock bands, guest artist and solo performer, he has developed a worldwide reputation as Japan's premier axe man and has sold over 25 million albums" (see the English language information Web site about Japan, Japan Zone, available at http://www.japan-zone.com/modern/hotei_tomoyasu.shtml [accessed December 21, 2009]).

57 Marx argued that, in the organic phase of production, use value overdetermines commodities, while in the phase of industrial production, the use value is displaced by the exchange value. The use value, however, does not disappear from commodities but becomes more deeply buried under the exchange value.

58 In 2003, Kimura was voted the most popular man in Japan for the tenth year in a row: See the English language information Web site about Japan, Japan Zone available at http://www.japan-zone.com/news/archives/2003_04.shtml (accessed December 21, 2009).

59 See Iwabuchi (2002) on this trend. See also Ming-tsung Lee's description of how Taiwanese travel agencies started to plan themed package tours known as "Japanese TV drama tours." He explains that what promoted these tours were new alliances between travel agencies and Taiwan's Japanese TV channels (an example of which is Creative Travel's cooperation with JET TV). At the same time, some television companies established travel agencies. For example, SET TV founded E-Lui Travel, an agency that focused on themed package tours to Japan (2004, 139).

60 The French singer Sylvie Vartan sang the song in 1963 for the movie *Cherchez L'idole* (Search for Celebrity). Aoyagi Hiroshi has noted that indeed the creation of tarento in Japan was influenced by that movie because it served as a model of employing celebrities across media genres. Featuring music idols of the 1960s (Charles Aznavour, Johnny Hallyday, and Sylvie Vartan), the film followed the story of a young man who stole a diamond for his girlfriend and hid it in an electric guitar while running from the police. Complications arose when the young man could not identify the guitar in which he had hidden the gem. The movie became a hit because it successfully blended fictional entertainment and popular music. The film was released in Japan under the title *Aidoru wo sagase*. Allegedly, it gave Japanese producers the idea to create multifunctional celebrities (Aoyagi 2005).

Imaged Away 2

1 *Single Lives* rests uneasily between two subgenres of trendy drama: love dramas and workplace dramas. Producers of workplace dramas have argued that their goal was to reintroduce "socially responsible entertainment" into commercial broadcasting. The producer and the lead actress of *Singles Lives* agreed that the

serial was intended to be a *shakaiha dorama*, or a drama that tackles social issues rather than celebrates the happiness of the individual (as is characteristic of love dramas).

2 Adopted from the English language, the term "office lady," or OL, refers to a young (often, but not necessarily, single) woman who holds a non-career-track clerical or secretarial position. Occasionally, the term "career-track office lady" is used for female employees in career-track positions.

3 Drama proposal submitted by Nariai to the programming department. I obtained a copy from the producer.

4 Many viewers noted that Ōsugi's cast was somewhat discordant, as he was a "veteran actor" who very seldom appeared in trendy drama.

5 The producer wanted to develop the theme of "solidarity among women," but the viewing rates indicated that the audiences were not interested in this story line.

6 In the serial, Kyōko's exposure to excessive stress was emphasized to justify her turn to prostitution. In addition to her work-related stress, she was blackmailed by Yamagishi, and later, by Yoshikawa who claimed that an executive at her bank had died of a heart attack when he learned that an elite career-track employee of his own corporation worked as a prostitute. This theme also derived from the media coverage of the murder case. A rumor had been circulating around Tokyo Utilities that Yasuko prostituted herself to pay off blackmailing debts.

7 Interview with Nariai Yūka, Tokyo, April 14, 2003.

8 A comment by Ōta (2004, 75) supports this observation: "In a Japanese drama's production process, casting comes first, even before scriptwriting. We do not choose actresses according to the role in a script. Popular actresses are already booked up for one to two years ahead."

9 Interview with Nariai.

10 She also played in art movies, including *Maboroshi no Hikari*, *Inochi*.

11 Indeed, the portrayal of prostitution was a venue for the producer to break away from the mainstream representational codes of trendy drama—namely, the Cinderella scenario and happy endings (*genjitsu wo kireigoto ni shite egaku torendii dorama*).

12 *Shin Chōsa Jōhō*, September 1999, 62.

13 Ōsawa Machiko, *Japanese Book News*, 34.

14 Interview with Nariai. For a complementary life story, see David Plath's interview with a female producer based in Osaka, which richly illustrates the contradictions in which female television professionals are enmeshed. I, too, recall a somewhat ironic remark made by a male producer when I asked him about the minuscule percentage of women in the television business. He told me that drama production is dirty (*kitanai*) work—unsuitable for women for whom preserving femininity (makeup and high heels) is of the utmost importance. Plath (1980) also notes that by choosing to pursue careers, women in Japan risk

being regarded as, and regarding themselves as, unfeminine. See also the comprehensive analysis of gender discrimination in an Osaka-based television network in Painter 1996.

15 In chapter 4, I will present further evidence to reinforce the claim that in the 1990s it was an extremely sensitive issue to televise Saimon's graphic novels, for she was the top manga artist.

16 Viewers' comments, a major Japanese Internet service provider, NTT Plala Inc.'s Web site, available at http://www1.plala.or.jp/tu-ji-/drama-talk2–1.html (accessed June 12, 2003).

17 Viewer's comment, Yahoo Geocities (a Web site that allows Internet users to create their own Web sites), available at http://www.geocities.co.jp/Hollywood-Stage/3915/story-dokushin.html (accessed June 12, 2003).

18 Viewer's comment, Television drama chat board, available at http://tv.applet.co.jp/cgi-bin/keijiban/9948.cgi (accessed June 18, 2003).

19 *Josei Jishin*, July 20, 1999, 200–202.

20 *Hōsō Bunka*, 1999, 10.

21 *Shūkan Posuto*, July 30, 1999, 222–23.

22 I understand "information capitalism" as an alternative term for post-Fordism.

23 As a parallel tendency, the jobs of drama workers—especially scriptwriters—are being made increasingly difficult as famous tarento are gradually assuming greater control over their own images. The tarento Kimura Takuya is known to be one of these. Magazines have gossiped at length that the TBS drama *Good Luck*, broadcast in the Sunday, 9 P.M., time slot, was partly "produced" by him. Kimura is becoming increasingly choosy about the roles he is willing to play and who he is willing to play with. It is rumored that in *Good Luck* he chose Shibasaki Kō for his partner role and designed many of the dramatic scenes, which allegedly led the producer to the verge of a nervous breakdown.

24 Esumi Makiko fan site, available at http://www.h6.dion.ne.jp/marutoku/Makiko_cm.htm (accessed June 18, 2003).

25 Suzuki Masayuki worked on both *Konna Watashini* and *Shomuni*. Thus, it is no wonder that the two characters are continuous.

Dream Labor in the Dream Factory 3

1 In drama productions, a rating of 15 percent is passable, a rating higher than 20 percent counts as a hit, and a rating higher than 25 percent is a mega-hit (15 percent equals 15 million viewers).

Here, my argument is inspired by Joseph Turow (1997), who describes a shift in the U.S. media environment from society-making media to segment-making media. He argues that in attempting to produce and maintain a mass audience, society-making media often fail to tackle the concerns of viewers on the margins of society. On the other hand, segment-making media also distort reality by representing only a limited view that a particular niche audience would find

agreeable. Turow concludes that segment-making media create the equivalent of electronic gated communities.

2 In the Japanese context, superb ethnographies have been published on the graphic novels industry (Kinsella 2000) and on the advertising industry (Moeran 1996). Both studies elegantly dispel the myth of the powerful culture industries within which all practitioners are united under the goal of transforming consumers into acquiescent consumers. Moeran and Kinsella emphasize that any message produced by the culture industries is the result of strenuous negotiations among media practitioners. Following in their footsteps, my work illustrates how the conflicts among media professionals have escalated in parallel with the commodification of the televisual medium.

3 Ōta, one of Fuji's most successful producers, was called a "hit man (*hitto man*)." His dramas occupy five of the top-twelve positions on Fuji's ranking of 113 trendy dramas, which include *Hyakuikkaime no Propozu* (The Hundred and First Marriage Proposal; 1991), at 36.7 percent; *Hitotsu Yane no Shita* (Under the Same Roof; 1993), at 35.9 percent; *Hitotsu Yane no Shita II* (1997), at 35.9 percent; *Ai to Iu Na no Moto ni* (In the Name of Love; 1992), at 32.6 percent; and *Tokyo Love Story* (1991), at 32.3 percent.

4 As I noted in the introduction, the program slots and the tarento not only enabled the networks to cater to diversified audiences; they were also crucial in coordinating domestic competition. Japanese networks have maintained a robust competition among themselves, and each wanted to target the most lucrative audience segment in its primetime slots. The system of program slots was an effort to control the competition in the domestic market by dividing the audience "pie" among the networks.

5 At the same time, genre slots helped networks brand themselves in the wake of the intensifying competition. Branding not only refers to the strategy that television networks use in their efforts to distinguish themselves from each other to attract particular audience segments. It also describes the tendency of networks to try to emotionalize their relationship with viewers. In this context, an emotional relationship serves to reinforce viewers' commitments to the networks. Theories of branding highlight the fact that, in contemporary capitalist economies, consumers buy not particular products but particular brands (Klein 2000). In the context of television, this means that people watch channels, not programs. In the Euro-American context, an example is the niche channel MTV. Viewers tune in because they know what kind of lifestyle and mood to expect. Similarly, the HBO slogan "It's not TV, it's HBO" also refers to the programmers' efforts to deliver a unique television experience the viewers cannot expect from any other channels. In the Japanese context, the genre slots serve a similar function. By featuring dramas that commit themselves to particular lifestyles and attitudes, networks forge a must-see mentality in which viewers who share the lifestyle are made to feel that they must watch the

programs to stay "in the loop." At the same time, when genre-slots assume clearly identifiable brand images, they establish a relationship of trust with the viewers, because they promise to deliver a certain quality.

6 Besides Fuji's Monday, 9–10 P.M., and TBS's Friday, 10–11 P.M., slots, the following drama slots have been introduced or made available for trendy dramas in the past sixteen years: Asahi TV, Monday, 8–9 P.M. (1993–2000); Fuji, Tuesday, 9–10 P.M. (1996–); Fuji, Tuesday, 10–11 P.M. (1996–); NTV, Wednesday, 10–11 P.M. (1987–); TBS, Friday, 9–10 P.M. (1988–); TBS, Thursday, 9–10 P.M., which began in 1957 and was made available for trendy dramas in 1989; and NTV, Saturday, 9–10 P.M. (1988–).

7 For instance, scholars attribute the success of *Tokyo Love Story* (Fuji 1991) to its refreshing portrayal of a heroine who clearly departed from earlier representations (see Iwabuchi 2002). While the scriptwriter, Hashimoto Yūji, was male, the serial was based on the comics of the female artist Saimon Fumi.

8 Tezuka Hiroyuki has noted that, in the postwar period, vaguely defined job descriptions were an important aspect of industrial relations and a vital source of economic growth. The absence of precise job descriptions prompted workers to define their own jobs. According to Tezuka (1997), this gave them the sense of having a high degree of control over their own labor, which in turn tended to foster intense work commitments.

9 Producers strongly identify with their companies, mainly as a result of the Japanese television networks' method of in-house training of employees, which begins at the very inception of employees' careers. This is a method of employee training particular to Japanese enterprises (see Morris-Suzuki 1988; Rohlen 1979).

10 Ōta (2004, 70) has noted that, until the late 1980s, scriptwriters and producers considered themselves artists and "were more concerned with their own self-expression than exploring what the audience wanted to see." This observation sheds light on the disconnect between drama production and reception in the Fordist era.

11 Interview with Nakatani Mayumi, Tokyo, June 23, 2003; emphasis added.

12 It is worth noting, however, that both Fuji and TBS established branch production companies in the 1990s—Kyōdō Terebi and Dreamax, respectively—which mark a move from vertical toward horizontal integration.

13 Interview in the TBS drama department, Tokyo, October 12, 2002. (The informant asked for anonymity.) Hashida Sugako is no longer required to hold consultations (*uchiawase*) with producers or directors. Her morning drama *Oshin* (1983) for NHK achieved viewing rates as high as 62.9 percent in the early 1980s; since then, she has had the reputation that "whatever she touches turns gold," and no producer has been in a position to argue with her. In the 1990s, she wrote the only primetime serial to target elderly consumers for TBS, *Wataru Seken wa Oni Bakari* (Making It Through), which was so popular that it survived

for five seasons (1990, 1993, 1996, 1998, 2000, and 2002; see Valaskivi 1999). It is rumored that TBS directors and producers carefully avoid conflicts with her because they are worried that she will "transfer" to another television network.

14 Ōta, one of the most successful producers of trendy dramas at Fuji, was in his late twenties when he produced his first dramatic hit (*Tokyo Love Story*; 1991).

15 These schools, including the Shinario Sakka Kyōkai (Association of Scenario Writers), Shinario Sentā (Scenario Center), Nihon Kyakuhonka Renmei (Japanese Scriptwriters' Guild), Nikkatsu Geijutsu Gakuin (Nikkatsu Fine Art School), and Shōchiku Shinario Kenkyūjo (Shōchiku Scenario Research Institute), offer courses that last from two to six months, and the tuition, ranging from 21,000 yen to 84,000 yen ($180–$700), is more than affordable (Satake 2000).

16 Similarly, Tessa Morris-Suzuki (1988, 143) has explained Japanese women's privileged role in supplying flexible, part-time labor: "The most desirable situation, therefore, is to have access to a flexible workforce: one which lacks a clear career structure, an expectation of steadily rising wages or a right to lifetime employment and the welfare and fringe benefits which that entails. Part-time workers fit the bill admirably."

17 Further examples are Komatsu Eriko, Nobumoto Keiko, Egashira Michiru, Yoshida Noriko, and Noroi Miyuki.

18 Examples include Nojima Shinji, Nozawa Hisashi, Okada Yoshikazu, Kimizuka Ryōichi, and Todayama Hisashi.

19 Interview with Takahashi Rumi, Tokyo, April 27, 2003.

20 Interviews with Nakazono Miho, Tokyo, 1 July 2003, 9 July 2003.

21 The main dilemma for Sakurako is: "Who, do you think, will make a woman happy? A handsome man, who can't see out of his debts, or a rich man, who looks like a pig (*Shakkin mamire no hansamu otoko to, yūfukuna buta otoko, docchi ga kekkon shite onna wo shiawase ni shitekureru to omoimasu ka*)?"

22 Here, my argument is inspired by John Caldwell's analysis of American cable television's preoccupation with authorial intent and manufactured notoriety in the 1980s as a strategy to reposition television from a purveyor of low culture to a producer of high-quality entertainment (Caldwell 1995).

4 Love Dramas and Branded Selves

Epigraph: Interview with Kitagawa Eriko, *Cosmopolitan*, September 2001, 29.

1 Japanese television networks do not gain substantial revenue from sale of goods merchandise. However, there are some successful examples. An exceedingly popular serial, and one of the very few home dramas to survive into the 1990s, *Wataru Seken wa Oni Bakari* (Living among People Is Nothing but Trouble; TBS) followed the life of the Okakuras and their five adult daughters. The parents ran a ramen shop whose trademark was "*ramen domburi*." Although

ramen domburi was completely fictional, it is sold at Haneda airport and Tokyo station and has become a symbol of "homecoming" for the Japanese: *Asahi Shinbun*, October 7, 2002.

2 Interview with Nakazono Miho, Tokyo, July 1, 2003. Nakazono recounted to me that her idea for the hit drama *Yamato Nadeshiko* (Ideal Wife; Fuji, 2000) was to criticize young women's preoccupation with fashion trends (and the ways in which trendy dramas exploited this trend). However, much to her surprise, her protagonist, Jinno Sakurako (played by Matsushima Nanako), generated the so-called Sakurako boom. Every week, women's magazines analyzed Sakurako's style, and Nakazono was even contracted to write a handbook on how to dress and comport oneself to "marry a millionaire." Nakazono teamed up with Aizawa Tomoko to publish *Yamato Nadeshiko Meigenshū, Sakurako Goroku* (Yamato Nadeshiko, Collection of Sakurako's Wise Sayings) in 2001.

3 Ōta's claim supports this argument: "We were not thinking of making dramas that would help viewers to define the meaning of their lives or would have any other serious impact on them. Rather, we simply wanted to cheer them up and fill them with positive energy. We wanted to make dramas that were neither poison, nor medicine" (Ōta 1996, 134–35).

4 Brian Massumi's interpretation of Ronald Reagan as a postmodern political star is also helpful in understanding the appeal of the tarento. He noted that Reagan could be so many things to so many people because he was without content. He had no charisma; rather, "he ruled primarily by projecting an air of confidence" in a context in which confidence "was the apotheosis of affective capture" (Massumi 2002, 41).

5 Examples include Fujii Fumiya, Fukuyama Masaharu, Smap, Tokyo, V6, and Takki and Tsubasa.

6 Fuji's motion picture *Reisei to Jōnetsu no Aida* (Between Serenity and Passion; 2001) was shot in Italy because Italy was one of the most popular tourist destinations among the young Japanese women whom the film targeted. The Jikko-ji and Gion-ji in Kyoto, and Kamakura's Tokei-ji (temples) are popular domestic-tourism destinations among young women. They are also mocked as the "An-Non temples," because they are frequently featured in the popular women magazines *An-An* and *Non-No* (McCreery 2000).

7 Yoshimi Shunya (1989) makes a complementary point. He argues that Disneyland's strategy of creating a world of consumerism that is entirely separate from the rest of the world (so that customers forget that there are alternatives to consumerism) is gradually penetrating city-planning policies in Tokyo. The blending of railway and subway stations into department stores is resulting in a transformation of Tokyo into an oversized theme park of consumerism.

8 This conclusion is erroneous. Market indicators suggest that an increasing number of single women buy their own homes. In response to this tendency, the Government Housing Loan Corporation has begun easing its lending guidelines to accommodate the needs of singles. Similarly, electronics manufacturers

have started catering to the needs of these women: see the "Web Japan" site that promotes Japan to non-Japanese Internet users, available at http://web-japan.org/trends/lifestyle/lif041029.html (accessed April 24, 2008).

9 In an editorial in a special issue of *Japan Echo* in 2001, Iwao Sumiko argued that the crisis of the social-security system was also responsible for the steady decline in the birthrate. She noted that distrust of the national pension system and a belief that pension funds would be depleted by the time today's young adults reach retirement age was widespread. "As young couples are concerned about saving for their own old-age financial security they are hesitating to take on the cost of raising children. This reluctance is accelerating the decline in the birthrate and making the maintenance of the social security system even more difficult": Iwao Sumiko, "Social Security Reform," *Japan Echo*, vol. 21, no. 1, available at http://japanecho.co.jp/sum/2001/280112.html (accessed July 14, 2008).

10 Correspondingly, in examining changes that have challenged the social order of new middle-class Japan, William Kelly analyzed young women's postponement of marriage not as indicative of women's improving position in the labor market but, rather, as an escape from constraint: "the sole responsibility for managing a household with an absentee husband, for raising the children, and for elder care of parents and in laws" (Kelly 2002, 247).

11 Sakai Junko (2004) notes that single women have always been stigmatized for being single. She suggests that single women should just shrug off their interpellation as "losers (*makeinu*)" by those who subscribe to retrograde gender ideologies. They should just say, "So what if I'm a loser?" and enjoy their single lives.

12 These programs are categorized as "pure love (*jun'ai*)" dramas because they center on love. Love is an important theme in trendy drama in general, of course, but in many dramas it is complemented with other motifs, such as mystery, mental or physical handicaps, gourmet pleasures, and so forth.

13 The first episode of *Love Generation* scored a 31.3 percent rating, the highest figure for a first episode of any Fuji TV drama. The second episode, broadcast on October 20, 1997, achieved a rating of 30.1 percent, indicating that the popularity of the program was likely to endure: *Daily Yomiuri*, October 30, 1997.

14 Love dramas advocate independence for young women—that is, they endorse a subject without responsibility to anyone but herself. As this woman has no one to provide for, she can spend her salary however she finds suitable—most commonly, in search of pleasure.

15 Inoue Miyako (2006, 173) has observed that, as the disposable income of Japanese women started to rise, women became increasingly selective regarding their future spouses: "The public seemed to be scandalized that women might 'shop around' and study the features of potential husbands, as one would weigh the pros and cons of a purchase."

16 Many of them go as far as to argue that this is the reason trendy dramas do not attract more male viewers.

17 The men in the dramas discussed in this chapter followed this pattern. The hero in *Long Vacation* became a top piano player, for example, and the male protagonist in *Love Generation* was an elite white-collar employee of an advertising company.

18 Examples include *Asunaro Hakusho* (Asunaro White Paper; Fuji, 1993); *Overtime* (Fuji, 1999); *Beautiful Life* (TBS, 2000); *Love Story* (TBS, 2001); and *Sora kara Furu Ichioku no Hoshi* (Millions of Stars Falling from the Sky; Fuji, 2001).

19 Chat board of the Internet service provider Asahi Net Inc., URL of specific posts available from author, accessed February 2, 2007; Kimura Takuya fan site, available at http://www.captain-takuya.com/loveroad.htm (accessed February 2, 2007).

20 Yahoo's Geocities social networking site, URL of specific post available from author (accessed August 24, 2006).

21 Edmund Leach's essay on the relevance of psychoanalysis for ethnographic research offers some insights to explain why this scene became the climax of episode one. Leach (1957) notes that psychoanalysts consider hair a universal symbol of sexual organs. They therefore understand haircutting as symbolic castration. (Note that the haircutting scene indeed articulates a form of socio-economic castration in episode one.) Correspondingly, Leach cites ethnographic examples showing that, in the context of rituals, hair symbolizes personal power, and the ritual cutting of hair signifies human sacrifice. I must note that viewers also frequently commented on the high erotic charge of the haircutting scene. Leach cites thought-provoking ethnographic data to understand this, noting that, in certain cultures, hair care is a reciprocal service between husband and wife and it is closely connected with intercourse.

22 *Daily Yomiuri*, October 30, 1997.

23 Ratings for dramas in which Kimura appeared did not fall below 23 percent, while the highest ratings were as high as 41.3 percent (the last episode of *Beautiful Life*; TBS, 2000): The official Web site of Video Research Ltd., the major Japanese marketing research company to conduct audience measurement for television and radio, available at http://www.videor.co.jp/data/ratedata/junre/01drama.htm (accessed February 2, 2007).

24 Kimura Takuya fan site, available at http://www.captain-takuya.com/loveroad.htm (accessed February 2, 2007). This bulletin-board site was dedicated to discussing Kimura's new hairstyle. Four days after his haircut in *Love Generation*, which aired on October 13, 1997, Kimura appeared on the music program *Tokuban*. Anticipation of this appearance was great as viewers wanted to see Kimura's new hairstyle in a more realistic talk-show context. The discussions on the website centered on Kimura's performance on *Tokuban*.

5 Labor Fantasies in Recessionary Japan

1 *Shomuni* has also been translated as "Power Office Ladies." It was originally broadcast in 1998 and was so popular that it was followed by a special in 1998; a sequel and a special in 2000; a final sequel in 2002; and the "*Shomuni* Forever" special in 2003.

2 "Anata wa otoko ya kaisha no tameni iru'n janai. Anata no tameni otoko mo kaisha mo arun'da yo. Yo wa jibun ka tanoshii ka dō ka? Sore dake."

3 Television dramas were not the only vehicle to promote individual responsibility. In the same period, the government was increasingly relying on the rhetoric of individual responsibility to cut public support for medical services and education (Itoh 2005).

4 This is not a new tendency. In the postwar period, companies aimed to secure their workers' loyalty and devotion not only by drawing on ideologies such as "one's company is one's family," but also by enforcing practices such as company trips (Kondo 1990) and male workers' after-work visits to hostess clubs (Allison 1994). These leisure practices were supported by corporate expense accounts. In the late 1990s, the question became, "How can workers' commitment be secured without further burdening corporate budgets?"

5 "Danseishi, OL Manga Pawā Zenkai, Honpōsani Kassai [Men's Magazines, OL Manga Full Power, Applause to the Wildness]," *Nihon Keizai Shinbun*, *Evening Edition*, May 13, 1996, 13. Other comics that featured OL protagonists and attracted wide popularity among male viewers were *Biggu Komikku Superioru's Massachusetts*, by Iwanami Kanko, whose heroine was an OL converted from a housewife, and *OL Shinkaron* (The Theory of OL Evolution).

6 The most common settings of the new work dramas were hospitals, medical-research institutes, police departments, hostess clubs, and corporations. Many of these dramas ran for several seasons, a fact that reflects their popularity. The dramas set in hospitals and medical-research institutes included *Kyūmei Byōtō 24 Jikan* (Emergency 24 Hours), *Nāsu no Oshigoto* (Nurse Labor), and *Kirakira Hikaru* (Shining Brightly). *Odoru Daisōsasen* (Minato Police Ward) was set at a police department; *Omizu no Hanamichi/Onna 30sai Gakeppuchi* (Bar Hostesses on the Central Path) was set in a hostess club; and *Shomuni* and *Sarariman Kintarō* (Salaryman Kintarō) used corporate settings.

7 Interview with Nakazono Miho, Tokyo, July 1, 2003, July 9, 2003.

8 Accordingly, the dialogue in workplace dramas is much longer and more difficult to memorize. Suzuki Kyoka and Matsuyuki Yasuko widely complained about this issue in relation to *Kirakira Hikaru* (Komatsu et al. 2000).

9 In the first episode of *Shomuni*'s first season, the company's president made a speech: "The Japanese economy is in devastating condition. A society plagued by an inefficient industrial system will be left behind in the global competition. The major source of the problems is not only the inefficient industrial system, but also the indifferent employees. Our company will not survive without restruc-

turing. Employees who are concerned only about their salaries will be fired immediately, regardless of gender and their length of tenure at the company."

10 *Shomuni* had aired on Fuji Television before I began my fieldwork in 2001. While I was unable to interview viewers during the period in which the series aired, I talked to informants about the show later. (Between 2001 and 2003, during my stay in Tokyo, Fuji aired reruns of the drama in afternoon program slots.) I also reviewed discussions of the show that appeared on fan sites or comments that were posted on Internet chat boards. Finally, I have reviewed articles accounting for the popularity of *Shomuni* published in print media.

11 As in Western societies during the same period, women's participation in the labor force fell, and by the 1980s a particular pattern of gendered employment had evolved: women temporarily stopped working after giving birth and returned to the workforce in their late thirties or early forties, mainly as part-time employees or blue-collar workers (Brinton 1993; Roberts 1994).

12 Self-employed workers never shared directly in the lifetime employment system, but they could aspire to it for their children. That possibility was foreclosed by the economic slowdown.

13 In 1998, protective labor laws were further relaxed. Recruiting practices (including the employment-agency business) were deregulated. Overtime work became exploitable without regulation, and the time limit of one year on part-time employment was abolished. This enabled companies to employ part-time female workers for longer periods of time (Itoh 2005).

14 "Japan Report Worried about Young Part-Time Workers." Jiji Press English News Service, May 30, 2003.

15 Given how narrow the definition of unemployment is in Japan, economists claim that the official statistics should be doubled to make them comparable with unemployment rates in Western countries (Itoh 2005).

16 In an editorial to a special issue of *Japan Focus*, Iwao Sumiko (2001) noted that the crisis of the social-security system played a key role in preventing young people from planning their future because they did not know what kind of pension benefits they would receive, or whether they would receive any at all.

17 This is a problematic notion. Many young people avoid paying their contributions to the national pension fund because of the widespread belief that the system is in crisis and that there will be no benefits to allocate to them by the time they reach retirement age.

18 Correspondingly, Nikolas Rose (1999, 227) writes: "The self is not merely enabled to choose, but obliged to construe a life in terms of its choices, its powers and values. Individuals are expected to construe the course of their life as the outcome of such choices, and to account for their lives in terms of the reasons for those choices."

19 See "Kore ga Osusume 'Oshigoto Manga'—'Shomuni' no Sakusha ga Kataru" [Workplace Manga That We Recommend: Interview with the Author of 'Shomuni,' Yasuda Hiroyuki], *Josei Jishin*, November 24, 1998, 151.

20 Produced by Takai Ichiro; directed by Suzuki Masayuki; script by Kimizuka Ryōichi. Akashiya Sanma and Hirosue Ryōko were the featured tarento.

21 Interview with Takahashi Rumi, Tokyo, April 27, 2003.

22 The first episode achieved a viewership of 18.8 percent, and the ratings gradually climbed from one episode to the next.

23 The serial's scripts were written by Takahashi Rumi and Hashimoto Yūji. Takahashi played a more important role in writing the scripts for the first season; however, in parallel with the growing popularity of *Shomuni* among male viewers, Hashimoto, took over the leading role. As Takahashi could not pursue her agenda of crafting story lines that she believed office ladies (and female viewers in general) would find empowering, she withdrew in the middle of the second series of the *Shomuni* enterprise. She was resentful that, as the male staff came to be more involved in production, the skirts of the office ladies became shorter and the catfights between Misono and Chinatsu became more frequent: personal communication; see also Satake 2000, 146.

24 See, e.g., "98nen Ninkisha Rankingu TOP 50 'GTO' Sorimachi and 'Shomuni' Esumi, Nidai Outlaw no Kyōtsūten? [Top 50 Popularity Ranking in 1998: GTO's Sorimachi and Shomuni's Esumi: Commonalties between the Two Outlaws]," *Nikkei Entāteinmento*, January 1999, 48–49.

25 Yasuda, the author of the original comic, had no experience working in the corporate world; thus, the original comic portrays the company as a space of ultimate absurdity, where the characters are all unfit losers and only luck prevents the company from drifting to the brink of bankruptcy. Ukyo Tomohiro, who becomes an elite salaryman in *Shomuni*, is a loser in the original comic, but the heroine of the comic, Tsukahara Sawako, falls for him.

26 "Ii jan? Tappuri tanoshimasete morau zo."

27 See the "Web Japan" site that promotes Japan to non-Japanese Internet users, available at http://web-japan.org/trends98/honbun/ntj980911.html (accessed October 4, 2003).

28 "Yoku sonna kaiwa dekiru yo ne."

29 "Omae mite saikōni iratsukunda yo. Itsumo mawarini furimawasararete, jibuntte mono ga nai."

30 *Individualism* and *difference* were keywords in marketing in the 1980s, marking a shift from mass consumption to the diversification of consumer demands. A decade later, when individualism was discussed in relation to work, it acquired a new meaning. In the new context, individualism was not simply the opposite of a group-oriented social structure; it was a recognition that individuals could no longer rely on institutional guarantees and social solidarity. For an analogous discussion, see the description of how a discourse on individualism served Thatcherite economic reforms by dissolving all forms of social solidarity in Britain in the 1980s in Harvey (2005).

31 Nakane is widely criticized for reifying masculine organizational forms such as

the Japanese corporate world as a mirror image of "authentically" Japanese social organization, as well as for endorsing the hierarchical (vertical) structure as indigenous to Japanese culture. Scholars such as Anne Imamura (1987) and Robin LeBlanc (1999) have argued that female-dominated groups are organized not vertically but horizontally and that they are task-oriented in terms of their structure. At the same time, Nakane's work is criticized as an a-historical study of Japanese culture in that it reinforces a false sense of historical continuity, thus erasing the effects of modernization and Western influence (Yoshino 1992).

32 "Jibun wo miushinatte made suru no wa shusse to wa iwanai'n da yo."

33 In July 2002, the Social Insurance Agency launched a public-relations campaign targeting young people (mainly freeters) who were not paying their mandatory contributions to the national pension fund. A poster for the campaign showed the actress Esumi Makiko (who played Chinatsu) looking annoyed. A red banner across the poster read: "So you don't mind crying in the future? Pay now. Or later, you won't get paid." The televised version of the advertisement had a sequel, which was said to be the worst commercial of 2003. In a patronizing tone, Esumi scolded a group of twenty-somethings: "Who told you that you won't get paid?" She was referring to the widespread belief that the national pension system is in crisis and that no funds will be available by the time today's young people reach retirement age. The association of Esumi with the message that young people should trust the government is puzzling. However, the scandal that followed the ad campaign put a new spin on the story. Journalists have disclosed that Esumi, indeed, has never contributed a cent to the national pension fund. In 2004, it was also revealed that numerous ministers, including the health minister, neglected to pay into the National Pension Plan.

34 However, this ideal often remains a political ideology in which opposition to neoliberalism becomes a discursive strategy to define Japanese identity in contrast to a ruthless West.

35 Andrea Arai related a pertinent observation to me. Many of her young informants emphasized that they were careful to choose a company whose atmosphere (*funiki*) suited their personalities. This understanding of work as a *lifestyle* choice is curious in an environment in which opportunities for meaningful work are shrinking.

Private Globalization 6

1 "Fansubber" comes from the words "fan" and "subtitling." It refers to fans who subtitle media that are not officially licensed in their countries. Fansubbers do not earn profits from their work.

2 "Dorama" is the romanization of the word "drama" in Japanese *kana*.

3 Correspondingly, another venue for Japanese hardware giants to gain access to

international audiences was to purchase Hollywood film studios and libraries. Acquiring globally successful media software enabled Japanese hardware producers to increase their international sales of national consumer electronics. For example, Sony purchased the film library of Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer to boost the global sales of its new generation of DVD players. In 1989, Sony bought Columbia Pictures, and a year later, Matsushita, one of the world's largest Japanese consumer-electronics manufacturers, purchased MCA. These buyouts reflected the changing movie business, in which revenue from videocassette (and, later, DVD) sales and rentals had surpassed the box-office take.

4 Henry Jenkins (2006a) uses the term "grassroots convergence" to theorize bottom-up practices of media production and distribution. Understanding grassroots convergence as an effect of "the increasingly central roles that digitally empowered consumers play in shaping the production, distribution, and reception of media content," Jenkins (2006a, 155) notes that grassroots convergence and corporate convergence sometimes reinforce each other by creating closer relationships between media producers and consumers, while sometimes they are at war. The global distribution of J-dorama, I suggest, evades these clean-cut binaries.

5 Other cable channels that aired Japanese drama serials were GoldSun TV, launched in 1993, and Videoland TV, which began broadcasting in 1995. Jet TV (Japan Entertainment Television)—a Japanese initiative in alliance with Sumitomo Corporation and Tokyo Broadcasting System—was established, with considerable delay, in 1997 (see Hu 2004a, 2004b).

6 An irony is that Sony, Panasonic, and other Japanese companies make and sell VCD players for Asian markets, where the technology is used to bootleg Japanese television programs (see Davis and Yeh 2004, 228).

7 Taiwan was upgraded to membership in the World Trade Organization (WTO) in 2002, and in response to pressure from the WTO, local police forces started to shut down unlicensed VCD manufacturers. However, the lack of criminal-law enforcement enables these companies to reopen the next day under a different name. Ultimately, this is a task with almost no chance of permanent success: http://www.asiaosc.org/article_6.html (accessed June 10, 2005).

8 Http://tronche.com/misc/copyright/no-berne-style-copyright-here.html (accessed June 10, 2005).

9 It is interesting to note that the seller does not respond to the question. Another seller is more honest in stating the sources from which he obtained his inventory

Question: Am I correct to assume that this drama serial is a fansub that comes on DVD-R format? If so, did you subtitle the series yourself? I'd appreciate if you could tell me anything about the quality.

Answer: I do not subtitle these dramas. All of the subtitles are excellent english translations. Some are TV rips, some are DVD rips that I have

acquired from various sources. The audio/video quality is very good. They do not come in a retail package, as these dramas are not available that way.

10 See chat board of AZN TV, available at http://www.aznlover.com/vbulletin/aznlover-news/14933-asian-television-gets-shut-down.html; official Web site of AZN TV, available at http://www.azntv.com (both accessed April 13, 2008).

11 While television captures are a convenient source of supply for eBay sellers, these copies—just like fansub rips—understandably upset buyers because they are obviously counterfeit. Many buyers express their frustration by leaving negative feedback for sellers who charge them $15–$20 (plus shipping and handling) for home-burned DVD-R copies that are not even appropriately packaged. The original Japanese DVDs with no subtitles cost $200, while VHS tapes cost $55: Official Web site of the Japanese video rental and retailer giant, Tsutaya, available at http://www.tsutaya.co.jp/main/movie/index.zhtml (accessed June 18, 2005).

12 JEM used to be a BitTorrent site.

13 eBay, online trading site, available at http://cgi2.ebay.com/aw-cgi/eBayISAPI.dll?ViewFeedback&userid=hargow0110&items=25&page=1&frompage=-1&item=-1&de=off (accessed June 18, 2005).

14 eBay, online trading site, available at http://pages.ebay.com/help/policies/unauthorized-copies.html (accessed June 18, 2005).

15 At the same time, because eBay has never succeeded in gaining a toehold in the lucrative Japanese market (where Internet trading services are monopolized by Yahoo Japan), its management is less keen to deal with trade violations involving Japanese commodities.

16 In the early 2000s, the most popular fansub collectives were at http://sars-fansubs.com, http://studiooto.com, http://chhocolatfansub.tripod.com/index.html, and http://www.jtv-drama.org. For a comprehensive fansub guide, see http://anything-asian.net/modules.php?name=Serie_Guide&file=fansub. The site focuses on anime, and the list includes 277 anime fansubbers and fansub groups and 36 groups that concentrate on manga. Only three fansubbers listed on the site translate dramas. (Accessed July 2, 2005.)

17 As fans widely expose programs to potential consumers, fan distribution is perceived as "free advertisement." With lawsuits, copyright holders run the risk of alienating fans, as legal battles with pirates may deter consumers from buying licensed programs. This, in turn, may end up costing more to copyright owners than what they had originally lost to media piracy. Series with fansubbed originals tend to sell better on the Western markets. This suggests that fansubs fuel anticipation for new Japanese releases in the United States and Europe: Personal blog site of Matthew Skala, available at http://ansuz.sooke.bc.ca/lawpoli/cases/2004121101.php (accessed December 22, 2009).

18 Personal Web site of a former fansubber, available at http://www.areiacreations.com (accessed December 22, 2009).

19 Http://www.freewebs.com/azndorama/rules.html (accessed July 18. 2005).

20 The Jdorama.com Web site was launched in 2000 and attracts users primarily from Australia, Canada, Indonesia, Japan, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and United Kingdom, and the United States.

21 English language database of Japanese trendy dramas (J-dorama), available at http://www.jdorama.com/viewtopic.4902.htm (accessed December 22, 2009).

22 The U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and the Cyber Division of the Federal Bureau of Investigation recently executed the first criminal enforcement targeting copyright infringement on peer-to-peer networks such as BitTorrent. Investigations revealed that, within four months, the BitTorrent network had attracted more than 133,000 members who distributed more than 17,800 titles, including movies and software, with 2.1 million downloads. Investigators noted that the offerings on the Elite Torrents network were virtually unlimited and often included illegal copies of copyrighted works before they were available in retail stores or movie theaters. For example, the third episode of Star Wars, *Revenge of the Sith*, was available for downloading on the network more than six hours before it was first shown in theaters. In the following twenty-four hours, it was downloaded more than ten thousand times: United States, Department of Justice, Web site, http://www.usdoj.gov/criminal/cybercrime/BitTorrent.htm (accessed February 2, 2006).

23 One can also download dramas via Streamload, a pay online storage service where one is allotted a certain amount of download bandwidth per month. Partners can upload their collections and swap with each other.

24 At http://www.jdorama.com. As I described earlier, Japanese dramas are circulated widely in Hong Kong and Taiwan. See Hu (2005) on the online community of Chinese fans of Japanese TV dramas. It is important to emphasize that it is not only media pirates that distribute Japanese dramas in East Asia and Southeast Asia. Fans do, too. However, an analysis of fansubbing in East and Southeast Asia goes beyond the scope of the chapter.

25 English language database of Japanese trendy dramas (J-dorama), available at http://www.jdorama.com/viewpost_58575.htm&sid=f5538520329f870cf3aa2012e68195ea (accessed December 22, 2009).

26 English language database of Japanese trendy dramas (J-dorama), available at http://www.jdorama.com/viewpost_58575.htm&sid=f5538520329f870cf3aa20 12e68195ea (accessed December 22, 2009).

27 Personal e-mail correspondence.

28 JN Productions, founded in 1981, started by producing commercials and broadcasting Japanese language programs on cable. It is now a full-service video-production house servicing various global clients with the capability to translate videos in English, Japanese, and Chinese; The *Honolulu Advertiser*,

online edition, http://the.honoluluadvertiser.com/article/2004/Oct/25/bz/bz05p.html (accessed December 22, 2009).

29 The link is http://pages.ebay.com/help/contact_inline/report_listing.html.

30 For further examples, see English language database of Japanese trendy dramas (J-dorama), available at http://www.jdorama.com/viewtopic/2315.htm; accessed July 18, 2005; English language database of Japanese trendy dramas (J-dorama), available at http://www.jdorama.com/viewtopic.3702.htm& high light=bootleg (accessed December 22, 2009). "Sellers Breaking Fanwork and Fansub Ethics" offers a list of sellers on eBay and other auction sites who sell fan work and fansubs.

31 eBay, online trading site, available at http://offer.ebay.com/ws/eBayISAPI.dll?ViewBids&item=6401571280 (accessed June 10, 2005).

32 Here I can make only a cursory remark about the role of anime in encouraging people all over the world to learn the Japanese language. Ultimately, the goal is to watch anime in the original language.

33 Similarly, Ubonrat Siriyuvasak (2004) reported that young Thai viewers consume Japanese popular culture to assume modern identity. In parallel with watching Japanese trendy dramas, they absorb and emulate the consumer culture these programs relay from the metropolitan center of Japan.

34 In different contexts, see also Gillespie 1995; Naficy 1993.

35 Japanese fashion designers such as Issei Miyake, Hanae Mori, and Takada Kenzo began working in Paris in the 1960s. However, they did not make a significant impact on the fashion world until the early 1980s, when journalists started celebrating them for their Japan-esque (*mode Japonaise* or *Japonaiserie*) aesthetic.

36 Henry Jenkins (2006b, 166) used the term "global cosmopolitanism" to argue that, for fans, global popular culture represents an escape route out of the parochialism and isolationism of their local communities, "the beginnings of a global perspective, and the awareness of alternative vantage points."

37 Since 1983, when it first aired on the public network NHK, *Oshin*, the story of a self-sacrificing woman who transcends one tragedy after another and finally becomes a successful businesswoman, has been broadcast in more than fifty countries. It offers a starkly different message from the one that lifestyle-driven trendy dramas encoded. The scriptwriter Hashida Sugako claims that she wanted the "over indulged modern youth" in Japan to know "the sacrifices that the older generation made on their behalf" (Harvey 1995, 87). *Oshin* offered a sense of familiarity. Foreign audiences appreciated the program because they could relate to its universal (i.e., rags-to-riches) theme (Singhal and Udornpim 1997).

38 When transnational flows of cultural commodities are generated by fans and media pirates, more space tends to be left for consumers to define the meaning of "J." By contrast, by deploying corporate branding practices, multinational

media-distribution companies tend to be more heavy-handed in shaping the context of consumption and, by extension, the meaning of "J." I would add that the meaning of "J" also varies depending on the genre of Japanese media culture that is consumed by global audiences. While what is perceived as particularly Japanese in J-dorama is the genre's preoccupation with consumer-oriented lifestyles, anime evokes an image of Japan as a producer of highly sophisticated media content. Western fans consistently emphasize that they prefer anime to domestic equivalents because of its superb quality of character portrayal, storytelling, and graphics (Napier 2007).

39 This plays out somewhat differently than the way anime achieved global popularity as a new form of artistic expression and alternative (i.e., non–Western) form of mass culture in prior decades. It was more common for international audiences to turn to Japan after having seen Japanese animation than the other way around.

40 About.com, an online producer of original content affiliated with The New York Times Company, available at http://worldfilm.about.com/library/weekly/aafpr092702.htm (accessed December 22, 2009).

41 Online news and review site of kung fu cinema, available at http://www.kungfucinema.com/reviews/killbi1101.htm (accessed August 21, 2005); OAFE, Online toy review site, available at http://www.oafe.net/yo/kb1_gogo.php (accessed December 22, 2009).

Epilogue

1 Completed in September 2000, the Do Communication Mobile (DoCoMo) Yoyogi Building in Tokyo reaches a height of 240 meters. The upper portion of the building features colored lights that indicate whether one should carry an umbrella. A clock, 15 meters in diameter, was put into operation in November 2002 to celebrate NTT DoCoMo's tenth anniversary. It is currently the tallest clock tower in the world.

2 "Finance and Economics: A Model Economy; Economics and Gaming," *Economist*, vol. 374, January 22, 2005, 85.

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